

BHAGAVAD GITA

365

REFLECTIONS
FOR DAILY
MINDFULNESS



CHAITANYA
CHARAN

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Readers interested in the subject matter
can contact the author at following address:

gitadailywisdom@gmail.com

www.gitadaily.com

Reviews

“Gita for Daily Mindfulness is a practical, contemporary and bitesize presentation of the traditional and timeless wisdom of the Bhagavad Gita. This book is relevant for all people no matter their age, sex, color, religious background, and nationality. As a ship would sway violently in a turbulent ocean, our lives are troubled by internal and external forces without the proper foundational understanding and the moral compass of spiritual knowledge. This book calms the ocean of one’s inner self thus enabling and arming us with knowledge to deal with problems of the outside world. This book is even more relevant for this age to guide us on the path of morality as our daily lives are influenced by the inter-connectedness of the world via social media leading us to question what to and what not to believe to be true and to guide us on further action.

This book represents the essence of life as detailed in the vast ocean of Vedic scriptures. The instruction in the book is structured progressively for anyone to grasp and understand. I understood the true meaning of inner happiness in relation to the external world by reading this book. It completely changed my perspective on life and transformed the way I deal with daily problems. I guarantee that your life will be enriched by reading this book as well.

The proof of the pudding is in the eating and the proof of this transcendental literature is in the realization of the self and transformation of our lives. I strongly recommend everyone to read this book so expertly written by His Grace Chaitanya Charan Das and experience the transformation for yourself.”

—Arun Lakshmanan, Director,

WW Delivery Excellence, Microsoft Corporation, Seattle

“Ever since a friend introduced me to his books, I have avidly followed Chaitanya Charan, the author of the world’s only Gita-daily feature, wherein he writes a 300-word inspirational reflection daily on a verse from the Bhagavad-Gita. This latest publication brings together a year’s worth of

his short Gita-daily essays into one book which is not only easy to read, but also deeply profound and extremely relevant. One can read a (short) page as a morning booster, for example, or as a midday pick-me-up, or an evening introspection. Or one can read several pages in one sitting. Each page takes a verse from the Bhagavad-Gita and turns it into a practical theme for our daily life, complete with examples, tips, and points for introspection.

I appreciate that Chaitanya Charan packs, into 300 words or less, impactful ideas that others - even those as wise as he is - might take several times more words to express. The effect of reading even a single page is akin to eating what looks like a light snack but it turns out to be nourishing and satisfying for the entire day.

If you want to improve your performance at work, relationships in all spheres, and your happiness levels, buy this book and read it! It will be useful for a wide range of people across many demographics and professions. I rank it among the best self-help books I have read in my life.”

—Yogesh Deshmukh,

Vice President, Finance and Admin, Plymouth Rock Assurance, New Jersey

“In this book “Gita for Mindfulness”, Chaitanya Charan Das (author) has elegantly decoded the age old spiritual wisdom. His analogies between real world experiences and principles of Gita with reference to specific verses from Gita are thought provoking and profoundly impactful. His brief, concise, rationally astute style of writing makes it an easy read, yet has the potential to steer life in a positive direction. There are several take home messages for us as readers such as how we can develop “spiritual wings to fly”, “scrutinize and align our belief system to ultimate reality”, “resize our hurt”, “prevent robbery of our consciousness” to mention a few and above all how we can live life fully and mindfully.”

—Pooja Gupta, MD,

Associate Professor of Pediatrics, Practicing Congenital Cardiologist,
Detroit, Michigan

“Chaitanya Charan presents the eternal wisdom of Bhagavad-gita uniquely. Instead of taking a verse and explaining the meaning to readers, he takes

life-situations, breaks them down using Gita wisdom and provides answers by mapping each situation to a Gita verse. He thus makes the Gita's timeless teachings more relevant and usable in solving our present-day life challenges."

—Shashi Raina,

Partner Solution Architect, Amazon Web Services

"What can a book written more than 5000 years ago educate us today when just about everything has changed? The Bhagavad Gita has endured the test of time because the questions raised by its protagonist remain particularly relevant today. When Arjuna is faced with the biggest challenge of his life in a battlefield, he asks a most consequential question: not "Krishna, should I fight", but "Krishna, what is my dharma (duty)?" In answering this insightful question, Krishna systematically deconstructs the psychology of human thought and its components: the mind, intelligence and ego. Krishna describes the impulses that drive one to action, the motives behind the work we do, the lenses through which we see the world and form perspectives, and finally the factors that lead to determination and decisive action". We are all called upon to make consequential decisions, whether in a career, calling or in relationships. Our lives have a frenzied pace with competing priorities making time our single most precious asset, more valuable than money. Living life with mindfulness allows us to act as an impartial witness of our actions, moods and life choices, providing inner clarity that helps catalyze the development of decisive actions. How do we access the timeless wisdom of the Gita to apply in our daily lives?

Chaitanya Charan Das with his incisive writing brings the message of the Gita alive in short summaries with provocative questions. Whether you are a somber professional who learns best by introspection or a comfortable extrovert who likes to lead a discussion among peers, the format of "Gita for Daily Mindfulness" provides rich food for thought. No matter what your station in life is, you could use these summaries for substantive discussions with your friends, families or peers at work. Since the Gita wrestles with humanity's fundamental questions and recognizes the living force within all of life, it cuts across man-made barriers of race, nationality or religion. The format of the Gita behooves us that each individual seek his own path and that we learn best by dialogue, until each one is fully convinced about the

Truth, without coercion or passive submission. An insightful practitioner of the Gita will recognize over time that he/she develops a non-judgmental worldview and conducts oneself with renewed vigor, less tormented by the highs and lows of life.”

—Dr Sumithira Vasu,

Medical Director, Stem Cell Therapy Lab, Arthur G. James Cancer Hospital, Columbus, Ohio

“Gita daily, the daily reflection on Bhagavad-gita, has impacted our entire family’s lives in innumerable ways.

On many occasions, I’ve been stunned by how apt it is for the event that I’m facing on a particular day. I had just finished a very emotional end-of-life discussion with a patient’s family who had an irreversible brain injury after a cardiac arrest. I felt their pain and the enormous decision that lay ahead for this family. As I was heading into the elevator, I checked Gita daily. I don’t remember the exact quote, but it was relevant to the moment. The frailty of life, uncertainty and the unconditional surrender to God as we make our decisions is what lifted me up after that conversation. It further reiterated another one of the Daily’s messages to always ensure one’s mind is focused on the spiritual needs and get away from material ones, for they simply leave you drained and depleted. Life is too short to make bad decisions.

There have been many days, where my husband and myself have exchanged messages that the day’s Gita message was relevant to the issues we were handling that day. That relevance made me a firmer believer in God. He knows to guide me and he knows how to do it which further reiterates my unconditional surrender.

On Sunday mornings, our family of four are at the Temple. After a meditation session, we turn to a Gita Daily message that resonated with the events of the week, especially as it pertains to our children and we talk about it. Each of us talks about the discussion questions listed. One particular discussion was talking about instances where we succumbed to our material self and others where we let our spiritual self dictate our actions. After the discussion, I realized how valuable it was for our kids to have parents acknowledge that they struggle too with these choices and how

the Gita provides that moral compass to consistently make good decisions. Being closer to our spiritual self is a conscious effort that takes daily work and we need to constantly strive to do better. It does not happen by accident, it takes effort.

Our family is closer to each other due to Gita daily. I am a better doctor, a better person and a much better mother and wife, thanks to Gita daily. I appreciate how well written these messages are and most importantly in a manner that can resonate with kids raised here and provide them with moral guidance that they can shield themselves from the many vices that surround us.”

—Suji Vasu MD,

Director of Advanced Cardiac Imaging, Wake Forest University School of Medicine, Winston Salem North Carolina

Dedicated to

His Divine Grace A.C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada,

whose masterly commentary

Bhagavad Gita As It Is

underscores the transformative power of spiritual love

that is the Gita's essence

&

To my many Gita-friends,

teachers and readers,

who have enriched my appreciation of the Gita

Brief Note for Using This Book

Each article in this book is based on a verse from the Bhagavad-Gita. That verse is mentioned at the bottom of the article in italics. Each article ends with a Think it over section that has three questions to aid you in applying Gita wisdom. If you are so inspired, you can keep a dedicated notebook to write your own reflections in response to the Think it over questions.

Contents

NOURISH YOURSELF

Empower Yourself

Hold your plans lightly, not tightly.

Inability to face life's challenges may diminish us, but unwillingness to face life's challenges will demolish us

Intelligence means to know what to do when we don't know what to do

Pleasure is too fragile a purpose to sustain us through life's troubles

To keep small things small, keep big things big

Determination is distilled desire directed decisively.

We are the makers of our destiny, but not the masters of our destiny.

Some limits restrict; some protect – knowing which limit does what is intelligence

To be caught unawares occasionally is condonable, to be caught unawares repeatedly is condemnable

As long as we hide behind ourselves, we can't challenge ourselves

Living for the moment is a prescription for chaos at best and calamity at worst

Seeking to understand our nature won't box us in, it will reveal the box we are already in

Never lose faith in your potential to improve, or you will court cowardice and malice

Addiction is an abductor who extorts ever-increasing ransom but never releases

Use cleverness to counter corruptness, not cover corruptness

Ask not why bad things happen to good people, ask what good people do when bad things happen to them

We have snakes inside us, but we are not one of them

Don't run from pain or rush towards pleasure – refocus on your purpose

If conscience doesn't create a barrier between impulse and indulgence, intelligence must

To free yourself from the burden of self-consciousness, become conscious of a purpose bigger than the self

For changing yourself, focus on comprehending yourself, not on criticizing yourself

No one has a right to mistreat you, not even you

We are our greatest hope – and our greatest horror

If we repeatedly let our mind take us to hell, eventually it won't let us come back

If we eat waste, it shows in our waist

What we treasure the greatest is often not our greatest treasure

For inner change, momentum matters more than movement

The essence of discipline is to make our intelligence faster than our mind

Virtue that is more talked than walked is not necessarily infertile; it may just be infantile

A rigid structure may not work for us, but without a structure, we may not work

To take sole credit for our abilities is to put too much burden on ourselves

To be dissatisfied with the material is ordinary; to be so dissatisfied as to look beyond the material is extraordinary

Meditation is not the antithesis of action, it is the basis of action

Our deepest desires should direct us from within, not disappear within

We can't avoid being pushed by time, but we can choose where we are pushed by time

Our future is shaped not so much by how many options we have as by how well we choose among the options we do have

Experience becomes our best teacher when we experience the Best Teacher

If we are tormented by strong conscience and weak willpower, the solution is strengthening willpower, not weakening conscience

Time can be a fire in which we burn or a teacher from whom we learn

On some days, in some ways, we all can make a difference — provided we try.

What we achieve depends on not just how we strive but also on what we believe

Humility frees us from dependence on our own power and grants us access to God's power

Attachment makes us psychologically stiff, detachment makes us psychologically flexible

Don't let the craving for clarity distract us from working with whatever clarity we have

Even if your better choices don't create a better world, they will create a better you

To put yourself together, put aside the things that pull you apart

When a danger is less visible, it leaves us more vulnerable

To be brave, we don't need to be free from fear; we just need a purpose bigger than fear

Intelligence is meant to be the mind's instructor, not its instrument

Be terrified about how terrible you can be, to never become that terrible

Weakness makes us hotheaded, wickedness makes us cold-blooded

When nothing feels filthy, everything may be tidy or everything may be filthy.

Exploiting others' weaknesses doesn't make us strong; overcoming our own weaknesses does

Envy targets the envied, but torments the envious

To understand what is wrong with the world, look first in the mirror, not in the newspaper

Words are not just vehicles of thought, but also engines of thought

Our intelligence is not like a fixed deposit; it is like a stock market share

We rarely do things without a reason, but reason is rarely behind the things we do

Accepting our weaknesses takes courage and so does accepting ourselves with our weaknesses

See memory not as an exhaustive guide to the past, but as a constructive guide from the past to the future

We can never start in our life unless we start with our life

When we limit our challenges, we can challenge our limits

To be responsible means to stop blaming the outer trigger for the inner trouble

Our expectation that nothing should come in our way, comes in our way

The world may not value our individuality, but we can and we should

Even if we can't change what we live with, we can change what we live for

Seek God's help for doing his will, or you will need his help to get out of the trouble you get into because of not doing his will

Self-acceptance should open the door for self-improvement, not shut the door

Regulate emotion with reason, animate reason with emotion

Conscience without intelligence is blunt, intelligence without conscience is numb

Growing through adversities

Even when our eyes are full of tears, we can still choose to be all ears

Amidst unmanageably distressing times, reduce your working frame to manageable units of time

When work doesn't work, detachment works

Life becomes meaningless not when we tire of life's problems, but when we tire of life's pleasures

Chemical highs can't cure life's lows, go spiritually high

Pleasure and pain are both life's ringtones – don't keep hearing the tone, start picking up the phone

Spirituality reveals that our destiny is bigger than the biggest adversity

There is more to us than what faces us

Just because pain is circumstantially beneficial doesn't mean it is intrinsically desirable

Life is a school in which everyone thinks their exam is the toughest

We can't change our past, but we can change how we see and explain our past

Life may be full of problems, but we don't have to be one of them

Passing blame is easy but disempowering, accepting responsibility is tough but empowering

No matter how bad things are, we can always make them worse; we are never powerless

Even if we have a million reasons to be resentful, still resentment remains utterly unhelpful and can be horribly harmful

Resilience comes when we accept what is unchangeable, but don't accept that everything is unchangeable

The night after a quake, the stars still shine in the sky; don't let the misery of your life blind you to the beauty of life

To keep fighting battles that are already lost is to be lost

To put something behind us, we need to put something ahead of us

Even if we can't see adversity as opportunity, we can still see opportunity in adversity

Even when bhakti doesn't make life easier, it makes us tougher

If we prayed as much as we worried, we would worry a lot less

God doesn't promise a stormless sea – he provides an unsinkable ship

Problems are like burdens whose weight increases with the attention we give them

Problems may get stuck inside us, but we don't have to get stuck inside them

Stop blaming your outer world, start building your inner world

Stronger than what faces us is what graces us

The size of our problems is inversely proportional to the size of our purpose - the bigger our purpose, the smaller our problems become

When time becomes unfavorable, don't become unfavorable to the Lord beyond time

Even if we can't understand Krishna, we can still stand under Krishna

Resenting reversals locks us in ignorance, accepting reversals opens the door to transcendence

We can't eliminate suffering from life, but we can cultivate a purpose that makes suffering bearable and life meaningful

Key to Happiness

Happiness is a state of being, not a status symbol

Happiness is savored best when seen through the corner of the eye, not when stared at straight

Fulfilling our every desire won't make us happy, focusing on our most important desire will

Our loudest desires won't lead us to happiness – our deepest desires will

Satisfaction comes by knowing ourselves, not by making ourselves known

The images of prosperous people that make us burn with envy are just our mind's illusions

The mind overvalues things it doesn't have and undervalues things it does have

To be happy is possible, to be happier than others is impossible

Stop resenting your struggles, start habituating yourselves to them – and they will start hurting less

To savor what is most sweet, we often need to shed the most sweat

We have to risk going too far to know how far we can go

Mindfulness

Manage the garbage in your mind or the garbage in your life will become unmanageable

The mind is like ice to truth and fire to lies

Everything is not in the mind, but everything comes through the mind

Mind your mind to know when it is in order, when on the border and when out of order

Respect the dark within you, to keep it within you

The media is mostly the mind multiplied, magnified and magnetized

To be thoughtful, attribute every thought first to the mind

Use introspection as a confession by the self to the self

Watch yourself as if you are someone you don't know; self-observation opens the door to self-transformation

Even if the mind is not shrill, it is still a shill

Our mind is constantly hiding and is constantly ready to give us a hiding

Stop playing games with your mind and with those who play games with your mind

As long as we don't mine under the mind, the mind will undermine us

Focus on life, not on the mind's commentary about life

To get out of the mind, go above it to the soul or go below it to the body

Intelligence means to know which thoughts are to be pinned and which to be binned

The lesser the structure in our life, the greater the rupture the mind can cause in our life

The mind is restless, reasonless, ruthless, relentless

The mind is so wild that it can make us homeless at home

The mind makes us spin like dirty laundry and leaves us dirtier

The mind stops us not just from achieving our dreams, but also from pursuing them

Watch the mind, or the mind will catch you

What the mind makes us do would be comic if its consequences were not so tragic

The mind's complaining about a problem is often a bigger problem than the problem itself

The mind is like a bully who has terrorized us for long; it's time to stand up

If we let our mind devalue our efforts to improve our life, it will end up devaluing our entire life

The mind burdens us and deems as burdens those who offer to relieve our burdens

Even if we can't control our emotions, we can control the attention we give to our emotions

The mind overpowers us by making us believe that we are powerless

When the mind takes charge, the only thing that works is we: hard

Mindless feeds don't feed our mind, they feed our mindlessness

The mind is a perpetual procrastinator – it postpones our resolutions to “some day”, then “some decade”, and then “some lifetime”

We don't know the future, but neither does our mind; its fears reflect the past, not the future

Worrying about world problems is often our mind's excuse for not working on our own problems

The mind often recasts antipathy as inability; what it doesn't want to do, it presents as if it can't do

When the mind believes something is enjoyable, it stops evaluating whether it is actually enjoyable

Overcoming Temptation

Fighting urges is like a timed arm-wrestling match; if we just survive the present round, we will resume on neutral ground

If we don't give the devil his due, he will take more than his due

Protect the fences that protect you; keep temptation at a healthy distance

Saying no to temptation doesn't mean much if we don't mean no

Friendly snakes are still snakes – beware of the snake-like senses

We relapse not because we are witless or will-less, but because we are weapon-less

Don't bolt from temptation, bolt the door to temptation

Stop struggling to turn off the inner darkness, start striving to turn on the inner light

Stop worrying about avoiding temptation, start working on cultivating absorption

Careless contemplation turns tempting thoughts into time bombs

Even when we can't avoid sensual perception, we can avoid sensual imagination

Seek the association that warns us about our urges, not warns us to our urges

Those who underestimate their mind undermine their intelligence

The mind is omnivorous; it devours whatever is present and feels pleasant

A sight on a site can trigger a fire inside – watch what you watch

What we feel doesn't tell us, what we will does

More damaging than the lies we tell others are the lies we tell ourselves

Impurity needs to be feared before it can be found, found before it can be fought and fought before it can be finished

More dangerous than the enemies that threaten are the enemies that tempt

Those who fight their inner devils are the ultimate daredevils

As long as the mind is impure, no place is secure

Love becomes blind when lust becomes the blindfold

Sensual pleasure touts itself as free and then takes toll forever

We are inflammable, not incorrigible; we need caution, not condemnation

No barrier is foolproof – that is not proof no barrier is useful

If we are robbed repeatedly by the same suspect, it is our intelligence that is suspect

Impulse may run over intelligence, but don't let it take over intelligence

To decrease unhealthy reactions, increase healthy reminders

To see our own stupidity, unvarnished and unjustified, is infuriating and invigorating

The body reacts mechanically — don't take its reactions personally

Turning away is not running away if we are turning toward something better

Intelligence shows how indulgence is harmful and how harmful indulgence is

Obscenity is objectionable not because it shows too much of a person, but because it shows too little and obsesses people with the too little

Even if we can't stop feeling sensual urges, we can stop feeding sensual urges

If we think we have no vices, we are novices

We don't have to outweigh our urges; we just have to out-wait them

When we resist our urges, they may become scarier, but they don't become stronger

When fighting temptation, focus just on surviving the present battle, not on winning the whole war

To regulate your eating, listen to your body, not to your mind

Those who think they aren't prone to evil are the most prone to evil

Just because we have drunk a sip of poison doesn't mean we have to drink the whole cup

If we don't fix the broken doors to our consciousness, we will be robbed

Our urges aren't like endlessly rising lines; they are like endlessly recurring waves – surf them patiently

When the sensual deludes the eye, the spiritual eludes the I

Even if we cover the tracks we make externally, the tracks we make internally still cover us

In dealing with our urges, if we don't consciously choose responsibility, we unconsciously choose slavery

Even if we can't close the door to temptation permanently, we can close it presently

Contemplation on temptation changes our disposition from zero tolerance to zero resistance

Intelligence is the last defense against indulgence – and also the first defense

Perfectionism is a serial killer in high heels

To best defend our consciousness from the world, raise it above the world

Positive Attitude

When the mind says our victories are too small to count, cross-question it: "What other way is there to big victories?"

The essence of commitment is recommitment

When life is uncomfortable, thank God that it is not unbearable

What differentiates spiritualists from materialists is not the absence of pain but the presence of healing

Learn to be comfortable with feeling uncomfortable

Where we are doesn't determine who we are

Complaining is no one's birthright – and it has made no one's birth right

Everything in history is not in memory; everything in memory is not in history – intelligence means to know what belongs where, and to keep it there

Look for the good in all situations, even in situations that don't look good

The less time we have for our problems, the less problems we have

Look up and things will look up

The Art of Balance

Equality that is imposed doesn't raise everyone up; it brings everyone down

Don't just work on our conditionings – work with our conditionings

Being conscious of the body is not bodily consciousness; being conscious only of the body is

Better to be crazy in being busy than to be just crazy; better still is to be busy without being crazy.

To live life fully, leave life regularly – take breaks before life breaks you

During our idle time, our mind works overtime

Possessing wealth is not the problem; being possessed by wealth is

NOURISH YOUR RELATIONSHIPS

Emotional Maturity.

Focus on the cause that brings us together, not on the conditions and conditionings that push us apart

To be assertive, we sometimes need to be aggressive, adequately and adeptly.

Never make irreversible decisions based on reversible emotions

Don't use others to feel better about yourself; learn from others how to become better

If we justify our weaknesses by comparing ourselves with those who are weaker, we weaken our motivation to rectify ourselves

Between naivete and cynicism is the courage to trust

Comparing is unavoidable, but comparing mentality is undesirable

Boring people find people boring

The notion that love can exist outside of sacrifice is a dangerous lie

Thinking about worldly things is not attachment; being unable to stop thinking of them is

Trying to get even with others gets us at odds with ourselves

Be childlike, not childish

Humility means to focus on how we can serve, not on what we deserve

Those who are not humble often help us to become humble

Commitment is emotional investment, attachment is emotional dependence

Mind your mind before you mind anyone else's mind

Don't be annoyed that people are so bad; be amazed that they aren't worse

Find your own story or you will become a bit player in someone else's story.

To be nice is not to be naive — it is to be free from the control of vice

Those who don't respect themselves are most agitated when others don't respect them

Those who don't find the reprehensible reprehensible, are reprehensible

The causes of anger rarely hurt us as much as the consequences of anger

Even if we are feeling miserable, that doesn't give us the right to make others miserable

To be compassionate, be both caring and careful

To resolve conflicts, begin with the 1% commonality, not the 99% differences

Self-pity makes feel-bad seem feel-good

When you feel like giving up, start looking up — not sentimentally, but spiritually.

Whose words we hear matters, but whose words we hold dear matters even more

How to speak effectively.

Wrong philosophy may not obstruct people spiritually as much as our calling their philosophy wrong

Be mindful of people's perceptions, but don't make your mind full of their perceptions

Just because we have a right to be angry doesn't mean we are right to be angry.

Don't forget to compliment those who complement you

Opening the mouth without opening the mind helps neither the mouth nor the mind

Our tongue is like a loaded gun that we carry with us always

Speak in a way that educates and engages, not enrages and estranges

Learn to let go of what you think you are speaking and to hear what others are hearing

Speak not just correctly, but also appropriately.

We don't owe our friends a positive response, but we do owe them a sensitive response

Appreciating others' achievement fosters extrinsic self-worth, appreciating their commitment fosters intrinsic self-worth

The essence of education is enlightenment, engagement, and encouragement

Before a prescription can inspire action, the diagnosis must inspire conviction

Nonjudgmental Attitude

An impurity censor makes no sense to those who don't have even an impurity sensor

Don't try to be someone better; try to be an example of something better

Know when to give others space and when to give them pace

Make judgments, but don't be judgmental

See the addicted not as demented or degraded, but as tormented

Spiritual vision sees people not as philosophical categories, but as conscious beings

We may have to fight against others, but we don't have to be against others

Don't reduce people to their group identity – differences within groups often exceed differences across groups

The desire that the dark be darker defines a dark mind

The Power of Letting Go

Attachment is the inability to say no, whatever the cost

Detachment is the absence of emotional dependence, not the absence of emotion

When we are attached to someone, we don't care much for them; we care much more for what they think about us

Tolerance empowers us when we focus on our purposefulness, not on our powerlessness

The mind makes us fight wars that aren't winnable and wars where victory is not even definable

If we are grateful when ability manifests through us, we can be graceful when it doesn't

Solutions that try to satisfy everyone usually sway no one and solve nothing

Value those who value you and don't overvalue those who devalue you

Don't pack what is back — the past — in your backpack

NOURISH YOUR DEVOTION

Divine love

The love that leads us to evil is evil masquerading as love

God keeps the door to him unlocked from his side till every soul, however degraded, comes to him

When we make God our friend, we become our own friend

Krishna is just one thought away from us – always

Devotion commences when God becomes our guide and culminates when he becomes our goal

We are like birds on a branch — our wings need to grow before the branch breaks

See Krishna's reciprocation more in spiritual absorption than in material protection

Praying to get our need fulfilled isn't our need – praying is our need

Sensual hope deludes, spiritual hope delivers

The appreciation we get for our service is not as consequential as the absorption we get in our service

The test of success in bhakti is taste for bhakti

To have fixity in purpose, we need flexibility in pace

Everything that happens may not be God's plan, but God can make his plan work through everything that happens

We may be circumstantially distanced from Krishna, but we don't have to be devotionally deprived of Krishna

With God, everyone is accepted, but everything isn't acceptable

Even our best race to the end will require the Best's grace in the end

Don't ask God to fix your problems, ask God to fix you so that you can fix your problems

God is always ready to work with us, are we ready to work with him?

Logical Spirituality

Just as our body needs physical nutrition, our soul needs metaphysical orientation: a sense of place and purpose in the world

Opinions are like onions — know when they need to be sealed and when peeled

Proving that we are right is not as empowering as probing if we are wrong

The human spirit is too big to stay satisfied within any material cage, however grand

We aren't merely physical beings seeking sustenance, safety and sex; we are essentially spiritual beings seeking purpose and progress

More important than understanding what we observe is understanding what it is that observes

What we know doesn't define us as much as what we want to know

We are not masters in our own house, but we don't have to be slaves

Covering our tracks thoroughly is not intelligence; choosing our tracks thoughtfully is

Seeking requires believing: believing that something worth seeking exists and that we have the capacity to find it

What the moonlight of reason shows dimly, the sunlight of revelation shows clearly

Our longing for equality points to our spirituality

When the mind insinuates, it is often more insidious than when it incites

Reason can't reach beyond reason, but it can give us reason to reach beyond reason

Our belief system doesn't just shape our perception of reality; it becomes our reality

The environment is not ours to take or leave; it is ours to make

Everything expensive is not valuable, everything valuable is not expensive

Our clock may stop, but time doesn't — don't waste time

Education centers not on building our resume, but on broadening our reality

Education is meant to remove ignorance and restore innocence, not remove innocence and reinforce ignorance

Thinking that thinking is troublesome, is troublesome

Insight comes by catching sight of the link between things already in sight

Materialism reduces organism to mechanism

Just because a wound is painless doesn't mean it is harmless – even when we are not hurting, we still need healing

The resilience of the human spirit reflects our longing for and our belonging to transcendence

Spiritual growth is defined not by the possessions we give up, but by the conceptions we give up

To believe whatever we see is to live like an animal

Arrogance keeps us not just in ignorance, but also in ignorance about the extent of our ignorance

To make people suffer for the sake of making them suffer is the very essence of evil

Some people get many insights from one sight, others don't get even one insight from many sights

We may forget gravity, but gravity won't forget us
Even if our worldview stays out of view, it shapes our every view
Everyone has values, but not everyone's values reflect real value
Moral relativism makes wrongdoing tough to identify, tougher to rectify
and toughest to purify.
Materialism reduces you to a number and glamorizes things that make
you number
If we put gravity to test, gravity will put us to rest
The choices you make, make you
Just as bigotry can blind emotionally, ideology can blind intellectually.
Science is the study of matter, spirituality is the study of what matters
Technology may change our world for the better, but let it not change
our worldview for the worse
Learn to wonder and ponder, not wander and pander
Spiritual knowledge is meant to make us devotionally fit, not
intellectually fat

Ritual to Spiritual

Keep the mind on one track, don't keep a one-track mind
If an ideal inspires more regret than reform, an intermediate ideal is
required
Without going deeply into one tradition, we can't deeply appreciate any
tradition
Ritualists see hierarchy above equality, spiritualists see equality above
hierarchy.
To respect Krishna, respect the time we have carved out for Krishna
Don't let our desire to use something for Krishna become greater than
our desire for Krishna
Fanatics use God's name to give God a bad name
Fanatics don't see how God is present everywhere; they see how God is
absent everywhere
Let your practices make you a spiritual fruit, not a religious nut

Understanding Gita Concepts

To understand one thing, we sometimes need to revise how we understand everything

Choose the good when it protects you from the bad, but not when it deprives you of the best

The capacity to trade the present for the future is the defining human characteristic

The Gita is not inciteful; it is insightful

Krishna retains his divine position even while he reclines in a supine position

Karma is not like a mysterious contagious disease; it is logical, not diabolical

A missed apostrophe can be a catastrophe – we are God's, not Gods

Doubt is a disease that makes the patient believe the doctor is sick

As long as we are self-seeking, we can't be a seeker of the self

Analyzing a spiritual text without applying it is like examining food without eating it

We are in illusion, but we are not an illusion

Don't reduce scripture to your conceptions of what scripture should be teaching; expand your conceptions to understand what scripture is actually teaching

To forget that the world is a hurtful place is to place ourselves on a path full of hurts

Even if we fare well in life, we still have to say farewell to life

Just because we can do the impossible doesn't mean we can do everything

Death is meant to point to enlightenment, not be a plot point in entertainment

When the part offers its whole to the Whole, the Whole makes the part whole

A God who pretended we had no shortcomings would be a God who did not take our potential seriously

Scripture is meant to be not just mapped, but also mined

Acknowledgments

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Introduction

The Bhagavad-gita is a time-honored guidebook for conscious living. Its profound wisdom has guided millions for millennia. Even today, millions all over the world draw from the Gita's insights to make their life more meaningful and joyful.

Mindfulness is essential if we want to focus and do anything worthwhile. And it's required not just for doing but also for being. The more we become aware of our emotions and our situations, the more we can understand the depths of our inner world and the richness of reality at large.

The Gita is an invaluable guide for mindful living. It offers penetrating insights into the workings of the mind and powerful practices to make the mind work for us instead of against us. Not only that, it provides an inspiring worldview within which our experiences and our existence acquire sublime meaning and purpose.

Many readers of the Gita face a challenge, however. The Gita has its own metaphysics, which is significantly different from whatever metaphysics we grew up with (or grew up without). Understanding that takes time and effort; thankfully, that task is made easier by the commentaries of the many great spiritual teachers. My understanding of the Gita has been enriched by many commentaries, among which Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada's stands first.

I have been studying the Gita for over two decades. It is more than a guidebook for me; it is a personal guide. Connecting with its verses, be it by remembering them, reciting them or speaking on them, rejuvenates me. But my deepest connection with the Gita has been forged in the crucible of writing. I have been writing daily on the Gita for nearly a decade. To make these daily reflections accessible, I keep them short: about 300 words. Over the years, the readership for these reflections has grown from a few friends to tens of thousands all over the world. The reviews offer

This book offers edited versions of some of the most-read articles from those daily reflections. These reflections provide an applicational, inspirational, motivational study of the Gita. This book is meant not as a replacement for commentaries that offer a systematic explanation of the Gita, but as a complement to those commentaries. Each of these articles can serve as a tool for reorientation and re-spiritualization. Every article is stand-alone; feel free to read any article that catches your attention. To make the content of the article more understandable and recollectable, I have provided titles that are full sentences. The title can help you churn the message throughout the day and longer.

Though all the articles are complete in themselves, they have also been classified into themes that can help you choose what to read. To have a fulfilling life, we need to relate well with three major realities: ourselves, the people around us and the Lord. Accordingly, the book has three major themes: Nourish Your Self, Nourish Your Relationships and Nourish Your Devotion.

These three themes are further classified into sub-themes:

I. NOURISH YOUR SELF

1. Empower Yourself
2. Growing Through Adversities
3. Key to Happiness
4. Mindfulness
5. Overcoming Temptation
6. Positive Attitude
7. The Art of Balance

II. NOURISH YOUR RELATIONSHIPS

1. Emotional Maturity
2. How to Speak Effectively
3. Non-Judgmental Attitude

4. The Power of Letting Go

III. NOURISH YOUR DEVOTION

1. Divine Love
2. Logical Spirituality
3. Ritual to Spiritual
4. Understanding Gita Concepts

I hope that reading these reflections on the Gita empowers you in your life-journey and enriches your heart with divine presence and guidance.

With best wishes

—Chaitanya Charan

NOURISH YOURSELF

Empower Yourself

Hold your plans lightly, not tightly

Suppose we catch a beautiful butterfly and hold it in our fingers. If we hold it too tightly, fearing that it may slip away, we may unwittingly squeeze its life out.

Something similarly counterproductive happens if we hold our plans too tightly. We all need plans to stay focused. Amidst life's many distractions and disruptions, holding on to our plans gives us a sense of orientation, progression and completion.

Still, while holding our plans, we need to guard against holding them too tightly. Otherwise, when life's upheavals wreck our plans, we may start resenting, blaming and complaining. By that negativity, we may squeeze out of our life the very vitality that the plan was supposed to bring.

The Bhagavad-gita begins with a terrible thwarting of Arjuna's plans. As a kshatriya, he had an overarching life-plan: use the power of his arms to rule virtuously for the pride and pleasure of his venerable elders. But the Kurukshetra war confronted him with two agonizing options: the path of virtue that required him to fight against his elders or the path of service to elders that required him to give up that fight. With his life-plans thus upended, Arjuna saw no good in the upcoming war (01.30).

Yet the Gita explained to Arjuna that a divine plan was still in operation for the ultimate good of everyone. Hearing the Gita, Arjuna became ready to cooperate with the divine plan, thereby regaining his composure (18.73).

The Gita can guide us all to hold our plans lightly, not tightly. Being thus guided, we make plans and try our best to execute them. But when factors beyond our control thwart our plans, we don't hyperventilate – we open ourselves for the working of a higher plan, confident that it will bring good in its own way.

Think it over

What is the difference between holding plans and holding them too tightly?

How can we hold our plans lightly, not tightly?

Is there any plan you are holding too tightly? How can you loosen your grip?

01.30 I am now unable to stand here any longer. I am forgetting myself, and my mind is reeling. I see only causes of misfortune, O Krishna, killer of the Keshi demon.

Inability to face life's challenges may diminish us, but unwillingness to face life's challenges will demolish us

We all face challenges in life. And some challenges are such that we are unequipped or underequipped to face them. At such times, we may become so disheartened that we may just lose our will to fight.

If we are found wanting in ability, that deficiency is somewhat understandable. After all, we all are born with a certain amount of ability; our practice and diligence can improve our ability to some extent, but it can never entirely make up for inborn differences. A tone-deaf person can never become a Mozart. When we are unable to face life's challenges, we may lose out on some things in life; we may be diminished on bowing before some challenges.

While that may be painful for our ego, what will be far more shattering for our morale is if we are found wanting in will. If we cave in and give up, that failure will torment us lifelong; it may demolish our fighting spirit, our self-confidence, our faith.

Let's see how Gita wisdom made the able willing. At the start of the Bhagavad-gita (01.46), when Arjuna lost his will to fight, it was as if he had lost the fight without a fight. Krishna highlighted how Arjuna's refusal would demolish him materially and spiritually. Materially because the loss of reputation would be unbearable. And spiritually because the alienation from the divine would take a long time to repair.

By hearing the Gita, Arjuna's morale was restored (18.73). His ability had never been in question, but his will had crumbled. Just as the Gita restored Arjuna's will, so too can it restore and reinforce our will, provided we hear its wisdom systematically.

When facing life's challenges, we can maintain our will to use whatever ability we have. If we do what we can. Krishna will do what we can't.

Think it over

Why is the inability to face life's challenges understandable?

Why is unwillingness far more damaging than inability?

Amid difficulties, how can you strengthen your morale?

01.46 Sanjaya said: Arjuna, having thus spoken on the battlefield, cast aside his bow and arrows and sat down on the chariot, his mind overwhelmed with grief.

Intelligence means to know what to do when we don't know what to do

Whenever we have to make decisions, we usually seek guidance from our intelligence. But life sometimes puts us in perplexing situations wherein our intelligence becomes paralyzed. We feel as if we were going along a familiar road and suddenly encountered an unfamiliar intersection. At such times, we need to turn towards someone knowledgeable and reliable for guidance. Consulting such a person amidst perplexity is also a sign of intelligence.

At the start of the Bhagavad-gita, Arjuna exhibited such intelligence. His life till then had been running along the track of dharma. But suddenly he came to an intersection wherein he was pulled in opposite directions by two dharmas as a Kuru scion (a member of the Kuru dynasty) and as a kshatriya (a martial guardian of society). Being thus conflicted, he felt baffled, disheartened, intellectually paralyzed (02.06).

When his intelligence didn't know what to do, it still knew what to do: turn to the supremely reliable guide, Krishna. He surrendered to Krishna to understand the essence of dharma (02.07). On hearing the Gita, Arjuna situated himself in his eternal identity as a part of the Whole. Thereby, he saw his various dharmas as integrated with and subordinated to his dharma of serving the Whole. Internalizing this vision resolved his dilemma (18.73).

Similarly, when we feel perplexed, we need to turn towards the Gita to remind ourselves of our core identity and our ultimate destiny. Once we become grounded in our fundamental function to serve the Whole, Krishna, we will gain divine guidance to figure out a constructive way through our dilemma (10.10).

Thus, Gita wisdom expands our conception of intelligence from a guide to decision-making to a guide amidst indecision too, thereby protecting us from intellectual paralysis.

Think it over

Why did Arjuna become intellectually paralyzed?

How did the Gita help Arjuna resolve his dilemma of contradictory dharmas?

How can the Gita protect us from intellectual paralysis?

02.07 Now I am confused about my duty and have lost all composure because of miserly weakness. In this condition I am asking You to tell me for certain what is best for me. Now I am Your disciple, and a soul surrendered unto You. Please instruct me.

Pleasure is too fragile a purpose to sustain us through life's troubles

We all seek pleasure. Yet life can put us in such dilemmas and traumas that pleasure can become utterly unavailable. In such situations, if we had made pleasure our life's purpose, we may feel that living itself is pointless.

Such was the condition in which Arjuna found himself at the start of the Bhagavad-gita. He declared that the greatest success for a warrior – a flourishing kingdom in this world or the next – would not remove the grief that was drying up his senses (02.08).

Encouraging him, the Gita revealed a higher purpose for life based on a spiritual worldview. At our core, we are indestructible souls; and we are parts of a transcendental Whole, Krishna. All our talents and achievements are meant ultimately to help us connect devotionally with Krishna and contribute practically in this world for our and others' well-being.

Krishna is always present with us, within us. And our consciousness is our defining characteristic; it too is always with us. When we strive to offer our consciousness to Krishna through outer service and inner remembrance, we become empowered with an inalienable purpose. This purpose of connection and contribution, when customized according to our particular interests, abilities and limitations, energizes our life with meaning and fulfillment. The knowledge that we have an enduring connection and are making a worthwhile contribution sustains us through life's distresses. And the resulting absorption provides, as a byproduct, a sublime fulfillment, which is far deeper and richer than the sensuality and hedonism that are often equated with pleasure.

Thus, using our talents and interests not just to gain pleasure but to establish inner connection and enhance outer contribution, thereby making our consciousness absorbed in Krishna, is life's most worthwhile purpose.

Think it over

Why is pleasure too fragile as a life-purpose?

How can spiritual purpose sustain us through life's troubles?

How can adopting a spiritual purpose empower you amid your challenges?

02.08 I can find no means to drive away this grief which is drying up my senses. I will not be able to dispel it even if I win a prosperous, unrivaled kingdom on earth with sovereignty like the demigods in heaven.

To keep small things small, keep big things big

Suppose we are driving on a crowded lane and we notice someone driving wildly on an adjacent lane. If we get angry at their irresponsible driving and start gesticulating and yelling at them, we may run into danger on our own lane. We need to keep small things small.

But how do small things become big in the first place? To understand, let's compare our mind to a computer screen. There, while we are focusing on one thing, many other thoughts pop up. If we uncritically dwell on such stray thoughts, they become big and distract us.

Even after we understand how small things become big, keeping them small is not easy. Why not? Because the mind's pop-ups come without any dismiss buttons; we can't easily drive stray thoughts out of our mind. What, then, can we do about them? Neglect them.

To neglect small things, we need some big thing to attend to. Further, we need to remind ourselves of that thing's importance and conscientiously direct our attention toward it. A pertinent psychological principle is: the more we dwell on anything, be it small or big, the bigger it becomes in our consciousness, thereby making other things small. If we focus on keeping big things big, small things concomitantly stay small. Even if some small thing remains in our mind, it can't distract us.

The Bhagavad-gita expands our vision of what the really big things are. We are souls who are on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution. During this evolution, we have faced many material ups and downs – such upheavals come and go, being temporary (02.14). If we focus in all situations on how we can evolve spiritually and thus keep that big thing big in our consciousness, we can progress calmly through all forms of material disturbance toward eternal transcendence (02.15).

Think it over

Why is keeping small things small difficult?

How can we keep small things small?

How does Gita wisdom help us keep small things small?

02.15 O best among men [Arjuna], the person who is not disturbed by happiness and distress and is steady in both is certainly eligible for liberation.

Determination is distilled desire directed decisively

To achieve anything challenging, we need determination. How can we develop this elusive thing called determination?

To understand, let's divide determination into its components. Essentially, determination is distilled desire directed decisively.

Desire: The starting point of determination is desire. When we desire something, and desire it strongly, we pursue it and persevere in pursuing it even amidst obstacles. And such perseverance is determination.

Distilled: Just as a distilled liquid is purified of all extraneous elements, our desires need to be distilled so that all impurities external to our core self are purged out. Then the distilled desires for the things that matter most drive us. Otherwise, some of our many lower desires may make us hooked to unworthy things. Addicts could be said to be determined for their object of addiction. But their determination is destructive – it is obstinacy.

Directed: Desire can be compared to a flashlight that illumines the path ahead. Our vision follows our intention. If our desires are undirected or misdirected, the phenomenal power of desires gets dissipated on trivialities. When we direct our desire constructively, we notice doors that we would otherwise overlook.

Decisively: If a flashlight keeps roving up and down, left and right, round and round, then it can't illumine the path ahead clearly. Similarly, if we keep second-guessing ourselves, desiring first this thing and then that, we can't clearly perceive either our purpose or the path to our purpose. When we are decisive, determination follows naturally.

How can we develop these components of determination? One way is by practicing bhakti-yoga with whatever determination we presently have. Such spiritual practice distills our desires and gives us the inner intelligence to direct them decisively (Bhagavad-gita 10.10). No wonder the Gita declares that those on the spiritual path are determined (02.41).

Think it over

How is desire the starting point of determination?

Why do our desires need to be distilled?

How can we develop determination?

02.41 Those who are on this path are resolute in purpose, and their aim is one. O beloved child of the Kurus, the intelligence of those who are irresolute is many-branched.

We are the makers of our destiny, but not the masters of our destiny

When we strive to achieve something challenging, we soon realize that the results don't depend on us alone. For example, in cricket, our favorite team may play brilliantly, but if rain washes out the match's decisive portion, that team may not win. The unknown factor that shapes results is conventionally called destiny.

We may wonder: What determines destiny? We do. Or rather, we have determined it, by our past actions. Destiny is essentially the sum total of our past karma, good and bad. A portion of that karma stockpile combines with our present actions to determine the results of those actions. Sometimes, we may do a small good deed and reap a windfall. Why? Because destiny is favorable; our past positive karma is coming into play. At other times, we may make a small mistake and face a catastrophe. Why? Because destiny is unfavorable; our past negative karma is coming into play. Thus, three factors determine the result (phala): our present action (karma), destiny (daiva) and time (kala).

Put mathematically, $Karma + Daiva + Kala = Phala$

Because destiny is nothing but the combination of our past actions, we are indeed the makers of our destiny. However, because we don't determine whether destiny will manifest positively or negatively at a particular time, we are not the masters of our destiny – the Supreme Lord is. Thus, the role of our present actions in shaping results is contributive, but not definitive. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita urges us to do our duty, but not be attached to the result (02.47).

Understanding that we are the makers of our destiny, we feel inspired to do our part wholeheartedly. Understanding that we are not the masters of our destiny, we learn to gracefully accept whatever results we get.

Think it over

Which factors determine the results of our actions? Explain.

How are we the makers of our destiny, but not its masters?

How can understanding destiny properly help us?

02.47 You have a right to perform your prescribed duty, but you are not entitled to the fruits of action. Never consider yourself the cause of the results of your activities, and never be attached to not doing your duty.

Some limits restrict; some protect – knowing which limit does what is intelligence

When we are limited in any way, we often see that limitation as a restriction to our freedom. And yes, many limits do restrict. But not all; some limits protect.

If a person has been unfairly jailed, then the jail walls restrict their freedom of movement. But suppose a person is living inside a fort that is being attacked by rioters who are out to kill that person. Though those walls too limit that person's movement, they are actually offering protection, not imposing the restriction. If that person foolishly leaves the safe haven of the fort in the name of freedom, they will be slaughtered.

For physical threats, we can easily discern that some walls protect. But we need intelligence to similarly discern when it comes to subtler threats: threats to our consciousness by temptations.

Whenever we are told to not do some activities that we consider pleasurable, we tend to rebel, "Why don't you let me enjoy?" However, such rebelliousness is blind to the reality that what we consider pleasurable often leaves us miserable. Many of the world's pleasures are baits that entice and entrap our consciousness in sensuality, immorality, and perversity, whereby we end up hurting, even destroying ourselves. That's how people who take cocaine shots to get high eventually end up addicted, tormented, defeated.

The Bhagavad-gita (02.64) states that when we keep our search for happiness within scriptural limits, that limitation protects us from self-destruction and takes us towards spiritual realization and lasting happiness thereof. Thus, returning to the fort metaphor, living the scriptural way not only keeps us safe from degrading temptations but also paves a way for us to the safe zone of spiritual absorption in the all-attractive Supreme.

To live within scriptural limits is the ultimate sign of intelligence, for it protects us from degradation and guides us towards liberation.

Think it over

Explain with examples of how some limits protect.

How are the world's pleasures baits?

Why is living within scriptural limits intelligent?

02.64 But a person free from all attachment and aversion and able to control his senses through regulative principles of freedom can obtain the complete mercy of the Lord .

To be caught unawares occasionally is condonable, to be caught unawares repeatedly is condemnable

Suppose a person who runs a ferryboat gets caught in a storm because they don't know that the sea tends to be stormy in that season. If that were the first time they were caught unawares, their lapse would be understandable and condonable. However, if they were caught unawares repeatedly, such regular lapses would be unacceptable and condemnable.

Gita wisdom explains that we all are souls navigating our way through the ocean of material existence where storms of sensual temptation often occur. In this ocean, most storms are triggered by us. How? By our contemplation on tempting objects. Such contemplation activates and aggravates our worldly desires till they become stormy, drowning us in delusion and degradation.

If we didn't know the danger of such contemplation and were swept away by a storm, that lapse would be condonable. But scripture repeatedly warns us about the danger of sensual contemplation. For example, the Bhagavad-gita (02.67) cautions that just as a stormy wind sweeps away a boat, the stormy desire generated when we contemplate tempting objects sweeps us away.

Despite such warnings, we sometimes contemplate sense objects nonchalantly, believing that we can get the pleasure of titillation while avoiding the trouble of delusion and degradation. Such foolhardiness sweeps us away, sooner or later. And if we get swept away repeatedly, our nonchalance would be condemnable, for we would have courted our own corruption.

That's why we need to carefully avoid giving undue attention to tempting objects. And since we are always conscious of something, the only effective way to stop giving our attention to a particular thing is by giving our attention to something else. And the best object to give our attention to is the all-pure, all-potent, all-loving ultimate reality, Krishna.

By absorption in Krishna, we gradually become immune to sensual temptation.

Think it over

How can stormy desires sweep us away?

How do we ourselves trigger the storm of desire? Which storm do you often trigger?

How can you avoid doing so?

02.67 As a strong wind sweeps away a boat on the water, even one of the roaming senses on which the mind focuses can carry away a man's intelligence .

As long as we hide behind ourselves, we can't challenge ourselves

Suppose we are afraid of some aggressor and choose to hide behind some protector. Later, if our protector starts oppressing us, we won't be able to challenge them because we have made ourselves dependent on them.

A similar dynamic applies in our inner world. We all face troubles and threats from the world outside of us. To protect ourselves, we often craft an image of ourselves as being tough. For example, if we fear betrayal by people around us, we might craft a public image of being cynical, hard-hearted and uncaring. While this image may protect us from heartbreak, it will also suppress our heart from growing and flourishing. If we are hiding behind that macho image, we will not be able to lower our guard and express our vulnerability even to people who truly care for us and whom we want to come closer to.

When enemies face each other, both brag about their strengths and conceal their weaknesses and wounds. When loved ones meet each other, however, they need to appropriately reveal their weaknesses and wounds so that treating and healing can take place.

The same principle applies to our moral flaws too. If we live in a morally demanding social circle, we might put on an appearance of being upstanding to be respected, or at least to not be rejected. But while concealing our moral weaknesses is sometimes necessary, we need to simultaneously work on rectifying those flaws. Otherwise, the Bhagavad-gita (03.06) cautions that we will end up not just deceiving the world but also deceiving ourselves, believing that we are morally healthy when we aren't.

We need to avoid becoming chronically dependent on our image by not hiding behind ourselves. Instead, we need to go beyond building the image to building the substance. How? By regularly challenging ourselves adequately and thereafter changing ourselves appropriately.

Think it over

Why do we sometimes hide behind ourselves?

Why is revealing our vulnerabilities sometimes necessary?

How do you hide behind your image? What can you do to change that?

03.06 One who restrains the senses of action but whose mind dwells on sense objects certainly deludes himself and is called a pretender.

Living for the moment is a prescription for chaos at best and calamity at worst

While driving along an expressway, suppose we see something attractive nearby and suddenly take a turn toward it. Other drivers will have to brake forcefully and come to a screeching halt. If everyone started taking such impulsive turns, traffic will be thrown into chaos, at best. At worst, calamitous car crashes will occur, turning roads into graveyards.

Just as we can't drive for the moment, we can't live for the moment either. During our life-journey, if we start living for the moment, indulging in anything that feels pleasurable, we will hurt ourselves. If we eat whatever tastes good, we will spoil our health. Worse still, if people start having physical relations with anyone they feel infatuated by, families will splinter; generations of unloved children will be born; and the foundations of society will crumble.

But shouldn't we live in the moment, as many mindfulness teachers recommend? Yes. However, living in the moment is not living for the moment.

Living in the moment is like driving in the moment – it means focusing on the road ahead of us and steering our car carefully toward our destination. Similarly, living in the moment means first, not letting regrets about the past or fears about the future distract us and second, focusing on the present to create the kind of life we aspire for.

Forsaking present indulgence for a better future is the essence of sacrifice. And the intelligence to do such sacrifice differentiates humans from animals. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (03.16) declares that those who live for their senses, without doing any sacrifice, waste their lives.

Ultimately, sacrifice done devotionally connects us with the all-attractive source of all joy, Krishna, and enriches us with lasting joy.

Think it over

What is wrong with living for the moment?

What is the difference between living for the moment and living in the moment?

What is sacrifice? How can you sacrifice now to create a brighter future?

03.16 My dear Arjuna, one who does not follow in human life the cycle of sacrifice thus established by the Vedas certainly leads a life full of sin. Living only for the satisfaction of the senses, such a person lives in vain .

Seeking to understand our nature won't box us in, it will reveal the box we are already in

Some people resist any system of categorization of human nature. They feel, "This will box me in." While their concern is understandable, it is based on the misconception that we can stay out of boxes if we avoid any system of categorization. It's akin to saying that if we don't identify the germ we are infected by, we won't be infected at all.

We all have a psychophysical nature with which we are born. That nature comes from the way we have acted in our previous lives. And this nature shapes our actions, often without our conscious awareness. The Bhagavad-gita states that we are more or less forced to act according to our nature (03.34). If we deny our nature, we are still forced to act according to that nature, even if we imagine we will be better off acting in some other way (03.35).

Consider a time-tested system of classification of human nature such as the fourfold classification given in the Gita — ministerial, managerial, mercantile and mechanical. Such a system serves as a map of our inner world. The map doesn't make the territory the way it is; it just makes us aware of how the territory is. Without the map, we will be caught unawares when we face the inevitable pitfalls in our inner terrain. The map equips us in our inner journey toward self-understanding.

Of course, if someone uses a system of classification to force a particular identity upon us, an identity that isn't in harmony with our nature, that would constrict and disempower us. But a system for better self-understanding can empower us when it reveals the reality and helps us harmonize with that reality.

Think it over

What is wrong with resisting the categorization of our nature?

What determines our nature? And how does it determine our actions?

How does understanding our nature help us in our inner journey?

03.35 It is far better to discharge one's prescribed duties, even though faultily, than another's duties perfectly. Destruction in the course of performing one's own duty is better than engaging in another's duties, for to follow another's path is dangerous.

Never lose faith in your potential to improve, or you will court cowardice and malice

Suppose a patient loses faith in the potential of any treatment to cure them. They will become sicker, suffer more and soon die.

What applies to our physical health applies much more to our moral and spiritual health. Why much more? Because when we become morally and spiritually sick, we can hurt not just ourselves but also others.

Let's backtrack to better understand this inner dynamic.

Suppose we resolve to improve ourselves. Unfortunately, some inner self-destructive force thwarts our resolutions. Being repeatedly frustrated, we give up and start justifying our status quo: "This is just the way I am."

However, even if we stop trying to improve, the inner self-destructive force won't let us stay where we are; it will increase its attack and drag us down to actions of depravity and even brutality. The Bhagavad-gita (03.37) states that the inner self-destructive force is voracious: it devours everything we hold sacred.

Giving in to this force, when we lose faith in our potential to improve, we unwittingly embrace cowardice and malice. Cowardice because we are chickening out of an inner war just because we have been bruised and battered earlier. Malice because this inner enemy will make us deride, even destroy, anyone who triggers our resentment: "When my life is so bad, why should their life be so good?"

To avoid becoming cowardly or malicious, we need to unsentimentally understand that in our inner war, we can't stay on neutral ground. Thankfully, Gita wisdom assures that our potential to improve is never lost. It is intrinsic to who we are: pure souls, parts of the all-pure source of everything.

When we resolve to resist our inner enemy and seek to connect with the all-pure divine, he empowers us to improve ourselves.

Think it over

Why can't we maintain the status quo in the inner war?

How does losing faith in our potential lead to cowardice and malice?

Why is our potential to improve never lost?

03.37 The Supreme Personality of Godhead said: It is lust only, Arjuna, which is born of contact with the

material mode of passion and later transformed into wrath, and which is the all-devouring sinful enemy

of this world.

Addiction is an abductor who extorts ever-increasing ransom but never releases

Suppose an abductor abducts a child and demands a huge ransom from the parents. Even after receiving the ransom, however, they don't release the child, but demand more ransom, again and again, ad infinitum. Such an abductor would be vicious indeed.

Scarily, we all are potential victims of such an abductor. That abductor is worldly attachment, which abducts our consciousness (Bhagavad-gita 02.44). If not guarded against, attachment can degenerate to addiction. Among our many attachments, sensual attachments centered on lust are especially prone to become addictive. If we indulge in them nonchalantly, they impel us to indulgences that become increasingly irresistible, till we end up addicted. Because of their ruthless relentlessness, the Gita calls such attachments our "eternal enemies" (03.39).

When we become attached to something, our consciousness gets dragged toward that thing. When we are thus tormented by the desire to indulge in it, we have to put more and more of our consciousness into how we can indulge so as to get more pleasure or at least more relief. While pursuing the indulgence, we also need to maintain the façade of normalcy in the other areas of our life. Thus, addiction consumes our consciousness even when we are not indulging – we are abducted, even if we seem free.

How can we guard against such addiction? We need to begin with whatever consciousness we have free from attachment, whenever we have it free. And we can offer that consciousness to the all-pure, all-powerful, all-pleasurable supreme reality, Krishna. The resulting connection with the divine will gradually satisfy and purify us, eventually empowering us to break free from addiction or stay free from it. But for us to seek that divine connection, we need to first unsentimentally understand that the attachments which seem like harmless titillations can become ruthless addictions, thereby remembering the necessity to counter them gravely and promptly.

Think it over

How is addiction a deadly abductor?

Why is addiction a peculiar abductor?

How can we protect ourselves from addiction?

3.39 Thus the wise living entity's pure consciousness becomes covered by his eternal enemy in the form of lust, which is never satisfied and which burns like fire.

Use cleverness to counter corruptness, not cover corruptness

We all have a certain amount of cleverness and a certain amount of corruptness. Our cleverness enables us to go beyond the appearance of things to their substance. Our corruptness arises from the presence within our consciousness of corrupting impurities such as lust, greed and envy.

How our cleverness and corruptness interact determines our destiny. If we use our cleverness to counter out corruptness, we can create a bright future for ourselves. How? By astutely seeing through the false promises of our impurities and resolutely refusing to pander to them.

Unfortunately, these corrupting impurities can be so insidious as to subvert and even pervert our intelligence. The Bhagavad-gita (03.40) points to this scary possibility when it states that lust resides not just in our senses and mind, but also in our intelligence.

When lust takes over our intelligence, we start using our cleverness to cover our corruptness. That means whenever we succumb to lust, we carefully cover our tracks so that we don't get caught by others. We use our cleverness to put on a façade of purity while pandering to the impurity within us. When our cleverness thus becomes a servant of our corruptness, we doom ourselves to degradation, even self-destruction.

Thankfully, we can nourish our intelligence by studying the Gita and use the resulting cleverness constructively. How? To remind ourselves that impure temptations are insidious; to alertly detect and reject sneaky temptations; to proactively protect ourselves from things that make us unnecessarily or excessively vulnerable to such temptations; and, most importantly, to situate ourselves on the spiritual platform (03.43) by diligently serving the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna, thus transcending temptation.

With our cleverness constructively channeled, we can firmly counter and gradually conquer our inner corruptness, thereby attaining spiritual integrity and eternal liberty.

Think it over

How can cleverness counter corruptness?

How can corruptness misuse cleverness?

How can we use our cleverness constructively?

03.43 Thus knowing oneself to be transcendental to the material senses, mind and intelligence, O mighty-armed Arjuna, one should steady the mind by deliberate spiritual intelligence [Krishna consciousness] and thus – by spiritual strength – conquer this insatiable enemy known as lust.

Ask not why bad things happen to good people, ask what good people do when bad things happen to them

One of the oldest philosophical questions is, “Why do bad things happen to good people?”

Gita wisdom answers by introducing the principle of karma, which extends the widespread understanding of causality, as enshrined in sayings such as, “As you sow, so shall you reap.” By introducing the principle of reincarnation, it explains how the action-reaction sequence extends to before birth and after death; we may get in this lifetime reactions to some actions done in a previous lifetime.

Karma is arguably the most satisfactory, or the least unsatisfactory, explanation for the problem of evil. Nonetheless, the Gita doesn’t use karma as a magic wand to explain away the problem of evil. It acknowledges that the movements of karma are so intricate as to elude human understanding (04.17).

Consequently, the Gita focuses not so much on karma as on dharma, the right thing to do. It urges us to look at the way great souls have lived to attain elevation and liberation — and to emulate their example (04.15). The principles taught in the Gita are expounded in bhakti texts such as the Srimad-Bhagavatam, which gives several narratives of what good people do when bad things happen to them. These narratives range from king Parikshit who is cursed to die in seven days for a minor infraction to five-year-old Prahlad who becomes the target of several assassination attempts by his own father. Through such narratives, the Bhagavatam demonstrates that devotional virtue centered on spiritual absorption in the divine is the best way to tolerate and transcend evil whenever it befalls us.

If we too learn to change our driving question to what can we do when bad things happen, we will find divine guidance from within showing us a way to light even amid overwhelming darkness.

Think it over

How does the Gita address the problem of evil?

How does the Gita equip us to deal with life’s distresses?

How can we change our driving question amid distress? What difference will that make?

04.15 All the liberated souls in ancient times acted with this understanding of My transcendental nature. Therefore you should perform your duty, following in their footsteps.

We have snakes inside us, but we are not one of them

Suppose someone we thought we knew suddenly does something terrible and hurtful. We may be aghast, wondering what kind of horrible desires lie hidden below their ordinary-looking appearance. We may worry, “Are they dangerous? Are they like vicious snakes?”

Worryingly enough, if we are honest and introspective, we can sense that we too have dark desires within us. We may not have the particular dark desire that they had, or we may not act on that desire to that depraved extent. But beyond such specifics, we do have a dark side that we conceal from the world. Still, we wouldn't call ourselves snakes; after all, there's some goodness inside us too.

Reassuringly enough, Gita wisdom explains that our core is good and godly; we are souls, who are parts of the divine. However, in our inner world, the pure soul is surrounded by many impurities which are like snakes. Thus, we have snakes inside us, but we are not one of them. And the essential adventure of human life is to go beyond the inner snakes to the soul and thereby relish unending spiritual joy.

Suppose we were seeking a treasure hidden in a snake-infested cave. To get to the treasure, we would need to slay all those snakes. Similarly, if we are to reach and realize the treasure of our spiritual identity, we need to slay the various snake-like desires that cover our soul. And we all can slay them. We just need to let ourselves be guided by transcendental knowledge, which the Bhagavad-gita (04.34) asserts can reform the greatest of wrongdoers.

Therefore, if we want to be internally enriched, we need to be cautious and adventurous: cautious to guard against our snake-like lower desires; and adventurous to fight an inner war till we reach and release our core goodness.

Think it over

We have snakes inside us what does that mean?

How are we not one of the snakes inside us?

What is the essential human adventure?

04.36 Even if you are considered to be the most sinful of all sinners, when you are situated in the boat of transcendental knowledge you will be able to cross over the ocean of miseries.

Don't run from pain or rush towards pleasure – refocus on your purpose

Suppose we are driving on a road to a destination. If the road is filled with traffic moving at a snail's pace, we may find it tiresome to move on, but if our destination is important for us, we won't turn away just because of the difficulty in driving.

Conversely, if we see an attractive movie playing in a theater along the road, again we won't stop driving just because of that movie; we will move on towards our destination.

Gita wisdom urges us to have a similar purposeful focus during our life-journey. We are souls who are on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution towards unending happiness in a loving relationship with the all-attractive whole, Krishna. During our life-journey, the pleasures and pains we encounter are like minor gains or losses. In contrast, the culmination of our spiritual evolution – eternal, ecstatic absorption in Krishna – is so glorious, so eternally fulfilling that everything else pales in comparison.

Therefore, the Bhagavad-gita (05.20) urges us to not get elated on getting the desirable or to get dejected on getting the undesirable; it urges us to remain fixed in spiritual knowledge and spiritual realization, staying free from illusion by virtue of a steady intelligence nourished by philosophical conviction. When we regularly study the Gita, we get the impetus to focus on our purpose and to not get distracted by pleasure or pain.

Undoubtedly, life's journey will bring dualities in our life. And some of those may be huge, in terms of promising enormous pleasure or threatening catastrophic pain. But in the long run, they won't matter much, just as huge pleasures or pains from a decade ago don't matter much now. What matters ultimately is the evolution of our consciousness. And focusing on that purpose is the way to eternal auspiciousness.

Think it over

What is the purposeful journey that helps us see our present in perspective?

How can we stay focused amidst dualities?

What matters most in our life?

05.20 A person who neither rejoices upon achieving something pleasant nor laments upon obtaining something unpleasant, who is self-intelligent, who is unbewildered, and who knows the science of God is already situated in transcendence.

If conscience doesn't create a barrier between impulse and indulgence, intelligence must

Suppose a river tends to overflow unpredictably, flooding the nearby areas. To protect those areas, a barrier would be constructed on the riverbank.

Similarly, in the river of our consciousness, unhealthy impulses sometimes rise as floods, sweeping us toward degradation and self-destruction. To protect ourselves, we need barriers.

Our conscience is meant to serve as a natural barrier. How? By emotionally pinching us when we start doing something wrong and emotionally patting us when we start doing something right. Whenever an unhealthy impulse rises, a functional conscience immediately deters us from indulgence.

Sometimes however, our conscience becomes disoriented or dumbed. If we have grown up in a licentious culture, then our conscience, being culturally disoriented, may no longer flag wrong things as wrong. Or if we have repeatedly indulged in something unhealthy, such habitual indulgence can dumb our conscience.

When our conscience doesn't act as a barrier to impulse, we need to create an alternative barrier. How? With our intelligence. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (05.22) states that the intelligent desist from sensual indulgence, knowing that such pleasures are temporary and end in misery.

How can we use our intelligence as a barrier against a particular impulse? With our intelligence, we can note down the dangers of pandering to that impulse and keep those notes readily, constantly accessible. Whenever that unhealthy impulse arises, we can train ourselves to look at those notes and thereby get the intellectual impetus to resist that impulse.

By thus using our intelligence to resist impulse and simultaneously pursue transcendence – specifically, the all-attractive divine – we can gradually repair our conscience, weaken our impulses and relish devotional absorption.

Think it over

How does our conscience serve as a natural barrier against impulse?

How can we use our intelligence to build an inner barrier?

List any impulse for which your conscience no longer pinches you. For that impulse, how can you use your intelligence to act as a barrier?

05.22 An intelligent person does not take part in the sources of misery, which are due to contact with the material senses. O son of Kunti, such pleasures have a beginning and an end, and so the wise man does not delight in them.

To free yourself from the burden of self-consciousness, become conscious of a purpose bigger than the self

Self-consciousness can be a big burden for many people. When they interact with others, especially in public settings, they are choked by their self-consciousness: “I stutter; I have low IQ; I weigh too much.”

How can we deal with such self-consciousness? By properly understanding our place and purpose in the overall scheme of things.

We all are finite beings; naturally, we have some limitations. While being conscious of our limitations may be functionally necessary, being conscious only of our limitations can be psychologically damaging. Such self-consciousness becomes like a heavy burden that buries us alive, leaving us with no self-confidence or energy.

To overcome self-consciousness, we need to get out of ourselves. Suppose we see someone sleep-walking near the edge of a tall terrace. Even if we stutter, we will still call out loudly to warn them about the danger.

What enables us to overcome our self-consciousness? Becoming conscious of something bigger than the self – in this case, becoming conscious of the danger the other person is in.

Gita wisdom helps us expand our consciousness by explaining that our life is meant for something bigger than ourselves – we are parts of the ultimate reality, Krishna (15.07). He is the omnibenevolent Lord of everyone (05.29). When we strive to do our various roles and responsibilities in a mood of service to him, he can empower us beyond our capacities. And soon, we start seeing that, despite our deficiencies and defects, we too can do some good.

When we thus appreciate the potency of working in a mood of service, we start replacing our self-consciousness with a far more empowering service consciousness.

Think it over

How can self-consciousness burden us?

Explain with an example of how getting out of ourselves can help us overcome self-consciousness.

How can Gita wisdom help us grow out of self-consciousness?

05.29 A person in full consciousness of Me, knowing Me to be the ultimate beneficiary of all sacrifices and austerities, the Supreme Lord of all planets and demigods, and the benefactor and well-wisher of all living entities, attains peace from the pangs of material miseries.

For changing yourself, focus on comprehending yourself, not on criticizing yourself

Suppose someone criticizes us constantly about something we are doing. Instead of understanding where we are coming from, if they simply judge and condemn us, then their constant critical mentality will irritate, dishearten and alienate us. Instead of considering if and how to apply what they are saying, our energy will get caught largely in avoiding them and getting away from them.

When the approach of constant criticism rarely works when someone else applies it to us, why do we think that that same approach will work if we apply it to ourselves? If we become our own unrelenting critic, we may end up becoming fed up. Fed up of ourselves as the faulty person or fed up of ourselves as the faultfinding person. Either way, we end up being the losers because we are our first resource – it is we who have to elevate ourselves with ourselves, as the Bhagavad-gita (06.05) indicates. Even if someone is there to help us – be it an outer mentor or the supreme inner mentor – it is we who have to internalize their guidance at the time of instruction and then give that guidance to ourselves at the time of application.

That's why when dealing with ourselves, we need to begin by comprehending ourselves – understanding what makes us click and what makes us crumble. If we fail to keep a resolution, instead of simply condemning ourselves for being weak-willed, we need to analyze how and why we flounder: what our thinking is when we make the resolution; how our thinking changes when we are to apply that resolution; and what is the reasoning, however misleading, by which our mind changes our resolution.

When we thus understand ourselves, we will be able to catch our faulty reasoning precisely and correct it effectively.

Think it over

Why does a constant critical mentality not work?

What does comprehending ourselves mean?

Identify some unsatisfactory behavior of yours and contemplate how and why you flounder to better understand yourself.

06.05 One must deliver himself with the help of his mind, and not degrade himself. The mind is the friend of the conditioned soul, and his enemy as well.

No one has a right to mistreat you, not even you

Suppose someone repeatedly derided us. We would be incensed: “You have no right to mistreat me like this.”

Yet we let ourselves be mistreated like this regularly, even daily. How? By listening to our mind. Inside us is our mind which mistreats us, by replaying an endless self-deprecating monologue. And we let our mind mistreat us by uncritically listening to the mind. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-Gita (06.05) urges us to elevate ourselves with ourselves and not degrade ourselves with ourselves.

A question may arise: Is self-deprecation always bad? What if we are degrading ourselves by our mistakes and misdeeds? Don’t we need to be strong with ourselves, castigating ourselves so that we will improve? Yes, we certainly need to improve, but we need to check what approach actually empowers us to improve. If our self-castigation jolts us out of our complacency and impels us to take determined steps for self-reformation, that’s productive. But if such self-castigation amounts to beating ourselves down when we are already down, demoralizing us so much that we stop even trying to rise, then that is counterproductive.

To prevent such counterproductive self-flagellation, Gita wisdom gives us a spiritual vision of ourselves. It explains that we are not our own property to mistreat. We are parts of a Whole far bigger than ourselves. That Whole is the ultimate reality, the all-loving person, Krishna. He can make each one of us as channels for his compassion, thereby doing good to us and doing good through us for the world. And we all have the right and the responsibility to become such instruments.

By seeing ourselves as parts of the divine, we can reject our mind’s self-destructive urges to mistreat ourselves. Simultaneously, we can take up the responsibility to treat ourselves spiritually, being hard when necessary and gentle when necessary – all for our and others’ all-round good.

Think it over

How do we mistreat ourselves?

When is being hard with ourselves productive and when counterproductive?

How does seeing ourselves spiritually change the way we treat ourselves?

06.05 One must deliver himself with the help of his mind, and not degrade himself. The mind is the friend of the conditioned soul, and his enemy as well.

We are our greatest hope – and our greatest horror

We all sometimes act like Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde; we act sometimes like a principled, selfless benefactor and sometimes like an opportunistic, self-centered malefactor.

And similar is our own story too. What makes us behave like this? Our mind, or more precisely, the way we respond to our mind. Our mind reacts impulsively to external perceptions and internal recollections, becoming allured by some things and appalled by others. During its roller coaster, it occasionally comes up with good ideas and regularly with bad ideas. When we uncritically buy into its ideas, we often do foolish things. Thus, we become our greatest horrors.

The Bhagavad-gita (06.05) cautions that our mind can act as both our friend and our enemy – and exhorts us to elevate ourselves with it, not degrade ourselves.

How can we elevate ourselves? By connecting with an inner presence that is stronger, steadier and wiser than the mind. That presence is God, Krishna, who is our greatest benefactor and is, therefore, the source of our supreme hope. All inspiration comes from Krishna (15.15), even if we don't realize it. All ability comes from him too (07.08). He is our greatest hope. However, the responsibility to connect with him is ours and can't be outsourced to anyone else, not even to him. In that sense of having the responsibility to elevate ourselves, we are our greatest hope. And bhakti-yoga practice enables us to connect with him, thereby empowering ourselves to resist our lower side and to release our higher side.

Rather than waiting for something special to happen in our life that will change us for the better, we need to see ourselves as our greatest hope. That is, we need to take responsibility and initiative to change ourselves. Equipped with Gita wisdom and bhakti practice, we can connect with the one who is our greatest hope – and our life will become brighter.

Think it over

How do we become our greatest horror?

How can we elevate ourselves?

How are we our greatest hope?

06.05 One must deliver himself with the help of his mind, and not degrade himself. The mind is the friend of the conditioned soul, and his enemy as well.

If we repeatedly let our mind take us to hell, eventually it won't let us come back

Addicts often live in their own mental hell. Their mind subjects them to tormenting emotions: unbearable cravings, crippling self-flagellation, utter hopelessness.

How do addicts enter such a hell? They aren't born as addicts; no one is. People slide into addiction by small indulgences that gradually increase in quantity and frequency. Eventually, the urge to indulge becomes irresistible, making their life unbearable. Being lured and lulled by their devilish mind, they unwittingly enter hell.

We may not be addicts, but our mind too can take us to hell, which can connote both a level of reality and a level of consciousness. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (16.21) identifies lust, anger and greed as the gates to hell. A lusty mind fantasizes how to enjoy illicit sensual liaisons; an angry mind fantasizes how to cold-bloodedly destroy one's enemies; a greedy mind fantasizes how to unethically get immense wealth. If we entertain such fantasies, we unwittingly let our consciousness enter hell, albeit temporarily. Each successive time we entertain those fantasies, we go deeper and longer into hell. Eventually, when life presents an opportunity to act out one of those fantasies, we succumb. And once a dark fantasy transmogrifies into a gory reality, we get sucked into a web of delusion, deception and degradation – we are trapped in hell.

How can we avoid this trap? By knowing that our mind can be our enemy (06.06) and refusing to entertain its hellish fantasies. Resisting the mind is tough, but redirecting it makes things easier. By practicing bhakti-yoga, we can strive to take our mind to paradise, ultimately to all-pure Krishna. When we thus bask in Krishna's presence, one day, our consciousness will become so devotionally absorbed as to never return to this world of temptation.

Think it over

How do addicts live in a mental hell? How do they get there?

How can our mind take us to hell?

Does your mind conjure any hellish fantasy? How can you resist and redirect your mind?

06.06 For him who has conquered the mind, the mind is the best of friends; but for one who has failed to do so, his mind will remain the greatest enemy.

If we eat waste, it shows in our waist

Whenever we eat a lot, we may enjoy it initially. But we will suffer eventually. Especially if we eat junk food, that comes with heavy costs, not just financially, but medically and even spiritually. Some junk food is like waste put into our body, as seen in phrases such as empty calories.

The Bhagavad-gita (06.16) cautions us against extremes in dealing with our body: extremes such as eating too much or eating too little. Pertinently, the body is a responsive machine; it lets us know when we handle it wrong. For example, if we eat too much, the body starts becoming heavy and bloated.

Of course, the correspondence between waste food and waist size may not always be one-to-one. Sometimes, people who overeat may remain slim, thanks to strong metabolism. Or people who eat modestly may have bloated bodies because of genetic or physiological factors. Still, the body usually gives noticeable warning signals when we start handling it wrong.

Most of us know the importance of regulating ourselves. Yet self-regulation remains so difficult. Why? Often, it's because our vision sabotages our determination. If we view life as meant for worldly enjoyment, regulation seems an interference in our enjoyment: "If eating more gives me more enjoyment, why cut it down?"

Gita wisdom offers us a more holistic vision of life, wherein we see the body as a vehicle for us, who are at our core spiritual beings. As souls, we are meant to find lasting happiness through spiritual evolution toward the all-attractive, all-pleasurable divine, Krishna.

When we focus on that spiritual purpose and therein relish non-material happiness, we start appreciating how bodily regulation eases and enhances our spiritual connection. Once we stop seeing regulation as a dreary, depriving discipline, we can embrace it as an empowering way to a better life.

Think it over

How is the body a responsive machine?

Why is regulating the body so difficult?

How can we see self-regulation more positively?

06.16 There is no possibility of one's becoming a yogi, O Arjuna, if one eats too much or eats too little, sleeps too much or does not sleep enough.

What we treasure the greatest is often not our greatest treasure

Suppose a child is asked to choose between a toy and a million-dollar-check. The child may grab the toy, not knowing that the check can get thousands of toys.

We are often like that child when we compare our material assets with our spiritual assets. Our material assets are wealth, gadgets, property, and so forth. Our spiritual asset is our realization of our spirituality: our identity as souls and our relationship with the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna. We often value the material more than the spiritual.

Such misevaluation may continue even after we become nominally religious; we may still treasure material possessions more than spiritual realizations. What Krishna gives us may matter more to us than Krishna himself and our connection with Krishna. If we don't get the material things we seek from him, we may discontinue the devotional practices that connect us with him.

How can we avoid such misevaluation? By studying Gita wisdom, which explains that our material assets are important, but they can't fill our life with meaning or contentment. And they will be lost at death or maybe even earlier. Only our spiritual realizations will stay with us forever (Bhagavad-gita 02.40).

How can we grow spiritually? By nourishing our intelligence with Gita wisdom and diligently engaging in bhakti-yoga practice for remembering Krishna. Over time, and especially amidst adversities, we will experience that our remembrance of Krishna shelters and strengthens us even when our worldly treasures let us down. Thus, we will gradually come to the realization of the topmost spiritualists (06.22): nothing is more valuable than absorption in Krishna.

Just as a child, on growing up, starts treasuring the check, we too start treasuring Krishna more as we grow up spiritually. Indeed, spiritual growth essentially means that our conception of our greatest treasure becomes increasingly aligned with our greatest treasure.

Think it over

How does Gita wisdom protect us from misevaluating our assets?

How can we come to the realization of the topmost spiritualists?

What does spiritual growth essentially mean?

06.22 Upon gaining this he thinks there is no greater gain. Being situated in such a position, one is never shaken, even in the midst of greatest difficulty.

For inner change, momentum matters more than movement

Suppose we strive to improve ourselves in some area, but fail repeatedly. We may feel disheartened, “There are so many things wrong with me. Even if I improve, the improvement is so tiny. What difference will it make?”

For inner change, how much positive change we make is not as defining as how many positive impressions we make in our mind. Our actions result not just from our conscious intentions but also from the subconscious impressions present in our mind.

Whenever we do any action, it forms within us a corresponding impression. And this impression impels us to repeat that action. The more we repeat the action, the deeper the impression becomes and the stronger it impels us to repeat that action. If we create an impression for a positive activity, even if that activity is done in a small quantity, that impression will create a momentum for inner change. That momentum will eventually move us much further on the path to inner change than one large movement. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (06.25) urges us to seek inner change by gradually, steadily focusing our mind on higher spiritual reality.

Suppose we want to read a wisdom-text such as the Bhagavad-gita. We may resolve to read the whole Gita during a vacation. If we succeed, that’s great. Even if we don’t - and even if we do - what will most spiritualize our consciousness is not just a one-time reading of the Gita but the habit of regularly reading the Gita. If we strive to read the Gita daily, even if it be just a verse daily, that repetition will create a momentum for regular scriptural study which will transform us significantly.

Therefore, while seeking inner change, when we learn to focus on momentum rather than movement, we will make positive changes that may not be sensational but will be substantial and sustainable.

Think it over

What do our actions result from?

How can small changes make a big difference?

Is seeking sensational change distracting you from sustainable change?

How can you rectify that?

06.26 Gradually, step by step, one should become situated in trance by means of intelligence sustained by full conviction, and thus the mind should be fixed on the Self alone and should think of nothing else.

The essence of discipline is to make our intelligence faster than our mind

Suppose we tend to waste too much time on Facebook. We can try to discipline ourselves, but fail. Why is becoming disciplined so difficult?

To understand that, let's analyze the inner factors that shape our actions. Broadly speaking, those factors can be called the mind and the intelligence. The mind impels us toward short-term gratification, whereas the intelligence inspires us toward long-term welfare.

When we are habituated to doing something, our mind functions so rapidly that it impels us to do that thing before our intelligence can evaluate that action. For example, if we are hooked to Facebook, then whenever we feel bored, our mind starts impelling us to browse Facebook even before our intelligence notices what we are doing.

To discipline ourselves, we need to make our intelligence faster than our mind. This means that as soon as our mind proposes that we go to Facebook, our intelligence cross-examines that proposition: "Do I need to do this right now?" Such intelligent scrutiny will ensure that we use social media only when it is necessary or important. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (06.25) urges us to use our intelligence to refocus our mind whenever it wanders.

What if our intelligence is not fast enough?

First, we can study the Gita regularly to sharpen our intelligence. Second, we can use our intelligence beforehand to boost our defenses, maybe by installing apps to help regulate our Facebook usage. Third, we can use our intelligence as soon as it becomes alert; regulating an impulse even partially is an improvement over giving in to it completely.

Each time we use our intelligence to resist our mind, our mind becomes weaker and slower, whereas our intelligence becomes stronger and swifter. Eventually, our intelligence outraces our mind, making disciplining ourselves easier and our endeavors more fruitful.

Think it over

What inner factors shape our actions? How?

How can we make our intelligence faster than our mind?

If our intelligence is not fast enough, what can we do?

06.25 Gradually, step by step, one should become situated in trance by means of intelligence sustained by full conviction, and thus the mind should be fixed on the Self alone and should think of nothing else.

Virtue that is more talked than walked is not necessarily infertile; it may just be infantile

Suppose someone speaks big things, but doesn't live accordingly. We may dismiss their talk as big bluster: "What they speak is infertile – nothing comes out of it."

Actually however, their virtue may just be infantile. Infants sometimes overestimate their abilities; they may believe they can run, but they can merely toddle. Similarly, some adults may overestimate their willpower or underestimate their conditionings. They may sincerely want to live virtuously and may therefore talk about it. But their conditionings may thwart them.

When infants can't run, we don't deride them; we encourage and assist them till they grow and learn. We can be similarly empathic with those who talk about virtue more than walk it. Instead of dismissing their talk as just a show, we can show them the way.

Re-envisioning talk about virtue as infantile, not infertile, can help us in dealing with ourselves too, whenever our actions don't match our aspirations. Instead of dismissing virtue as impractical, we can patiently persevere.

The Bhagavad-gita recommends such patience when it states that we need to focus our mind gradually (06.25). Instead of expecting our mind to focus on virtue just by our declared intention, we can expect it to wander and can be ready to resolutely refocus it (06.26).

Moreover, in bhakti-yoga, which is a time-honored process for self-transformation, talking about virtue can also be a part of walking toward virtue. Talking about the virtues that the devoted manifest can be a glorification of God, Krishna. And glorification is a limb of bhakti. Practicing this limb can purify us and accelerate our growth toward virtue – provided we speak not condescendingly, but aspirationally.

By thus talking about virtue and striving to practice bhakti-yoga, we can all grow toward virtue.

Think it over

How may our talk about virtue be infantile, not infertile?

Seeking talk about virtue as infantile can change our attitude toward such talk. How?

How can talking about virtue also help us walk toward virtue?

06.25 Gradually, step by step, one should become situated in trance by means of intelligence sustained by full conviction, and thus the mind should be fixed on the Self alone and should think of nothing else.

A rigid structure may not work for us, but without a structure, we may not work

We all have various structures that bring order to our daily life. Such structures include rules, customs, routines, schedules and obligations. We may sometimes find such structures restrictive.

While structures can be limiting, they can also be liberating. Suppose we want to travel somewhere. For getting there, a supportive structure is a road: it liberates us from all the worries of going cross country. Such worries may include: Will the terrain ahead be navigable? Are we on the right track? But that same road can limit us if it gets blocked due to heavy traffic or a landslide. Then, we may be better off going cross country.

The various structures in our life are meant to serve as roads for our life-journey. Life can become unlimitedly complex, burdening us with hundreds of choices, right from what time we wake up, what we eat, what we wear and so forth. And as if the complexity of life were not bad enough, our mind complicates even simple things, making us agonize over straightforward choices. That's why we all need some supportive structure to simplify our life. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita stresses that if we wish to control our mind, we absolutely need a supportive structure, that is, an appropriate process (06.36)

Of course, depending on our nature and situations, some structures can become more restrictive than supportive. When some structures start working against us instead of for us, we may need to re-evaluate them, either reforming them or repositioning our relationship with them. But we needn't reject all structures as undesirable.

By focusing on our essential purpose — to better manage our mind and life, and to fulfill our various potentials, material and spiritual — we can judiciously adopt the structures that enable us to manifest our best.

Think it over

How can structures be liberating?

When do structures become limiting?

List three prominent structures in your life. Contemplate how you can ensure that they work for you instead of against you.

06.36 For one whose mind is unbridled, self-realization is difficult work. But he whose mind is controlled and who strives by appropriate means is assured of success. That is my opinion.

To take sole credit for our abilities is to put too much burden on ourselves

Amid life's inevitable struggles, we all seek some abilities that help us thrive or at least survive. When we discover some such abilities, we naturally build our sense of self-worth and even our very identity around those abilities.

Sometimes, however, our abilities seemingly check out. Although we try our best to perform, things just don't work. What do we do amid such incomprehensible incompetence? We may rail in anger or sink into depression. Some Nobel Laureate authors have even committed suicide on finding that they just couldn't replicate their former magic.

If we don't want such negative responses to crush us, we can become more introspective and philosophical. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (07.08) indicates that our abilities are manifestations of Krishna's potency. This means that our abilities are not our entitlements, but are our endowments; they are given to us by divine grace, on a rental basis and can be withdrawn at any moment. And that's what happens to us periodically.

When we thus understand our dependence on a reality beyond ourselves, we stop taking sole credit for our abilities. Understanding that our creative endeavors are cooperative projects is empowering – it frees us from the burden of self-obsession, both positive and negative. We don't become inflated when we rise to excellence or deflated when we fall to mediocrity. Understanding our place and purpose in the overall scheme of things, we keep doing our part in a mood of service.

When abilities seem to stop manifesting, we can humbly persevere as a discipline and as an offering of our dedication to the divine. Then, when abilities do manifest, we can gratefully cherish those moments for increasing not just our material productivity but also our spiritual self-understanding.

Think it over

Why is taking sole credit for our abilities an unbearable burden?

How does Gita wisdom explain our phases of incomprehensible incompetence?

How is seeing creativity as a cooperative project empowering?

07.08 O son of Kunti, I am the taste of water, the light of the sun and the moon, the syllable om in the Vedic mantras; I am the sound in ether and ability in man.

To be dissatisfied with the material is ordinary; to be so dissatisfied
as to look beyond the material is extraordinary

During the course of life, we often feel dissatisfied – with our phone, vehicle, house, salary, looks. Essentially, we feel dissatisfied that some material thing in our life is not as we want it to be.

To remove such dissatisfaction, we usually seek some other material thing: a smarter phone, a faster vehicle, a bigger house. Such material improvement can help, if it changes a situation from unbearable to bearable. Still, it can't resolve dissatisfaction fundamentally.

Why not? Because no matter how many material things we improve, the material world still remains a temporary place with finite resources. Here, we can fulfill our worldly desires only partially and only till disease, debility and death descend upon us.

How, then, can dissatisfaction be uprooted? By seeking something beyond the material.

Gita wisdom explains that we are at our core non-material beings. We are parts of the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna, who is the reservoir of all happiness. Everything attractive manifests a spark of his supreme attractiveness (Bhagavad-gita 10.41). The satisfaction coming from any material thing is like the illumination provided by a spark, whereas the satisfaction coming from Krishna is like the illumination from the sun.

To become convinced that Krishna is the most desirable of all desirable things takes lifetimes of spiritual evolution – indeed, those thus convinced are extraordinary and rare (07.19). Thankfully, we all can progress toward that conviction in this very lifetime if we let Gita wisdom direct our love toward Krishna.

Amid dissatisfaction, will we stay ordinary by seeking something material? Or will we join the extraordinary few who use their dissatisfaction as an impetus to seek the Omni-attractive One beyond the material: Krishna? Our decision will determine our destiny.

Think it over

For dealing with dissatisfaction, how can material improvement help and not help?

How can seeking beyond the material uproot dissatisfaction?

Why is seeking something beyond the material extraordinary?

07.19 After many births and deaths, he who is actually in knowledge surrenders unto Me, knowing Me to be the cause of all causes and all that is. Such a great soul is very rare.

Meditation is not the antithesis of action, it is the basis of action

Some people consider meditation to be a scandalous waste of time. They question dedicated meditators: “How can you waste so much time doing nothing? If you used that time for something practical, you could do so many things.”

Their objection rests on a presumption: that meditation is the antithesis of action, that it takes us away from productive work. However, the productivity of our work depends not just on how long we work but also on how well we work – that is, how we undistractedly focus on the things that matter the most.

When we meditate, though we appear to be doing nothing, we are doing something vital: we are reminding ourselves of life’s most important things; we are reconnecting ourselves with the values and purposes that are sacred to us; we are reorienting toward those things during the rest of our life. While meditation is always helpful in separating the important from the urgent, it is especially powerful in today’s digital world with hundreds of apparently urgent distractions.

Among the many different types of meditations, the most empowering meditation is that which connects us with the most empowering reality: the all-attractive supreme, Krishna. Gita wisdom stresses that he is the being of supreme value, for he underlies everything of value; staying connected with him helps us do things of enduring value. The Bhagavad-gita (08.07) asks us to meditate on Krishna internally while discharging our responsibilities externally. Even those who retreat from the world to a mountain cave for practicing inactive meditation need to eventually come to the level of meditating on Krishna (06.47).

When we thus make meditation the basis of our action, it empowers us to connect with our deepest values and to choose actions that create maximum value.

Think it over

While meditating, how are we doing something vital?

Which meditation is the most empowering?

How is meditation the basis of action?

08.07 Therefore, Arjuna, you should always think of Me in the form of Krishna and at the same time carry out your prescribed duty of fighting. With your activities dedicated to Me and your mind and intelligence fixed on Me, you will attain Me without doubt.

Our deepest desires should direct us from within, not disappear within

Suppose we have something precious that we are afraid of losing. We may keep it carefully, deep inside a secret safe. However, if we don't use it regularly or at least remember it regularly, we may get so caught up in other things as to forget where we kept it. By thus losing access to it, we may unwittingly lose it for all practical purposes.

We may similarly forget our treasured desires. Usually, we have many desires that exist at different levels in our consciousness. Some desires are superficial and circumstantial, such as longing for a trinket we saw on TV. Some desires are sacred and central to who we are or at least to who we want to be, such as desires for our spiritual growth. Unfortunately, such cherished desires may not be appreciated or even understood by the people around us. Therefore, we may keep those desires secretly inside us. However, our many surface desires may consume our consciousness so much that our deepest desires may disappear within us.

What can we do to prevent such unfortunate misdirection? Prioritize conscientiously.

The Bhagavad-gita's eighth chapter underscores the need for such prioritization. First, it (08.05) reminds us of what matters the most: remembering the all-attractive Whole, Krishna, at the time of death, thereby attaining him for an eternal life of love. In fact, whatever we remember at death, we attain that after death (08.06). To ensure that we don't get so caught in our surface desires that we remember those desires at death, we need to practice remembering Krishna throughout our life (08.07). By such regular remembrance, our deepest desires will direct us from within, shaping our choices so that we progress steadily toward life's supreme attainment.

Think it over

How may we lose something precious?

How may our deepest desires disappear within us?

How can we ensure that our deepest desires direct us?

08.07 Therefore, Arjuna, you should always think of Me in the form of Krishna and at the same time carry out your prescribed duty of fighting. With your activities dedicated to Me and your mind and intelligence fixed on Me, you will attain Me without doubt.

We can't avoid being pushed by time, but we can choose where we are pushed by time

Just as leaves fallen in an ocean are pushed inexorably by waves, we are pushed inexorably by time toward death. Does that mean we are hopelessly doomed, living pointlessly till death does us in? No, we can choose where we are pushed by time.

To utilize this choosing capacity, we need to understand our present existence as bi-dimensional: body and soul. The soul's defining energy is consciousness. As long as our consciousness is attached to our material body and to material things connected with the body, we experience death as a trauma directly befalling us. But the more our consciousness becomes attached to spiritual reality – ultimately, the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna – the more we realize and relish our identity as indestructible beings, different from our material shells that are tossed helplessly by time.

How can we become attached to Krishna? By practicing bhakti-yoga centered on remembering him. Through lifelong bhakti practice, if by the time of death our attachment to Krishna has come to supersede our worldly attachments, we will remember him at that fateful moment. And what we remember at death – matter or spirit – determines what we attain after death: material entanglement or spiritual liberation.

To prepare for that test at death, the Bhagavad-gita (08.07) enjoins us to cultivate Krishna's remembrance throughout our life. When we thus practice bhakti, our body will still be pushed by time toward deterioration and destruction. But our soul – we ourselves – will simultaneously be pushed toward elevation and liberation.

If we conscientiously use the time we have to push our consciousness toward Krishna, then the flow of time will push us toward Krishna.

Think it over

Explain metaphorically why we can't avoid being pushed by time.

How can we choose where we are pushed by time?

Based on your current consciousness, what will you probably remember at death?

08.07 Therefore, Arjuna, you should always think of Me in the form of Krishna and at the same time carry out your prescribed duty of fighting. With your activities dedicated to Me and your mind and intelligence fixed on Me, you will attain Me without doubt.

Our future is shaped not so much by how many options we have as by how well we choose among the options we do have

We are sometimes constrained by our situations, wherein they leave us with very few options to choose from, be they financial, relational, professional, educational or whatever else. At such times, we may become resentful, especially when we see others who have many more options than we do.

While having more options may increase our freedom, it also increases the burden of choosing: deliberating over all those options is often no easy task. If we don't choose well, we may hurt ourselves. And when we have big options to choose from, the consequences of wrong choices can be catastrophic. Moreover, making a bad choice when we had better alternatives can lead to endless self-flagellation.

Therefore, rather than worrying about getting more options, we can focus on learning how to choose wisely among whatever options we have. If we develop the ability to choose wisely, that ability will empower us to choose wisely whenever in future we have more options to choose from.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (09.06) gives an apt example. The sky limits the area of movement of the air, but doesn't limit the movement itself. Similarly, our situations constrain the scope of our free will, but not our free will itself.

And we can use our free will better if we are not so fixated on our material situation but have developed greater awareness of our spiritual connection with the ultimate reality, Krishna. If we put Krishna first and strive to serve him devotionally, he will guide us to choose wisely (10.10).

By focusing on choosing wisely instead of resenting our lack of options, we all can create a better future for ourselves.

Think it over

How can having too many options be problematic?

What is our free will both limited and not limited? Explain with a Gita example.

How can we use our free will better?

09.06 Understand that as the mighty wind, blowing everywhere, rests always in the sky, all created beings rest in Me.

Experience becomes our best teacher when we experience the Best Teacher

As the common saying goes, experience is the best teacher. But we see so many people who don't learn from experience; they keep repeating the same mistakes.

Most sayings convey broad truths that need to be contextually qualified and nuanced. Experience is the best teacher in the sense that it teaches more effectively than merely hearing or observing; what we undergo, that goes much deeper inside us.

Still, we go through so many experiences in life. Not all of them go equally deep inside us. And that's not undesirable because otherwise we would get totally overwhelmed. We need to know which experiences to bounce off us and which to bind to us – that too is a lesson we can learn from experience.

This discerning capacity is essentially about learning on the move. And such learning during the course of life comes not just by the theoretical knowledge we may have accumulated; it comes by a somewhat mystical presence of mind that enables us to recollect and apply that theoretical knowledge to our life's situations.

Such insights, intuitions and inspirations often come from a divine source, the indwelling manifestation of God within our hearts (Bhagavad-gita 15.15). And we can increase our receptivity to such inner guidance by cultivating a devotional disposition toward God, Krishna. He is the universal teacher, guiding us in a universe that is ultimately meant to function like a university.

By practicing bhakti-yoga, when we experience Krishna's greatness and sweetness, we delight in that divine experience. And that taste is so relishable that we seek it again and again, through our various life experiences. That's how we seek the divine in our experiences and learn to gain divine insights from such experiences.

Think it over

How is experience the best teacher?

Experience is the best teacher – why does this saying need to be nuanced?

How is God the Best Teacher?

10.10 To those who are constantly devoted to serving Me with love, I give the understanding by which they can come to Me.

If we are tormented by strong conscience and weak willpower, the solution is strengthening willpower, not weakening conscience

We all face situations in our life wherein we feel impelled to do things that go against our values and principles. At such times, we often feel tormented because of two factors: our conscience, our inner sense of right and wrong, is strong; and our willpower, our inner power to choose right over wrong, is weak.

To be tormented is never pleasant. We want to get out of that state as quickly as possible. An easy way to get out of that state is by weakening our conscience so that we don't feel bad about our morally inadequate actions. To better contextualize our actions, we could adopt a model of our inner world comprising four quadrants. Those quadrants would be weak conscience and weak willpower; strong conscience and weak willpower; weak conscience and strong willpower; strong conscience and strong willpower.

If we weaken our conscience, we make ourselves defenseless against future temptations and degradations, ending up on a trajectory that is destructive and self-destructive.

Thankfully, we can choose a more constructive approach; we can strengthen our willpower. Gita wisdom helps us strengthen our willpower by linking with the source of all power, the omnipotent supreme, Krishna. Bhakti-yoga is a time-honored process that enables us to connect with Krishna and therein experience higher insight and taste. The Bhagavad-gita (10.10) states that if we strive to serve Krishna in a mood of devotion, he helps us by illuminating our inner world, thereby enabling us to choose wisely.

But doesn't practicing bhakti-yoga require willpower? Yes, it does. Thankfully, bhakti-yoga is an accommodatingly multi-level process, allowing us to connect with Krishna at whatever level is presently practical for us (12.08-12); we can start with whatever willpower we have. And we can use our present willpower most effectively if we use it first not to fight against our lower desires but to connect with Krishna, thereby multiplying our willpower.

Think it over

Why may we feel tormented?

Why is weakening our conscience easy and dangerous?

How can we strengthen our willpower?

10.10 To those who are constantly devoted to serving Me with love, I give the understanding by which they can come to Me.

Time can be a fire in which we burn or a teacher from whom we learn

Time is a formidable, inexorable force that pushes us all towards death when our body will be burnt in the funeral fire. Even if the body is not burnt in our tradition, we will still lose at death everything we have held dear. And that loss will be no less painful than being burnt in a fierce fire.

Depicting this scary reality, the Bhagavad-gita in its eleventh chapter describes the kala-rupa, the manifestation of the divine as all-devouring time (11.32). The mouth of this fierce form emanates fire and engulfs everyone, thereby driving home the ultimate futility of all material pursuits.

The temporariness of the material is meant to provoke within us existential questions: “What actually lasts? What really matters? What is life meant for?” These questions point us towards life’s spiritual side, as revealed in wisdom-texts such as the Bhagavad-gita. Unfortunately, most of us don’t ponder existential questions; we prefer to live in denial of death, enjoying worldly pleasures.

When a student is not interested in an important subject, a good teacher does whatever is necessary to kindle that student’s interest. Similar is the purpose of the supreme teacher, Krishna, in his form as time. When he teaches the Bhagavad-gita, not many of us are interested. To trigger our interest, he as time depicts graphically the ephemerality of everything material. Even if we don’t see the kala-rupa, we can see time’s destructive power all around us. Time makes smooth faces shriveled, powerful physiques paraplegic and sharp brains senile.

The more we learn from Krishna as time the ultimate futility of the material, the more we open ourselves to Krishna as the speaker of the Gita and as our inner guide. And he leads us to the unending serenity of the spiritual.

Think it over

How is time like a fire?

How is time like a teacher?

How do Krishna as time and Krishna as our spiritual guide teach together?

11.32 The Supreme Personality of Godhead said: Time I am, the great destroyer of the worlds, and I have come here to destroy all people. With the exception of you [the Pandavas], all the soldiers here on both sides will be slain.

On some days, in some ways, we all can make a difference —
provided we try

During our lives, we sometimes wonder, “Whatever I do, does it count? Does even my existence count?” Especially when we try to do something good and it doesn’t produce any noticeable result, we may feel discouraged: “Whatever I am doing is so tiny. Does it have any value in this big bad world?”

Yes, it does. The Bhagavad-gita explains we are parts of a reality far bigger than ourselves — the ultimate reality, Krishna. We are not destructible bags of matter hurtling from birth to death in a meaningless journey. We are indestructible souls on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution. As parts of the divine, we are meant to become channels of his light to shine through us. We are all called to become instruments of the divine (11.33).

When we connect with him through devotion and contribute on his behalf through dedication, we all can make a difference. Given that the world is so big and we so small, the difference we make isn’t seen on most days. Still, on some days, in some ways, we get some evidence that we have made a difference.

On other days, inner impurities and outer insecurities overwhelm us so much that they block out all inner light, leaving us disheartened. On these dark days, we need to draw light by remembering the moments when our efforts have made a difference.

Such recollection rejuvenates us and energizes us to re-affirm our connection with the divine. Ultimately, that connection is what will lift us out of all darkness and enable us to help others too. Taking whatever steps we can to establish that inner connection is the ultimate difference we all can and should make.

Think it over

What makes us doubt the value of our existence and endeavors?

How does Gita wisdom affirm our potency to make a difference?

During your nights of doubt, what memories can you draw on to dispel that darkness?

11.33 Therefore get up. Prepare to fight and win glory. Conquer your enemies and enjoy a flourishing kingdom. They are already put to death by My arrangement, and you, O Savyasaachi, can be but an instrument in the fight.

What we achieve depends on not just how we strive but also on what we believe

Some people think, “If you just work hard, you can achieve anything.” However, many people work hard throughout their lives, but still don’t achieve their dreams. Why? Because what we achieve depends not just on our outer actions, but also on our inner convictions. Apart from working hard to achieve something, we also need to believe strongly that we can achieve it.

Significantly we need to believe not just strongly, but also correctly. If we simplistically believe that we can achieve anything we want, we are essentially believing that we are omnipotent, that we are God. That belief is an illusion that gets exposed when we try to resist a strong call of nature.

Gita wisdom helps us align our beliefs with reality. It explains that we are souls who are parts of God. He wants us to evolve toward ultimate fulfillment by connecting with him through inner recollection and outer contribution. To this end, we all have been given certain interests and abilities. Using such gifts, when we wholeheartedly strive to contribute with him in a mood of service, we find ourselves empowered to do things that would have been otherwise impossible for us. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (11.33) urges Arjuna to act, assuring that divine arrangement will clear his path.

Still, even if we have both a service attitude and a belief that we will be empowered by God, that doesn’t make us God; it doesn’t mean that we will achieve all our dreams. But such devotional conviction empowers us to strive wholeheartedly and to attract providence, thereby increasing our chances of success. More importantly, that conviction empowers us to persevere, irrespective of success or failure, till we achieve loving, lasting absorption in God. And such absorption is life’s supreme achievement.

Think it over

Can we achieve whatever we want merely by striving? Explain.

If we believe strongly, can we achieve whatever we want? Explain.

How does devotional conviction empower us?

11.33 Therefore get up. Prepare to fight and win glory. Conquer your enemies and enjoy a flourishing kingdom. They are already put to death by My arrangement, and you, O Savyasaci, can be but an instrument in the fight.

Humility frees us from dependence on our own power and grants us access to God's power

Some people think of humility as weakness, "If I am humble, people will walk all over me."

Such an understanding arises from a misunderstanding of humility. Actual humility is not about looking down at ourselves but about looking up at something bigger than ourselves.

When we face challenges in life, especially challenges that are beyond us to face on our own, we learn the power of humility. If we aren't humble, we are left with nothing except our own inadequate power. But if we are humble, we can seek help from some power bigger than ourselves. The biggest such power is God, Krishna. And humility frees us from self-consciousness and empowers us to rise to God consciousness.

At the start of the Bhagavad-gita, Arjuna was trying to figure out the right course of action using his own intellectual power. And despite his many glorious abilities, he couldn't decide; he ended up so confused that he cast aside his bow in discouragement (01.46).

Thankfully however, he had the humility to seek guidance from Krishna by surrendering to him (02.07). And then, he found an entire universe of meaning opening before him through the message of the Gita. When he used his intelligence to understand that message, the expanded perspective illumined and empowered him so much that he became free from all confusion (18.73) Thus, Arjuna's example demonstrates the Gita's teaching (13.08) that humility is the doorway to knowledge.

We too have access to that knowledge not just by studying the Gita but also by connecting with Krishna within our heart by practicing bhakti-yoga and getting guidance from within (10.10).

To summarize, humility doesn't take away whatever power we already have; it helps us use that power to access a far greater power that empowers us to face life's challenges.

Think it over

What is actual humility?

How did humility empower Arjuna?

How can humility empower us?

13.08 Humility; pridelessness; nonviolence; tolerance; simplicity; approaching a bona fide spiritual master; cleanliness; steadiness; self-control; ... [– all these I declare to be knowledge].

Attachment makes us psychologically stiff, detachment makes us psychologically flexible

A tree that is stiff breaks when battered by strong storms, but a flexible tree survives. What applies to trees also applies to us.

We all have our attachments. These make us want and demand that things should be done in particular ways or that people should act in particular ways. But our expectations and demands are often thwarted by the way the world works. And such twists and turns of life can seem stormy to us. Indeed, most of the emotional trauma that we undergo during life's ups and downs is not so much due to those events themselves as due to our attachments. Such attachments make us psychologically stiff, unable to cope with life's uncertainties.

The Bhagavad-gita (13.10) mentions that detachment is a characteristic of those in knowledge. One purpose of knowledge is to enable better functioning. If we know someone well, we can anticipate their behaviors and mood swings, and mold our work accordingly. Similarly, if we know the nature of reality, we can live with it better. And undeniable is the reality that we have only limited control over things. We may have the best of intentions and plans, but reality can upend them all in one moment. Only if we are detached can we be flexible enough to accept reality and find a way that works in the changed reality.

Ultimately, the best way to cultivate detachment from the world is to cultivate attachment to the overseer of the world, Krishna. If we stay connected with him, we experience inner security and stability, thereby increasing our capacity to face outer change.

When we give up our attachment to doing things our way, we often become more receptive to other ways of getting those things done. Such flexibility makes us more resourceful in executing our responsibilities. Thus, paradoxically, attachment impedes us in being responsible, whereas detachment helps us act more responsibly.

Think it over

How does attachment make us stiff?

What is the best way to cultivate detachment?

How does detachment help us become more responsible?

13.10 ... Detachment; freedom from entanglement with children, wife, home and the rest, even-mindedness amid pleasant and unpleasant events; ... [– all these I declare to be knowledge].

Don't let the craving for clarity distract us from working with whatever clarity we have

Suppose we are driving through a storm. If water, sleet and dust obscure our front window, we will keep navigating the car with whatever clarity we have. Though we would long for clarity, we won't make our driving conditional to clarity. We won't crave so much for clarity as to be blinded by demanding its presence or by resenting its absence.

We need to be similarly pragmatic when driving our body-mind vehicle. During our life-journey, external difficulties or internal dilemmas may steal our clarity about what to do, why and how. As clarity can help us function optimally, we can seek it. But seeking clarity shouldn't morph into compulsive craving for clarity or relentless resentment about its absence. Why not? Because compulsive craving characterizes the mode of passion, and relentless resentment characterizes the mode of ignorance. And both these lower modes alienate us from the mode of goodness, which is characterized by clarity (Bhagavad-gita 14.11).

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (14.22) recommends that we unemotionally observe the arrival and departure of the various modes in our consciousness. For such detached observation, we need to identify ourselves as souls who are situated above the arrival and departure of the various modes, including the mode of goodness. That is, when the mode of goodness departs, taking clarity with it, we needn't crave obsessively for it, thereby degrading our consciousness to the mode of passion. Instead, we can use spiritual knowledge and practices to rise above the modes to transcendence and strive to do our duty in a devotional mood, using whatever clarity we have. By such devotional diligence, our consciousness will become purified and elevated above the fluctuations of the modes. And then clarity will return – not the short-lived clarity coming from the mode of goodness, but the long-lived clarity coming from spiritual purity.

Think it over

What is the problem with a craving for clarity?

How can we observe the modes dispassionately?

How can clarity come to us sustainably?

14.22 He who does not hate illumination, attachment and delusion when they are present or long for them when they disappear; ... [– such a person is said to have transcended the modes of nature].

Even if your better choices don't create a better world, they will
create a better you

The daily news of destruction, deceit and death can dishearten us: “In this big bad world, I am so tiny; I can't make any difference.”

Actually, we can – provided we understand our place and purpose in the world.

Gita wisdom states that we are not the world's problem-solver – we are parts of the ultimate problem-solver, Krishna (Bhagavad-gita 15.07). This implies that we haven't been tasked with the responsibility to solve the world's problems; we are tasked only with the responsibility to play our part in a mood of service to Krishna. Once we appreciate our foundational purpose, we connect devotionally with him. By that connection, we gain strength to resist the wild whims of our mind and senses, which can otherwise get us into big trouble. In fact, the world's problems frequently originate in people who are misled by their mind and senses.

Moreover, when we choose to connect with Krishna, we evolve spiritually, growing in our capacity to learn and love. Thereby, we become more equipped to make overall better choices. Thus, even if whatever we do seems insignificant, our better choices have at least one significant effect: they make us better.

When we focus on self-improvement instead of world-improvement, are we being self-centered? Not if our intent is to change the world by changing that aspect of the world over which we have the most control: we ourselves.

Additionally, while we play our worldly roles in devotional consciousness as Krishna's parts, he may empower us to make a bigger difference than what was possible with our under-evolved consciousness.

When we thus understand that our choices matter, we determinedly make the choices that first make us better and second make us better positioned to make the world better.

Think it over

With regard to solving the world's problems, what is our place and purpose in the world?

How does connecting with Krishna make us better?

While focusing on improving ourselves, how can we not be self-centered?

15.07 The living entities in this conditioned world are My eternal fragmental parts. Due to conditioned life, they are struggling very hard with the six senses, which include the mind.

To put yourself together, put aside the things that pull you apart

Suppose we are driving and come across an intersection with many roads ahead. We need to choose the road that takes us to our destination.

In our inner world, we are at such an intersection almost constantly, for we need to choose what we focus on at every moment. In our consciousness, many perceptions enter from external stimuli through our senses, and many recollections arise from past impressions in our mind. All these become the myriad options that compete for our attention. And they compete not just by presenting themselves as passive pathways for our consciousness to travel on, but also as active allurements that pull our consciousness toward them. Thus do many things pull us apart in our inner world. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (15.07) indicates that we struggle, being dragged here and there by our mind and senses.

To do anything worthwhile, we need to focus our consciousness constructively, consistently, carefully. Our consciousness is like a flashlight. If its light is dissipated over a hundred things, we can't see anything clearly. Similarly, if our consciousness gets dissipated by random perceptions and recollections, our life ends up distracted, dissipated, even dissolute. Why dissolute? Because if we are indiscriminate about what we dwell on, those objects of contemplation will eventually exert a gravitational pull strong enough to drag us down to degradation and depravity. That's why we need to turn away from the many things that turn us away from the things important for us.

We can best put ourselves together by putting ourselves with Krishna. He is the whole whose parts we are eternally. Because he is all-attractive, all-powerful and all-pure, focusing on him weakens the forces that pull us apart.

When we thus put ourselves together, the resulting steady focus helps us become intelligently purposeful and meaningfully productive.

Think it over

In our inner world, how are we at an intersection at each moment?

If we let ourselves be pulled apart, what is the result?

How can we best put ourselves together?

15.07 The living entities in this conditioned world are My eternal fragmental parts. Due to conditioned life, they are struggling very hard with the six senses, which include the mind.

When a danger is less visible, it leaves us more vulnerable

If we are afflicted by some disease with visible symptoms such as TB, we would seek diagnosis and treatment. But suppose we are afflicted by some disease without any visible symptoms such as cancer. Externally, we might seem normal, but internally cancer might be wrecking our body.

Less visible dangers leave us more vulnerable – this principle applies also to spiritual dangers. Major dangers on the spiritual path are attachments that divert us from Krishna and degrade us to sensuality, immorality, even perversity.

Some attachments have visible effects. Suppose someone becomes an alcoholic. To drink alcohol, they need to physically go to particular places such as bars. After they become drunk, their behavior changes perceptibly – their mouth smells, they speak incoherently, they move unsteadily.

But some attachments have hardly any visible effects. Suppose someone consumes inappropriate sensual images with their eyes. As these images are readily available by a few clicks on regularly used devices, they don't need to physically go out of their way to indulge. Also, even if they are addicted to such visual consumption, their behavior may not change noticeably. But internally, it will damage their capacity for healthy relationships, distort their values and doom them spiritually.

To detect diseases with no visible symptoms, we need regular medical checkups. Similarly, to detect indulgences whose dangers are less visible, we need to undergo regular spiritual checkups. Spiritual checkup means that we study scripture regularly and examine our consciousness critically. With the eye of spiritual knowledge (Bhagavad-gita 15.10), we can see how we are materially attached and where we are spiritually headed, thereby doing course correction as necessary.

When we learn to periodically test our consciousness with the light of scripture, we can protect and promote our spiritual health.

Think it over

How are we medically more vulnerable to less visible diseases?

How are we spiritually more vulnerable to less visible attachments?

How can we detect and correct less visible attachments?

15.10 The foolish cannot understand how a living entity can quit his body, nor can they understand what sort of body he enjoys under the spell of the modes of nature. But one whose eyes are trained in knowledge can see all this.

To be brave, we don't need to be free from fear; we just need a purpose bigger than fear

Whenever we are called to do something difficult and dangerous, we may feel apprehensive and think, “As I am feeling so much fear, maybe I am not brave enough to do this.”

However, the brave aren't necessarily free from fear. More fundamentally, freedom from fear is not always desirable. Fear is often a healthy and necessary indicator of danger; it protects us from foolhardiness.

But when fear dominates and paralyzes us, that fear needs to be surmounted. How? By pursuing a purpose bigger than fear.

Suppose we feel afraid to drive in the dark. But suppose a loved one has a medical emergency at night, and we are the only person available to drive them to the hospital. If we focus on the purpose of caring for our loved one, that purposefulness will empower us to brave our fears and drive through the dark.

We all can acquire a purpose bigger than fear by studying Gita wisdom. It explains that we are souls on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution toward Krishna, the all-attractive Supreme. Every situation we face, no matter how it has circumstantially originated and how scary it appears, is a step in that evolution.

Moreover, if we strive to evolve, our omnipotent, omnibenevolent Lord, Krishna, is always with us. And he is eager to empower us if we take up the baton of serving him.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (16.01) states that godly people, who are convinced about these spiritual truths, can push on despite their fears .

The Gita stands ready to empower all of us with a purpose that dwarfs fear.

Think it over

How can we be brave even if we aren't free from fear? Explain with an example.

How does Gita wisdom provide us a purpose bigger than fear?

Which fear most often holds you back? What purpose is bigger than that fear for you?

16.01 The Supreme Personality of Godhead said: Fearlessness; purification of one's existence; cultivation of spiritual knowledge; charity; self-control; performance of sacrifice; study of the Vedas; austerity; simplicity ... these transcendental qualities, O son of Bharata, belong to godly men endowed with divine nature.

Intelligence is meant to be the mind's instructor, not its instrument

We all have within us something that is impulsive and something that is reflective. Gita wisdom identifies the impulsive part as the mind and the reflective part as the intelligence. To function constructively, our intelligence needs to be our mind's instructor; it needs to review, regulate and redirect our mind's impulses.

Unfortunately however, the mind can sometimes overpower the intelligence and impel us to act short-sightedly. While the mind's pushing aside the intelligence is dangerous, far more dangerous is the mind's taking over the intelligence. Why more dangerous? Because when the mind sidelines the intelligence, we become hot-headed; whereas when the mind takes over the intelligence, we become cold-blooded. That is, we do wrong things slyly so that we can cover our tracks; we even congratulate ourselves for being so clever as to have gotten away with our wrongdoings. When the intelligence is reduced to the role of the mind's instrument, all its intellectual power gets abused in justifying and executing the mind's schemes.

Such inner role reversal characterizes demonic people, as depicted in the Bhagavad-gita (16.13). The demonic scheme to earn more and more money, which might sound like just normal human greed. However, such people go down from being merely covetous to becoming remorselessly murderous; they conspire to assassinate their rivals and delight in the success of their diabolical designs (16.15).

Even if we never do such things, we all are prone to the danger of our intelligence being taken over by the mind. How can we prevent such inner role reversal? First, weaken our mind by minimizing exposure to the stimuli that feed its impulses; second, strengthen our intelligence by studying the Bhagavad-gita; and third, purify ourselves of our lower impulses by connecting with all-pure Krishna.

Think it over

What is the healthy relationship between the intelligence and the mind?

Why is the mind's taking over the intelligence more dangerous than its pushing aside the intelligence?

How can we preserve our inner balance of power?

16.13 The demoniac person thinks: “So much wealth do I have today, and I will gain more according to my schemes. So much is mine now, and it will increase in the future, more and more.”

Be terrified about how terrible you can be, to never become that terrible

Suppose we read about some people doing terrible things, such as terrorists murdering innocent people. We may feel revolted, “What kind of human being would do such a thing? I would never do anything like that. That person must be an animal, a beast.”

To feel revolted with revolting actions is desirable: it shows that our conscience is functioning. Still, we need to resist the temptation to otherify the perpetrators of such actions: to treat them like someone who has nothing in common with us, someone who is not even a human being.

Why shouldn't we otherify them? Because we all have two sides: divine and demonic. The same demonic side that impelled them to barbaric actions is also present within us, even if in a much smaller degree. For example, we may have some greed, because of which we may take minor ethical shortcuts to make some quick money. Or we may have some anger, because of which we may bully someone weaker than us. Initially, we may regret such lapses; eventually however, we may become nonchalant about them. Thereafter, when we are sufficiently provoked, our greed or anger might drag us to deeds that we presently find revolting. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (16.14) outlines how the demonic, impelled by greed, plot to eliminate their rivals – and even get a devilish delight in cold-bloodedly eliminating them.

Thus, outer provocation and inner nonchalance can together bring out the beast within us. If we unflinchingly contemplate this possibility, that will terrify us. Then, we will diligently nourish our divine side by connecting devotionally with the supreme divinity, Krishna. When we are steadily absorbed in Krishna, in a mood of service, we can best protect our consciousness from take-over by our demonic side.

Think it over

How may we otherify terrible people?

How may we end up doing the same terrible things that we now find appalling?

How can we protect ourselves from acting terribly?

16.14 The demoniac person thinks: "... He is my enemy, and I have killed him, and my other enemies will also be killed. I am the lord of everything. I am the enjoyer. I am perfect, powerful and happy."

Weakness makes us hotheaded, wickedness makes us cold-blooded

We all sometimes act wrongly. But not all wrong actions are equally serious – they fall at different points on a scale that extends from weakness to wickedness. Where they fall on that scale depends on how they affect our inner defense mechanism.

Our inner defense mechanism is primarily our intelligence and our conscience. Our intelligence reminds us why something is wrong through rational analysis, whereas our conscience serves the same purpose through unpleasant feelings of guilt and remorse.

In those with weaknesses, their lower impulses such as lust, anger or greed sometimes become so strong as to forcefully overpower their inner defense mechanism. But once those impulses subside, that mechanism gets reactivated. Thereafter, when they contemplate their hotheaded actions, they feel ashamed, even appalled.

In contrast, those with wickedness have no inner defense mechanism. By their repeated wrongdoings, their conscience has become deadened; they do wrong nonchalantly, hardly ever feeling bad about it. And their intelligence has been taken over by their impulses. They abuse their intelligence to cold-bloodedly plot their wrongdoings. They plan deliberately to hurt others the most, to avoid getting caught in the process and to be ready with rationalizations if they get caught.

In the weak, the inner defense mechanism is temporarily sidelined, whereas, in the wicked, that mechanism is permanently sabotaged. Like Duryodhana in the Mahabharata, the wicked take a devilish delight in doing terrible things such as murdering their rivals (16.14). They need to be penalized, even neutralized – as was Duryodhana through the Kurukshetra war.

Fortunately, bhakti is so powerful that it can reform everyone – even the wicked, provided they want to be reformed. If we practice bhakti determinedly, then, even if we sometimes act wrongly, still, we can and will become purified (09.30-31). Such is the remarkable redeeming power of Krishna's grace.

Think it over

What is our inner defense mechanism?

How does weakness affect our inner defense mechanism?

How does wickedness affect our inner defense mechanism?

16.14 The demoniac person thinks: "... He is my enemy, and I have killed him, and my other enemies will also be killed. I am the lord of everything. I am the enjoyer. I am perfect, powerful and happy."

When nothing feels filthy, everything may be tidy or everything may be filthy

Suppose we enter a tidy room. If we cast one thing around carelessly, it stands out as an eyesore. But if the whole room is a mess, whatever we cast around is not even noticed. Thus, if nothing feels out of place, it could be because everything is in its place or because everything is out of place.

What applies to physical filth also applies to mental filth. Suppose we see something impure. Normally, we would feel a twinge of conscience. But if we don't, it could mean that our consciousness is filled with so many impurities that this particular impurity doesn't trigger any inner alarm. Thus, if a stimulus doesn't feel impure, that feeling may arise from two possible reasons: it may not be impure or we may be too impure to sense its impurity. To know which, we need to evaluate not just that stimulus, but also the overall state of our consciousness.

What makes such evaluation difficult is that mental dirt can feel the opposite of repulsive: it can seem attractive. For example, when we expose ourselves to sensuality or violence, we feel more attracted to extreme depictions of sensuality and violence. And this applies not just to cultural depictions, but even to our own actions. The Bhagavad-gita (16.14) states that the demonic – those whose minds are filled with filth – delight in violently eliminating their rivals. Rather than finding the thought of killing someone shocking, they find it exciting. Because everything is filthy within them, they find nothing filthy, not even murder.

To evaluate our purity level, we can't rely just on whether anything we perceive presently feels impure. We need an objective moral meter best provided by time-honored wisdom-texts such as the Bhagavad-gita.

Think it over

How does our perception of filth depend on context?

What is a significant difference between physical dirt and mental dirt?

How can we evaluate the purity level of our consciousness?

16.14 The demoniac person thinks: "... He is my enemy, and I have killed him, and my other enemies will also be killed. I am the lord of everything. I am the enjoyer. I am perfect, powerful and happy."

Exploiting others' weaknesses doesn't make us strong; overcoming our own weaknesses does

Some people see the world primarily in terms of power struggles. They center their life on maneuvering and manipulating to get the upper hand over others. To that end, they often zero in on others' weaknesses. And if they succeed in exploiting such weaknesses, they consider themselves smart and strong.

In the Mahabharata, the Kuru king Dhritarashtra had one big weakness: his attachment to his son, the evil Duryodhana. That prince fully exploited his father's weakness, making the latter acquiesce to his various machinations to bring down the Pandavas, the cousins he was envious of. And Duryodhana thought himself brilliant every time he made his father dance to his tune. Though he thought he was becoming stronger by his scheming, what was actually becoming stronger was his envy. Because he was so envious and because he overestimated his strength, he rejected Krishna's most accommodating peace proposal, thereby courting his own destruction in the ensuing Kurukshetra war.

Duryodhana typifies the demonic people, whose mindset is described in the Bhagavad-gita's sixteenth chapter. If their schemes to down others succeed, they think themselves perfect, with no one as good as them – such is their delusion (16.15).

Significantly however, the way to strength is not outward, by exploiting others' weaknesses; it is inward, by overcoming our own weaknesses. How can we go inward? By identification and connection. We need to identify our core, our spiritual essence; and then connect it with the whole: our indwelling Lord, the all-attractive source of all satisfaction. We can best connect with him by practicing bhakti-yoga.

When we become thus connected, we gain the strength to win the most consequential power struggle: the struggle against our own weaknesses. Why is this struggle the most consequential? Because winning it yields the ultimate victory: a life of lasting love and joy.

Think it over

How did exploiting Dhritarashtra's weakness weaken Duryodhana?

How can we become truly strong?

Which is the most consequential power struggle? Why?

16.15 The demoniac person thinks: "... There is none so powerful and happy as I am. I shall perform sacrifices, I shall give some charity, and thus I shall rejoice." In this way, such persons are deluded by ignorance."

Envy targets the envied, but torments the envious

Envy is the inner dark tendency that makes us miserable at others' successes; it impels us to drag them down and plot their destruction.

Envy targets the envied, as seen in how the envious Duryodhana targeted the Pandavas. He envied Yudhishtira's royal position, Bhima's physical power, and Arjuna's peerless archery. Driven by envy, he conspired repeatedly to humiliate and destroy the Pandavas.

But envy's malevolence extends beyond its targets to its hosts. Because of his envy, Duryodhana was not satisfied even when he had deceitfully got the Pandavas' kingdom for himself. While they were living in exile in the forest, he went there to parade his prosperity before them. He wanted to humiliate them by showing them the glaring contrast between his prosperity and their poverty. As fate would have it, his plan boomeranged when he was defeated by celestial beings and had to be rescued by the Pandavas. Those whose humiliation he wanted to see ended up seeing his humiliation.

He could have lived luxuriously in his prosperous kingdom, but envy wouldn't let him live in peace. Envy tormented him so much that he ended up doing something self-destructive. Actually, not just one thing – his whole life was a litany of envy-impelled actions. Envy kept him relentlessly dissatisfied.

If we entertain envy, it will similarly torture us incessantly. By understanding envy's nature, we can become determined to adopt a zero-tolerance approach towards it. The Bhagavad-gita (16.18) indicates that envy towards anyone is ultimately envy towards the all-attractive supreme, Krishna. Whatever opulence anyone has is a spark of Krishna's supreme opulence (10.41).

When we practice bhakti-yoga and start relishing Krishna's glories, we learn to see others' opulence devotionally: instead of being reminded of our inferiority, we are reminded of our Lord's glory. By such redirection, our devotion intensifies, and envy decreases and disappears.

Think it over

How did envy torment Duryodhana?

How can we get the impetus to stop entertaining envy?

How can we cure envy by bhakti?

16.18 Bewildered by false ego, strength, pride, lust and anger, the demons become envious of the Supreme Personality of Godhead, who is situated in their own bodies and in the bodies of others, and blaspheme against the real religion.

To understand what is wrong with the world, look first in the mirror, not in the newspaper

When we hear about the many things wrong in the world, we may feel distressed and disheartened. To make sense of things, we may read newspaper editorials. While such reading may offer useful social analysis, that won't empower us as much as if we look in the mirror, that is, take a hard look at ourselves. Let's see how.

The world's major problems originate in common human impurities such as lust, anger and greed. Lust impels sexual crimes, anger impels violent crimes, and greed impels financial crimes. When people give in to these impurities to an extreme degree, their actions become grisly newspaper headlines. Such crimes need to be corrected by the government. If we have the power and the zeal to bring about such corrective action, we can and should do so.

While such administrative punitive intervention may be necessary, it is never sufficient. As long as people remain controlled by their impurities, they will do wrong and will make things worse. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita cautions that lust, anger and greed make life hellish (16.21), and assures that those who steer clear of these impurities can act constructively (16.22). Therefore more important than governmental legislation is individual purification.

And such purification can begin with ourselves. A hard look at ourselves will show us how we too are infected by these impurities and how they impel us to wrongdoings, even if minor. By purifying ourselves of these impurities, if we become as good as we can be or even if we become slightly better than what we are, we can act as small but significant change agents. Further, if we connect with the all-pure divine, Krishna, he may empower us beyond our present capacities to help raise human consciousness, thereby bringing about effective, enduring change.

Think it over

Where do the world's major problems originate?

For becoming change agents, how can looking in the mirror empower us more than looking in the newspaper?

How can we become effective change agents?

16.22 The man who has escaped these three gates of hell, O son of Kunti, performs acts conducive to

self-realization and thus gradually attains the supreme destination.

Words are not just vehicles of thought, but also engines of thought

We often think of words as tools for expressing our thoughts. When we expand our vocabulary by memorizing new words, we usually desire to express ourselves better. In this understanding, we see words as vehicles for carrying our thoughts from us to others.

Simultaneously however, words serve another important purpose: they are also engines that animate our thinking process. This role of words can help us appreciate the importance of memorizing and reciting verses, which is recommended as an austerity of speech in the Bhagavad-gita (17.15).

When we recite verses, such recitation doesn't have to remain just a verbal activity – it can also become an intellectual activity and even a spiritual activity. Our thoughts may be wandering, but verse recitation focuses our thought-energy on the meaning of the verses, thereby triggering intellectual activity. And when the verses are filled with spiritual import, especially when they describe the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna, then verse recitation doesn't just trigger spiritual activity; it is intrinsically a spiritual activity. Habitual verse recitation brings scriptural words on our lips and into our ears. From there, those words gain entrance into our consciousness and gradually entrance our consciousness.

Indeed, words are readymade templates for sublimating our thoughts. Once we appreciate this potency of scriptural words, we not only look forward to reciting verses but also take the necessary efforts to memorize them. Why memorize? Because memorization makes these templates constantly accessible to us, serving as ever-ready engines for propelling our consciousness away from worldly illusion toward divine illumination. Therefore, words that convey deep intellectual or spiritual truths are eminently worth churning and cherishing.

When we experience how easily and effectively words sublimate our thoughts, we re-envision verse memorization and recitation as not a religious chore, but as a powerful spiritual engine for elevating our consciousness.

Think it over

How are words engines for thought?

How can verse recitation be an intellectual and spiritual activity?

How is verse memorization helpful?

17.15 Austerity of speech consists in speaking words that are truthful, pleasing, beneficial, and not agitating to others, and also in regularly reciting Vedic literature.

Our intelligence is not like a fixed deposit; it is like a stock market share

Suppose we invest in stocks but think of such an investment to be as stable as a fixed deposit. If the stocks go down, we will lose money. To protect our investment, we need to regularly monitor stock market prices.

If we compare knowledge to wealth, then we often misunderstand the nature of the wealth of spiritual knowledge. When we study the Bhagavad-gita and understand its overall philosophy, we often think that our intelligence has become equipped with Gita wisdom.

However, intelligence is essentially transformational, not informational; it is meant to transform our actions, empowering us to resist our unhealthy impulses and to reinforce our healthy instincts. The Gita (18.30) states that healthy intelligence perceives the consequences of actions and then chooses wisely. Such is intelligence in the mode of goodness. In the mode of passion, our intelligence gets misused to implement our impulses, not to inspect them (18.31). And in the mode of ignorance, our intelligence often rationalizes and glamorizes our unhealthy impulses, thereby totally misleading us (18.32).

Just as the modes influencing us keep changing, so too does our intelligence keep changing. That's why the wealth of our intelligence is not like a fixed deposit – it is not determined by the spiritual information we have, but by the spiritual inclination we have. And as such inclination is shaped by the changing modes, our intelligence is like a volatile stock market share.

We need to monitor our intelligence regularly – and strengthen it by repeatedly studying the Gita and resiliently striving to live the Gita. Then that intelligence will become like a fixed deposit. Not only that, it will appreciate in value, eventually granting us the return of lasting fulfillment.

Think it over

What is the essence of intelligence?

How is our intelligence like a stock market share?

How can we make our intelligence like a fixed deposit?

18.32 That understanding which considers irreligion to be religion and religion to be irreligion, under the spell of illusion and darkness, and strives always in the wrong direction, O Partha, is in the mode of ignorance.

We rarely do things without a reason, but reason is rarely behind the things we do

Suppose someone does something stupid or terrible. If they are asked why they did what they did, they usually come up with some justification for their actions. Even criminals who do ghastly deeds rationalize their actions. We humans have enough intelligence to justify whatever we want to believe.

We ourselves too come up with reasons to justify whatever actions we do. If we are to truly make wise choices, we need to check if the reasons we give for our actions are actually good. Which reasons are good reasons? Those that are based on sound scriptural understanding. Scripture provides time-honored ethical and spiritual values that help us mold our lives for our all-round growth.

If we aren't scripturally guided, we often use our intelligence to arrive at understandings that are actually misunderstandings. By such misunderstanding, we come up with unreasonable reasons. These are reasons that can make sense if we want them to make sense, but they don't add sense; they don't make us more sensible. And they don't add value to our life – they make us fritter away our precious time in activities that are at best frivolous and at worst disastrous.

The Bhagavad-gita (18.32) states that the intelligence which foists and fosters misunderstanding is intelligence in the mode of ignorance. To avoid such misunderstandings, we need to raise our consciousness from the lower modes of ignorance to the higher mode of goodness and beyond it to transcendence, whereby whatever intelligence we have is used constructively, not destructively.

When we study and live scripture, our intelligence becomes spiritually oriented, thereby ensuring that the reasons we come up with are not just sensible but also positively transformational.

Think it over

How do we come up with unreasonable reasons for our actions?

What reasons for our actions are good reasons?

How can we ensure that our reasons for our actions are good reasons?

18.32 That understanding which considers irreligion to be religion and religion to be irreligion, under the spell of illusion and darkness, and strives always in the wrong direction, O Partha, is in the mode of ignorance.

Accepting our weaknesses takes courage and so does accepting ourselves with our weaknesses

Life's battles often expose our weaknesses. Accepting those weaknesses can make us feel unsafe, undermined and unworthy. Recoiling from such threatening feelings, we often try to find some scapegoat and deny our weaknesses.

However, denying our defects is cowardly. It takes courage to confront ourselves, to take responsibility for the things that are wrong with us and to strive to fix them as much as possible.

Though self-confrontation is essential for any positive self-transformation, we can't let self-confrontation veer to the other extreme of self-condemnation, wherein we consider our very existence worthless. Such a resentful, fretful approach is also cowardly; if we are worthless, we don't need to even try to improve ourselves; we can conveniently avoid facing our demons. An excessively negative mentality – filled with fear, lamentation and moroseness – is typical of the mode of ignorance (Bhagavad-gita 18.35).

Put succinctly, believing we are flawless characterizes the mode of passion; believing we are worthless characterizes the mode of ignorance.

Healthy self-acceptance begins with appreciating that we are our only resource; we can't get an alternative to our present body-mind machine. Suppose we were being attacked, and had only a heavy and rusty gun. We would need to both accept the gun's limitations and accept the gun with its limitations. Failure to accept either could be fatal. Similarly, if we are to do anything worthwhile with our life, we need to accept our weaknesses and accept ourselves with our weaknesses.

Such healthy self-acceptance becomes easier when we understand our core spirituality. Below the weaknesses that beset our body and mind, we all are pure souls – we are parts of God, with an innate potential for godliness. Disconnection from God is the root cause of our weakness. When we courageously reconnect with him through devotion, we become purified, guided and empowered to manifest our best.

Think it over

Why is refusing to accept our weakness cowardly?

Why is refusing to accept ourselves with our weakness also cowardly?

What two understandings can foster healthy self-acceptance?

18.35 And that determination which cannot go beyond dreaming, fearfulness, lamentation, moroseness and illusion – such unintelligent determination, O son of Prutha, is in the mode of darkness.

See memory not as an exhaustive guide to the past, but as a constructive guide from the past to the future

We usually think of memory as a tool to remember the past. Actually however, the past is too vast to be remembered entirely or accurately. Consider one incident. It is often remembered differently by different people. Even the same person may remember it differently at different times. If we start thinking of our memory as an exhaustive guide to the past, we can get caught endlessly in the past.

In fact, some people get caught like that. They endlessly replay past events. And they keep doing inconclusive post-mortems of who did what and what could have been done instead. The Bhagavad-gita (18.35) cautions against such self-destructive mental patterns centered on fearing, lamenting and resenting – all these point to a consciousness steeped in ignorance, specifically ignorance about the nature of memory.

To use our memory constructively, we need to primarily look ahead, not behind. What's happened has already happened. What we can do is learn, as much as possible, to prevent the recurrence of the unwanted past.

To learn from the past without being consumed by negativity, we need to first raise our vision to the one who reigns above the past, the present and the future: Krishna. He can bring good even out of the bad, provided we do our part in the present. However dark our past, we can still have a rich life of loving service to him. And for such a life of service, our memory is meant to be a facilitator, not an impedier.

With this vision of service, we re-envision memory not as a torch that shows us the past, but as a torch that is fueled by insights from the past for seeing the future more clearly.

Think it over

What goes wrong if we see memory as an exhaustive guide to the past?

How can focusing on Krishna help us to learn from the past?

How does bhakti vision help us re-envision the role of memory?

18.35 And that determination which cannot go beyond dreaming,
fearfulness, lamentation, moroseness
and illusion – such unintelligent determination, O son of Prutha,
is in the mode of darkness.

We can never start in our life unless we start with our life

Suppose we wanted to walk somewhere, but somehow took several wrong turns and ended up far away from our destination. To get there, we will need to start from where we are, not from where we think we should have been.

The same principle applies to our life-journey too. To start in our life means to begin moving in our life toward some worthwhile purpose. To start with our life means to begin that journey by accepting our present state without denial or resentment.

If we stay in denial, refusing to accept the things that are wrong about us, then, metaphorically speaking, our feet are way above the ground; we can't take solid steps toward any destination. Veering to the other extreme, if we become resentful, we keep mentally beating ourselves and burying ourselves in the ground; we are left with little energy to move forward.

To bring about self-transformation, we need to begin with self-acceptance. Unfortunately, we can't accept ourselves because of self-defeating thought-patterns such as daydreaming and resentfulness, which characterize the mode of ignorance (Bhagavad-gita 18.35).

How can we learn to accept ourselves? First, by understanding that we are our only resource. If we don't accept ourselves, we leave ourselves resource-less for the task of changing ourselves. The more we accept ourselves, the more we – that is, our inner energies – become available for working on self-transformation.

Second, by raising our vision from ourselves, with all our imperfections, to our source: Krishna, who is pure and perfect. He accepts us, as we are. Despite our many wrongs, past and present, he stays with us in our heart. If he can accept us as we are, why can't we?

When we thus cultivate self-acceptance and start working with our present life, we pave the way toward a better life.

Think it over

What are the two attitudes that obstruct self-acceptance?

How can we learn to accept ourselves?

Which aspect of yourself do you struggle to accept? How does that impede your transformation?

18.35 And that determination which cannot go beyond dreaming, fearfulness, lamentation, moroseness

and illusion – such unintelligent determination, O son of Prutha, is in the mode of darkness.

When we limit our challenges, we can challenge our limits

Suppose an army is fighting a multifront war against a formidable enemy. For the army to succeed or even survive, it needs to limit the fronts on which it fights. Otherwise, it will be stretched too thin and may well be defeated on all fronts. Instead, if it chooses the fronts that are most critical or most winnable, it can dramatically improve its prospects.

During our life, we all face multiple challenges. We have things we need to improve, things we can improve, things we want to improve. But we can't fight on all those fronts simultaneously, lest we be overwhelmed. When we limit our challenges, prioritizing those areas that are most important or most improvable, we can take tangible positive steps in those areas, thereby challenging those limits.

Pertinently, the traditional system of social organization, named varnashrama, was meant to provide people with challenges that would harmonize with their basic psychophysical nature (Bhagavad-gita 18.41). In keeping with that spirit, we too need to limit our challenges to those areas that are natural for us.

How can we identify those areas? We can begin by observing ourselves and noting down what we're good at and what we feel good doing. When we thus focus on the areas we are competent and comfortable at, we can both make outer contribution and find inner satisfaction.

Ultimately, we can never become materially perfect, but we can become spiritually perfect, realizing and relishing our position as parts of the all-attractive supreme, Krishna. When we limit our challenges in improving our material situation, then we can challenge the limits to our spiritual consciousness. By extending those limits, we can become increasingly absorbed in Krishna. In that divine absorption, we will find the fulfillment that we won't find even if we achieved the impossible by successfully challenging all our limits.

Think it over

How can limiting our challenges help us?

How can we identify the areas natural to us?

How can limiting our challenges maximize our spiritual growth?

18.41 Brahmanas, kshatriyas, vaishyas and shudras are distinguished by the qualities born of their own natures in accordance with the material modes, O chastiser of the enemy.

To be responsible means to stop blaming the outer trigger for the inner trouble

Suppose we feel tempted by someone who wears revealing clothes. Or we feel irritated by someone who behaves in an annoying way. We may blame that person. Such blaming may be easy but it is disempowering. We have only limited control over how people behave. What we can control is how we respond to their behavior.

To be responsible means to recognize that we are response-able, able to choose our responses. What agitates us may be triggered by someone external, but that won't trouble us much if there were no weaknesses inside us, just as merely pressing the trigger of a gun will not harm if the gun isn't loaded with bullets.

The Bhagavad-gita states that those who are intellectually and spiritually evolved — the brahmanas — learn to restrain both their mind and their senses (18.42). To restrain the mind and to be peaceful means that they don't dwell on agitating stimuli; even if such stimuli come within their perception, they don't give undue attention to them, thereby preventing unnecessary agitation. If somehow such stimuli register within them and start agitating them, they still maintain the necessary physical restraint to not let their inner wild emotions express themselves at the level of the senses.

Such capacity for mental and physical restraint centers on understanding that we are souls, who are different from our mind and body. And if we complement this spiritual understanding with a devotional connection to the ultimate spiritual reality, Krishna, then we get the necessary strength to minimize the inner troubles caused by outer triggers.

Still, all such self-reformation begins with putting an end to the blame game and taking responsibility for our emotions and actions, as the Gita calls for in its conclusion: deliberate and do as you desire (18.63).

Think it over

How are external temptations like triggers, not causes?

What does becoming responsible mean?

How can spirituality help us become more responsible?

18.42 Peacefulness, self-control, austerity, purity, tolerance, honesty, knowledge, wisdom and religiousness – these are the natural qualities by which the brahmanas work.

Our expectation that nothing should come in our way, comes in our way

Our culture often glamorizes go-getters who achieve great goals without letting anything come in their way. Captivated by such portrayals, we may resolve to rigidly stick to our dreams and plans, no matter what happens.

But life is tough, being filled with unexpected obstacles. When such obstacles thwart our plans, we may keep pushing on. However, over time, when we hit roadblocks repeatedly, we may become increasingly disheartened and resentful.

Often, what triggers such negativity is not so much the outer obstacles but the inner expectation that those obstacles shouldn't be there. Thus, the more we hold on to unrealistic expectations, the more we increase our negativity.

Should we, then, stop having expectations? No, we just need to expect obstacles too and learn to respond to them resourcefully, not resentfully.

The Bhagavad-gita (18.43) explains that people who get things done are resourceful. Resourcefulness is the ability to improvise and innovate for finding ways around obstacles without becoming unduly attached to predetermined expectations or plans.

How can we become more resourceful? Apart from various specific strategies, we can seek spiritual self-understanding, which can unleash our resourcefulness.

Gita wisdom explains that we are not the Supreme Controller, but are parts of the Supreme Controller. Being finite, we have a finite capacity to control, which we are meant to use to plan and execute our plans. But when things don't go as per our plan, we need to remind ourselves that things are still within the purview of Krishna's plan. And within his plan, we always have roles; if we keep doing our part creatively, he will take care of things.

When we thus understand our place and purpose in the overall scheme of things, we feel inspired to resourcefully keep doing our best, whether things go according to our plan or not.

Think it over

How can our expectations become obstacles?

Do we need to give up all expectations?

How does spiritual self-understanding foster resourcefulness?

18.43 Heroism, power, determination, resourcefulness, courage in battle, generosity and leadership are the natural qualities of work for the kshatriyas.

The world may not value our individuality, but we can and we should

Each one of us is an individual, with our own strengths and weaknesses, interests and blind spots, aspirations and anxieties. The constellation of all these makes us who we are – it underlies our individuality.

Unfortunately, our individuality is threatened by today's culture of machines, mechanical behavior and mechanistic thinking. In workplaces where we interact more with machines than with people, we gravitate toward treating people mechanically and seeing the world mechanistically. This trio of things, doings and thoughts — machines, mechanical behavior and mechanistic thinking — erodes our individuality.

But isn't our individuality fostered by the culture's mantra to "be yourself"? Not necessarily. The culture charts predictable ways to express our individuality: buy, wear and do whatever is fashionable. Those who glamorize such product-centered individuality are commercially driven; for them, we count not as individuals, but merely as statistics to boost their sales scores.

How can we reject such reduction of our individuality to a statistic? By refusing to look at the world for validation, and instead looking within to understand our deepest values and purposes. When we strive to contribute accordingly, we manifest our individuality in a way that fills our heart, not empties our pocket.

To look within, we need spiritual self-understanding. Gita wisdom explains that we are spiritual beings, who are eternal parts of the supreme spiritual being, Krishna. Just as Krishna is a spiritual individual, so are we. Each one of us has been equipped with a psychophysical machine that has its own typical characteristics. The Bhagavad-gita (18.45) urges us to work according to our individual nature; by such individually customized work, we all can attain perfection. When we work in awareness of our indestructible spirituality, the resulting security keeps us purposefully focused, despite the world's temptations.

Being thus focused, we all make valuable contributions, whether the world values them or not.

Think it over

How does the world devalue our individuality?

How can we avoid being reduced to a statistic?

How does spiritual self-understanding foster our individuality?

18.45 By following his qualities of work, every man can become perfect.
Now please hear from Me how this can be done.

Even if we can't change what we live with, we can change what we live for

Suppose we are stuck with a slow, noisy, messy car in a congested and polluted place. If we can't change our place or our car, we may feel helpless. But even in that condition, we can slowly drive our car to a better place.

What applies to driving also applies to living. We are sometimes caught in terrible situations that are unchangeable. Nothing we do seems to be working. If we are not to sink into hopelessness, we need to differentiate between the things we live with and the things we live for.

The things we live with: Life places us among many things that just can't be changed, or at least can't be changed quickly. Such things that we have to live with may include our family situations, our financial levels, our social relations, our physical limitations and our psychological inclinations. Though these define us presently, they don't define us permanently.

The things we live for: These center on our aspirations, which are shaped by our conceptions of our identity and purpose. Gita wisdom expands those conceptions, showing that we aren't prisoners of our situations. It explains that we all are indestructible souls who are parts of the all-loving Supreme, Krishna. He is not a remote principle, but is an indwelling loving person. All situations are opportunities to evolve spiritually, by connecting with him and thereby gaining sublime strength. The more we evolve in our spirituality, the more our consciousness rises above our situations, revealing how we can better deal with those situations (Bhagavad-gita 18.58).

However bleak the things we live with, if we focus on the things we live for, we can create a better future for ourselves.

Think it over

What are some things you have to live with?

What would you like to live for?

How can Gita wisdom help you focus on what you live for, not on what you live with?

18.58 If you become conscious of Me, you will pass over all the obstacles of conditioned life by My grace. If, however, you do not work in such consciousness but act through false ego, not hearing Me, you will be lost.

Seek God's help for doing his will, or you will need his help to get out of the trouble you get into because of not doing his will

Suppose a mildly sick patient has to take a bitter medicine. If they reject that medicine, their sickness will worsen. When they become unbearably sick, they may well be forced to take a more bitter medicine.

Gita wisdom explains that we all are spiritually sick. Though we are eternal spiritual beings, we are seeking happiness in temporary material things because of the disease of misdirected desires. To cure this disease, we need to regulate ourselves according to God's will. His will is revealed through scripture and through the voice of our conscience aligned with scripture.

However, regulating ourselves tastes bitter because it requires us to give up worldly pleasures. And enduring this bitterness seems unnecessary when our disease seems to be mild. Such is the case while we are doing reasonably well materially, as when we are young, healthy and wealthy. But if we don't regulate ourselves, we get increasingly attached and entangled. And eventually, the consequences hit us, as happens when we start losing our material assets due to the inevitable power of time. Then, we find ourselves in such misery that we have to desperately run to God for help.

Therefore, instead of initially rejecting God's will as unpalatable or impractical, we can seek his help for abiding by his will. The Bhagavad-gita (18.58) assures us that if we strive to become conscious of Krishna, we will get the grace and guidance to cross over all obstacles. If we seek to align ourselves with his will by associating with and learning from those devoted to doing his will, regulation will become increasingly doable. And gradually, as we become purified, spiritual life will become increasingly relishable.

Think it over

What is our disease? When does it seem mild?

How does not doing God's will increase our trouble?

How can we ease the difficulty in doing God's will?

18.58 If you become conscious of Me, you will pass over all the obstacles of conditioned life by My grace. If, however, you do not work in such consciousness but act through false ego, not hearing Me, you will be lost.

Self-acceptance should open the door for self-improvement, not shut the door

Today's ultra-competitive, globally-connected world can afflict us with low self-esteem. As the whole world is presented before us for comparison, we can compare ourselves negatively with those who are better than us. Such comparison can make us feel terrible about ourselves: "Whatever I do will never count much; my existence is worthless."

How can we prevent such crippling self-condemnation? By self-acceptance. We need to acknowledge that we are our only resource — if we reject ourselves, we are left with nothing.

Self-acceptance doesn't mean, however, that we consider ourselves perfect as we are. Who among us doesn't have painful inadequacies? To think we are already perfect is an extremist delusion. Such a self-congratulatory notion of self-acceptance shuts the door for self-improvement.

Gita wisdom imbues our self-acceptance with the strong steel of spiritual insight. It explains that our existence has intrinsic value; we are parts of the divine and can be a part of the divine plan for our and others' spiritual evolution; we have the potential to make the world better, or at least to make our own world better.

Even if we have failed to transform ourselves till now, we still have the potential for positive transformation. But this potential has to struggle through the layers of conditionings accumulated through our present and past actions. These conditionings can impel us toward actions that are binding and blinding (Bhagavad-gita 18.60). For the divine potential to surface through our dark conditionings, we need to connect with the indwelling divine (18.61-62).

Thus, self-acceptance means acknowledging that though we have defects and deficiencies, we still have the divine potential that if accessed and unleashed can make our life meaningful and worthwhile. Such self-acceptance can fill our life with hope and energy, opening for us the door for self-transformation and beckoning us to march through.

Think it over

Why is self-acceptance essential? How can it become extremist?

How does Gita wisdom foster self-acceptance?

How can self-acceptance fill us with hope?

18.60 Under illusion you are now declining to act according to My direction. But, compelled by the work born of your own nature, you will act all the same, O son of Kunti.

Regulate emotion with reason, animate reason with emotion

Reason and emotion are two of our fundamental human faculties. By reason, we can be orderly, logical, consistent. By emotion, we can be creative, intuitive, spontaneous.

However, these two faculties are sometimes seen as opposites. We need a balance of both reason and emotion, whereby both these faculties can be channeled for our all-round welfare. Such harmony has two broad features:

Regulate emotion with reason: When emotion becomes dominant, it drives us to bouts of sentimentality that can degenerate into stupidity or even perversity. This happens when emotion is manipulated by self-interested people who whip up mass hysteria to cause riots and even wars. To avoid such emotional extremes, we need to subject emotion to the scrutiny of reason by asking ourselves: does this make sense?

Animate reason with emotion: When reason becomes dominant, it makes us unfeeling, to the extent that we become depersonalized robots; we treat people as tools for getting things done, not as conscious beings. To avoid such depersonalized dealings, we need to permeate reason with emotion by asking ourselves: how will this feel to others?

The Bhagavad-gita demonstrates this balance of reason and emotion. When Arjuna's emotion disorients and disheartens him, Krishna speaks the philosophical message of the Gita to regulate that emotion and to return his focus to his duty. Still, the Gita is not filled with rational arguments alone. Its reason is animated with emotion; Krishna expresses his deep affection and concern for Arjuna especially when he complements his call for deliberation on the metaphysical message (18.63) with an assurance that he will speak the most confidential knowledge because he dearly loves Arjuna and fervently desires his welfare (18.64).

When we share the Gita's message with others, we too can strive to balance reason with emotion, thereby enabling people to turn with both their head and their heart toward Krishna.

Think it over

Why does emotion need to be regulated by reason?

Why does reason need to be animated by emotion?

How does the Gita integrate reason and emotion?

18.64 Because you are My very dear friend, I am speaking to you My supreme instruction, the most confidential knowledge of all. Hear this from Me, for it is for your benefit.

Conscience without intelligence is blunt, intelligence without conscience is numb

Conscience and intelligence are two vital components of our inner defense mechanism. Whenever we feel tempted to do something wrong, conscience deters us through feelings of guilt and intelligence, through rational analysis. Ideally, both conscience and intelligence work together. But when they sometimes get separated, here's what happens

Conscience without intelligence is blunt: Just as a blunt object can't cut through other things, conscience without intelligence can't cut through the misconceptions that impel us to misdeeds. When we have conscience without intelligence, we feel bad on seeing someone doing something wrong. But we can't explain systematically why that thing is wrong. So, we can't bring intellectual conviction to our moral sense, thus blunting our ability to aid others in making good choices. For example, we may innately feel that killing animals to eat them is bad but may struggle to logically explain why it is bad.

Intelligence without conscience is numb: Just as a numb bodily part doesn't feel any sensation, intelligence without conviction doesn't feel any pinch on encountering a misdeed. When we have intelligence without conscience, we may explain rationally, even brilliantly, why something is wrong. Yet we stay unfeeling when that very thing happens in front of us; we have no fervor when communicating moral principles to others. For example, we may insightfully analyze the harms of meat-eating, yet feel nothing on seeing the meat-packing industry flourishing.

The Bhagavad-gita is a handbook for winning the inner war; it strengthens both our intelligence and our conscience. By hearing the Gita (18.73), Arjuna's doubts were dissipated, indicating that he was intellectually convinced. And he became permeated with a divine calmness that enabled him to harmonize his conscience with the divine will.

Thus, by learning and living the Gita, when our conscience and intelligence become aligned, we can ourselves choose wisely and help others to choose wisely.

Think it over

How is conscience without intelligence blunt?

How is intelligence without conscience numb?

How can the Gita strengthen our inner defense mechanism?

18.73 Arjuna said: My dear Krishna, O infallible one, my illusion is now gone. I have regained my memory by Your mercy. I am now firm and free from doubt and am prepared to act according to Your instructions.

Growing through adversities

Even when our eyes are full of tears, we can still choose to be all ears

Sometimes, life afflicts us so grievously that we feel broken, tearful and blinded by confusion and dejection. How can we move ahead when our vision is thus blinded? By seeing with our ears.

Bhagavad-gita demonstrates this principle. At the Gita's start, Arjuna was so overwhelmed by grief that his bow started slipping from his hands (01.28), his eyes became filled with tears (02.01), and he lost the will to do anything (01.46).

However, instead of passively giving in, he consciously turned to Krishna for guidance (02.07). And he heard the Gita's message of immortal love. That message raised his vision above his precarious material situation to his imperishable spiritual essence. As his vision rose, his consciousness expanded so that he could see that despite his frustrating situation, a benevolent divine plan was still operational. By thus situating himself in spiritual understanding received by hearing, he became filled with clarity and energy (18.73).

Amidst tears, we too can become illumined and animated. How? By hearing Krishna's message in the Gita and letting it become our eye for looking ahead. By the Gita's vision, we realize that we as souls are still indestructible and that we are still parts of Krishna, who is always our benefactor. When we practice bhakti-yoga, we become tuned to hear Krishna internally in his Supersoul manifestation. Thereby, despite the darkness around us, we will spot a ray of light and get inspired to move ahead, taking small steps towards a sustainable solution.

Therefore, rather than giving in to our fears, let's be all ears for Krishna. By taking his sublime guidance, cultivating his divine remembrance and sensing his serene presence, our tears and fears will gradually go away, and our way ahead in life will become clear.

Think it over

How did the Gita guide Arjuna?

How can we see with our ears amidst tears?

How will our way ahead become clear?

02.01 Sanjaya said: Seeing Arjuna full of compassion, his mind depressed, his eyes full of tears, Madhusudana, Krishna, spoke the following words.

Amidst unmanageably distressing times, reduce your working frame to manageable units of time

Sometimes, we face such huge distress that everything seems dark. How can we deal with such times?

By reducing our working frame.

If we start thinking about what will happen to us after one year, we will become overwhelmed, paralyzed, paranoid, for the variables and unknowns are too many.

To work constructively, we need to reduce our working frame to manageable units of time such as just one day. We can challenge ourselves, “Yes, this time is tough. But for this one day, can I not freak out, not hyperventilate, not collapse under pressure?” If one day seems too long, we can reduce our working frame to just one hour.

If we try, we can surely keep ourselves together for one hour. And when we do so, we can pause, take a few deep breaths, thank God for keeping us together. When things around us are discouraging, we need to encourage ourselves; we can appreciate ourselves for that hour’s efforts and prepare ourselves for the next hour’s battle.

Gita wisdom can help us reduce our working frame. It reminds us first that everything in the world is temporary, meaning that even the darkest of times are temporary. Second, that we are indestructible souls; we have weathered many storms in the past and we will weather this storm too if we just tolerate (02.14). And helping us weather such storms is the Supreme Being, who stands by us during our travels and shelters us in our travails. Guided by him, we can become spiritually conscious and materially resourceful.

When we thus reduce our working frame, we will navigate through dark times and emerge stronger.

Think it over

What does it mean to reduce our working frame amidst distressing times?

How does spiritual knowledge help us reduce our working frame?

Consider one challenge facing you now. To deal with it better, how can you reduce your working frame?

02.14 O son of Kunti, the nonpermanent appearance of happiness and distress, and their disappearance in due course, are like the appearance and disappearance of winter and summer seasons. They arise from sense perception, O scion of Bharata, and one must learn to tolerate them without being disturbed.

When work doesn't work, detachment works

Sometimes, we work at something, yet nothing seems to work. We struggle to improve a relationship, but things keep going south. What can we do when work doesn't work?

We can seek detachment. To see how detachment works, we need to understand that all work has two results: outer and inner. When we work on a relationship, the outer result is that the relationship improves and the inner result is that we become more mature and empathic. The outer result is determined not just by our endeavor but also by destiny. If destiny is unfavorable, then that result doesn't come despite our best efforts.

Does this mean that we passively resign ourselves to fate? No, not at all. It just means that we don't work solely for the outer results. Attachment fixates our vision on those outer results, making us believe that without such results, the work is useless. Detachment frees our vision to look at inner results too. Even if we don't improve a particular relationship, becoming more mature and empathic makes us a better person and improves our overall prospects in other relationships. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (02.47) recommends that we work with detachment.

Detachment works best when it is based not on material frustration but on spiritual illumination. Gita wisdom offers such illumination by explaining that we are at our core souls who are on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution. We evolve as we expand our capacity to learn and to love. If we learn about the ultimate reality, Krishna, and direct our love from the world to him, we re-envision our work as an offering of devotion to him. Even if the outer results don't come, detachment and devotion ensure that our heart grows and goes closer to him. And that is life's most enduring and fulfilling result.

Think it over

What are the two results of all work?

When work doesn't work, how does detachment work?

How does detachment work best with spiritual illumination?

02.47 You have a right to perform your prescribed duty, but you are not entitled to the fruits of action. Never consider yourself the cause of the results of your activities, and never be attached to not doing your duty.

Life becomes meaningless not when we tire of life's problems, but when we tire of life's pleasures

When we face many problems repeatedly, we may become disheartened. And such discouragement becomes aggravated when problems thwart us in something extremely important. We may start thinking, “What is the point of it all? Why should I keep struggling against so many problems?”

Such feelings are understandable. Not so well understood, however, is another truth: life becomes stripped of meaning not so much by problems that seem pointless as by pleasures that turn out to be pointless.

Suppose we seek some pleasure as our life’s purpose. Suppose further we achieve that pleasure and it turns out to be disappointing and anti-climactic. That afflicts us with a profound crisis of purpose: “What am I living for?” Unfortunately, today’s materialistic culture doesn’t let us dwell on such existential questions; it allures us with myriad worldly goals, including an increasingly large variety of mind-numbing entertainment. However, chasing such goals becomes more and more unfulfilling. Thus, for example, people fantasize incessantly about sex, but many people find themselves bored while actually indulging in sex.

Gita wisdom explains that we are souls, who are parts of a whole bigger than ourselves. That whole is the all-attractive, all-loving supreme, Krishna. We are meant to live in harmony with him. How? By striving to connect with him internally through remembrance. And by contributing to his purpose of benefiting everyone by using our resources in a mood of service. If we neglect our role as parts of a bigger Whole and live for our own sensual pleasures, we live in vain (Bhagavad-gita 03.16).

When we live for a purpose bigger than ourselves — serving Krishna and serving others in relationship with Krishna — we find our life enriched with a sublime meaning that makes life’s problems bearable.

Think it over

How can life’s problems make us question life’s meaning?

How can life’s pleasures strip our life of meaning?

How can we infuse our life with sublime meaning?

03.16 My dear Arjuna, one who does not follow in human life the cycle of sacrifice thus established by the Vedas certainly leads a life full of sin. Living only for the satisfaction of the senses, such a person lives in vain.

Chemical highs can't cure life's lows, go spiritually high

When life's adversities push people down, they often feel so dejected that they desperately seek something to lift themselves. And often they turn to chemicals such as drugs.

Drugs can raise their drooping spirits, but that rise lasts only as long as the chemical surge in their brains. Thereafter, their spirits go low, in fact, lower than earlier. Why lower? Multiple reasons.

Nature of life: Life never stops sending difficulties. Once the capacity to endure discomfort is weakened by drug use, life's next blow pushes drug users down further than earlier.

Nature of drugs: Drugs have a powerful gravity pull – even when life is good, drugs allure users towards relapse, with increasing compulsiveness.

Nature of people: When drug users resolve to stop using drugs but fail, they start losing their self-confidence and self-respect, thereby compounding their emotional woes and lows.

We may not be taking drugs, but we all may have unhealthy ways to deal with life's lows.

How can we move towards healthier responses? By getting a healthy dose of reality through Gita wisdom.

The Gita explains that though we can't stop life's lows, we can stop ourselves from going low. How? By connecting ourselves with something higher. Higher than our situations and our emotions is our spiritual essence: our souls. As spiritual beings, we are parts of the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna (Bhagavad-gita 15.07). By spiritualizing our consciousness, we can face life's dualities steadily (05.20).

How can we spiritualize our consciousness? Through the process of yoga, which raises our consciousness to the spiritual level.

Bhakti-yoga is especially efficacious because it gives us direct access to Krishna. When we diligently engage ourselves in those limbs of bhakti-yoga that connect us easily and joyfully with Krishna, we gradually attain inner stability that isn't shaken by life's lows.

Think it over

How do chemical highs aggravate life's lows?

How can we protect ourselves from life's lows?

How can bhakti-yoga help us access spiritual reality efficaciously?

05.20 A person who neither rejoices upon achieving something pleasant nor laments upon obtaining something unpleasant, who is self-intelligent, who is unbewildered, and who knows the science of God is already situated in transcendence.

Pleasure and pain are both life's ringtones – don't keep hearing the tone, start picking up the phone

Suppose our phone rings. Some ringtones are soothing; some, jarring. However, how the ringtone sounds is not as important as what it indicates: that someone is calling us. If we get caught in the ringtone, delighting in its sweetness or ranting at its harshness, we miss the call. If someone were calling us to convey an important message, we would be big-time losers.

We may incur a similar loss when life's positive and negative experiences subject us respectively to elation and dejection. Being carried away by such situational emotions, we miss out on something bigger that life is teaching us, or more precisely, that our supreme teacher, Krishna, is teaching us through life.

Gita wisdom explains that the universe is like a university. In this university, we all are souls on a multi-life educational course. The course is meant to help us realize Krishna's centrality in our life: through all of life's dualities, he remains the unchanging reality, beckoning us to connect more strongly with him. The more we become connected with him, the more we relish sublime spiritual joy. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (05.20) urges us to stay equipoised amidst dualities by becoming situated in spiritual knowledge and realization. Being thus situated, we see life's pleasures as Krishna's reminders of the pleasure that awaits us when our consciousness ascends to the spiritual level through increasing absorption in him. And we see life's troubles as Krishna's reminders of the far bigger troubles that will befall those who let their consciousness tarry at the material level in the vain hope of finding worldly pleasure.

When we thus see life's dualities as Krishna's calls urging us to turn toward him, we pass through those dualities with lesser turbulence, progressing steadily toward the supreme transcendence.

Think it over

How are pleasures and pains like life's ringtones?

What are life's pleasures meant to remind us?

What are life's troubles meant to remind us?

05.20 A person who neither rejoices upon achieving something pleasant nor laments upon obtaining something unpleasant, who is self-intelligent, who is unbewildered, and who knows the science of God is already situated in transcendence.

Spirituality reveals that our destiny is bigger than the biggest adversity

We all wish to have a better future. Using whatever talents we have, we often dream of achieving something wonderful, thereby fulfilling our destiny. But then, life may devastate our dreams through one sweeping adversity.

Such adversity can crush us. If we have lived with a materialistic worldview, considering worldly gain to be life's defining purpose, we will feel our destiny has been thwarted, that everything we have worked for is lost, that our life has become pointless.

How can we face such adversity? Can we achieve something that adversity can't thwart? Yes, if we understand our spiritual essence by studying wisdom-texts like the Bhagavad-gita. The Gita reveals that our destiny is far bigger than even the biggest adversity. We are eternal spiritual beings and are parts of the supreme spiritual being, Krishna. As his parts, we are meant for a life of eternal loving harmony with him, wherein we use all our abilities and resources in his service. And he reciprocates by filling and flooding our heart with the nectar of unending love.

The Gita (06.22) explains that when we become absorbed in spiritual reality, we gain an unflappable inner calm that is not shaken by life's adversities. Whatever we may gain or lose materially, the gain of inner absorption in Krishna is so enriching and fulfilling that we no longer crave for anything.

Being thus internally satisfied, we can work more clearly and effectively to do justice to our potentials. Thus, we can fulfill our outer destiny in this world, making the contributions that we are meant to make. Thereby we relish in this very life inner contentment that keeps us stable, whether we gain outer achievement or not. And eventually, we fulfill our ultimate destiny of attaining eternal life with Krishna.

Think it over

If we live materialistically, how can adversity thwart our destiny?

How can our outer destiny be furthered by pursuing our inner destiny?

How does spiritual realization keep us calm amidst life's storms?

06.22 Upon gaining this he thinks there is no greater gain. Being situated in such a position, one is never shaken, even in the midst of greatest difficulty.

There is more to us than what faces us

Suppose an unarmed civilian is facing an armed aggressor. The odds may seem hopeless. But if they discover that they have a weapon more powerful than their aggressor's weapon, the odds will change dramatically in their favor.

In our life-journey, we sometimes face adversities that apparently have an atrocious advantage over us. At any moment, backstabbing friends, incurable diseases or unstoppable natural calamities may attack us. Our apparent powerlessness against such attacks may dishearten us so much that we just give up.

But we don't have to give up. There's more to us than what we normally perceive. We are not vulnerable bags of flesh battling alone in an uncaring world. Gita wisdom explains that we are indestructible spiritual beings, who are inalienable parts of the infallible whole, Krishna. The world's attacks can hurt our shell – our body and mind – but they can't even touch our core, our soul. And even when our shell is badly hurt, such injuries can still be means through which Krishna furthers his plan – provided we cooperate with that plan. Krishna's plan is meant ultimately for our spiritual evolution toward lasting love and joy. And we can cooperate with his plan by spiritualizing our consciousness.

Amid life's battles, our spiritual side is our untapped weapon that can dramatically change the odds in our favor. The Bhagavad-gita (06.22) assures that those who become spiritually situated stay undisturbed even amid great distresses.

However, we can't become spiritually situated merely by gaining spiritual knowledge. We need to transform that knowledge into realization by regularly practicing yoga, especially bhakti-yoga. By such practice, we train our consciousness to rise to the spiritual level. With that game-changing training, we become equipped to raise our consciousness above life's attacks, thereby facing those attacks wisely, maturely, effectively.

Think it over

In life's battles, why may the odds seem heavily against us?

When we are attacked, what is our game-changing weapon?

Amid your battles, how can you become more spiritually situated?

06.22 Established thus, one never departs from the truth, and upon gaining this he thinks there is no greater gain. Being situated in such a position, one is never shaken, even in the midst of greatest difficulty.

Just because pain is circumstantially beneficial doesn't mean it is intrinsically desirable

Some people try to make sense of life's difficulties by saying, "Pain helps us appreciate pleasure better. Bad times make good times sweeter."

Certainly, pain can have beneficial results if seen positively. For example, being burnt deters us from approaching fire carelessly. A painful disease makes us value good health more.

However, such benefits of pain are circumstantial, not intrinsic. If pain were inherently good, we would voluntarily expose ourselves to painful stimuli. But do we consciously choose to put our legs under an oncoming truck to better appreciate the blessing of functional legs? Or intentionally lose our money and become paupers to better appreciate prosperity? Or deliberately insult our loved ones and become lonely to appreciate good relationships? Our actions show that we don't consider pain intrinsically desirable.

Seeking to learn positive lessons from pain is good. But to learn the most positive lesson from pain, we need to unsentimentally acknowledge that pain is undesirable and ask why we are in a situation prone to pain when we long for pleasure.

Gita wisdom answers by highlighting our existential predicament: we are eternal spiritual beings caught in ephemeral material bodies. We are trapped in this incompatibility because of our desire to enjoy matter. This desire is a misdirection of our original pure desire to rejoice in a loving relationship with Krishna, the all-attractive source of everything material and spiritual.

Worldly pains are ultimately meant to prompt us to redirect our desire from matter to Krishna. We can redirect ourselves most expeditiously by practicing bhakti-yoga. Indeed, the Bhagavad-gita (08.15) assures that if we become devoted to Krishna, we go beyond this world of misery to his joyful indestructible abode.

When we thus see both pain's circumstantial benefits and its intrinsic undesirability, we can respond to pain most positively.

Think it over

How do our actions show that we don't consider pain intrinsically desirable?

How can we learn the most positive lesson from pain?

What is the ultimate purpose of pain?

08.15 After attaining Me, the great souls, who are yogis in devotion, never return to this temporary world, which is full of miseries, because they have attained the highest perfection.

Life is a school in which everyone thinks their exam is the toughest

Suppose a school has an examination system in which each student gets a different question paper. The system might seem unfair, but actually, it is fair. How? First, all students get the test they need for their progressive education. Second, the difficulty levels of the tests even out in the long run – sometimes, the students get easy papers and sometimes, tough papers.

But suppose the students obsess over those of their tests that are tougher than those of others and become disheartened, angry or resentful. Overwhelmed by such negative emotions, they flunk in the tough tests and then do poorly even in the subsequent easier tests.

Similar is our predicament in material existence. The universe is like a university in which we all are tested for our wisdom and maturity. Wisdom comes from intellectual development and maturity from emotional development – and both come organically and synergistically when we evolve spiritually. Gita wisdom explains that we all are souls on a multi-life journey toward the supreme, to be united with him in unending love and bliss. During this journey, we all have to work through our past karma; that karma's good and bad reactions come during this life as easy and tough situations respectively.

Though the problems of various people vary in their specifics, the world's overall nature ensures that eventually everyone faces distress; no one escapes unscathed. Despite differences in levels of intelligence, beauty, wealth, talents and so forth, the world is a distressful place for everyone (Bhagavad-gita 09.33).

If we can appreciate and assimilate this Gita insight, then we can avoid both resenting our tough tests or envying others' easy tests. Instead, we can best focus on our spiritual evolution by connecting with the Lord through devotion. By such devotion, we can gain a sublime absorption that helps us pass all tests.

Think it over

What is special about life's tests?

What happens when we see life's tests negatively?

How can Gita wisdom help us face life's tests?

09.33 How much more this is so of the righteous brahmanas, the devotees and the saintly kings. Therefore, having come to this temporary, miserable world, engage in loving service unto Me.

We can't change our past, but we can change how we see and explain our past

We often have things in our past that we resent. If terrible things have happened to us, we may feel that we are so damaged as to have no way to create a better future.

Thankfully, the past can never take away our capacity to change how we see and explain it. The past is a vast sequence of countless events, big and small. What we remember of it is a selection understood through an interpretation. And we can change both the selection and the interpretation.

Change how we see our past: We may remember those incidents from our past where we were wronged. But if we seek the positive, we may discover that some good things also happened to us. While some people have hurt us, others have helped us. Just the fact that we are alive, that we have survived till today, indicates that there's been more good than bad in our past.

Gita wisdom can help us change our vision of everything, including the past. The Gita explains that we all are eternal souls on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution. When we understand that we have an indestructible core, we feel less scarred by our past.

Change how we explain our past: Events in themselves don't affect us much; what primarily affects us is the meaning we assign to them. And Gita wisdom helps us discover an eminently positive meaning to everything, including to the events from our past. The Bhagavad-gita (13.23) indicates that the supreme reality, Krishna, oversees everything. We are his eternal parts, and he orchestrates things for our ultimate welfare. Even when bad things happen, he retains the ability to bring good out of them.

When we thus learn to see and explain our past positively, we can play our part in creating a better future.

Think it over

How do we remember our past?

How can we change how we see our past?

How can we change how we explain our past?

13.23 Yet in this body there is another, a transcendental enjoyer, who is the Lord, the supreme proprietor, who exists as the overseer and permitter, and who is known as the Supersoul.

Life may be full of problems, but we don't have to be one of them

Life is tough. We all face problems. When multiple problems attack us, we may feel overwhelmed, resentful, hopeless. These feelings can induce knee-jerk reactions that only make things worse. By such emotions and reactions, we become an addition to the problems confronting us.

How can we avoid aggravating our problems? By understanding two things: the nature of problems, and our identity different from those problems.

The nature of problems: Problems can arise, broadly speaking, from the situations we are going through, from the dispositions of people we are working with and from the limitations we ourselves have. Gita wisdom explains that inherent to material existence are these three sets of problems: situational (adhidaivika), dispositional (adhibhautika) and limitational (adhyatmika).

Our identity different from such problems: We are indestructible souls. We exist as conscious observers, above all problems at a higher, spiritual level of reality. Just as the sky exists above the world, we exist above the world with all its problems (Bhagavad-gita 13.33). If we remind ourselves that we are imperishable witnesses who have weathered many problems in the past and will weather these problems too, we start feeling calmer.

Moreover, spiritual practices such as bhakti-yoga help us raise our consciousness to the supremely attractive object of consciousness, Krishna. When we focus on him, knowing that he is in control and is our benefactor (05.29), a sublime serenity starts streaming into us. When we focus on him in a mood of prayer, seeking to understand how we can serve him amidst our problems, he gives us the intelligence to deal with those problems (10.10).

By thus gaining access to serenity and clarity, we shift our position from being a part of the problems to become a part of the solution.

Think it over

How do we become a part of the problems facing us?

How can understanding our identity calm us?

How can bhakti-yoga help us become a part of the solution?

13.33 The sky, due to its subtle nature, does not mix with anything, although it is all-pervading. Similarly, the soul situated in Brahman vision does not mix with the body, though situated in that body.

Passing blame is easy but disempowering, accepting responsibility is tough but empowering

Whenever things go wrong, our mind naturally looks for a scapegoat. We want to blame others because it seems to be an easy escape-way: “If I am not responsible for this mess, I don’t have to take the trouble to fix it.”

However, passing the buck is disempowering. Why? Because it takes away our agency, our capacity to do anything to improve things. We can self-righteously live on, believing our innocence and the world’s culpability. But the world moves on, while we stay stuck in a behavioral rut, unable to improve ourselves or create a better future for ourselves.

The way to empowerment is the opposite, that is, taking responsibility. Only when we accept responsibility for the situation can we regain any agency to rectify it. This is tough because it hurts our ego.

What if someone else is primarily responsible for the mess? We can still begin by asking ourselves, “Did I play any part, however small, in aggravating this situation? If yes, what can I do to fix that?” Once we begin this journey of introspection, we soon discover incremental changes that we can make. And such changes can, over time, significantly rectify the situation. At the very least, they can create a better me, who can then work to create a better future.

Pointing us in this direction of taking responsibility, the Bhagavad-gita states that the godly are averse to finding faults (16.02). They focus primarily on seeing good and doing good. Whenever faults need to be pointed out, they do so gently (17.15). In contrast, the ungodly revel in harshness and violence (16.04), indicating that they love to blame others.

Whatever our nature, Gita wisdom stands ready to empower us to take greater responsibility and create a better future.

Think it over

Why is passing blame disempowering?

How can we begin taking responsibility?

Is there any situation in your life where you are passing blame? How can you take responsibility?

16.02 Nonviolence; truthfulness; freedom from anger; renunciation; tranquillity; aversion to faultfinding; compassion for all living entities; freedom from covetousness; gentleness; modesty; steady determination; ... [– these transcendental qualities, O son of Bharata, belong to godly men endowed with divine nature.]

No matter how bad things are, we can always make them worse;
we are never powerless

Sometimes, life puts us in so many difficulties that we feel utterly powerless. That feeling can drown us in despair, self-pity, resentment and even suicidal thoughts. And it can prevent us from doing things that are still within our power to do.

To dissipate such negativity, we can ask ourselves a counter-intuitive question: “No matter how bad things are, can I make them worse?”

Our first reaction would be: “Who would want to make things worse?” The point here is not to make things worse, but to challenge our feeling of powerlessness. No situation can be so disempowering as to take away our power to make things worse. If a knee fracture has immobilized us, we can still take a hammer and fracture our other knee. Obviously, we won’t, and we shouldn’t.

But this thought-exercise underscores that we are not as powerless as we imagine; if we can make things worse, we can make them better too. Even if we can’t change a single thing externally, we can still change our disposition internally. Instead of complaining about how bad things are, we can be grateful they aren’t worse. Instead of feeling sorry for ourselves, we can start taking responsibility for making things better. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (17.16) urges us to discipline our mind by choosing satisfying thoughts.

For those who resolve to be responsible, not resentful, Gita wisdom reveals a wealth of spiritual resources. Specifically, the process of bhakti-yoga helps us realize that we are, at our core, indestructible and are protected by a loving God whose purposes, even if sometimes inscrutable, are always benevolent.

When we thus spiritualize our inner world, we get the calmness, clarity and creativity to improvise in our outer world and find positive options where none seemed to exist.

Think it over

What counter-intuitive question can dissipate the illusion that we are powerless?

Even if we can't change anything externally, what can we still do?

Do you feel powerless in some area of your life? How can you change that perception?

17.16: And satisfaction, simplicity, gravity, self-control and purification of one's existence are the austerities of the mind.

Even if we have a million reasons to be resentful, still resentment remains utterly unhelpful and can be horribly harmful

Life is tough. People let us down. Things go downhill for no apparent reason. We ourselves make a mess of things, often against our better judgment. Such adversities can naturally make us resentful. To justify such resentment, we may come up with hundreds or even millions of reasons.

Despite many such reasons, the reality remains that resentment is at best utterly unhelpful and at worst horribly harmful. Here's how.

Utterly unhelpful: Being resentful is at best like driving a car with brakes pressed. No motion results – the only results are noise, wasted fuel, and unnecessary frustration.

Horribly harmful: Resentment can make us not just impotently passive but also violently destructive. Resentful people may feel, “If I can't get something good, what right does anyone have for anything good? They must have got the good things of life unfairly by cheating or exploiting others. They don't deserve those things; I have a right to destroy them by any means, fair or foul.” Indeed, history shows that many revolutions against prosperous rulers start off ostensibly as virtuous campaigns against inequality and inequity, but soon degenerate into resentment-driven indiscriminate genocides.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (18.35) cautions that self-destructive thought patterns such as resentment are typical of the destructive mode of ignorance.

Yes, life does sometimes give us a terrible deal. But resentment prevents us from making the best out of it – and it increases the probability that we may make the worst out of it.

True, not being resentful isn't easy. But nothing worthwhile is.

Gita wisdom helps us transcend resentment by explaining that the omnibenevolent supreme, Krishna, oversees everything and can bring good out of the bad. We just need to play our part by striving to maintain a service attitude and prayerfully doing our best.

Think it over

What do you feel most resentful about?

Has resentment ever impelled you to do something shocking?

How can we transcend resentment?

18.35 And that determination which cannot go beyond dreaming, fearfulness, lamentation, moroseness and illusion – such unintelligent determination, O son of Prutha, is in the mode of darkness.

Resilience comes when we accept what is unchangeable, but don't accept that everything is unchangeable

What makes some people resilient and some people weak? It's primarily their vision when things go wrong.

Life is tough. Everyone faces adversities. At such times, some people obsess over all that has gone wrong and become resentful, labeling the world as a horrible place. Or they start feeling sorry for themselves and sink into self-pity and suicidal thoughts, labeling themselves worthless. Neither vision is helpful — both make us internally brittle and bitter. The Bhagavad-gita (18.35) declares such negative, self-defeating thought-patterns as characteristic of the destructive mode of ignorance.

Suppose a ball is hit hard on the ground. The harder it is hit, the higher it bounces back. How? It doesn't deny the fact that it has been hurled down by a greater force. But it uses that very force to rebound when it hits the ground. Of course, the ball isn't conscious and functions according to mechanical laws.

But we can learn from it the dynamics that define resilience. When life knocks us down, by bringing upon us situations that are unchangeable, we need to accept them and let go of resentment, knowing that resentment of reality often hurts more than reality. Simultaneously, we need to focus on what is changeable, without succumbing to the pessimistic, fatalistic attitude that nothing is changeable.

If we ask ourselves, "What can I do, however small, to make things better in this situation?" we will find a path to bounce back. Such bouncing back becomes easier when we identify ourselves not with our material externals which may be breakable by the world's reversals, but with our spiritual internals which are indestructible. And our rebounding ability increases further when we understand that we are parts of God, Krishna, who can bring good even out of the bad.

By letting Gita wisdom shift our identity to our spirituality, we all can increase our resilience.

Think it over

What makes some people brittle?

What vision enables us to bounce back?

How can we develop the vision that fosters resilience?

18.35 And that determination which cannot go beyond dreaming,
fearfulness, lamentation, moroseness

and illusion – such unintelligent determination, O son of Prutha,
is in the mode of darkness.

The night after a quake, the stars still shine in the sky; don't let the misery of your life blind you to the beauty of life

Suppose a deadly quake has hit a place, leaving it in ruins. If we gaze at all the debris, the sight can be depressing, even devastatingly depressing. While our heart is thus sinking, suppose we happen to look up at the sky and see it filled with beautiful stars. The sight of that celestial beauty can get our thoughts out of the terrestrial misery around us and help us regain perspective: even if our world has come crashing down, the world at large endures.

During our lives, we sometimes face reversals that seem like quakes which bring our whole world crashing down. How can we cope? By raising our vision to the spiritual sky, filled with stars of timeless truths.

Gita wisdom raises our vision to that star-filled sky. It reminds us that our core identity is spiritual: beyond our perishable bodies, we are indestructible souls. Beyond the distress that afflicts us at the bodily level, hope springs eternal at the spiritual level. And the spiritual level is the springboard of not just hope but also opportunity: we all have the potential to realize our indestructibility.

To perceive the spiritual level, we need to free our vision from being locked in our problems. What locks our vision in our problems? Ignorance. The Bhagavad-gita (18.35) states that obsessing over life's negativities by worrying, lamenting, moping, blaming, resenting characterizes a mind afflicted by ignorance.

Amid adversity, we can choose to look at the stars of spiritual truths: we are indestructible souls; our benevolent Lord still reigns supreme, orchestrating things for our ultimate good; we still have the opportunity to evolve spiritually. By looking up at these stars, we can get the necessary positivity to manifest good out of the bad.

Think it over

How does the Gita raise our vision to the spiritual level?

What are the stars that illumine the spiritual sky?

What practices help you to get your thoughts out of your immediate problems?

18.35 And that determination which cannot go beyond dreaming, fearfulness, lamentation, moroseness and illusion – such unintelligent determination, O son of Prutha, is in the mode of darkness.

To keep fighting battles that are already lost is to be lost

Suppose in a cricket match a batsman had a great opportunity to score on a loose delivery, but somehow they missed that opportunity. They would naturally be annoyed with themselves. But if they kept berating themselves so much that they became distracted from the next delivery and missed it too, they would simply be making a bad situation worse.

Sports matches are sometimes compared to wars, just without the bullets. Not only sports, but our life too is like a war. We all fight daily battles, wherein we try to capitalize on whatever opportunities we get. But fallible humans that we are, we all miss some opportunities. Such lost battles sometimes keep replaying in our head, almost against our will. These replays can distract and dishearten us so much that we may lose winnable battles in the present too. The Bhagavad-gita (18.35) indicates that self-defeating mental thought patterns signify a perverse determination in the mode of ignorance.

How can we stop fighting lost battles? One powerful strategy is by raising our self-conception from material to spiritual.

As long as we consider ourselves materialist beings, we define success in materialistic terms. With that conception, some mistakes can seem so catastrophic as to have ruined everything important in our life. But when we understand that we are indestructible spiritual beings, we see mistakes in perspective, as bumps on the road of life toward our spiritual evolution.

Additionally, we understand that overseeing all of existence is the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna. He is expert enough to bring good even out of our mistakes. With this understanding, we can let go of the past, entrusting it to his safe hands.

Being thus spiritually boosted, we can focus on doing our best in the present and lay the foundation for a better future.

Think it over

How does replaying the past make bad things worse?

How does spiritual consciousness help us stop fighting lost battles?

Is there any lost battle you are still fighting? Plan how you can let go of it.

18.35 And that determination which cannot go beyond dreaming, fearfulness, lamentation, moroseness and illusion – such unintelligent determination, O son of Prutha, is in the mode of darkness.

To put something behind us, we need to put something ahead of us

When some misfortune befalls us, our mind tends to keep replaying that misfortune, making us feel fearful, morose, helpless. Such negativity characterizes the mode of ignorance (Bhagavad-gita 18.35).

How can we put that misfortune behind us? By putting something ahead of us – literally and metaphorically. Literally, we need to find something positive that we strongly long to do. Then, we put reminders of that purpose in front of us as, say, stickie notes, thereby helping that purpose permeate our consciousness.

Metaphorically, if we compare life to a drive, the misfortune is like a scary car crash. Dwelling on that crash can make us paranoid about driving. But if we had somewhere important to go to, we would gather our courage and start driving. The same principle applies to our life-journey too. When we have something important to do, that purpose impels us to get out of our mind and into our life.

What if the misfortune destroyed our purpose itself? That's why beyond our various contextual purposes, we need an indestructible purpose: we need Krishna. Gita wisdom explains that Krishna is the supreme indestructible reality. He is already ahead of us and behind us and within us too. Even if our purpose has been foiled, Krishna's purpose still remains operational. Our ultimate purpose is to cooperate with his purpose because we are his eternal parts (15.07).

To put Krishna in front of us means: first, to recognize that, no matter how grim our present situation, we can still serve him; and second, to start taking small steps for serving him. By such spiritual purposefulness, we increasingly experience his solacing and strengthening presence. And the darkness around us starts giving way to light.

When we thus let Krishna lead us, our life becomes perennially purposeful and sublimely joyful.

Think it over

How can we put something ahead of us, literally and metaphorically?

Why do we need Krishna as our life's purpose?

What does putting Krishna in front of us mean?

18.35 And that determination which cannot go beyond dreaming, fearfulness, lamentation, moroseness and illusion – such unintelligent determination, O son of Prutha, is in the mode of darkness.

Even if we can't see adversity as opportunity, we can still see opportunity in adversity

Some people say, “See every adversity as an opportunity.” While such an exhortation to think positive sounds good and can be helpful, it can be platitudinous, insensitive or unhelpful especially if we have gone through a catastrophic upheaval.

What can we do amidst such situations? If we can't see adversity itself as an opportunity, we can still seek some opportunity within that adversity or seek some opportunity that may emerge through that adversity. What we seek is what we increase the chance of finding; what we aren't seeking, we are less likely to find.

In fact, the attitude of looking for some opportunity within adversity is both realistic and optimistic. Realistic because we don't deny the problem, and optimistic because we simultaneously don't deny ourselves the opportunity to look for some positivity within the negativity of the problem.

Such thinking becomes easier if we equip ourselves with spiritual knowledge. Gita wisdom explains that we are at our core souls who are on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution. And overseeing and even orchestrating our evolution is an omniscient, omni-benevolent Lord who can bring good even out of the bad.

During our life-journey, what is our lasting possession? It is not any material acquisition or relationship — these may be threatened or lost amidst adversity. It is our spiritual realization: our awareness of our own indestructibility and our inalienable relationship with our Lord. And this realization can be furthered through both materially favorable and unfavorable situations. By connecting ourselves with Krishna through the practice of bhakti-yoga regularly, we will be better equipped to think of him amidst difficulties too, thereby seeing spiritual positivity amidst material negativity.

Echoing this theme, the Bhagavad-gita (18.58) assures that if we become conscious of Krishna, we can rise over all obstacles.

Think it over

What is the problem with seeing adversity as opportunity?

How can we see opportunity in adversity?

How can spiritual knowledge help us see opportunity in adversity?

18.58 If you become conscious of Me, you will pass over all the obstacles of conditioned life by My grace. If, however, you do not work in such consciousness but act through false ego, not hearing Me, you will be lost.

Even when bhakti doesn't make life easier, it makes us tougher

Suppose we have a job to lift huge weights. That job can become easier if someone lightens that load or if our muscles become stronger.

Similarly, when we have to face burdensome problems, our life can become easier in two ways: if those problems decrease or if we become tougher. When we practice bhakti, we often expect Krishna to remove or reduce our problems. And that does happen sometimes. But if that doesn't happen, does it mean Krishna is not helping us? No, it just means that Krishna is helping us in the other way: by making us internally stronger.

Our inner strength depends on the default focus of our consciousness. The more we are attached to externals that are not in our control, the more those attachments weaken us internally. If we are attached to wealth as the basis of our self-worth, loss of wealth can seem unbearable.

How can we strengthen ourselves? By shifting our attachment to something internal and unchangeable. Bhakti wisdom reveals the highest reality to be the one with unfading, unfailing potency: God, Krishna. By bhakti practice, we realize not just Krishna's infallibility but also our own indestructibility as souls who are his eternal parts.

By thus centering us on Krishna, bhakti strengthens us to face whatever burdens life may throw upon us externally. The Bhagavad-gita (18.58) assures that if we become conscious of Krishna, we will pass over all obstacles by his grace. This assurance's thrust is significant: not that obstacles will disappear, but that our consciousness will rise above them.

If we expect bhakti practice to make our life easier, our expectations may or may not be met. Instead, if we see bhakti as a practice meant primarily for toughening us internally, we will never be disappointed.

Think it over

When our bhakti practice doesn't reduce our problems, does that mean Krishna is not reciprocating?

What determines our inner strength or weakness?

How does bhakti make us tougher?

18.58 If you become conscious of Me, you will pass over all the obstacles of conditioned life by My grace. If, however, you do not work in such consciousness but act through false ego, not hearing Me, you will be lost.

If we prayed as much as we worried, we would worry a lot less

We all worry, sometime or the other. Worrying may seem natural and unavoidable because so many things that are important for us are not in our control.

Still, if we consider the amount of mental time we spend on worrying, we will recognize that it is enormous – and enormously unproductive, in fact counterproductive.

While there are no quick fixes to the problem of excessive worrying, still we can progress towards a solution by appreciating that the same mental time can be more productively used by connecting with the one who is the controller of everything – including the things that are not in our control, the things about which we are worrying so much.

The best way to shift our focus thus is by praying, praying not just that the uncontrollable issues be resolved but also that our own uncontrolled mind's tendency to obsess over the uncontrollable be curbed. And that inner redirection happens through not just praying for something material but by praying to connect with the supreme trans-material reality, God, Krishna. The Bhagavad-gita (18.58) assures that the more we become conscious of Krishna, the more we can pass over all obstacles by his grace.

Henceforth, each time we start experiencing a worry attack – a sudden upsurge in our mind's tendency to obsess over the uncontrollable – we can strive to become prayer warriors; we can counter that worry attack by focusing on the Lord of our hearts and of our world, Krishna. The time-honored process of bhakti-yoga enables us to become expert prayer-warriors who can resolutely and resourcefully focus on Krishna.

Even if our bhakti practice doesn't remove all our worry, it can decrease that worry substantially, thereby decreasing our distress.

Think it over

How can we get the impetus to stop or at least decrease worrying?

When dealing with worry, what can we pray for?

How can we become prayer warriors?

18.58 If you become conscious of Me, you will pass over all the obstacles of conditioned life by My grace. If, however, you do not work in such consciousness but act through false ego, not hearing Me, you will be lost.

God doesn't promise a stormless sea – he provides an unsinkable ship

When we practice bhakti, we often expect to become free from problems. And if that expectation is not met, we become disheartened.

Dharmic traditions often compare the material world to a vast ocean wherein we souls are caught. During our life-journey, we are meant to navigate through this ocean to the shore of eternity.

Just as an ocean sometimes turns stormy, the material world sometimes turns distressful. If we expect the ocean to be always calm, not even the best shipping captain can guarantee that; our very expectation sets us up for frustration. We similarly set ourselves up for frustration when we expect our life-journey to be smooth.

But that doesn't mean we have to be helplessly tossed about. The world's storminess is aggravated by our worldliness; the more we are attached to worldly things, the more we suffer when those things are threatened or lost.

Gita wisdom, including especially its recommended practice of bhakti-yoga, acts as a sturdy ship for us to sail through material existence. And this ship is unsinkable; as long as we stay inside it, we stay safe. That is, as long as we keep our consciousness connected with Krishna, we stay anchored in the eternal, thereby buffering ourselves from the insecurity, anxiety, and misery caused by the world's temporariness. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (18.58) assures that if we stay conscious of Krishna, we will cross over all obstacles by his grace.

Therefore, instead of expecting the ocean to become storm-free, we can strive to stay inside the ship. Then we won't hyperventilate amidst problems, but will resourcefully re-connect ourselves with Krishna. We will find security by staying connecting with the one who exists beyond all storms. And he will empower us to steer through the storms towards him for a life of eternal safety and joy.

Think it over

How does our expectation set us up for frustration?

What aggravates the world's storminess?

How does bhakti help us weather life's storms?

18.58 If you become conscious of Me, you will pass over all the obstacles of conditioned life by My grace. If, however, you do not work in such consciousness but act through false ego, not hearing Me, you will be lost.

Problems are like burdens whose weight increases with the attention we give them

Suppose we have to carry a huge bag. We may struggle to carry it, but if that bag became bigger and bigger, the struggle would worsen.

Such is often our predicament when we face problems. Every problem is like a burden that weighs us down internally; thinking about problems drains our energy.

Of course, we need to think adequately about problems so that we have a basic working understanding of how to deal with them. But beyond such necessary attention, if we keep thinking about a problem – as our mind is inclined to do – the problem seems to grow bigger. It gains a stronger hold on our thoughts and leaves us weaker.

How can we prevent problems from gaining a choke-hold on us? By holding on to a purpose bigger than the problem. If we focus on a purpose that is deeply meaningful and valuable for us, then progressing toward that purpose makes bearable the burden of whatever problems come along the way.

The best such purpose is the purpose of spiritual evolution: the growth of our consciousness from matter to spirit, ultimately to the supreme spiritual reality, the all-attractive supreme, Krishna. Gita wisdom explains that absorbing our consciousness in Krishna is the source of life's supreme satisfaction. Striving to serve him is the ultimate standard of success for all our endeavors, irrespective of whether they are externally successful or not. Just the intention of serving him furthers our connection with him, giving us inner steadiness and strength. Being thus nourished, we can persevere through the problems without being pressured into paranoia by them. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (18.58) assures that if we become conscious of Krishna, his grace empowers us to face all problems.

Think it over

What happens when we think excessively about our problems?

How can we shift our thoughts away from our problems?

How does thinking about Krishna nourish us even amid problems?

18.58 If you become conscious of Me, you will pass over all the obstacles of conditioned life by My grace. If, however, you do not work in such consciousness but act through false ego, not hearing Me, you will be lost.

Problems may get stuck inside us, but we don't have to get stuck inside them

Suppose someone writes abusive graffiti on our house wall. We will be annoyed. If the graffiti is written with indelible ink, we will be more annoyed. But more troubling than the graffiti getting stuck on the wall is we getting stuck in the graffiti by having our thoughts caught in thinking repeatedly about it.

What applies to graffiti on a wall also applies to problems inside our consciousness. Having problems is annoying. Even more annoying is those problems getting stuck in our consciousness because we just can't stop thinking about them. But most troubling is our getting stuck inside those problems by our fixating on them till they grow so big as to dwarf, dishearten and disempower us.

How can we deal with such problems? By focusing on doing whatever is in our power.

We can't avoid problems entirely because the world is a tough place where problems are unavoidable. Sometimes, we can't avoid thinking about problems because some problems come with inbuilt glue that makes them stick inside us. But we can prevent problems from growing disproportionately inside us. How? By refusing to obsess over them and by focusing our consciousness elsewhere.

The best object to focus on is the all-attractive supreme, Krishna. Thinking about him provides us peace, power and perspective, thereby making problems more manageable. And if we habituate ourselves to thinking of him by practicing bhakti-yoga, then our consciousness becomes attached to him.

With such devotional attachment, we can more easily unglue our consciousness from problems and clear our consciousness, thereby becoming empowered to deal with those problems more effectively. No wonder the Bhagavad-gita (18.58) assures that those who become conscious of Krishna can cross over all problems.

Think it over

How is our mind like a wall with graffiti written on it?

When dealing with problems, what is in our control and what isn't?

How can we avoid getting stuck inside our problems?

18.58 If you become conscious of Me, you will pass over all the obstacles of conditioned life by My grace. If, however, you do not work in such consciousness but act through false ego, not hearing Me, you will be lost.

Stop blaming your outer world, start building your inner world

Suppose the weather suddenly turns chilly. We could blame the weather and feel sorry for ourselves. Or we could don warm clothes and get on with our life.

We would naturally choose the second option whenever the weather turns unfavorable. But we don't choose so prudently when our emotional weather turns unfavorable, that is when we start feeling resentful and fretful amid difficulties. We start blaming people or things or the world at large. However, such blaming simply disempowers us – by making us feel we have been helplessly victimized by a cruel world, it submerges us in a swamp of self-pity.

We have a far more empowering alternative: build our inner world and gain the strength to endure. How can we build our inner world? A time-honored way is to increase our spiritual awareness, which can become the inner equivalent of warm clothes amid cold weather.

What is spiritual awareness? The awareness that we are indestructible spiritual beings, who are parts of the supreme spiritual being, Krishna. He is all-powerful and all-merciful, being the well-wisher of everyone (Bhagavad-gita 05.29). He is expert enough to bring good even out of bad. If we stay devotionally disposed towards him, our heart opens to his voice. And he gives us the grace and guidance to overcome all obstacles (18.58).

Such spiritual awareness benefits us far more than warm clothes. Warm clothes can protect us from the cold at present, but they get worn out with time. In contrast, spiritual awareness protects us from our present difficulty – and also increases our overall devotional absorption in Krishna, thereby buffering us from future difficulties.

And with time and practice, our absorption in Krishna deepens, filling us with unflappable inner security and ultimately taking us to the arena of eternal security.

Think it over

How does blaming the world disempower us?

What is spiritual awareness?

When life turns chilly, how does spiritual awareness benefit us more than warm clothes?

18.58 If you become conscious of Me, you will pass over all the obstacles of conditioned life by My grace. If, however, you do not work in such consciousness but act through false ego, not hearing Me, you will be lost.

Stronger than what faces us is what graces us

Life sometimes hurls at us overwhelming obstacles that we feel utterly unequipped to deal with. Amid crises, we may pray for help to some higher power.

Does such a power really exist? Its existence can be a reasonable inference. Our very existence depends on many factors beyond our control. To do something as seemingly routine as read this article, we need air to breathe, a body healthy enough to read, a climate congenial enough to survive. We can't do much to control these things, yet they align favorably for most of our life. Might their favorable alignment and even their very existence point to some benevolent higher being.

Someone may object, "But this favorable alignment eventually falls apart because we all ultimately die. Even before death, some of us may suffer immensely. Is that higher being really benevolent?"

To appreciate divine benevolence, we need to see the world's design in the context of its purpose. The point of this world is to point beyond the world, to raise our consciousness to the spiritual level. The factors necessary for our existence align favorably not to facilitate not our worldly gratification but to stimulate our spiritual evolution. Such evolution centers on the expansion of our consciousness to perceive our spirituality and the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna.

When things fall apart, that situation serves as a forceful impetus for accelerating our spiritual evolution. Amid difficulties, if we strive to connect with Krishna by absorbing our consciousness in him, we experience calmness and clarity streaming into us from some ineffable source. Such experiences will convince us that whatever the obstacle facing us, we can rise above it if we focus on Krishna and his grace (Bhagavad-gita 18.58).

Think it over

How can we infer the existence of a benevolent higher being?

Amid the prevalence of death and distress in this world, how can we appreciate divine benevolence?

When faced with obstacles, how can we experience divine grace?

18.58 If you become conscious of Me, you will pass over all the obstacles of conditioned life by My grace. If, however, you do not work in such consciousness but act through false ego, not hearing Me, you will be lost.

The size of our problems is inversely proportional to the size of our purpose - the bigger our purpose, the smaller our problems become

Suppose a truck is moving rapidly on a road on which a tree has fallen. If the truck is large and has high momentum, it can just knock the tree aside and move on. Instead, if a cycle is being pedaled along that road, it would be brought to a stop by the fallen tree.

During our life-journey, we sometimes face problems that are like trees fallen across the path of our life. When such problems come upon us, they can overwhelm and paralyze us, if we don't do anything constructive about them.

And the most constructive thing we can do is find a purpose bigger than those problems. Our purpose shapes our perspective and determines our momentum. When we have a big purpose, that brings with it a higher inspiration, which can dwarf our problems. And the biggest purpose is that which brings enduring meaning and joy to our life, both in this world and the next. The best such purpose is to connect with our all-attractive Lord, Krishna, through loving remembrance and to contribute in this world in a mood of loving service.

When we seek something worldly, our momentum is like that of a bicycle; worldly changes which make that goal unattainable bring us to a stop. But when we seek to connect with Krishna as our life's overarching purpose, then our momentum becomes like that of a giant truck which can push its way through any obstacle. Worldly changes may obstruct a particular service, but no change can strip us of all opportunities to serve our Lord. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (18.58) assures that if we become conscious of Krishna, his grace will enable us to overcome all obstacles.

Think it over

How does our purpose determine our momentum?

What purpose can make our momentum unstoppable? How?

Is any problem overwhelming you? Can you think of a purpose that can dwarf that problem?

18.58 If you become conscious of Me, you will pass over all the obstacles of conditioned life by My grace. If, however, you do not work in such consciousness but act through false ego, not hearing Me, you will be lost.

When time becomes unfavorable, don't become unfavorable to the Lord beyond time

We all go through phases in our life when many things go wrong. While going through such bad times, if we let our attitude go bad, we just make things worse.

A particularly bad attitude is to blame God for inflicting those bad things upon us. Such an attitude cuts off our access to the resource we need the most amidst tough times: God. Gita wisdom asserts that he is not the cause of our distresses; he is the cure.

Why distresses befall us is a question with no easy answers. Using our intelligence, if we can find some reasonable, actionable answers, that's helpful. But if no satisfactory answers are forthcoming, what can we do? The only healthy course of action left with us is to accept those bad times as something we need to go through; though their specific reason remains unknown, they are meant ultimately for our growth.

Such acceptance becomes easier when we focus on the ultimate transcendence. Though God exists beyond time, he stays with us through all times: good and bad. As the indwelling Supersoul, he is always guiding our life-journey (18.61). We just need to surrender to him wholeheartedly (18.62). If we strive to surrender, we start breaking the inner negativity that keeps us distanced from him. The more we connect with him, the more a sublime sense of peace, power and purpose permeates our being. And we start taking small positive steps according to our capacity, while leaving the rest in Krishna's hands. Because everything in the world ends, those bad times too will end. But going through them will have made us spiritually stronger, wiser and purer.

By thus connecting with the Lord beyond time, we can navigate through bad times, till we attain a level of consciousness and ultimately a level of reality that is beyond all bad times.

Think it over

Why is becoming unfavorable to God disempowering?

How can connecting with God help us amidst bad times?

Has connecting with God helped you or anyone you know to weather bad times?

18.62 O scion of Bharata, surrender unto Him utterly. By His grace you will attain transcendental peace and the supreme and eternal abode.

Even if we can't understand Krishna, we can still stand under Krishna

Life sometimes assaults us with devastating adversities that cripple us materially and spiritually. Unable to understand why God is letting such things happen to us, we can become disheartened and overwhelmed. Or we can choose a more empowering option: stand under Krishna.

“To stand under” has two connotations: protection and guidance. Let's see how both these connotations apply to our standing under Krishna.

Protection: When we stand under someone, we seek their protection, as does a person standing under a tree during heavy rains. We can stand under Krishna by practicing bhakti-yoga centered on remembering him. Such remembrance may not immediately remove our problems, but it will steady our mind. This ensures that we don't unwittingly aggravate those problems by our kneejerk reactions impelled by our frantic mind. If we stand under Krishna, our mind calms down, as happened to Arjuna on hearing the Bhagavad-gita (18.73).

Guidance: When we stand under someone, we seek and await their guidance, as does a child holding tight to their parent's leg in a crowded mall. We can stand under Krishna by praying to him with service attitude: “You are my eternal Lord, and I am your eternal servant. How can I serve you now?” Responding to our earnest request, Krishna, from within our heart, will illumine one step ahead for us, even if the whole path still remains dark. And if we take that step, doing our best in that situation, then the next step will be shown. As we keep taking one step after another, eventually, we will come to light: we will realize how Krishna, through that adversity, furthered our spiritual evolution.

By thus standing under Krishna, we will be protected amid darkness and guided toward light.

Think it over

How can standing under Krishna protect us?

How can standing under Krishna guide us?

Has standing under Krishna helped you during difficulties? Plan how you can stand under him amidst present or future challenges.

18.73 Arjuna said: My dear Krishna, O infallible one, my illusion is now gone. I have regained my memory by Your mercy. I am now firm and free from doubt and am prepared to act according to Your instructions.

Resenting reversals locks us in ignorance, accepting reversals opens the door to transcendence

When things start going wrong, we often feel resentful: ‘Why is this happening to me? Why do things always go wrong with me? Why is life so unfair?’

Faced with reversals and the resulting resentment, we usually seek rational answers to make sense of things. But rational answers are often elusive — the workings of karma can be too complex to comprehend (Bhagavad-gita 04.17).

When resentment starts overwhelming us, we start sinking into the mode of ignorance. To accept one thing as everything is a perception in the mode of ignorance (18.22). To see the frustration of our plans as the frustration of our entire life is such a perception that locks us in ignorance.

What is the way out of the prison of such ignorance? Acceptance.

Acceptance becomes easier when we seek knowledge of transcendence from wisdom-texts such as the Gita. If we contemplate that we are indestructible souls existing above our situations and above our emotions, our consciousness expands beyond the threat of that reversal. Further, if we contemplate that our all-benevolent Lord Krishna is expert enough to bring good out of the bad, our consciousness expands further to look for some way forward amid the reversal: “Even if my plan isn’t working, Krishna’s plan is still working. Let me cooperate with his plan. Let me do whatever little I can to make things better, in a mood of service to him. Let me do his will.”

The Gita itself demonstrates how its wisdom empowered Arjuna with acceptance, thereby raising him from the perplexity of ignorance (02.06) to the clarity of transcendence (18.73). Similarly, the Gita stands ready to open the door to transcendence for all of us.

Think it over

Why is resentment a perception in the mode of ignorance?

How can knowledge of transcendence increase our acceptance of reversals?

Do you feel resentful about something right now? How can you use Gita wisdom to replace resentment with acceptance?

18.73 Arjuna said: My dear Krishna, O infallible one, my illusion is now gone. I have regained my memory by Your mercy. I am now firm and free from doubt and am prepared to act according to Your instructions.

We can't eliminate suffering from life, but we can cultivate a purpose that makes suffering bearable and life meaningful

Consider soldiers fighting to free their country from tyrannical invaders. They are ready to face pain, even death, because the war is deeply meaningful for them: it is the price for their motherland's liberty.

If those soldiers are simply trying to avoid their opponents' arrows, they can't win the war. Similarly, during our life, if we focus only on avoiding problems, we can't do anything worthwhile. Moreover, in the war that is life, we just can't dodge problems. Why not? Because sufferings such as old age, disease, and death are unavoidable (Bhagavad-gita 13.09).

To persevere in life's war, we need a deeply meaningful purpose. Gita wisdom reveals such a purpose. It explains that we are souls on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution till we attain love for the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna. By such devotion, we win the war against the world's illusions, break free from the constraints of matter and relish eternal love for Krishna. To further our spiritual evolution is the ultimate purpose of everything that happens in life. Distresses stimulate such evolution by impelling us to redirect our consciousness from the world to Krishna.

How spiritual purpose empowers is demonstrated in the Gita itself. Arjuna was reluctant to fight an unbearably painful war. But when the Gita revealed how his fighting that war would further everyone's spiritual evolution, his as well as that of those opposing him, he became ready to fight for fulfilling life's ultimate purpose (18.73).

If we accept spiritual evolution as our life's purpose and strive to spiritualize our consciousness, we start becoming purer, wiser, stronger and happier. When we are thus empowered by sublime purpose, our suffering becomes bearable and our life, meaningful.

Think it over

Explain with an example how purpose makes suffering bearable.

How did a sublime purpose make Arjuna's suffering bearable?

What are the sufferings confronting you? How can focusing on spiritual purpose make them bearable?

18.73 Arjuna said: My dear Krishna, O infallible one, my illusion is now gone. I have regained my memory by Your mercy. I am now firm and free from doubt and am prepared to act according to Your instructions.

Key to Happiness

Happiness is a state of being, not a status symbol

People often pretend to be happy. No matter how distressed they are, they plaster a smile on their face in front of others and say they are fine.

Why the facade? Because in today's world happiness has become a status symbol. People who are successful are expected to be happy. As everyone wants to be considered successful, they act as if they are happy.

Does the foregoing mean we always go around with a long face? No, certainly not. The point here is that we need to unsentimentally re-examine our conception of happiness.

We often equate happiness with the trappings of success such as possessions and positions. These can titillate temporarily, but they can't satisfy sustainably. We may have the best sensual pleasures, but if we are internally agitated, we just can't be happy. Happiness requires, first and foremost, a calm consciousness. Unfortunately, as long as we conceive of happiness as a status symbol, we suppress our inner agitation and pretend to be happy.

We need the courage to shed the pretense of happiness so that we can enquire about real happiness. Arjuna demonstrates this courage at the start of the Bhagavad-gita. He had been following the standard chart to a successful life for a warrior: fight heroically and gain a flourishing kingdom. But when circumstantially he had to fight against his venerable elders, he was overwhelmed by ambivalence (02.06) and agony (02.01). Acknowledging that no victory, however glorious, would dissipate his distress (02.08), he determinedly sought spiritual enlightenment (02.07). Thus emerged the Gita's wisdom that helped him understand his essential identity and ultimate purpose. Being thus illumined, he became situated in a state of divine harmony that brought him calm, clarity and confidence (18.73)

By similarly seeking spiritual realization, we too can attain the state of lasting happiness.

Think it over

Why do people pretend to be happy?

What is wrong with pretending to be happy?

How was Arjuna's crying a courageous act?

02.01 The Supreme Personality of Godhead said: My dear Arjuna, how have these impurities come upon you? They are not at all befitting a man who knows the value of life. They lead not to higher planets but to infamy.

Happiness is savored best when seen through the corner of the eye,
not when stared at straight

Suppose an image looks attractive when seen straight, but looks breathtaking when seen from an angle. To best relish that image, we need to consciously strive to look at it laterally.

We need a similar approach when pursuing happiness. Many worldly things look enjoyable. But when we stare straight at those things, that is, when we pursue them as our life's purpose, they often turn out to be anti-climactic. For example, we may enjoy comedy shows, but if we start watching such shows constantly for the rest of our life, we will soon be bored to death.

How, then, can we find happiness? By pursuing not what is merely enjoyable, but what is valuable. If we focus on something deeply meaningful, happiness gradually appears in the corner of our eye as a byproduct.

Consider someone who likes writing. The writers who find writing most fulfilling aren't those who write only when it is enjoyable. They write to express themselves, to convey something that matters to them and potentially to their readers. When they try to express themselves, sometimes the right words elude them, leaving them annoyed, frustrated, dejected. Still, they persevere. Once they connect with their core and articulate a meaningful message, a sublime satisfaction blossoms in their consciousness.

Happiness is best savored as a byproduct of meaningful engagement, not as the product of pleasure-seeking engagement. This universal principle applies even to spiritual happiness. The Bhagavad-gita (02.55) urges us to turn away from external things that promise pleasure, that is, to not stare at happiness straight; instead, it urges us to focus on turning our consciousness inward and understanding who we actually are. When we appreciate our identity as beloved parts of the all-attractive Whole, Krishna, and connect devotionally with him, we relish life's supreme joy.

Think it over

What happens when happiness is stared at straight?

How does happiness appear in the corner of our eye?

How can we savor spiritual happiness?

02.55 When a man gives up all varieties of desire for sense gratification, which arise from mental concoction, and when his mind, thus purified, finds satisfaction in the self alone, then he is said to be in pure transcendental consciousness.

Fulfilling our every desire won't make us happy, focusing on our most important desire will

We all have many desires that remain unfulfilled because we don't have the necessary resources. For example, we may want to wear the trendiest clothes, drive the fastest cars or own the biggest houses. But we may not be able to afford these – and so we may feel dissatisfied.

We often spend our life slaving to earn enough so that we can fulfill our many desires. Amidst such slaving, one question is rarely asked: will fulfilling our desires make us happy? While our reflexive answer may be obviously yes, deeper thought may give us cause for pause.

Our desires are countless. And each desire can expand in countless ways. For example, we may desire a grand house. If we succeed in getting one, we may then desire hundreds of accouterments to go with or enhance the house's grandness. Such desires will keep us endlessly indentured and unfulfilled.

To prevent such perpetual discontentment, we need to choose which desires to fulfill. Functionally speaking, we do shortlist our desires; however, our shortlist is based not on which desire is most important, but on which desire seems most tempting. And the most tempting desires are rarely, if ever, the most fulfilling.

Which desire is the most important and most fulfilling? The desire that connects us with our core, thereby filling us with meaning, purpose and joy.

Gita wisdom explains that we are at our core spiritual beings, parts of the all-attractive whole, Krishna. Whatever we find attractive reflects just a spark of his supreme all-attractiveness (10.41). If we become attracted to him with spiritual love, we gain the supreme fulfillment.

Focusing on Krishna who is our most important desire is therefore the expressway to happiness. Indeed, those who turn away from external pleasures and turn inward to him attain imperishable happiness (05.21).

Think it over

Why will fulfilling desires not lead to fulfillment?

How do we shortlist our desires?

Why is Krishna our most important desire?

05.21 Such a liberated person is not attracted to material sense pleasure but is always in trance, enjoying the pleasure within. In this way the self-realized person enjoys unlimited happiness, for he concentrates on the Supreme.

Our loudest desires won't lead us to happiness – our deepest desires will

In a conversation, suppose one person speaks the loudest. That doesn't make them right; the person who has given the deepest thought to the issues being discussed is most likely to be right.

Similarly, inside us, a conversation is constantly going on among our various desires. This conversation usually centers on what we need to do to attain happiness. And the loudest talkers therein are sensual desires for worldly pleasures. These desires often scream and yell inside us, goading us to do their will. Though they promise us happiness, they deliver disappointment at best and distress at worst. The much-hyped pleasure ends soon and often becomes the cause of trouble, as happens frequently in addictions.

Within our mind exist desires at multiple levels. Below the sensual desires that are triggered by external stimuli are desires for things that we deeply care about. When the time comes for us to leave this world, we won't value how much time we spend seeing the latest social media notifications or the latest TV soap operas. If we minimize our exposure to the stimuli that set off these desires, their volume will fall, and neglecting them won't be so difficult.

Additionally, to find happiness, neglecting our loudest desires is not as important as focusing on our deepest desires. And the deepest of all desires is the desire to realize who we are essentially and to mold our life accordingly. Gita wisdom explains that we are souls, parts of the all-attractive supreme, Krishna; and linking with him devotionally is the path to peace and joy.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (05.21) assures that when we turn away from sensual stimuli and connect with our spiritual essence, we relish inexhaustible joy.

Think it over

How do our loudest desires deceive us?

What are our deepest desires?

List three of your loudest and deepest desires. How can you listen more to your deepest desires than your loudest desires?

05.21 Such a liberated person is not attracted to material sense pleasure but is always in trance, enjoying the pleasure within. In this way the self-realized person enjoys unlimited happiness, for he concentrates on the Supreme.

Satisfaction comes by knowing ourselves, not by making ourselves known

Suppose we see someone who turns heads wherever they go. We may naturally want to be similarly well known. Given the world's hugeness and crowdedness, we may feel insignificant and worthless, unless we do something that makes us known.

Consequently, we long for some special talent or some special break – anything – that will give us our shot at fame. Most of us struggle through life, never becoming famous. Some of us, however, discover a talent, get a break and become somewhat famous. But the craving for fame is like an insatiable fire – no matter how much it is fuelled, it keeps burning more, making us crave for more fame.

And if we do become hugely famous, we face a poignant irony. That very fame often becomes the cause of annoyance, even distress. Celebrities often crave anonymity, struggling to do some normal human activities like going out for a walk without attracting unwanted attention and getting mobbed.

A healthier way to satisfaction is by knowing ourselves. Knowing ourselves begins by understanding that there are many layers to our being; we exist not just as our physical bodies or our subtle minds, but essentially as souls. We are characterized by pure consciousness that radiates through us and is meant to connect with the all-attractive supreme, Krishna.

The Bhagavad-gita (06.20) declares that we restrain our mind's frantic search of outer pleasure and turn our consciousness inward by the practice of yoga. By such practice, we perceive ourselves as blissful parts of the blissful Whole, Krishna. Being thus situated in inner joy, we use our talents and interests to contribute devotionally in this world without needing the world's acclaim.

When we thus know ourselves, we know happiness, whether the world knows us or not.

Think it over

Why do we long to be famous?

Why does the longing for fame not lead to happiness?

How can knowing ourselves lead to happiness?

06.20 In the stage of perfection called trance, or samadhi, one's mind is completely restrained from material mental activities by practice of yoga. This perfection is characterized by one's ability to see the Self by the pure mind and to relish and rejoice in the Self.

The images of prosperous people that make us burn with envy are just our mind's illusions

Suppose we see someone driving a Porsche and looking prosperous. That sight may make us burn with envy and resentment: “Why do they get to drive such a car? Why can’t I have something similar? Why are they so happy?”

Such burning arises from the presumption that the trappings of wealth are the providers of happiness. But is that presumption true? That person driving the Porsche may well be so lonely and miserable that they may drive off the next sharp turn to end their lives.

Such tragedies are not all that improbable; the news periodically reports celebrity suicides. People often appear happier than what they are. Worse still, our mind makes us unhappier than what we need to be. How? By making us believe that others are happier because they have more things than we do.

No matter how our mind imagines other people’s lives to be, no one’s life is perfect. Someone who owns a mansion may have a broken family. Someone who has the picture-perfect family may have a terminal disease. Someone who is a comedian may suffer from depression after the laughter.

Rather than getting carried away by images that look good, we need to train our mind for good. Such training centers on looking at the things we have, not at the things we don’t have. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (17.16) urges us to cultivate satisfaction as a mental discipline.

Cultivating satisfaction becomes easier once we understand spiritual knowledge: that we are parts of the all-attractive ultimate reality, Krishna, and that our ultimate satisfaction lies in our personal loving connection with him. When we practice bhakti-yoga to develop our inner connection with Krishna, our mind becomes purified. Thus, we start finding satisfaction in him and in using whatever we have, little or large, in a mood of service to him.

Think it over

Did you ever experience that someone whose life seemed perfect was not as happy as you thought?

Why do we overestimate others' happiness?

How can we cultivate satisfaction?

17.16 And satisfaction, simplicity, gravity, self-control and purification of one's existence are the austerities of the mind.

The mind overvalues things it doesn't have and undervalues things it does have

Suppose we want to sell something to buy something in exchange. If we undervalued what we had and overvalued what we didn't have, we would accept a bad deal.

Something similar happens to us in life at large. We often misidentify with our mind, which tends to overvalue the many things that the world dangles before us. And such dangling is increased manifold in today's world by the ad industry, which scientifically, systematically, ceaselessly tempts us with millions of things most of which we don't need but crave for. Feeling dissatisfied because of all the things we don't have, we don't appreciate or even notice the many good things we still have.

The Bhagavad-gita (17.16) urges us to cultivate satisfaction as a mental discipline. And an essential aspect of staying satisfied is training ourselves to value the things we have, without letting what we don't have infatuate and blind us.

And the most precious thing we have, the thing which we never lose, the thing that is always within us – that is not a thing at all. That is a person, more precisely, the Supreme Person, Krishna.

We need regular reminders of what really matters, because the world will make us forget that. Whatever is presented most prominently, persuasively and persistently to us starts consuming our consciousness, and we start valuing it more and more. As the world will not stop presenting worldly things to us, we need to present to ourselves the things that really matter. Or we need to place ourselves in social and spiritual circles that will provide us such reminders.

When we thus learn to value things properly, we won't sell our eternal soul for the temporary world, but will use the temporary world to regain our eternal soul.

Think it over

Why do we often overvalue things?

How can we value things properly?

List three things you overvalue and three things you undervalue.

17.16 And satisfaction, simplicity, gravity, self-control and purification of one's existence are the austerities of the mind.

To be happy is possible, to be happier than others is impossible

We all want to be happy, but we often tie our happiness to certain conceptions. One such common conception is that we will become happy when we become better than others in the things we consider as sources of happiness. For example, as compared to others, if we get a slimmer body, a higher paycheck, a bigger house, a sleeker car, a smarter phone, we will be happier. Or so we believe.

Even if we surpass others in such things, someone in our circle of comparison will soon surpass us. And with today's interconnected world enormously expanding our circle of comparison, we will almost always encounter someone who surpasses us.

Additionally and more importantly, we often believe that others are happier than what they actually are. Why do we believe this? Because we attribute to worldly things the capacity to provide far greater happiness than what they actually provide.

Because of these twin misbeliefs – having more things than others can make us happy, and people with lots of those things are happy – our trying to be happier than others is a permanently doomed pursuit.

Then, can we never be happy? We can be, provided we cultivate satisfaction as a mental discipline (Bhagavad-gita 17.16). To practice this discipline, we need to focus on the good things we have and relish them.

The most important good thing we always have is our indwelling Lord, Krishna. Being the all-attractive Supreme, he is the ultimate source of all sources of happiness. When we connect with him by practicing bhakti-yoga, we start relishing a sublime inner fulfillment that doesn't depend on externals. Moreover, that inner connection gives us access to divine guidance. Being thus guided, we learn to use the things we have to make worthwhile contributions and thereby gain meaningful satisfaction.

Think it over

Why is trying to be happier than others a doomed pursuit?

How can we cultivate satisfaction?

What causes you dissatisfaction? Does a comparison with others underlie that dissatisfaction? How can you free yourself from such dissatisfaction?

17.16 And satisfaction, simplicity, gravity, self-control and purification of one's existence are the austerities of the mind.

Stop resenting your struggles, start habituating yourselves to them – and they will start hurting less

Suppose we have to do something difficult, be it physical such as push-ups or intellectual such as complicated assignments or spiritual such as mantra meditation. While doing such things, we often resent the struggle involved.

However, resentment wastes our emotional energy and makes that difficult thing more difficult. Highlighting that worthwhile joys require prior payment, the Bhagavad-gita (18.37) states that such joys taste like poison initially and like nectar eventually. Using our intelligence, if we just consciously accept that worthwhile things come at a price, such acceptance decreases the inner struggle.

How? First, through the power of habit. Whatever we do repeatedly, we become habituated to it – and once something becomes a habit, the mental impressions within us that comprise the habit start prompting us to do that thing again, thereby lessening the inner struggle. Second, once we penetrate through the initial poison to the eventual nectar, the memory of that nectar inspires us to keep persevering.

Additionally, if we take up struggles to practice bhakti-yoga, that practice purifies us too. Purification essentially means that our material consciousness with its associated attraction for worldly pleasures decreases, and our spiritual consciousness with its associated attraction for Krishna increases, thereby decreasing the initial poison and increasing our access to the eventual nectar. Why does the initial poison decrease? Because we feel that poison primarily due to our mind and senses clamoring for sensual pleasure, and their clamor decreases as our material attachments decrease. And why does the eventual nectar become more accessible? Because we feel that nectar when our consciousness connects with Krishna, and that connection becomes easier as we become more attached to him.

By thus habituating ourselves to inner struggle, we can go through the poison to the nectar with less drama and trauma.

Think it over

How does acceptance of inner struggle decrease that struggle?

How does bhakti decrease our inner struggle?

Which struggle troubles you the most? How can you habituate yourself to that struggle?

18.37 That which in the beginning may be just like poison but at the end is just like nectar and which awakens one to self-realization is said to be happiness in the mode of goodness.

To savor what is most sweet, we often need to shed the most sweat

If we want to eat food, we need to earn it. If we want to eat sweet food, we need to pay more, that is, shed more sweat to earn that money. To get what is sweet, we need to shed sweat.

As the saying goes, there are no free lunches. To get something, we need to give something. More specifically, to relish higher happiness, we need to give up our current conceptions of happiness, most of which center on lower pleasures.

Why are some pleasures considered lower and some higher? Because of their results. If they lower our consciousness, making us more fixated on small things and more self-centered, then those pleasures are lower. They are lower also because they last for a lesser time; they are fleeting.

Higher pleasures are those that last much longer. Also, they bring out our higher side; they expand our consciousness and align our actions with higher realities, infusing our life with meaning and purpose.

Gita wisdom explains that our higher side is our spiritual side: we are at our core spiritual beings. We are presently encased in bodies and minds that are currently conduits for our consciousness to manifest and function in the world. Higher pleasures are those which elevate our consciousness to the spiritual level. The highest spiritual happiness is found when we as souls link with the supreme soul, the all-attractive person, Krishna in a bond of spiritual love. As the soul, the Supersoul and spiritual love all are eternal, the happiness found therein is also eternal.

However, raising our consciousness to the spiritual level requires effort because our consciousness is presently caught and bound at the material level. That's why the Bhagavad-gita (18.37) states that uplifting joys taste like poison initially but like nectar eventually.

Think it over

Why are some pleasures considered higher and some lower?

Why do higher pleasures cost more?

How are higher pleasures worth the higher cost?

18.37 That which in the beginning may be just like poison but at the end is just like nectar and which awakens one to self-realization is said to be happiness in the mode of goodness.

We have to risk going too far to know how far we can go

Suppose we are seeking something that requires effort and involves risk. When we start stretching ourselves, others may caution us, “You are going too far now. Better be careful.”

While caution is desirable, letting caution stop us from action is undesirable. To achieve anything worthwhile, we need to dedicate ourselves, which often equates with going too far in the world’s estimate. Only when we stretch ourselves do we discover the layers of strength and stamina that lie hidden within us. During life’s normal course, we don’t even bother to test the possible existence of such layers — and we deprive ourselves of higher happiness. For attaining any happiness that is meaningful and fulfilling, we sometimes need to go beyond our comfort zone, that is, we need to go too far. For such higher joys in the mode of goodness, the underlying principle is stated in the Bhagavad-gita (18.37); they taste like poison initially and like nectar eventually.

This principle applies especially to our spiritual pursuit. If we want to realize the ultimate spiritual reality and relish the highest transcendental joy, we need to offer our body, mind, soul, our everything, to our spiritual quest. Pertinently, the Gita states that those on the spiritual path are single-pointed in their determination (02.41).

When we thus strive to go too far, endeavoring to go beyond the worldly consciousness that is our comfort zone, we start relishing glimpses of love for Krishna, which is the zenith of all spiritual joys. Thus, we realize that, by divine grace, we can contribute toward creating a life that is far more meaningful and fulfilling than what we thought was ever possible.

Think it over

How does any worthwhile achievement require us to go too far?

How does the spiritual quest require us to go too far?

Have you ever stretched yourself and thereby discovered hidden capacities?
How can you apply that remembrance to your spiritual quest?

18.37 That which in the beginning may be just like poison but at the end is just like nectar and which awakens one to self-realization is said to be happiness in the mode of goodness.

Mindfulness

Manage the garbage in your mind or the garbage in your life will become unmanageable

Garbage that is not cleared often tends to multiply – even if it is kept in a bin, the bin starts stinking or polluting the environment.

The same principle applies to garbage in our mind. We all have certain waste thoughts – stray desires that are utterly unworthy. Such garbage often crowds and clouds our mind. And this garbage tends to grow, not just inside us but also outside us. Filthy thoughts inside us grow till they impel us to filthy actions that only make things worse, sometimes horrifyingly worse.

Pointing to how garbage within expands as garbage without, the Bhagavad-gita (02.62-63) outlines the trajectory through which our contemplation grows to infatuation, obsession, delusion and so on till we are dragged down to degradation, even destruction.

If we don't want to thus make a mess in our life or, worse still, a mess of our life, we need to begin by minimizing the mess in our mind. Just as a bin that is cleaned regularly remains usable, so too a mind that is cleaned regularly remains usable, instead of becoming useless or even harmful.

How can we manage the garbage in our mind?

By choosing what we take in, what we dwell on and what we turn away from.

The content in the mind is determined by perception, contemplation and rejection. On a more positive and transformative note, if we learn to carefully fill our mind with positivity, then negativity gets automatically driven out or kept out. And the ultimate positivity centers on the supreme positive reality, Krishna, and our eternal relationship of service with him.

When we invest time regularly to clean our mind by cultivating thoughts of Krishna through disciplined bhakti-yoga practice, we make our inner and outer worlds better.

Think it over

How does mental garbage multiply?

Where may mental garbage come from?

How can we best clean our mind?

02.62 One who restrains his senses, keeping them under full control, and fixes his consciousness upon Me, is known as a man of steady intelligence.

The mind is like ice to truth and fire to lies

The mind is meant to serve as a tool for us souls to perceive the world, but it is often the greatest obstacle for us to perceive the world. Here's how.

The mind is like ice to truth: Ice blocks the flow of things. When the relationship between two people is icy, their mutual communication gets impeded, if not blocked. Pointing to ice's blocking nature, ice-breakers are the names used for strategies to connect with new people.

We need to break ice not just for outer communication with others, but also for inner communication with ourselves. Our mind often becomes like ice for those truths which it finds unpalatable. One such unpalatable truth is that sensual pleasures are insubstantial. Because the mind is strongly attached to sensual pleasures, it ferociously resists any truths that scrutinize those pleasures.

The mind is like fire to lies: Forest fires are infamous for spreading rapidly, uncontrollably, destructively. Similarly, whenever the mind hears any rumor, gossip or even glamorization of sensual pleasures, it becomes like fire, spreading those half-truths and untruths both internally and externally. Internally, the promise of sensual pleasure consumes our consciousness, leaving us with no room to think of any higher truths. Indeed, once our mind starts believing the lies about how immense and irresistible sensual pleasures are, it burns away our scriptural knowledge and our spiritual inclination, thereby propelling us on the path to self-destructive indulgence.

Given the mind's resistance to truth and receptivity to lies, how can we protect ourselves? By cultivating the regular discipline of studying scripture, irrespective of how we feel. Thus, we can keep open in our consciousness at least one steady channel to timeless truth. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (03.43) declares that spiritualized intelligence can empower us to conquer our inner self-destructive desires.

Think it over

How is the mind like ice to truth?

How is the mind like fire to lies?

How can we protect ourselves from our mind?

03.43 Thus knowing oneself to be transcendental to the material senses, mind and intelligence, O mighty-armed Arjuna, one should steady the mind by deliberate spiritual intelligence [Krishna consciousness] and thus – by spiritual strength – conquer this insatiable enemy known as lust.

Everything is not in the mind, but everything comes through the mind

Some people say, “Everything is in the mind; if you just learn to train your mind, you won’t face any problems.”

Is that true? Not exactly. To understand why, consider two statements:

Everything is not in the mind: Why not? Because all reality is not just a construct of the mind. Gita wisdom explains that reality has three levels: physical, mental and spiritual. What happens at the physical level is real; it’s not just a mental conception. Suppose we bump our head into a wall and injure ourselves. The wall is real, the bump is real, the injury is real. If the injury is serious, we will need real medicinal treatment, not mere mental adjustment – just changing our mind’s thoughts won’t cure the injury.

Everything comes through the mind: Still, our mind determines the meaning we assign to that injury. We may label ourselves as bumbling fools and become depressed. Or we may label the world as cruel and become resentful. Or we may learn to avoid bumping into walls, take the necessary medication and move on. Thus, how our mind interprets the injury determines how it impacts our emotions.

In general, when we face any problem, that problem’s size is determined by the mind. How can we see our problems in proper perspective? By understanding that we ourselves exist beyond the mind, at the third level of reality: spiritual. The more we situate our consciousness at the indestructible spiritual level, the more we can have the inner security and clarity to constructively reshape our mind’s conceptions. By such reshaping, we can elevate ourselves with the mind, and not degrade ourselves (Bhagavad-gita 06.05).

By understanding that everything is not in the mind, we won’t minimize problems that need practical rectification. And by understanding that everything comes through the mind, we won’t let the mind maximize our problems either.

Think it over

Why is everything not in the mind?

How does everything come through the mind?

How can we see our problems in proper perspective?

06.05 One must deliver himself with the help of his mind, and not degrade himself. The mind is the friend of the conditioned soul, and his enemy as well.

Mind your mind to know when it is in order, when on the border and when out of order

Suppose we use a laptop for vital, high-stake work. We would not only do the work carefully, but would also carefully monitor the device to check its functionality.

The same principle applies all the more so to the device within us that is critical for everything we do. That device is our mind. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (06.05) states that we need to take responsibility to elevate ourselves with our mind and not degrade ourselves because our mind can be both our friend and our enemy.

To observe our mind, we need to be mindful. Mindfulness can be said to center on checking three things:

Is the mind in order? Just as a functioning device enables us to do what we want to do, an orderly mind enables us to have those thoughts, emotions and desires that help us pursue our values and purposes.

Is the mind on the border? Just as a machine on the border doesn't function properly, a mind on the border stutters and stumbles and bungles and lingers and meanders. It doesn't outright militate against our purposes and values, but it does distract us. When the mind is on the border, we need to soon take time out for activities that rejuvenate our mind such as meditation and study of wisdom-texts.

Is the mind out of order? Whereas an out-of-order machine usually just stops functioning, an out-of-order mind works against our values and purposes, making us our own worst enemy. We need to immediately fix our mind by doing spiritual activities that strengthen us.

When we thus mind our mind, we learn to harmonize our life with the all-attractive source of the ultimate order, Krishna, thereby relishing the supreme peace and joy.

Think it over

How can we know if our mind is in order?

If our mind is on the border, what do we need to do?

If our mind is out of order, how can we know? And what can we do?

06.05 One must deliver himself with the help of his mind, and not degrade himself. The mind is the friend of the conditioned soul, and his enemy as well.

Respect the dark within you, to keep it within you

Suppose we had a serious enemy out to destroy us. We couldn't afford to take them lightly; we would need to treat them with respect. Respect not in the sense that we bow down, but in the sense that we raise our guard. By forcing us to improve our defenses and increase our strength, our enemy may make us better, despite having no intention to do so.

We all have an enemy within us: our dark side. This dark side is comprised of our inner impurities such as lust, anger, greed, envy, arrogance, and illusion. These dark drives are stored as impressions in our mind. If we come under our mind's control, the dark impressions therein can make us act regrettably, even reprehensibly.

Because this dark side is inside us, it is like an enemy who has infiltrated us. We need to respect that dark side – respect not by submitting to it, but by guarding against it so that it doesn't take control of us and pervert us.

Thankfully, along with the dark side, we also have a bright side: our spiritual essence, our potential divinity as parts of the supreme divinity. If we take the responsibility to connect with the supreme and unleash our divinity, we become agents of positive change in the world.

Unfortunately, we don't usually strive sufficiently to manifest it. But when we realize how degraded our dark side can make us, we become jolted out of our complacency. We commit ourselves to connect with the divine, thereby initially restraining our dark side and then purging ourselves of it.

Acknowledging that inside us lie both our dark side that we need to restrain and our bright side that we need to release, the Bhagavad-gita (06.05) urges us to not degrade ourselves with our dark side, but elevate ourselves with our bright side.

Think it over

What is the dark side inside us?

What is the bright side inside us?

How does our dark side impel us to unleash our bright side?

06.05 For him who has conquered the mind, the mind is the best of friends;
but for one who has failed to do so, his mind will remain the greatest
enemy.

The media is mostly the mind multiplied, magnified and magnetized

Whenever some people hear of shocking instances of brutality or perversity, they hold the media responsible: “The media is feeding people’s minds with such images. That’s why people are doing such things.”

While their analysis has some validity, it sees things only one way. While the media affects the mind, it also expresses the mind. After all, the media is produced by people who are essentially like you and me. The media just expresses the mind multiplied, magnified and magnetized. Let’s see how.

Multiplied: The media pools together the imagination of many people — and gives expression to that collective creativity. Everyone has lust, but the media depicts the most lurid fantasies of multiple people.

Magnified: What might be present in one corner of our mind, the media presents it in full-screen before us. Not only that, the media depicts in multi-color what our mind may depict in black-and-white.

Magnetized: Just as a magnet attracts iron filings, the media is designed to be like a magnet to captivate us. Most media depictions are made using scientific studies into human psychology about how the mind can be manipulated most effectively.

We can’t immediately control what the media depicts, but we can begin by controlling our mind. The Bhagavad-gita (06.05) reminds us that the mind can be both our enemy and our friend — and urges us to take responsibility to elevate ourselves with the mind and not degrade ourselves. How can we make the mind our friend? By not exposing it to sensually agitating media and exposing it to spiritually uplifting media. Thereby, our mind will become purified and it will express itself by creating pure and purifying content in the outer media.

Thus, instead of blaming the media, if we focus on improving our mind, we can contribute toward creating a better media and a better world.

Think it over

How does the media express the mind?

How is the media the mind multiplied, magnified and magnetized?

What can we do to create a better media?

06.05 One must deliver himself with the help of his mind, and not degrade himself. The mind is the friend of the conditioned soul, and his enemy as well.

To be thoughtful, attribute every thought first to the mind

Our mind is like a thought-factory that churns out thoughts constantly. Most of these thoughts are irrelevant and unproductive, some are dark and destructive, and a few are insightful and creative.

If we uncritically identify with our thoughts and act accordingly, we will frequently be misled. We may end up stressed, obsessed, depressed, deluded, degraded. Ironically, identifying with our thoughts can make us act thoughtlessly. To become thoughtful, we need to carefully evaluate our thoughts.

However, because thoughts arise inside us, we tend to instinctively identify with them, presuming that they are our thoughts. How can we prevent this presumption? By reminding ourselves that we are not alone inside us – our mind is there too, and it is the source of most of our thoughts. The Bhagavad-gita provides us such reminders repeatedly, as when it (06.05) urges us to elevate ourselves with our mind, and not degrade ourselves. To elevate ourselves, we need to accept the mind's creative thoughts. To avoid degrading ourselves, we need to reject its destructive thoughts.

How can we practically do such thought-selection? By training ourselves to attribute every thought first to our mind. Whenever some thought arises inside us, we can precede it with the words, "The mind is saying ...". Thus, if we feel like watching something on Youtube, we can say to ourselves, "The mind is saying: watch something on Youtube." By such attribution, we can create a distance between that thought and us. Once the thought is held at a distance for our inspection, we can treat it as if it were a suggestion from someone else – to be neither summarily accepted nor summarily rejected but to be calmly considered on merit.

By training ourselves to attribute our thoughts first to our mind, we can rise from thoughtlessness to thoughtfulness.

Think it over

List three typical troublesome thoughts that you can attribute to your mind.

At the end of each day, take stock of how you fared in such attribution.

When you failed, note how much time you lost. When you succeeded, note how much time you saved.

06.05 One must deliver himself with the help of his mind, and not degrade himself. The mind is the friend of the conditioned soul, and his enemy as well.

Use introspection as a confession by the self to the self

Confession is a religious practice wherein confessants, people who have done something wrong, admit those wrongs to an authority figure, a confessor. As admitting our wrongs is embarrassing, the imperative to confess can deter us from repeating those wrongs. And the confessors' guidance can also help us rectify ourselves. Thus, confession can be a powerful tool for course correction.

And we all need regular course correction because we are prone to be misled by the world outside, which is filled with temptations, as well as by the mind inside, which is filled with impressions.

Nowadays, however, the practice of confession has fallen into disrepute because confessors have sometimes exploited confessants. Also, with society becoming increasingly fragmented and fast-paced, people may not have anyone trustworthy and available to confess to.

Even if we can't confess to others, we can still use the course-correcting capacity of confession. How? By adapting introspection as a tool for confession. Introspection literally means to see within. While introspecting to confess, the active I – the part of us that keeps us on the move, wanting to achieve and accumulate – can confess to the contemplative I: the part of us that is aware of our deeper values and higher purposes. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita points to this dynamic of two selves within us when it urges us to elevate ourselves with the self, not degrade ourselves (06.05).

If we create regular pauses in our schedule, report to ourselves what we have been doing and evaluate how and why we have done it, then we can catch ourselves before we go too off-track. We can introspect better if we study wisdom-texts like the Gita that nourish our contemplative side and purify our active side.

By periodic introspection, we can do the necessary course correction, thereby staying true to our deeper values and moving toward our higher purposes.

Think it over

How can introspection serve the purpose served by confession?

In which areas of your life do you tend to go off-course?

To stay on-course, how can you use introspection effectively?

06.05 One must deliver himself with the help of his mind, and not degrade himself. The mind is the friend of the conditioned soul, and his enemy as well.

Watch yourself as if you are someone you don't know; self-observation opens the door to self-transformation

Suppose we want to develop a relationship with someone. We will observe them carefully, noting how they behave in various situations, especially in difficult situations. By such observation, we can understand them better.

Intriguingly, we can use this same strategy to learn about ourselves. Why would we want to do that? Don't we already know ourselves? Not entirely. We are incredibly complex, having manifold thoughts, emotions and desires, many of which run contrary to each other. And these exist at various levels inside us: some at the surface; some, buried deep within.

We can get a sense of the unknown within us by contemplating how we sometimes surprise ourselves by our good actions and sometimes shock ourselves by our bad actions. Clearly, we don't know ourselves well enough. That's why we can and should use self-observation to increase our self-understanding.

While observing ourselves, we shouldn't get so lost in ourselves that we forget the purpose of observing ourselves: self-transformation. The Bhagavad-gita (06.05) recommends such purposeful self-observation when it urges us to elevate ourselves with ourselves, not degrade ourselves with ourselves.

When we try to transform ourselves, we often fail. Why? One reason is that we often focus on self-restraint and self-criticism, thereby creating negative feelings such as discouragement, deprivation and resentment. Instead, if we focus on self-observation, then we can better understand how to transform ourselves.

Suppose we spot someone doing something counter-productive. Suppose further that we don't know them well, but still care for them. Then we won't immediately restrain or reproach them; we will seek to find a way to communicate our concern as sensitively and effectively as possible.

When we adopt a similar approach toward ourselves, then self-observation, self-understanding and self-transformation will grow simultaneously, seamlessly, symbiotically.

Think it over

Why do we need to observe ourselves?

Why is it helpful to shift our focus from self-transformation to self-observation?

For three days, try to look at yourself once every hour. Did you learn anything useful about yourself?

06.05 For him who has conquered the mind, the mind is the best of friends; but for one who has failed to do so, his mind will remain the greatest enemy.

Even if the mind is not shrill, it is still a shill

A shill is someone who enthusiastically pretends to buy something from a shop so as to allure others to also buy. Our mind is sometimes shrill and sometimes a shill. Here's how.

When the mind is shrill, we sense something within us sharply goading, yelling, pushing us to do something. A shrilling mind is difficult to resist, but at least it's easy to notice, provided we are aware of the basic dynamics of our inner world. Once we recognize that the inner impelling voice is our mind, we can find appropriate measures to evaluate and regulate it.

However, the mind is often tougher to resist when it is difficult to notice, as when it acts subtly by becoming a shill. To understand how the mind works as a shill, we need to appreciate a basic truth about how we function: all things are done twice, first by our mind, then by us. That is, we think about doing something and we create mental avatars of ourselves which does those things in our inner world. And once we uncritically accept what those avatars are doing, we start doing them ourselves. Thus, for example, when we spend hours surfing the net randomly, it's our mind that first surfs the net in our imagination and then we surf the net.

By being shrill or by being a shill, the mind acts as our enemy, as the Bhagavad-gita (06.06) cautions. By knowing how dangerous our mind can be, we can take more seriously the twin disciplines of inner observation and inner purification. Inner observation is stimulated by scriptural study, and inner purification is stimulated by connecting with the all-pure supreme spiritual reality, Krishna. Once we become situated in our spiritual identity through observation and purification, then we can more effectively get the mind to chill, both when it is shrill and when a shill.

Think it over

How is our mind shrill?

How is our mind a shill?

How can we discipline our mind?

06.06 For him who has conquered the mind, the mind is the best of friends; but for one who has failed to do so, his mind will remain the greatest enemy.

Our mind is constantly hiding and is constantly ready to give us a hiding

On our daily path, suppose someone waits hiding for us. Catching us unawares, they bully and beat us. As long as they are hiding, we can't stop them from giving us a hiding.

Unfortunately, similar is our actual plight. Inside all of us is our mind, which often acts like our worst enemy (Bhagavad-gita 06.06). It makes us believe that life's troubles are far bigger than what they actually are, thereby making us feel resentful, victimized, depressed. It also makes us believe that worldly pleasures are far more enjoyable than what they actually are, thereby making us crave and slave for them. Overall, by inducing negative feelings of dissatisfaction that degenerate to self-pity, self-loathing and self-destruction, the mind gives us a terrible hiding. Today, tormented by their minds, millions are distressed, seeking escape in mindless entertainment. Finding the mind's constant beating unbearable, thousands even end their lives.

Despite being tormented repeatedly, we often fail to even identify our terrible tormentor. Why? Because it's hiding within us. Instead of pointing to the mind, we point to a myriad of other things: to ourselves because we keep doing unworthy things; to the world because it troubles and tempts us in so many ways; to people who come in the way of our getting what we want to get.

Gita wisdom serves as a flashlight that illumines our inner world. It helps us understand how everything inside us is not us, that our mind is not us. More importantly, it reveals that hiding within us is not just our mind, but also our Lord, who is stronger, subtler and smarter than our mind and can save us from its shenanigans. When we live in the light of the Gita, we start catching the mind before it catches us.

Think it over

How does our mind give us a hiding?

Why can't we identify our inner tormentor?

How can we catch the mind before it catches us?

06.06 For him who has conquered the mind, the mind is the best of friends; but for one who has failed to do so, his mind will remain the greatest enemy.

Stop playing games with your mind and with those who play games with your mind

Suppose a person starts playing with a poisonous snake, treating it like a pet or a toy. They would be courting danger. Suppose they had charmed and tamed the snake. Still, if they later associated with someone who could drive the snake wild and mad, then again, they would be in danger.

Our mind is like a poisonous snake, for it can at any moment inject into us self-destructive desires and feelings. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (06.06) declares that the uncontrolled mind can be our worst enemy.

How do we play games with our mind? We often forget or neglect the reality that the mind is dangerous, and we nonchalantly pander to its whims, thinking that they are harmless. And suddenly, we may find ourselves badly bitten, as those innocuous-seeming whims metastasize into deadly self-defeating drives. To prevent such danger, we need to remember the mind's potential malevolence and deal with it alertly.

How do others play games with our mind? Even if we have succeeded in reasonably restraining our mind, some people around us may know our weaknesses and deliberately exploit them. For example, if they know that we have a deep-rooted fear of abandonment, they may plant doubts in our mind about our loved ones. And we may spend hours and years agonizing over suspicions that have no basis in fact. If we don't want to be tormented thus, we need to keep at a safe distance such people who play games with our mind.

To keep both our mind and its manipulators at a distance, an effective way is to stay purposefully engaged in the loving service of the all-powerful supreme, Krishna. Such service invokes his pure presence in our heart, thereby driving afar all ungodly influences, internal and external.

Think it over

Why is playing games with our mind dangerous?

How can people play games with our mind?

How can we stop playing games with our mind and its manipulators?

06.06 For him who has conquered the mind, the mind is the best of friends; but for one who has failed to do so, his mind will remain the greatest enemy.

As long as we don't mine under the mind, the mind will undermine us

Suppose someone is digging for buried gold. If they find iron coated to look like gold and celebrate prematurely, they will miss the real treasure.

A similar misapprehension can undermine our quest for self-understanding. Genuine self-understanding is a treasure; it helps us know our real needs and, concomitantly, the way to real happiness.

However, self-understanding can be elusive because our inner world is complex and multi-level. Within us, there is the mind, whose voice is often prominent, incessant and insistent. Beyond or under the mind is the soul, which is who we are essentially. Because in our inner world, the mind is loud, we often misidentify with it. When we act to fulfill the mind's promptings, what we get at best is fleeting gratification. Why? Because the things the mind craves for are temporary. In fact, even the mind's cravings for them are temporary, for the mind is fickle. If we settle for such fleeting gratification instead of seeking enduring satisfaction available through authentic self-realization, we undermine ourselves. That's why we need to mine under the mind means, to seek self-understanding beyond the mind's promptings.

How can we mine under the mind? Through education and purification. Education in Gita wisdom equips us to separate gold-coated iron from gold, that is, to separate the mind's feelings and cravings from the soul's longings. Purification by connecting with all-pure Krishna cleanses the impure impressions in our mind, thereby weakening its misleading voice.

When we mine under the mind, we realize ourselves to be souls, who are parts of the all-attractive Whole, Krishna. To gain this realization is to find gold in our inner world, thereby transcending the world's dualities: heat-cold, pleasure-pain, honor-dishonor (Bhagavad-gita 06.07).

By thus mining under the mind, we all can be enriched, eternally and ecstatically.

Think it over

Why do we misidentify with the mind?

How does misidentifying with the mind undermine us?

How can we mine under the mind?

06.07 For one who has conquered the mind, the Supersoul is already reached, for he has attained tranquillity. To such a man happiness and distress, heat and cold, honor and dishonor are all the same.

Focus on life, not on the mind's commentary about life

Suppose a cricket match is accompanied by a special kind of commentary that is heard not just by the spectators, but also by the players.

Suppose further that the commentator is biased and gives a negative spin to everything the batsman does. Suppose the batsman is batting well, gallantly and expertly leading the team's recovery after a sudden batting collapse. But the commentator labels the batsman's performance as a mere short-lived fluke before the batting team's inevitable defeat.

If the batsman hears such commentary uncritically, they will become disheartened. They may even play a poor shot and get out. To bat properly, they need to focus on the match, not on the commentary.

Similarly, our life is like a cricket match, wherein we are like the batsman and our mind is like the commentator. The mind comments negatively on whatever we do, even when we are acting constructively and are doing reasonably well. If we listen uncritically to the mind's commentary, we will become disheartened and give up. We need to neglect the mind's commentary and focus on life: on how things actually are and how we can best respond.

However, because the mind is inside us, it's difficult to neglect. Thankfully, inside us is also our Lord and guide, Krishna. When we connect devotionally with him, we start becoming increasingly calm, realizing that he is in ultimate control of things and will raise us through life's lows, provided we just keep doing our part. This conviction stabilizes us, decreasing our vulnerability to the mind whenever it exaggerates life's inevitable negative phases (Bhagavad-gita 06.07). Moreover, that connection increases our inner positivity, thereby gradually silencing the mind's negative commentary and energizing us to create a better life.

Think it over

Explain with an example how the mind's commentary distorts reality.

How can we deal with the mind's negative commentary?

Typically, what kind of negative commentaries does your mind give? Give those typical commentaries names so that you can identify them before they

mislead you.

06.07 For one who has conquered the mind, the Supersoul is already reached, for he has attained tranquillity. To such a man happiness and distress, heat and cold, honor and dishonor are all the same.

To get out of the mind, go above it to the soul or go below it to the body

The mind can be a deadly enemy that can delude and degrade us at any moment. To protect ourselves from it, we need to get our consciousness out of the mind's thoughts. How can we do that? Either by going above it to the soul or by going below it to the body.

Going above the mind to the soul: When we are situated in spiritual knowledge, we can observe the things outside and the thoughts inside without getting caught in the melodrama at either level. The more we distance ourselves from both, the more we can evaluate the mind's thoughts on merit and then act appropriately. We can raise our consciousness to the spiritual level through time-tested practices such as meditation. Especially potent is devotional meditation on the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna, as recommended in the Bhagavad-gita (06.14).

Going below the mind to the body: When we focus our consciousness on some specific physical object such as our breath (06.11), the tip of our nose (06.13) or the space between our eyebrows (05.27), that physical focus can aid us in distancing ourselves from the mind. Best is if that physical focus is connected with some spiritual reality, that is, our object of focus is a sacred image or a divine sound. Then the redirection of consciousness from the physical to the spiritual level is faster. Initially however, just going for a walk or retreating to a place close to nature may help us kickstart the process of getting out of our mind.

When we thus resourcefully learn to get out of our mind, we can protect ourselves from self-destruction and progress toward self-realization.

Think it over

How can we get out of the mind to the spiritual level?

How can we get out of the mind to the physical level?

For getting out of the mind, what ways work best for you?

06.13 One should hold one's body, neck and head erect in a straight line and stare steadily at the tip of the nose.

Intelligence means to know which thoughts are to be pinned and which to be binned

Suppose we regularly use sticky notes. If too many notes clutter our notice board, we would need to sort them. We would pin those that are still relevant and trash the remaining.

We need a similar discernment in dealing with our thoughts. If we consider our mind to be like an internal sticky board, various thoughts are like sticky notes on the mind. Hundreds of thoughts appear in the mind – some of them stick there for long. However, the thoughts that stick are not always about things that are the most important; they are often about things that we are most attached to or most exposed to.

A fundamental psychological principle is that our thoughts gain prominence and power in proportion to the attention we give them. If some thoughts get pinned on our minds, we keep thinking about them repeatedly. Fueled by that attention, they grow till they fill our mental screen, preventing us from contemplating or doing anything else. That's how, even while doing important things, we get distracted by trivial things or even terrible things.

If our inner notice board is to help us manage our lives better, thoughts about important things need to be pinned there. How? By conscientiously thinking about those things repeatedly, even if our attention wanders elsewhere. Conversely, trivial thoughts need to be binned. How? By intentional neglect. Because thoughts are not physical things, we can't physically send them to a bin. But we can neglect them till they decline and disappear due to the lack of attention.

Analyzing accurately which thoughts are to be pinned and which to be binned characterizes good intelligence. The Bhagavad-gita (06.25) recommends that we use our intelligence sustained by conviction to monitor our mind and focus it on the things that matter.

Think it over

How do we get distracted?

How can we pin some thoughts and bin others?

List three thoughts that you need to pin and three you need to bin.

06.25 Gradually, step by step, one should become situated in trance by means of intelligence sustained by full conviction, and thus the mind should be fixed on the Self alone and should think of nothing else.

The lesser the structure in our life, the greater the rupture the mind can cause in our life

Our mind is restless (Bhagavad-gita 06.34) – it's like a child. Children can spend their entire day or even their entire life playing with toys. Their guardians need to bring some structure to their lives by allotting some time to go to school, some time to study and so forth.

We may be adults, but our mind remains childishly restless. Suppose on waking up in the morning, our mind suggests that we watch TV. We might watch for some time, but will stop thereafter if our life is structured, whereby certain things such as going to work need to be done at certain times. If, however, it's an unstructured weekend, we might spend the whole day or even the whole weekend glued to the idiot box.

Nowadays technology, especially the Internet, has opened almost unending doors for distraction and delusion. Consequently, the rupture the mind can cause in our life is almost unlimited.

That's why we all need some structure for our life: some fixed times, or at least time ranges, to wake up, to sleep, to take our meals, to read, to exercise, to do our spiritual practices.

What if the structure feels too restrictive? Then, by experience and self-observation, we can gradually adapt the structure to suit our needs and nature. A rigid structure may not work for us; but without a structure, we may not work.

By designing a customized structure for ourselves, we can gradually progress toward creating a life that is meaningful, productive and fulfilling.

Think it over

List three occasions when a lack of structure let you get excessively distracted.

List three occasions when a structure protected you from the mind's distractions.

List three things that are most important for you. Plan how you can structure your life around those things.

06.34 Lord Shri Krishna said: O mighty-armed son of Kunti, it is undoubtedly very difficult to curb the restless mind, but it is possible by suitable practice and by detachment.

The mind is restless, reasonless, ruthless, relentless

Why is controlling the mind so difficult?

The Bhagavad-gita (06.34) explains using four describers, which can be summarized as four R's:

Restless (canchala): The mind is like a child that doesn't stay fixed on one activity, but keeps flitting from one thing to the next. Because the mind jumps from one thing to another to another, it obstructs us in doing things that require sustained attention.

Reasonless (pramathi): The mind is like a madman who doesn't listen to reason. Whereas a child is relatively harmless, a madman can be hugely dangerous. Once the mind gets infatuated with something, it goes after that thing like crazy, impelling us to act senselessly.

Ruthless (balavad): The mind is like a bully who abuses their strength to cause others fear and pain – and delights in doing so. Once the mind gets captivated by something, it uses all its formidable power to coax and coerce us to get that thing. If we resolve to say no to whatever the mind is proposing, it sadistically intimidates us till we give up our resolution and give in to its will.

Relentless (drudham): The mind is like a leech. Once a leech finds a prey and starts sucking blood, it just doesn't let go; if it is pulled, it pulls out the prey's skin. Similarly, once the mind catches hold of something as its pet infatuation, it relentlessly holds fast. No matter how much we try to stop thinking of that thing, the mind sticks to it till we lose heart and do the mind's bidding.

When we unsentimentally understand how formidable an enemy the mind is, we become much more internally vigilant. Guided by Gita wisdom, we become diligent in allying with our greatest well-wisher, Krishna, who is far stronger than the mind and can empower us to rein it in.

Think it over

How is the mind restless and reasonless?

How is the mind ruthless and relentless?

How can we rein in the mind?

06.34 The mind is restless, turbulent, obstinate and very strong, O Krishna, and to subdue it, I think, is more difficult than controlling the wind.

The mind is so wild that it can make us homeless at home

Our mind is extremely powerful and restless. Through its thoughts, it can go from one end of the universe to another within a moment. It can similarly shift our emotions toward someone from immense attraction to utter aversion, again within a moment.

Home is the place where we feel protected, comforted, connected. Yet when we are driven by our mind, we can be dragged far away from the very people that make us feel at home — till we end up feeling lonely, suspicious, miserable. Someone may be physically close to us, but emotionally our mind can take us light years away from them. When our relationships with our loved ones become strained, we need to check whether our mind is making us averse to them.

The Bhagavad-gita (06.34) cautions that our mind is restless, reasonless, relentless, ruthless; indeed, it is like a furious wind. Just as a stormy wind can sweep things far away and is unstoppable, our mind can sweep us — our emotions, our thoughts, our consciousness — far away from everything we value.

That's why we need to restrain the mind before it gains momentum. How to restrain it? By not giving undue attention to its petty gripes or irrational mood swings.

More importantly, we need to lead the mind to its ultimate home: our all-loving Lord, Krishna. He is the reservoir of all attractiveness — the attractive principle underlying the many things that attract and agitate the mind. When we habituate ourselves to focusing on him by practicing bhakti-yoga, the mind finds shelter and satisfaction in his remembrance, thereby coming to rest.

If we don't feel sufficiently at home in our home, we can begin by training our mind to find its home in Krishna. Being thus mentally stabilized, we can deal with issues appropriately and thereby find our way home, both materially and spiritually.

Think it over

How can our mind make us feel homeless at home?

How can we check our stormy mind?

How does focusing on Krishna calm our mind?

06.34 The mind is restless, turbulent, obstinate and very strong, O Krishna, and to subdue it, I think, is more difficult than controlling the wind.

The mind makes us spin like dirty laundry and leaves us dirtier

Suppose we put our laundry in a washing machine. After being washed, if the laundry ends up dirtier, we would be appalled. Before washing any other laundry, we would first fix the machine.

Our mind is like an inner machine that can make us spin like laundry. Here's how. We are essentially where our thoughts are. We don't just think our thoughts; we travel with our thoughts. And our mind is the generator of thoughts. Sometimes, it generates thoughts at a stormy speed (Bhagavad-gita 06.34). When we get caught in such thoughts, we get hurled far away from where we wanted to be.

Sometimes however, the mind doesn't hurl us away; it just whirls us round and round. This happens when our mind generates thoughts that are pointless, fruitless and endless. When we face vexing problems, our mind keeps brooding on them, to no avail. After such unproductive thinking, we end up more confused, more troubled, more drained. Desperately needing relief, we seek some pleasure that seems readily available. And such pleasure is usually impure.

We all have some desires for impure pleasures that hover at the back of our consciousness. Thus, we are already like dirty laundry. And when we are spun around by the mind, the resulting exasperation and exhaustion make us seek relief in that impure indulgence, thus making us more impure.

Understanding how our mind can delude and degrade us, we need to give top priority to fixing our mind before trying to think our way through any perplexing problem. How can we fix our mind? By fixing our thoughts on the one shelter that the mind can't spin: the all-powerful Supreme, Krishna. Being thus internally fixed, we can seek the clarity and competence necessary for fixing external issues.

Think it over

How does our mind make us spin like laundry?

How are we like dirty laundry? How does our mind make us dirtier?

Before trying to fix perplexing problems, what do we need to do as a top priority?

06.34 The mind is restless, turbulent, obstinate and very strong, O Krishna, and to subdue it, I think, is more difficult than controlling the wind.

The mind stops us not just from achieving our dreams, but also from pursuing them

People on the deathbed often have many regrets. The greatest of such regrets center on, “If only I had done this ...”.

We all dream of doing something wonderful or at least worthwhile in their lives. But very few of us even start pursuing such dreams, leave alone achieving them. Why? Because our mind discourages us. One common way the mind discourages is by demanding certainty of success: “What if I don’t succeed? All my hard work will go waste. Why waste my energy?”

However, we live in a world of uncertainty. We can’t have certainty of success or even of survival – we may not be alive tomorrow. By demanding certainty of success as a precondition for any endeavor, the mind sentences us to the certainty of failure: if nothing is sought, nothing is got.

Our mind is, of course, a champion at dreaming – it’s like a child with an overactive imagination. However, when it comes to working for actualizing any dream, it exhibits another childish trait: restlessness (Bhagavad-gita 06.34). It keeps flitting over a hundred things, committing to hardly anything and achieving nothing.

How can we prevent the mind from sabotaging our dreams? By raising our vision above the uncertain material level to the unchanging spiritual level. Gita wisdom explains that we are souls, parts of the supreme spiritual being, Krishna. He has gifted all of us certain potentials. If we connect with him by practicing bhakti-yoga, we start tuning in to his empowering voice, thereby transcending and silencing the mind’s discouraging voice. Being guided by him, we start manifesting our potentials in a mood of contribution.

When we thus live for Krishna, he enriches our hearts with his divine presence. Being thus enriched, we can better fulfill our dreams. And even if we can’t fulfill some specific dreams, we will still be fulfilled.

Think it over

How does the mind sentence us to failure?

How can we transcend the mind's discouraging voice?

Even when our dreams aren't fulfilled, how can we be fulfilled?

06.34 The mind is restless, turbulent, obstinate and very strong, O Krishna, and to subdue it, I think, is more difficult than controlling the wind.

Watch the mind, or the mind will catch you

Suppose we are living in a high crime locality where thieves will catch and steal from us if we aren't alert. Naturally, we will give the highest priority to staying alert.

We all already live in such a high crime locality. That locality is our inner world, where reigns a formidable thief: our own mind. Our mind is formidable not just because it is so strong but also because it is so stealthy. At any moment, it can sneak in and steal away that which matters most: our consciousness. Why does our consciousness matter so much? Because it is our fundamental resource for doing anything at all.

How does the mind pull off the robbery of our consciousness? By deluding us into a sense of complacency and blindness. Because the mind is inside us, it often passes below the threshold of our perception.

To notice it, we need to expand our perception so that we start perceiving our inner world. For such perception expansion, the Bhagavad-gita is a time-tested guidebook. Urging us to become more watchful about our inner world, the Gita (06.34) cautions that the mind is restless, reasonless, ruthless and relentless.

How can we protect ourselves from our mind's formidable power? By watching it carefully. Significantly, the best way to watch the mind is by having something higher to watch and work on. If we seek to watch the mind alone, it will subtly swallow us into its illusions and illusory actions. Instead, we can focus on a higher reality, especially the highest reality, Krishna. When we connect with him through inner remembrance and outer service, that connection will eventually become increasingly fulfilling. Thus, we will see the mind's distraction as a deprivation, and get the resolve to resist it firmly and transcend it eventually.

Think it over

Why does our consciousness matter so much?

What does our mind rob from us?

How does it rob? What is the best way to watch the mind?

06.34 The mind is restless, turbulent, obstinate and very strong, O Krishna, and to subdue it, I think, is more difficult than controlling the wind.

What the mind makes us do would be comic if its consequences were not so tragic

In some comedy shows, some people do stunningly stupid things, repeatedly. Seeing their stupidity can be hilarious.

Sadly, many people's real lives are not much different. Suppose someone stuffed themselves with food so much that they became sick. And they did the same thing repeatedly. It might seem comic, but over time, if they developed some serious digestive disorder or worse still a life-threatening condition, that would be tragic indeed.

Why do they act in this way? Because of their mind. Within everyone is their worst enemy, their own mind, which often makes them do stupid things. If we looked at their life in fast-forward, slowing down to notice the times when they blundered, we might find such actions laughable. The Bhagavad-gita (06.34) cautions that the mind is restless and forceful — a deadly combination that makes resisting it almost impossible and relapsing to its whims almost unavoidable.

Our mind may not impel us to anything that blatant, but it impels us to minor indiscretions that can have major consequences. If we counted how much time we wasted on pointless TV watching, we may well discover that even small daily time wastages amount to colossal time expenses in the long run. If we cut down just ten minutes from our daily time wastage, we would gain 3,600 minutes every year. That's enough time to read the Bhagavad-gita with a commentary.

If we kept ourselves deprived of the wisdom from such wisdom-texts, that would be tragic indeed. How many other things that bring meaning and value to our life do we not do because of our mind's misdirections?

Thankfully, Gita wisdom stands ready to equip us with time-tested spiritual practices for managing our mind and fulfilling our potentials — provided we become aware and alert to equip ourselves.

Think it over

How are the consequences of our mind-induced actions tragic?

Are there any occasions when you realized the tragic consequences of succumbing to your mind?

How can we stand up to our mind?

06.34 The mind is restless, turbulent, obstinate and very strong, O Krishna, and to subdue it, I think, is more difficult than controlling the wind.

The mind's complaining about a problem is often a bigger problem than the problem itself

When the weather is bad, say, too cold, we all are inconvenienced. But some people start complaining repeatedly, "It's so cold, it's so cold, it's so cold." Over time, their continuous complaining becomes more irritating than the cold itself. To keep our sanity and clarity, we need to move away and stay away from such complainers.

Unfortunately, we all have such a chronic complainer right inside us: our mind. When we face some problem, especially some problem that leaves us with little power to rectify it, our mind starts complaining, "This is terrible, terrible, terrible." It becomes like a stuck audio player replaying the same track endlessly. Hearing that unrelenting track, we start becoming more and more discouraged till we stop even trying to do anything constructive. The Bhagavad-gita (06.34) states that relentlessness is one of the attributes of the mind that makes it almost unmanageable.

How can we manage such a mind? We can't move away or stay away from it, but we needn't always focus on what it is saying.

Returning to the starting example of the weather complainer, suppose we are absorbed in working on something important. That absorption can make us transcend both the weather and the complaining. And just as absorption can help us neglect outer complainers, it can help us neglect the inner complainer too.

We all need to cultivate absorption in something bigger than ourselves. Bhakti wisdom offers us the highest purpose by helping us connect with Krishna. By that connection, we develop faith in his plan for us and we strive to reshape ourselves as malleable instruments in his plan. Once we start sensing his presence and benevolence in our life, even if the problems persist, we can neglect and transcend our mind's complaining.

Think it over

How can the mind's complaining magnify a problem?

How can absorption in Krishna protect us from the mind's complaining?

What does your mind complain the most about? What can you most easily absorb yourself in?

06.34 The mind is restless, turbulent, obstinate and very strong, O Krishna, and to subdue it, I think, is more difficult than controlling the wind.

The mind is like a bully who has terrorized us for long; it's time to stand up

Suppose a school has a bully who terrorizes smaller children. Bullies generally prey on the weak and the weak-willed. Whoever becomes scared of them, they start dominating those kids more and more.

Our mind is like a big bully. The Bhagavad-gita (06.34) cautions that the mind is ruthless, relentless, reasonless and remorseless. It intimidates us into doing things that range from trivial to reprehensible, and it interrupts us whenever we are doing anything worthwhile.

How can we manage the mind? The Gita acknowledges that the mind is undoubtedly difficult to control (06.35), but it is possible by the appropriate process (06.36). To understand the appropriate process, consider how a bully can be countered.

To keep a bully at bay, kids need to stand up to that bully. But how can someone who is far smaller than a bully stand up to them? By connecting with someone who is stronger than the bully.

We too need to stand up to the mind, resolving to no longer pander to its whims. To get the necessary strength, we can connect with omnipotent Krishna by practicing bhakti-yoga.

But bhakti practices done ritualistically won't help much – those practices need to be done intensely to show Krishna our desire to resist the mind. When we strive to engage in worthwhile activities centered on Krishna's service and resist the mind whenever it tries to distract us, our determination shows Krishna that we want his help.

We have spent days, months, years, decades, lifetimes cowering to the mind, failing to fulfill our potentials. Enough is enough. It's time to stand up to the mind. And when we start standing up to the mind, we will soon find Krishna standing next to us, empowering us to put the mind in its place.

Think it over

How is the mind like a bully?

How can we counter the mind's bullying?

How can we get the determination to put the mind in its place?

06.36 For one whose mind is unbridled, self-realization is difficult work. But he whose mind is controlled and who strives by appropriate means is assured of success. That is My opinion.

If we let our mind devalue our efforts to improve our life, it will
end up devaluing our entire life

We sometimes try to do some things to improve our life. Though we start enthusiastically, soon our mind starts devaluing our efforts: “Even if you improve in this area, how long will the improvement stay? Not for long. Even if you improve steadily, still so many things are wrong with you. What difference will fixing one thing make? Not much. Why bother struggling to improve?”

If we listen to our mind’s devaluing insinuations, it will gradually start devaluing our entire life: “What difference is your life going to make? Given all the struggles of life, what is the point of living?” Such dark thoughts can make us disheartened, chronically depressed, even suicidal.

How can we prevent such deadly devaluation? By learning to listen to Krishna instead of listening to the mind.

If we regularly hear Krishna’s words in the Bhagavad-gita, we will start seeing ourselves spiritually. When we see that within our perishable body exists the imperishable soul, accompanied by the imperishable Supersoul, then we won’t be misled by our mind (13.29). Spiritual vision reassures us that no matter how much our mind devalues us, Krishna still values us – and values us so much that he stays constantly with us. If we connect with him devotionally and strive to improve ourselves in a mood of service, he will empower us to improve in ways we had earlier considered impossible.

In fact, Krishna values our life so much that if we devote our present human life to him, he will grant us eternal life in return. Thus, he not only values us, but also infuses our life with enduring value.

When Krishna already values us and is eager to enrich our life with value, why should we value our mind’s words more than Krishna’s words?

Think it over

How can the mind devalue our efforts and even our entire life?

How can we protect ourselves from the mind’s devaluing insinuations?

How can Krishna infuse our life with value?

13.29 One who sees the Supersoul equally present everywhere, in every living being, does not degrade himself by his mind. Thus he approaches the transcendental destination.

The mind burdens us and deems as burdens those who offer to relieve our burdens

Suppose someone thrusts a huge burden upon us. We'll feel annoyed, even angered, thinking: "Why do I have to carry this?" But, if they force us to carry it and we can't refuse to do so, we'll still carry it reluctantly.

Seeing us burdened, suppose some kind person offers to share or carry our burden. But, then the burden-giver drives them away. We would feel infuriated, "Why are you making my life miserable?"

Unfortunately, that's exactly what the mind does to us, but we hardly ever realize it.

Suppose something has gone wrong in our life. Almost instantly, the mind floods us with negative feelings such as: "Life stinks. The world is so cruel. No one cares for me. I am a good-for-nothing." When we start feeling burdened by such thoughts, some well-wishers approach and ask us, "Are you ok? Can I do anything to help? Do you want to talk?" Our mind then makes us see their offer for assistance as interference, impelling us to say something like: "I am ok. Just leave me alone."

Even if the mind doesn't make us rebuff other people, it certainly makes us rebuff our all-loving Lord, Krishna. Whatever burdens we are carrying can be best relieved if we turn toward him. When the light of his remembrance enters our consciousness, the darkness of negativity has to flee.

But the impudent mind makes us feel that the bhakti practices meant for connecting us with Krishna are a big burden. Thereby keeping us burdened.

Empowering us to see through the mind's shenanigans, the Bhagavad-gita (13.29) reminds us that Krishna is present in everyone's heart, including ours. If we can remember that he is ready to help and if we reciprocate appropriately with offers for help from our various well-wishers, then our mind won't be able to keep us down for long.

Think it over

How does the mind burden us?

How does the mind drive away potential helpers?

How can we see through the mind's shenanigans?

13.29 One who sees the Supersoul equally present everywhere, in every living being, does not degrade himself by his mind. Thus he approaches the transcendental destination.

Even if we can't control our emotions, we can control the attention we give to our emotions

Suppose some hawker comes near our property and starts peddling their wares. If we pay attention to them, they will start promoting more loudly, excitedly, aggressively. Hearing them, we may gradually get interested, attracted, persuaded – and end up buying something we didn't need at all.

Like uninvited hawkers, various distracting emotions appear uninvited at the periphery of our consciousness. Despite no apparent trigger, we start feeling emotions such as loneliness, boredom or anger. Faced with such mood swings, we may feel helpless and get carried away.

But are we really helpless in the face of our emotions? Not entirely. If we compare our emotions to hawkers, even if we can't drive them away, we can choose to not pay attention. Even if we can't control how we feel, we can still control how much we think about how we feel. Emotions that are fed with our attention become stronger; starved of our attention, they weaken.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (14.22) reminds us that our emotions usually arise from the modes of material nature, whereas we are spiritual beings, souls, who are different from those emotions. Just as we can more easily neglect hawkers if we are busy doing something important, we can neglect distracting emotions more effectively if we busy ourselves in the most important activity: purposeful service to the all-attractive supreme soul, Krishna (14.26).

If we just try to serve Krishna as much as we can despite the presence of distracting emotions, our intent will please him. And he will give us the taste to become absorbed in him, thereby fully turning away from unwanted emotions.

Think it over

How are we not helpless in the face of our emotions?

Can you recollect any incidents when your attention strengthened a distracting emotion and your lack of attention weakened it?

When distracted by emotions, list three activities that you can busy yourself in.

14.22 The Supreme Personality of Godhead said: O son of Pandu, he who does not hate illumination, attachment and delusion when they are present or long for them when they disappear;[– such a person is said to have transcended the modes of nature].

The mind overpowers us by making us believe that we are powerless

Suppose a person about to confront an opponent is told that their opponent is so powerful that fighting is fruitless. If the fighter believes that assessment, they will become so disheartened as to accept defeat even before the fight begins. Or they will fight so halfheartedly as to make defeat nearly inevitable. Whoever misleads them thus is an enemy they need to defeat before they can meaningfully confront their opponent.

Our mind is such an insidious inner enemy. When we have to confront difficult situations, our mind often makes us obsess over all the things that are not in our control. This obsession can become so overwhelming that we soon start believing that nothing is in our control and that we are utterly powerless. Being thus misled, we quit or act halfheartedly, making failure inevitable.

How can we protect ourselves from being thus misled? By shifting our vision to the power that we still have, the power that we never lose: the power of our spirituality. We can access this power by remembering two essential spiritual truths: we are at core souls who are indestructible; and we are parts of a Whole, Krishna, whose love for us is inexhaustible. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (15.07) cautions that if we don't act as parts of the Whole, we are pulled by our mind into struggle and suffering.

How can we act as parts of the Whole? By service attitude. By asking ourselves, "How can I serve Krishna in this situation? How can I improve my thoughts, attitude and behavior? What can I do, however small, to make things better?"

When we thus focus on changing our consciousness, we discover that our difficulties aren't as overpowering as they seemed. Being thus reassured, we find ways to make things bearable or even make them better.

Think it over

Amid difficulties, how does our mind mislead us?

How can we access the power of our spirituality?

Do you feel powerless about any situation? How can you shift your vision to empower yourself?

15.07 The living entities in this conditioned world are My eternal fragmental parts. Due to conditioned life, they are struggling very hard with the six senses, which include the mind.

When the mind takes charge, the only thing that works is we: hard

Suppose a competent leader takes charge of a project. They ensure that everyone works hard and productively. But if the leader is incompetent, no one works productively. Worse still, if the leader is incompetent and dominant, they make others work unproductively, but hard. Worst of all, if the leader is incompetent, dominant and malevolent, they make others slave till breaking point on work that is painful and pointless.

Our mind often acts like a taskmaster of this last category. If it conceives that something is enjoyable, it makes us crave and slave to get it, no matter what the cost. Consider addicts. They often squander their time, money, sanity, self-respect, relationships, everything – all because their mind craves a pleasure that is nothing more than a short-lived relief from an insatiable and irresistible craving.

We may not be addicts, but we may still be very much under the mind's dictatorship. Driven by its conceptions of enjoyment, we labor excruciatingly and uselessly.

The Bhagavad-gita (15.07) states that we struggle and suffer when we come under the spell of the mind, along with the senses. If we let it take charge of our life, nothing works under its dictatorship except we ourselves. And we work not in the positive sense of functioning constructively, but in the negative sense of slaving pointlessly.

Thankfully, the same verse points the way to freedom from the mind's dictatorship: We are eternal parts of Krishna, the omnipotent supreme. As parts, we are meant to serve the Whole. When we strive to serve him by practicing bhakti-yoga, he makes things work positively in our life. And we slowly and increasingly free ourselves from the mind's dictatorship.

Doesn't serving Krishna also require hard work? Yes, but this work purifies us. And as we become purified, serving him becomes increasingly joyful till it finally becomes supremely, unendingly blissful.

Think it over

What kind of taskmaster is the mind?

How are addicts under their mind's dictatorship?

How does serving Krishna free us from the mind's dictatorship?

15.07 The living entities in this conditioned world are My eternal fragmental parts. Due to conditioned life, they are struggling very hard with the six senses, which include the mind.

Mindless feeds don't feed our mind, they feed our mindlessness

Suppose we regularly eat food that is high in calories and low in nutrition. We would soon become bloated and drained. To be more productive, we need to choose food that is high in nutrition and low in calories.

What applies to our physical productivity also applies to our mental productivity. Just as our body is fed by the food we eat, our mind is fed by the various stimuli we take in. Nowadays, we are bombarded by scores of feeds: notifications that pop up on our various devices and demand our attention. Most such stimuli are about random things that aren't worth our time or thought.

Unfortunately, we often give such stimuli our unfiltered and uncritical attention. And then we find ourselves distracted and drained: we think of many things, yet we hardly think of the things that matter. Eventually, when life forces us to think of the things that matter, we have no mental energy left. The Bhagavad-gita (16.16) cautions that when our consciousness is dissipated in myriad directions, our life becomes hellish.

When we study Gita wisdom regularly, we become more aware of our inner dynamics and more discerning about what we are feeding: our mindlessness or our mind. To feed our mindlessness means to expose ourselves to stimuli that accelerate the thoughtless wandering of our mind from one thing to another without giving due consideration to anything, without even considering whether the things being contemplated are worth contemplating. In contrast, to feed our mind means to give ourselves something worthwhile to think about.

Significantly, the Gita doesn't just train us to evaluate what we feed ourselves; it is also itself the best food for the mind. Its profound wisdom equips and energizes us to think about the things that really matter.

Think it over

How do we become mentally hyperactive and drained?

How does Gita wisdom help increase our mental productivity?

What do you regularly feed your mind with? What one thing can you do to improve the quality of those feeds?

16.16 Thus perplexed by various anxieties and bound by a network of illusions, they become too strongly attached to sense enjoyment and fall down into hell.

The mind is a perpetual procrastinator – it postpones our resolutions to “some day”, then “some decade”, and then “some lifetime”

Suppose we wanted to go somewhere important. If someone physically tied us up, we would struggle to break free. Yet if someone deterred us by speaking discouraging half-truths, we may stay where we are, without struggling to break free. That’s how our mind deters us.

In our life-journey, we resolve to do things that can improve our life. However, our mind sabotages us by using a sneaky strategy: procrastination. If our mind outright forbade us from doing something important, we would notice its bossiness and maliciousness. Leading us to fight against it. Pre-empting such opposition from us, our mind says gently, innocuously, and nonchalantly: “Yes, this is important; you must do it. But why now? You are tired; you have many responsibilities; you have many dreams to fulfill. You can do this later.” Leading us to procrastinate.

If we look back at our lives and think of a good habit that we could’ve cultivated years ago, we often notice how our mind made us put it off for one day – and that one day became one week, one month, one year, one decade. If we keep listening to the mind, we’ll keep delaying for our entire lifetime, maybe even several lifetimes. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (18.28) cautions against the perpetual procrastination that characterizes those who function in ignorance.

If we want our life to improve, we need to reject the mind’s procrastinating rationalizations – and reject them now. Even if that rejection takes the form of just one baby step, that’s enough; the key is not how much distance we cover, but how much resistance we muster against our mind.

Think it over

To sabotage us, what strategy does the mind use? Why?

In our journey toward self-improvement, why is even one baby step enough?

What rationalizations does your mind use to make you procrastinate? How can you counter those lies?

18.28 The worker who is always engaged in work against the injunctions of the scripture, who is materialistic, obstinate, cheating and expert in insulting others, and who is lazy, always morose and procrastinating is said to be a worker in the mode of ignorance.

We don't know the future, but neither does our mind; its fears reflect the past, not the future

Our mind often fills us with fears about the future: “What if this goes wrong? What if that goes wrong?” Indeed, “What if?” is the question by which the mind starts showing us many horror movies that can paralyze and traumatize us.

As we live in a world of uncertainty, some amount of anxiety about the future is natural and unavoidable. Fear is a fundamental feature of our existential predicament. Yet fearfulness, in the sense of having our mind full of fears and making us incapable of thinking of other things, is unhealthy.

One way to counter fearfulness is by remembering that the mind is as ignorant as us. We don't know about the future, but then neither does our mind. Its dark dystopian forecasts are no more probable of coming true than any other of the millions of possible outcomes. The mind is neither a futurologist nor an astrologer; it is simply a fear-monger. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (18.35) cautions that fearfulness characterizes a mind infected by the mode of ignorance.

Once we understand the mind's fear-mongering tendency, we can turn from it to someone who is a far better forecaster of the future: the supreme controller, Krishna. He is our greatest well-wisher (05.29) and the overseer of everything that happens (13.23). He is present in our hearts (15.15) and can give us the necessary intelligence to face whatever situation we may face (10.10), in the present or the future. And we can easily connect with him by practicing bhakti-yoga, which enables us to sense his pacifying presence and bask in his empowering grace. The more we become habituated to practicing bhakti-yoga, the more our default thoughts shift from the mind's fears to the heart's faith in our supremely faith-worthy Lord.

Think it over

How is the mind a fear-monger?

How can Krishna help us calm the mind?

How does bhakti-yoga raise us above fear?

18.35 And that determination which cannot go beyond dreaming, fearfulness, lamentation, moroseness and illusion – such unintelligent determination, O son of Prutha, is in the mode of darkness.

Worrying about world problems is often our mind's excuse for not working on our own problems

Many people worry constantly about world problems such as climate change or discrimination.

While these are serious problems that require dedicated action, we need to begin with whatever is in our control. Otherwise, we may be deluded by our mind's diversions. One diversionary trick of the mind is to fixate us on uncontrollable problems and blind us to controllable problems. The Bhagavad-gita (18.35) indicates that lamenting over uncontrollable things characterizes a mind infected by the mode of ignorance.

If we worry about how we will fare at a job interview instead of studying to prepare for that interview, we hurt ourselves, and we know that we are hurting ourselves. But when the object of our worry is a global issue that is also often in the public eye, we hardly ever realize that we are hurting ourselves. To the contrary, professing that we are worried about that issue when other people aren't, gives us a sense of moral superiority. Additionally, we get this moral superiority without paying any tangible price except raising slogans and striking public poses. Such virtue signaling about world problems is far easier than becoming virtuous in our personal life, which requires committed effort.

Even if we aren't virtue signaling, still the inside-out approach remains the most viable. If we can't cultivate basic virtues such as punctuality, tidiness and steadiness, how can we solve world problems? If we have never fixed our own car, could we fix a plane?

A universally helpful virtue that we all can develop is a cleaner consciousness. When our consciousness isn't dissipated in pet peeves and resentment-induced paralysis, we get the inner clarity to understand how we can best improve things in our own small world and thereby gain insight to help improve things in the bigger world.

Think it over

How does our mind divert us?

How is virtue signaling easier than virtue cultivation?

How can a cleaner consciousness help us?

18.35 And that determination which cannot go beyond dreaming, fearfulness, lamentation, moroseness and illusion – such unintelligent determination, O son of Prutha, is in the mode of darkness.

The mind often recasts antipathy as inability; what it doesn't want to do, it presents as if it can't do

Suppose a child doesn't want to study a particular subject, say, math. He may protest to his mother, "I can't do this." If the mother naively believes him, he will never learn. That's why a responsible mother will expertly push the child to study.

Our mind is like a child. It is averse to anything that requires hard work, and anything worthwhile almost always requires hard work. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (18.37) states that meaningful joys seem like poison initially, but taste like nectar eventually. Unfortunately, we falter at the poison stage; we keep postponing difficult things such as studying a subject our mind doesn't like. Eventually however, when we can't postpone it any more, we get down to doing it, as when an exam is just a day away. Once we start, we soon experience that the work wasn't as difficult as our mind had depicted.

Knowing this, if we persevere through the initial poison phase, we will duly come to the nectar. Once we glimpse that nectar, we discover that we can do what we had earlier believed was impossible. Not only that, we also gain greater belief that we can challenge our supposed limits in other life-areas too. Therefore, rather than accepting our mind's diagnosis that we can't do something, we can focus on analyzing whether we can take any small steps toward doing it and on taking those steps.

And the most important area where we need to challenge ourselves is in the area of our spiritual growth. We are at our core souls, who are parts of the divine; we are replete with spiritual virtues. If we commit to growing spiritually by striving to serve the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna, we can become wiser, tougher, happier.

Think it over

What is the nature of meaningful joys?

What happens when we get down to doing difficult things?

While pursuing something worthwhile, how can we persevere through the initial poison phase?

18.37 That which in the beginning may be just like poison but at the end is just like nectar and which awakens one to self-realization is said to be happiness in the mode of goodness.

When the mind believes something is enjoyable, it stops evaluating whether it is actually enjoyable

Our mind often works like a programmed device, giving particular responses to particular stimuli. Some of this programming protects us from pain. For example, if we touch something hot, our mind impels us to move away from it, even before we consciously think about what is happening.

While some such programming works for us, it mostly works against us. Prominent among such harmful programs are our mind's beliefs about pleasure. When the mind believes that something is enjoyable, it pushes us toward that object, even without our conscious intention – and even when such indulgence hurts us.

Consider alcoholics. Their mind has a deep-rooted belief that alcohol is life's greatest enjoyment. Driven by this belief, they drink, even if they have resolved not to. After such drinking binges, even if they get brief highs, they also get long hangovers. Over time, the highs start getting shorter and the hangovers start getting worse. Drinking gives them far more trouble than pleasure.

Our mind may believe that indulgences such as over-eating, over-sleeping or indiscriminate net surfing are enjoyable, but are they, really? Do they leave us feeling contented and fulfilled? Rarely, if ever. Thus, experience demonstrates that our mind's beliefs about material pleasures are false. Yet we tragically choose to trust our mind's beliefs rather than our own experiences.

To protect ourselves, we need to counter our blind faith in our mind. How? By studying Gita wisdom regularly. Helping us see beyond the initial appearances that the mind sees, the Bhagavad-gita (18.38) states that sensual pleasures feel delightful initially, but painful eventually.

Guided by the Gita, when we conscientiously practice bhakti-yoga, we start accessing lasting happiness. And such sublime experiences gradually change our mind's beliefs about happiness, till those beliefs align with eternal spiritual realities.

Think it over

How does our mind's programming sometimes work against us?

How can we understand that our mind's beliefs about material pleasures are false?

How can we counter our blind faith in our mind?

18.38 That happiness which is derived from contact of the senses with their objects and which appears like nectar at first but poison at the end is said to be of the nature of passion.

Overcoming Temptation

Fighting urges is like a timed arm-wrestling match; if we just survive the present round, we will resume on neutral ground

Suppose we are playing an arm wrestling match with someone. If our opponent is much stronger than us, they will force our arm down. On seeing that we can't resist them for long, we may start thinking, "I will be overpowered eventually. Why undergo the pain of resisting till then?"

But suppose the match featured timed three-minute rounds. Timed rounds would mean that the pain of resisting wouldn't go on forever and that resisting wouldn't be pointless; by holding on for a few moments more, we can survive. And then we can resume the next round with our arm vertical, not nearly horizontal.

A similar principle applies to our inner struggle with our sensual urges. When we strive to resist them, they sometimes grow stronger. Thinking that they will keep growing forever, we give up. However, our urges are temporary, like everything else in the world – we need to resist them only for a finite time.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (02.56) recommends that we stay equipoised among life's dualities. Such dualities can include the arrival and departure of our urges. Whenever an urge arrives, we needn't get delighted or dismayed: delighted thinking that they pave the pathways to our enjoyment, or dismayed thinking that they are bullies who will force us to succumb. Instead, if we see an urge's arrival as the beginning of a timed arm-wrestling match, then we can remind ourselves that the round will end with the urge's departure.

Though we don't know how long the round will last, just knowing that it won't last forever can inspire us to keep resisting. And if we simultaneously persist in focusing on higher spiritual reality, ultimately on Krishna, then outlasting those urges will become easier.

Think it over

Whenever our urges hit us, what misconception makes us succumb to them?

How can we treat urges as a part of the world's dualities?

How can outlasting urges become easier?

02.56 One who is not disturbed in mind even amidst the threefold miseries or elated when there is happiness, and who is free from attachment, fear and anger, is called a sage of steady mind.

If we don't give the devil his due, he will take more than his due

The devil is envisioned in some traditions as a malefic being who tempts us toward wrongdoing and then traps us in distress. But beyond such religious usages, the word 'devil' has gained mainstream currency; troubled people, especially mentally troubled people, are often said to be dealing with their personal devils.

Within Gita wisdom, the devil can refer to the dark desires within us that can delude and degrade us. To give the devil his due means to respectfully take the necessary protective measures against temptations, especially those temptations to which we are particularly vulnerable. If we don't protect ourselves, we may get captivated and end up wasting hours, days, weeks, months, years, even lifetimes. By deceiving us into such destructively disproportionate dissoluteness, the devil will take far more than his due. The Bhagavad-gita conveys the need to give the devil his due when it urges us to withdraw our consciousness from sense objects just as a tortoise withdraws its limbs within itself (02.58).

Significantly however, the best protection is not just keeping the devil afar, but keeping close the opposite of the devil, the supreme divinity. Pertinently, the Gita states that merely distancing ourselves from sense objects doesn't work; it creates a strong feeling of deprivation (02.59) that eventually drags even the discerning to delusion (02.60). The sustainable solution, then, is to focus our consciousness on the all-attractive divinity, Krishna, thereby relishing a higher satisfaction that makes sensual deprivation tolerable.

Nonetheless, even when we strive to connect with Krishna, we still need to stay aware of the devil's deadly might. If we become lax in either our sensual restraint or our spiritual redirection, we will be trapped.

We can avoid such terrible trouble if we learn to give the devil his due by taking the necessary efforts to guard ourselves.

Think it over

What are the different senses of the word 'devil'?

What does giving the devil his due mean?

How can the devil take more than his due?

02.58 One who is able to withdraw his senses from sense objects, as the tortoise draws its limbs within the shell, is firmly fixed in perfect consciousness.

Protect the fences that protect you; keep temptation at a healthy distance

Suppose we live in a neighborhood where robbery is common. We will naturally build a strong fence around our home. Does building a fence signify that we distrust our ability to defend ourselves or that we distrust our neighbors? Not necessarily; it just signifies that we don't under-estimate the dangers.

Just as physical fences can aid us, so can behavioral fences. Suppose someone is a recovering alcoholic. To prevent relapses, they may rigidly refuse cocktail party invitations — and that may be a vital precondition for their recovery.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (02.58) underscores the necessity of fences: it urges us to distance our consciousness from tempting objects just as a tortoise withdraws its limbs into a shell. Similarly, traditions across the world have had some boundaries to regulate interactions between the genders because therein lies the oldest and strongest temptation that we humans are vulnerable to. Those exact boundaries may not always be feasible in today's world where both genders study and work together. Still, the temptation remains – those boundaries can't be rejected; they need to be adapted to our cultural contexts and our individual weaknesses. Such behavioral boundaries doesn't mean we don't trust each other; it just means we don't underestimate the power of temptation. If we define and explain appropriate behavioral boundaries, they can help keep interactions socially smooth yet spiritually safe.

In today's hi-tech culture, another fence we may need to erect and protect is digital. With the Internet easily available, the privacy of our rooms can become the stage for indiscriminate surfing binges. A net filter may aid us in protecting ourselves.

By introspecting to understand our own vulnerabilities, by improvising to build the fences necessary for protecting ourselves and by inspecting regularly to ensure that the fences are functional, we can protect ourselves from much avoidable trouble.

Think it over

While setting behavioral boundaries, how do we need to consider today's context?

What fence do we need in today's digital world?

What behavioral fences do you need?

02.58 One who is able to withdraw his senses from sense objects, as the tortoise draws its limbs within the shell, is firmly fixed in perfect consciousness.

Saying no to temptation doesn't mean much if we don't mean no

Suppose someone we know succumbs to an unworthy temptation. On being confronted about their wrongdoings, they may apologize and promise to never repeat that lapse. And yet they soon have a relapse. If this pattern of resolving and relapsing repeats itself, we may stop taking their words seriously.

If we turn the flashlight on ourselves, we may find a similar difference between our own words and actions. Why the difference? Often, it's because we don't mean what we say; our words are just tongue-deep, not heart-deep. This doesn't necessarily mean we are hypocritical; it may just mean our convictions don't run deep enough. Even when we resolve to give up something, we still retain the notion that it is enjoyable. The Bhagavad-gita (02.59) cautions that when we abstain from temptation, we feel as if we are starving, as if we are deprived of something as essential as food.

To abstain sustainably, we need to challenge that presumption of deprivation: "Is this actually as enjoyable as it seems? Or even if it is enjoyable, is it worth the price?" And to ground that challenge on a firm foundation, we need a higher taste: an experience of higher happiness, or at least the intelligence to see and seek a higher happiness (02.61). Our conviction needs to be aligned with our resolution. With that conviction, our resolution on saying yes to something higher that fulfills the need fulfilled by the pleasure we are saying no to.

When we thus reinforce the resolution to disconnect from something unworthy with a resolution to connect with something higher, then we can increasingly translate our articulated no into an enacted no.

Think it over

Why is there a difference between our words and actions?

How can we translate our articulated no into an enacted no?

What resolution do you struggle with? How can you reinforce that resolution with conviction and a more positive resolution?

02.59 Though the embodied soul may be restricted from sense enjoyment, the taste for sense objects remains. But, ceasing such engagements by experiencing a higher taste, he is fixed in consciousness.

Friendly snakes are still snakes – beware of the snake-like senses

Suppose someone adopts a poisonous snake as a pet. Even if that snake appears friendly, it can still bite venomously at any moment. Snake-owners need to be always cautious.

Spiritual traditions sometimes compare our senses to snakes. Just as snakes can inject poison into our body, our senses can inject into our consciousness the poison of wanton cravings. If that wantonness is allowed to spread, it can kill our spiritual knowledge and spiritual interest (Bhagavad-gita 03.41). And as we are essentially spiritual beings, when our spiritual awareness dies, we lose our real life. Being thus lost, we sentence ourselves to repeated birth and death in this distressful material world.

How can we protect ourselves? By staying alert while working with our snake-like senses. And because our senses are always with us, we need to be constantly cautious, even if they sometimes act decent and docile. Pertinently, the Gita (02.60) warns that our senses are so fickle and forceful as to delude and degrade us at any moment.

Does this mean that we have to live always in fear of our senses? No, provided we focus on something bigger than the worldly pleasures promised by the senses. The biggest such reality is Krishna, the all-attractive whole whose parts we are eternal. When we fix our consciousness on him and engage in his service, that divine contact grants us sublime satisfaction and purification (02.61). When our senses are thus purged of their wantonness, they become like fangless snakes.

Still, we can't easily ascertain if and when our senses have become defanged. So, it's best to be sensually cautious while focusing our energy on becoming spiritually conscious. Being thus vigilant and diligent, we stay safely on the path to purification and higher satisfaction.

Think it over

How are our senses like snakes?

Do we have to live always in fear of our senses?

How can we stay safely on the path to purification?

02.60 The senses are so strong and impetuous, O Arjuna, that they forcibly carry away the mind even of a man of discrimination who is endeavoring to control them.

We relapse not because we are witless or will-less, but because we are weapon-less

When we make resolutions to give up some unhealthy indulgence, we often relapse. On succumbing thus, we may berate ourselves for being witless: “How could I have been so dumb as to fall for that yet again?” Or we may berate ourselves for being will less: “I am too much into this; I have no determination. I am lost.”

Such self-condemnation is often misconceived because our relapse is often caused by something else: weaponlessness.

Suppose a heavily armed enemy attacks an unarmed soldier. Even if the soldier is spirited and sharp, if they are arm-less, they will most likely succumb.

Similar may be our predicament in our war against temptation. In this war, temptation attacks us with the weapon of inner torment, with a sense of being deprived of pleasure. Over time, that sense of deprivation becomes so unbearable that we indulge — not because indulging is so joyful, but because resisting is so painful.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (02.60) states that sensuality overcomes even those who are discerning and endeavoring. That they are discerning means they have wit. And that they are endeavoring means they have will. Why do they still succumb? Because they are weaponless, as indicated by the preceding and succeeding Gita verses. The taste for sensuality remains even if we physically restrain ourselves (02.59). We transcend sensual taste when we get a higher spiritual taste, when we focus our consciousness on the all-attractive divine, Krishna (02.61). This divine focus gives us a higher fulfillment or at least a higher purpose. Either of these can shield us from the torment with which temptation hounds us.

Therefore, when we relapse, we needn’t berate ourselves for relapsing. Instead, we can strive to equip ourselves with absorption in Krishna or at least connection with Krishna. Being thus equipped, we will gradually start winning the war against temptation.

Think it over

When fighting against temptation, why do we relapse?

What is the weapon with which temptation attacks us?

How can we equip ourselves to win the war against temptation?

02.60 While contemplating the objects of the senses, a person develops attachment for them, and from such attachment lust develops, and from lust anger arises.

Don't bolt from temptation, bolt the door to temptation

When a horse hears a sudden loud sound, like that of a gunshot or a thunderclap, it bolts from that sound. Struck with fear, it runs wildly to get away from that dangerous sound.

When we start striving to live a principle-centered life that involves abstaining from self-centered sensual pleasures, we too may bolt from temptation. Not wanting to succumb to it and not wanting to take even a slight risk of succumbing to it, we may try to frantically flee from temptation.

However, no matter how fast we run, temptation can run faster and can catch up with us. Why? Because temptation doesn't just exist outside, in tempting objects that allure us and that can be avoided by fleeing from them. Temptation exists primarily inside: in our senses, mind, and intelligence (Bhagavad-gita 03.40). And from there, it can delude us at any moment.

Moreover, even externally, temptation exists at a million places, places that we sometimes can't anticipate and sometimes can't avoid. That's why bolting from temptation can set us up for a life of paranoia and ultimate failure.

What, then, is the solution? We can instead bolt the door to temptation. If we consider our consciousness to be like a territory within us, we certainly can't cede that territory to the forces of illusion and try to flee. Instead, we can see that territory as our responsibility to protect by diligence and vigilance; we strive to keep temptation outside our consciousness.

Just as a territory can be protected if its entry doors are closed, similarly, we too can lock the entry door for our consciousness. How? By deciding to turn our senses away from sense objects and by using our senses to focus wholeheartedly on a higher purpose: the purpose of lovingly serving the all-attractive Supreme (02.61).

Think it over

What does bolting from temptation mean?

How can we bolt the door to temptation?

Which temptation torments you the most? Do you bolt from it? Can you bolt the door to it?

02.61 One who is not disturbed in mind even amidst the threefold miseries or elated when there is happiness, and who is free from attachment, fear and anger, is called a sage of steady mind.

Stop struggling to turn off the inner darkness, start striving to turn on the inner light

Suppose we are lost in a dark room. We stumble over various things, hurting ourselves. To avoid such trouble, do we try to turn off the darkness? No, we strive to turn on the light, knowing that thereby darkness will automatically be dissipated.

We need a similar approach to deal with the darkness that pervades our inner world. Because of this darkness, we can't see which things provide pleasure and which things engender trouble. We mistakenly think of sensual desires that propel us toward sense objects as pathways to pleasure. Actually, however, those desires lead us to attachment, addiction, and various karmic consequences.

Gradually, we realize through our experience and intelligence that sensual desires mislead us. Understanding this, we try to resist those desires. But we frequently fail. Why? Because we are, metaphorically speaking, trying to turn off the inner darkness – an impossible task.

Why is saying no to sensual desires an impossible task? Because saying no makes us feel deprived, for we are still thinking of the thing we are saying no to. And dwelling on sense objects, even for resisting them, eventually drags us down, despite our discernment and determination (Bhagavad-gita 02.60).

What, then, is the solution? We need to focus on turning on the inner light. How? By striving to appreciate the glory of our indwelling Lord, Krishna, who is the source of the supreme light, the ultimate wisdom. Understanding how loving and lovable he is, we become attracted to him or at least seek to become attracted to him. By that divine intention to lovingly connect with him, our heart becomes filled and illumined by spiritual desires.

When we thus bring our consciousness in Krishna's illuminating, enriching presence, we relish increasing inner enrichment, thereby transcending sensual desires (02.61).

Think it over

How is our inner world dark? How does that darkness trouble us?

Why do we fail to resist sensual desires?

How can we turn on the inner light? How does that light free us from sensual desires?

02.61 One who restrains his senses, keeping them under full control, and fixes his consciousness upon Me, is known as a man of steady intelligence.

Stop worrying about avoiding temptation, start working on cultivating absorption

When we resolve to resist some harmful temptation, we may fear, “The world is filled with tempting objects. How can I avoid all those objects and stay safe?”

This is a valid concern. Given that temptation can drag us down to stupidity, immorality or even perversity, it is helpful to keep a safe distance from temptation.

However, if we become obsessed with avoiding temptation, we may become culturally paranoid and socially paralyzed. Culturally paranoid means that we feel that the entire culture is our enemy, out to get us. Socially paralyzed means that we become inhibited during routine social interactions.

Moreover, thinking about avoiding temptation constantly is still thinking about temptation – and that thought may make us feel deprived till we feel driven to indulge again. The Bhagavad-gita (02.59) cautions that avoidance of tempting objects doesn’t free us from the desire for those objects. And that residual desire can impel even the discerning and determined among us to relapse (02.60).

What, then, is the solution? Focusing on something higher that engages and consumes our consciousness.

Gita wisdom offers us the most absorbing higher reality: the all-attractive supreme person, Krishna. By the process of bhakti-yoga, we can increase our attraction to Krishna (12.09), thereby making absorption in him easier.

Even if we don’t presently feel attracted to Krishna, we can practice bhakti-yoga as a discipline. Amidst such disciplined practice, we can note those bhakti activities that connect us most with him. And we can strive to do those activities more and more, at every opportunity.

Absorbing ourselves in Krishna generically can require practice and purification, but absorbing ourselves in those specific activities that naturally connect us with him is much easier and much more enriching.

When we thus become absorbed in Krishna, the resulting higher satisfaction will enable us to tolerate and transcend temptation (02.61).

Think it over

If we become obsessed with avoiding temptation, what are the consequences?

How can we cultivate absorption in Krishna?

To go beyond temptation, what can you absorb yourself in?

02.61 One who restrains his senses, keeping them under full control, and fixes his consciousness upon Me, is known as a man of steady intelligence.

Careless contemplation turns tempting thoughts into time bombs

When a time bomb is placed somewhere, it may not even be noticed by anyone; it might seem just like any other innocuous object lying in that area. But once it starts ticking, it becomes capable of terrible destruction, towards which it moves with every passing moment.

Something similar happens in our own consciousness. When tempting thoughts arise therein, either by outer perception or inner recollection, they often initially seem as innocuous as any other thought occurring in our consciousness. Yet such thoughts can be enormously destructive – they can impel us to act in ways that destroy our rationality, sensitivity, morality, humanity, spirituality. The Bhagavad-gita (02.62) outlines how this spiral to self-destruction is triggered by careless contemplation.

Just as a time bomb needs to be activated to begin its ticking towards explosion, similarly, tempting thoughts need to be activated to propel our consciousness towards degrading self-destruction. Whereas time bombs are often mechanically activated, either by physical knobs or by remote controls, thoughts are activated when we give them our attention. Curiously however, we are often not conscious that we are giving them our attention; we are so captivated by the images arising from those thoughts that we get carried away.

Just as time bombs can be defused by trained experts, similarly, tempting thoughts can be defused if we get the necessary spiritual training and become experts in monitoring our consciousness. The spiritual training is to habitually direct our consciousness towards the all-attractive spiritual reality, Krishna. And the inner expertise is in knowing when our consciousness is being sensually misdirected and then redirecting it towards Krishna's service. We can gain such training and expertise by practicing bhakti-yoga.

By understanding unsentimentally that careless contemplation can be disastrous, we can apply ourselves to practicing bhakti-yoga diligently and vigilantly.

Think it over

How are tempting thoughts like time bombs?

How do our time bomb-like thoughts get activated?

How can we defuse our time bomb-like thoughts?

02.62 While contemplating the objects of the senses, a person develops attachment for them,

and from such attachment lust develops, and from lust anger arises.

Even when we can't avoid sensual perception, we can avoid sensual imagination

We live in a world rife with temptation. Such temptation can deceive and degrade us at any moment. Given that we can neither remove temptation from the world nor live with closed eyes, we may wonder: how can we resist temptation?

By understanding how temptation attacks, as outlined in the Bhagavad-gita (02.62): from perception comes contemplation, as we start investing our imagination in the tempting object we perceive; then comes fascination, as our imagination fantasizes how enjoyable that object will be; then comes obsession, when our imagination makes that object seem irresistible; then comes infuriation, when our imagination rails against anything that obstructs our enjoyment. Then (02.63) delusion, oblivion and stupefaction follow as sensual fantasies fill our consciousness, driving out anything that might deter us from indulgence: our higher values, our scriptural knowledge, our past disappointments with indulgence. With our consciousness captivated, we soon succumb to self-destructive indulgence. The fuel that propels our consciousness from perception to self-destruction is imagination.

How can we avoid imagining about sense objects? By giving our imagination something else to imagine and by giving our intelligence wisdom to analyze sensual pleasure. Essentially, our consciousness gets invested in anything by two primary ways: the mind's imagination or the intelligence's analysis.

Gita wisdom empowers our intelligence to analyze the deceptiveness of sensual pleasure, thereby deterring our sensual imagination. And Gita wisdom reveals a beautiful conception of God, the all-attractive supreme Krishna, with whom we can joyfully engage our imagination in various creative forms such as music, dance, drama, poetry and painting. When our imagination is thus constructively engaged, it doesn't run off so forcefully toward sensual fantasies.

The more we invest our consciousness in Krishna through both analysis and imagination, the less sensual perception will trigger sensual imagination, and the more we will be protected from temptation.

Think it over

How is imagination the fuel that drives our consciousness from perception to degradation?

How can we avoid imagining about sense objects?

How does Gita wisdom protect us from sensual temptation?

02.62 While contemplating the objects of the senses, a person develops attachment for them,

and from such attachment lust develops, and from lust anger arises.

Seek the association that warns us about our urges, not warms us to our urges

Suppose we meet a stranger belonging to a group that is hostile to us. Naturally, we would be reserved while dealing with them. But if someone we trust praised that stranger, that would break the ice and bring some warmth into that meeting. However, if that stranger were still hostile to us, then the warmth would mean we would be in bigger danger.

Suppose, however, that the hostile person is not unfamiliar, but familiar. Then if someone further warmed us to them, we would be in even greater danger.

Similar is our plight when we deal with our urges. Most of our urges are familiar to us, for we have indulged in them repeatedly. Though such indulgence is often unfulfilling and sometimes degrading, we somehow remain favorably inclined toward our urges whenever they arise within us.

Why do we remain favorable to urges which lead to unfavorable results? Because of our association. The Bhagavad-gita (02.62) indicates that our desires are shaped by our association.

In today's materialistic culture, we are surrounded by worldly association that warms us to our urges. Even if our past negative experience with indulgence creates some reservations within us toward our urges, that reservation is dissipated by the incessant glamorization of those urges by the people around us. Misled by those depictions, we lower our guard and relapse.

To protect ourselves from our urges, we need to conscientiously seek the association that warns us about our urges. We can find such association among those who learn and live the Gita. In the association of such spiritual seers and seekers, we are reminded not just about the folly of sensual indulgence, but also the glory of spiritual realization.

By such reminders, we get the inspiration and conviction to stop pandering to our urges and to start transcending them.

Think it over

What's wrong with indulging in our urges?

Despite the unfavorable results of pandering to our urges, why do we remain favorable to our urges?

Whose association can protect us from our urges? How?

02.62 While contemplating the objects of the senses, a person develops attachment for them,

and from such attachment lust develops, and from lust anger arises.

Those who underestimate their mind undermine their intelligence

Suppose a country has a hostile neighbor. If they underestimate their neighbor, they will not pay attention to their own intelligence agencies which may warn them about the neighbor's power. Worse still, they may not even adequately fund their intelligence agencies. By thus undermining their intelligence, they will court imminent destruction.

Gita wisdom explains that we are souls who have a hostile neighbor: our own mind. The mind often misdirects our attention away from things of enduring importance to things that promise fleeting pleasure. If we let ourselves be misled by our mind, we end up deprived of spiritual joys and entangled in material troubles.

Unfortunately, we often underestimate our mind's capacity to mislead. Because it resides inside us, it slips below our radar while we assess our enemies. When we do something self-destructive, we sometimes sense our mind's dangerousness. That sense is our intelligence cautioning us. Unfortunately, we often shrug off that self-destructive behavior as a one-off occurrence. We neglect the intelligence's warning that such behavior results from the mind's insidious strategy to sabotage us.

Worse still, we imagine that we are safe and deem unnecessary the inner defense provided by our intelligence. And we neglect to adequately nourish our intelligence by studying wisdom-texts like Bhagavad-gita.

When we thus underestimate the mind, we let ourselves nonchalantly contemplate the many sense objects that the mind brings to our recollection. Such contemplation gives those recollections a momentum by which they grow to attraction, infatuation and infuriation (02.62). Then, come delusion, oblivion and stupefaction, which is essentially the destruction of intelligence. Stripped of our intelligence, we succumb to increasingly injurious indiscretions (02.63).

If we consider how seemingly minor lapses, repeated regularly over months and years, consume enormous time and energy, we can get the impetus to stop underestimating our mind and to start fortifying our intelligence.

Think it over

How does our mind mislead us?

How do we undermine our intelligence?

How can we get the impetus to stop underestimating our mind?

02.63 From anger, complete delusion arises, and from delusion bewilderment of memory. When memory is bewildered, intelligence is lost, and when intelligence is lost one falls down again into the material pool.

The mind is omnivorous; it devours whatever is present and feels pleasant

Omnivorous creatures are indiscriminate in their eating; they consume whatever is available and feels pleasurable.

Our mind is omnivorous in the sensory stimuli it consumes. If any stimulus is present before it, it wants to try that out immediately. If that stimulus feels pleasant, it wants to enjoy it more and more. And if something is both present and pleasant, it forcefully rushes to consume that compulsively and continuously.

The mind's omnivorous nature is thoroughly exploited by today's hi-tech materialistic culture. How? First, the culture makes sensual stimuli constantly available, by just a few clicks away on our devices. Second, it doctors such stimuli, physically and digitally, to make them appear irresistibly pleasurable.

Consequently, our mind gets caught in craving to consume sensual stimuli more and more. And whatever the mind consumes, it regurgitates as desires and delusions that can degrade and even destroy us. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (02.67) cautions that whatever our senses perceive, if the mind finds that attractive, it downs our intelligence and drags us into indulgence.

Knowing that the mind is indiscriminate, we need to be discriminating to protect ourselves. How? Through a two-pronged program: from below, physically; and from above, intellectually.

Physically, we can regulate our environment so that tempting stimuli are not readily available. Even if we can't change the mainstream culture, we can create a spiritual culture in our vicinity.

Intellectually, we can study the Gita regularly, thereby equipping ourselves to see beyond appearances. Then, we won't gullibly believe that whatever feels pleasant is beneficent.

However, protection from temptation is not enough; we also need purification. When we connect with all-pure Krishna by practicing bhakti-yoga, gradually our mind starts relishing his remembrance and service.

With our mind thus purged of its dietary indiscriminateness, we naturally shun sensual stimuli and savor spiritual stimuli.

Think it over

How is the mind's omnivorous nature exploited by today's culture?

How can we protect ourselves from the mind's indiscriminate consumption?

How can we purify our mind?

02.67 As a strong wind sweeps away a boat on the water, even one of the roaming senses on which the mind focuses can carry away a man's intelligence.

A sight on a site can trigger a fire inside – watch what you watch

If we live in a house made of inflammable material, we will meticulously avoid throwing about a matchstick, lest it triggers a house-destroying fire.

Actually, we all are living in an inflammable house: the house of our consciousness. At any moment, a spark of sensual desire can set our consciousness on fire, burning our good intentions, intelligence, and integrity.

What worsens our vulnerability is our culture; it keeps sending dangerous sensual sparks into our consciousness incessantly. Materialistic culture throws sensual sparks into us, especially through our eyes. How? By constantly parading alluring objects. And nowadays, this parade extends far beyond our physical vicinity to the entire world through the internet. Therein are visible, just a few clicks away, the dirtiest depravities of the world's darkest minds. One sight on some site can trigger a fearsome fire inside.

Sensual sparks are more dangerous than fire sparks. Why? Because sensual sparks can burn unpredictably and repeatedly. Unpredictably because whereas a matchstick ignites anything inflammable immediately, a sensual sight can smolder in our consciousness for any amount of time before suddenly blazing up. And repeatedly because the same sensual memory can inflame our consciousness again and again.

Understanding how vulnerable we are, we need to watch what we watch. That is, we need to guard our eyes from dwelling on incendiary images. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (02.68) recommends rigorous sensual restraint.

We can best protect ourselves by practicing bhakti-yoga. This yoga of love brings all-pure Krishna into our consciousness, thereby purifying it and decreasing its sensual inflammability. By regular bhakti-yoga practice, we become increasingly attracted to Krishna. And sights and memories of his supreme beauty and glory start sticking in our consciousness more and more. These spiritual stimuli ignite our divine desire for him, filling our consciousness with him and insulating it from sensual fires.

Think it over

How are we living in an inflammable house?

Why are sensual sparks especially dangerous?

How can we best protect our consciousness?

02.68 Therefore, O mighty-armed, one whose senses are restrained from their objects is certainly of steady intelligence.

What we feel doesn't feel us, what we will does

When we strive to free ourselves from impurities, we may still feel impure desires rising in our consciousness.

To not become disheartened by such desires, we need to know that we become impure not so much by what we feel as by what we will. This difference between emotions and intentions doesn't mean that whatever happens in our inner world is ok and that any kinds of thoughts and feelings are acceptable; it just means that we need to first win battles that are winnable and then work toward winning remaining battles. For example, a state can have good law and order not necessarily by purging criminal mentality among citizens, but by preventing criminal activity.

The Bhagavad-gita (02.70) compares the rising of sensual desires in our consciousness to the occurrence of disturbances in an ocean whenever a river flows into it. If the river is large, naturally some disturbance will occur; but if the ocean is far larger than the river, then the disturbance won't disturb much. Our consciousness is like that ocean into which various stimuli will pour in like incoming rivers. We can't entirely control the size of the rivers, for we can't entirely control what kind of stimuli we will encounter in the outer world. But we can change the size of our consciousness by changing the primary object of focus for our consciousness, by changing what we are primarily attached to, by changing what we think most about.

When our consciousness becomes attached to the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna, then that gives us such inner fullness that we don't feel inclined to act on lower desires even if they arise within us.

Think it over

In the context of our consciousness, what does winning battles that are winnable mean?

What metaphor can help us appreciate the difference between feeling and willing?

How can we enlarge our consciousness?

02.70 A person who is not disturbed by the incessant flow of desires – that enter like rivers into the ocean, which is ever being filled but is always still – can alone achieve peace, and not the man who strives to satisfy such desires.

More damaging than the lies we tell others are the lies we tell ourselves

Suppose someone has diabetes and they secretly eat desserts. If they lie to their caregivers about what they are doing, that's bad; they will worsen their health. But suppose they lie to themselves, believing that all the medical guidance about sweet food being damaging to diabetics is just misleading propaganda. They will hurt themselves far more.

Similar is the predicament of those who live sensually and deny even to themselves the harmful effects of sensuality. In today's world where sensuality is rampant in its visibility, availability and appeal, it's so easy to succumb to sensual temptation. Nonetheless, even in today's world, some moral restraints do exist – certain forms of sensuality are still considered immoral. Those who indulge in such sensuality do so secretly, thereby continuing the façade of morality. But suppose they themselves start believing that nothing is intrinsically wrong with sensuality and they can still be spiritually advanced, no matter how long and how much they have been engaged in gross sensuality. Then, they are taking their consciousness far, far away from the spiritual level where lasting peace and joy exist.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (03.05) states that those who delight in sensual contemplation while pretending to be spiritually advanced mislead others — and mislead themselves too. How do they mislead themselves? Because though they may put on a façade of spiritual advancement, they deprive themselves of the genuine happiness that comes from authentic spiritual advancement.

Thankfully, we always have access to the supreme truth of the Gita. If we learn from the Gita, it stands ready to empower us to free ourselves from all lies: the lies we tell others and the lies we tell ourselves.

Think it over

Why do we lie to others?

Why do we lie to ourselves?

How can we free ourselves from all lies?

03.06 One who restrains the senses of action but whose mind dwells on sense objects certainly deludes himself and is called a pretender.

Impurity needs to be feared before it can be found, found before it can be fought and fought before it can be finished

Suppose a person has a treasure kept in a high-security area. But if a thief sneaks in and if the owner is not vigilant, the treasure will soon be plundered.

Our consciousness is like a high-security area wherein lies the treasure of our spiritual potential: our capacity to enquire about life's spiritual side and to ultimately relish life and love eternal. But within our consciousness, impurity often sneaks in to strip us of our spiritual potential by drowning us in materialistic consciousness.

Alerting us to the danger in our consciousness, the Bhagavad-gita (03.37) stresses that our greatest enemy lies not outside, but inside us — in the self-destructive desires within our heart. To deal with this deadly enemy, we need three layers of vigilance.

Impurity needs to be feared before it can be found: When we understand how deadly our enemy is, how much suffering we may be subjected to if we get caught by it, then we start having a healthy fear for it. Only with that fear will we check for it constantly and eventually detect it.

Impurity needs to be found before it can be fought: Only when we find the modus operandi of impurity can we make effective strategies for countering it. Even if we are armed, if we don't know where an enemy is, we can't attack them.

Impurity needs to be fought before it can be finished: Just because we are fighting doesn't guarantee we will be winning. But if we are not fighting against an enemy that is advancing against us, our defeat is guaranteed. Once we start fighting against impurity by connecting with the all-pure divinity indwelling within us, we can gradually progress toward the inner purity that bestows unshakeable peace and unending pleasure

Think it over

How can impurity be feared?

How can impurity be found?

How can impurity be fought?

03.37 The Supreme Personality of Godhead said: It is lust only, Arjuna, which is born of contact with the material mode of passion and later transformed into wrath, and which is the all-devouring sinful enemy of this world.

More dangerous than the enemies that threaten are the enemies that tempt

Suppose we are fighting a war. We will be on guard against those who threaten to destroy us. But suppose someone allures us with pleasure. We may not even consider that they may be covert enemy agents. Honey trapping is a widespread practice in warfare.

We all are fighting an inner war against the forces of illusion, which often honey-trap us. By dangling various captivating sense objects before us, they lull us into lowering our guard. And then they charge into our consciousness, inciting us with worldly desires and impelling us to indulge far beyond our plans and principles. Eventually, such excessive indulgence rivets our consciousness to the material level and shackles us with worldly attachments that end in immense misery.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita stresses that our biggest enemy lies inside, not outside. Though Arjuna is on a battlefield, facing enemies bent on destroying him, the Gita urges him to guard against lust, which is the all-devouring sinful enemy of the world (03.37). Here, lust signifies not just sensual desire, but also the sinister inner force that impels us to sabotage ourselves (03.36).

If we wish to grow spiritually or even survive ethically, we need to see as potentially dangerous the things that tempt us. For seeing thus, we need to learn to observe the world with the eyes of Gita wisdom, not just with our physical eyes that are so easily deluded by sense objects. And the Gita equips us not just with knowledge of who our threats are, but also how to win against them: by cultivating devotional absorption in the all-attractive supreme reality, Krishna.

When we thus equip ourselves with Gita wisdom for fighting the inner war, we can gradually progress toward safety and victory.

Think it over

How do the forces of illusion honey-trap us?

How can we see the dangerousness of the forces that tempt?

What tempts you the most? For facing it, how can you better equip yourself?

03.37 The Supreme Personality of Godhead said: It is lust only, Arjuna, which is born of contact with the material mode of passion and later transformed into wrath, and which is the all-devouring sinful enemy of this world.

Those who fight their inner devils are the ultimate daredevils

Many people like to be daredevils. Wanting a sense of adventure and achievement, they dive into extreme sports.

While those living on the edge may be few, we all have an inner daredevil. That's what makes us seek vicarious thrills by identifying with sports stars, action movie stars or our own digital avatars in video games.

While such daredevilry might be exciting, it is often unproductive; people can waste awful amounts of time on escapist entertainment. Worse still, daredevilry can be needlessly destructive; super-fast drivers might end up in deadly car pileups.

Can we channel our inner daredevil constructively? Yes, to fight our inner devils: dark desires such as lust that make us act devilishly.

The Bhagavad-gita (03.37) states that lust is our vicious and voracious inner foe. The Gita's focusing on lust as our enemy is revealing. Though it is spoken on a battlefield, it doesn't focus on the opponents lined up to fight the war. By focusing on lust, it reveals the reality, gravity, and immediacy of the inner war that we all need to fight.

We usually know that we should restrain our lower desires. But we often see such restraint negatively, as a pleasure-depriving norm or as an impractically difficult austerity. When guided by the Gita, we learn to see the inner war positively. Victory can unleash our spiritual potential, enabling us to make substantial contributions in the world and relish sublime satisfaction that is out of the world. Even the moment-to-moment battles can become exciting; they inspire us to become expert and alert to detect and reject lust's sneaky seductions.

If we train ourselves to see the inner fight as stimulating and rewarding, we will gradually find ourselves getting stimulated and rewarded, increasingly and endlessly. By fighting our inner war wholeheartedly, we all can become the ultimate daredevils.

Think it over

What is wrong with most daredevilry?

Why is the Gita's focusing on lust as the enemy revealing?

How can we see our inner war positively?

03.37 The Supreme Personality of Godhead said: It is lust only, Arjuna, which is born of contact with the material mode of passion and later transformed into wrath, and which is the all-devouring sinful enemy of this world.

As long as the mind is impure, no place is secure

If we move to a new place, we look for a safe locality. Similarly, we need for our consciousness a safe place, a place free from immoral temptations.

Which places are safe? Natural settings with serene atmospheres? Possibly. But even in such places, temptations may assault us. How? Through sensual memories.

Tempting desires arise not just from the place where our body is, but primarily from the place where our mind is. And our mind goes wherever its foremost impressions pull it. If our foremost impressions are of impure indulgences, we will feel tempted, no matter where we are physically. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita cautions that self-destructive desire is our eternal enemy (03.39) – it hounds us at all places. Indeed, self-destructive desires don't reside outside, in sense objects; they reside inside, in our own senses, mind, and intelligence (03.40).

Does that mean external places don't matter? They do. Though desires arise from inner impressions, they are often triggered by outer perceptions. So, hedonistic places where explicit sensual perceptions invade our consciousness are unsafe and are best avoided.

However, if we focus only on such avoidance, we often run into two major problems. First, we may feel constantly persecuted because in today's materialistic culture, tempting stimuli are almost ubiquitous. Second, in the absence of sensual stimuli, we may be lulled into a false sense of security and may lower our guard. And wham! Our mind may ambush us by forcefully filling us internally with sensual recollections.

How, then, can we stay safe? By striving to place our consciousness at the supremely safe place: at Krishna's lotus feet. Krishna is all-pure, all-powerful, all-pleasurable. When we remember and serve him by practicing bhakti-yoga, we access a higher happiness. And that happiness empowers us to neglect impure impressions persistently till they get purged from our consciousness permanently.

Think it over

Why do we sometimes feel tempted even in serene natural settings?

If we focus only on avoiding tempting places, what are the problems?

How does placing our consciousness with Krishna protect us?

03.39 Thus the wise living entity's pure consciousness becomes covered by his eternal enemy in the form of lust, which is never satisfied and which burns like fire.

Love becomes blind when lust becomes the blindfold

Love is the heart's deepest aspiration; we all want to love and be loved. Through love, we can establish the sweetest connections with others.

Yet, in the name of love, people sometimes act stupidly, shamelessly, self-destructively – they ruin their own lives or break the hearts of others. Believing that they are “in love,” they may rush into incompatible relationships that soon turn toxic. Or they may wreck their own happy families for unsavory affairs. No wonder love is often deemed blind.

Actually, love itself is not blind; love distorted by lust is blind. Lust is the self-centered obsession that makes us treat others' looks and features as sources of irresistible pleasure. When the blindfold of lust falls on our consciousness, we can't see anything except the way to gratify that lust. And we crave and slave for it, blind to its cost – financially, ethically, relationally, socially, spiritually. The Bhagavad-gita (03.39) underscores this blinding nature of lust when it states that lust covers our knowledge.

How can we remove the blindfold of lust? By guiding our love with spiritual knowledge.

Gita wisdom explains that we are, at our core, non-material beings, who are parts of the all-attractive supreme spiritual reality, Krishna. He is the ultimate object of our love – we are meant for an eternal relationship of loving service with him. We can connect with him by practicing bhakti-yoga, the time-honored process for purifying our love and giving us a taste of the immortal joy of spiritual love.

Once we taste that joy, our love becomes spiritualized: we see others not as objects for our material gratification, but as partners in our spiritual evolution. When we infuse this vision into our relationships, physical infatuation is gradually superseded by spiritual camaraderie. Such a Krishna-centered bond leads to transformational loving exchanges that help bring out each other's fullest spiritual potential.

Think it over

Why is love deemed blind?

How does lust blind love?

How does bhakti remove the blindfold of lust?

03.39 Thus the wise living entity's pure consciousness becomes covered by his eternal enemy in the form of lust, which is never satisfied and which burns like fire.

Sensual pleasure touts itself as free and then takes toll forever

Many drug dealers give drugs free to gullible kids. Though the drugs may be delivered free, those dealers do take a price: the price of making the kids attached, addicted, afflicted. And once the kids are hooked, the dealers start charging — and charging heavily. Till the poor kids start doing reprehensible things just to get one more shot.

The same principle applies to the Internet, which opens for us a whole universe of indulgence, much of which touts itself as free. People get hooked to indiscriminate net surfing, till it becomes an addiction that alienates them from their loved ones and even from themselves. Even if people don't stoop to criminal activities – as they might with drug addiction – still Internet addiction by seeming less harmful becomes even more widespread. It robs people of their mental balance, moral compass and spiritual purpose.

When we indulge in any sense object repeatedly, an invisible shackle is formed between our consciousness and that object. With every future indulgence, that rope thickens and tightens till we become puppets who are pulled toward that sense object. And the providers of that object become our puppet masters.

The Bhagavad-gita (03.39) cautions that self-destructive desire – the lust for sensual pleasure – can be an eternal enemy. That desire torments us lifelong, and in our future lives too; the impressions stored in our mind go with us souls to our future bodies.

Is the bondage really eternal? No, nothing except spiritual love and joy are eternal. But the bondage can feel eternal when we are tormented. And that torment will end only when we resolve to say no and stick to that resolve.

If we will have to abstain eventually, why not abstain immediately and protect ourselves from immeasurable torment?

Think it over

How are free pleasures actually not free?

Why is the torment of sensual pleasure considered eternal?

Do you know anyone who has lost their freedom to free pleasure? How can you protect yourself from repeating their sorry story?

03.39 Thus the wise living entity's pure consciousness becomes covered by his eternal enemy in the form of lust, which is never satisfied and which burns like fire.

We are inflammable, not incorrigible; we need caution, not condemnation

Suppose we can't resist some sensual temptation despite trying repeatedly. Over time, we may become disheartened, thinking: "Maybe I am incorrigible."

Thankfully, no one is incorrigible. Why? Because we all have the potential to be godly. At our core, we all are souls, who are parts of God (Bhagavad-gita 15.07).

Why, then, do we keep relapsing? Because our inner world is inflammable. Materialistic impressions from our past indulgences are stored in our senses, mind and intelligence (03.40). These impressions inflame our consciousness with sensual desire whenever we are exposed to provocative stimuli, either externally through perception or internally through recollection.

If a house is made of inflammable material and has a history of catching fire, do its residents condemn or abandon it? Not necessarily. They meticulously implement two precautionary measures: don't handle fire carelessly, and keep good fire extinguishers always at hand.

Similarly, just because the fire of sensual desire has burned us in the past doesn't mean we have to condemn ourselves as incorrigible. Pragmatically speaking, our present inner world is the only inner residence we have; we can't shift to some other inner world.

What, then, can we do? We can retrospect to note the typical triggers that inflame us and carefully stay away from them, or at least stay on high alert whenever we are near them.

And we can keep readily accessible good fire extinguishers: stimuli that douse sensual desire by redirecting our consciousness toward something meaningful and satisfying. Bhakti-yoga provides us many such stimuli including holy names, scriptural verses and devotional images – these redirect our consciousness toward all-pure Krishna, thereby pacifying and purifying us.

When we thus cautiously avoid sensual inflammation and cultivate devotional absorption, we gradually increase our capacity to initially

tolerate and eventually transcend temptation.

Think it over

Why are we not incorrigible? Why are we inflammable?

What are the triggers that you need to be alert about?

What are the fire extinguishers that work for you? How can you make them more accessible?

03.40 The senses, the mind and the intelligence are the sitting places of this lust. Through them lust covers the real knowledge of the living entity and bewilders him.

No barrier is foolproof – that is not proof no barrier is useful

Suppose a particular coastal area is prone to get flooded because of high tides or sea-storms or tsunamis. Suppose the government constructs a barricade, but it is breached during a flood. Suppose the government builds a higher or stronger barricade, and that too is breached in a subsequent flood.

Would the government thereafter decide that no barricade is useful? Certainly not. Even if no protection works against huge floods, the barricades will protect at least from smaller floods.

Similarly, we all need some protection from the many sensual temptations that surround us. For example, if someone is trying to recover from alcoholism, they need to keep some safe distance from bars and places with ready access to alcohol.

Of course, temptations can flood our consciousness with varying forces – and some may breach through whatever barrier we may erect around us. Sometimes, even if alcohol is nowhere near an alcoholic, they may still go as far as is needed to get alcohol. Still, though the barriers may be breached whenever very strong urges to drink arise, that doesn't mean that the barriers are useless. When urges that are not so strong arise, the barriers may act as sufficient delayers of indulgence till the urge passes and the intelligence is restored. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (03.41) urges us to protect ourselves from self-destructive desires by first regulating our senses. One way such sensory regulation can be implemented is by creating barriers against the temptations that we are most vulnerable to.

Of course, the best barriers are not those that block flow but those that direct flow. If we can facilitate the flow of our consciousness toward more satisfying objects, ultimately the supremely satisfying object, Krishna, then we will be best protected from temptation.

Think it over

How are barriers useful in fighting against temptation?

What do the best barriers do?

Has a barrier protected you recently? How can you fortify that barrier?

03.41 Therefore, O Arjuna, best of the Bharatas, in the very beginning curb this great symbol of sin [lust] by regulating the senses, and slay this destroyer of knowledge and self-realization.

If we are robbed repeatedly by the same suspect, it is our intelligence that is suspect

Suppose we are robbed and the prime suspect is a shady neighbor. We would confront them to recover what had been stolen. Or at least, we would do whatever is necessary to protect ourselves from being robbed again. If they rob us repeatedly and we let ourselves be robbed, it is our intelligence that would be suspect.

Something similar happens in our inner world wherein our desires for sensual gratification rob us of our time, energy, attention, morality, spirituality. Yet we rarely do anything substantial to protect ourselves. We keep exposing ourselves to the same temptations; we keep letting ourselves be beguiled by the same rationalizations before indulging, after indulging or both; we keep making halfhearted resolutions that we abandon when pleasure allures us.

The Bhagavad-gita (03.37) states that sensual desire is our greatest enemy; indeed, it's the whole world's enemy because it impels everyone toward self-destructive actions. And such sensuality is our eternal enemy (03.39) — it has robbed us in this and previous lifetimes, leaving us souls with nothing in terms of spiritual growth to carry forward from one life to the next. All it gives us is a large burden of strengthened sensual impressions that impel us to re-indulge, again and again, lifetime after lifetime. And such desires are like our inner neighbors: they reside in our senses, mind and intelligence (03.40).

How can we overcome our insane passivity in the face of sensuality? By the combination of intelligence and transcendence (03.43). We let transcendence in the form of Gita wisdom equip our intelligence, and we use our intelligence to focus on transcendence through bhakti-yoga practices that connect us with the all-attractive supreme. By such reinforcement, we gain the inner satisfaction necessary to resist outer titillation.

Think it over

How do our sensual desires rob us repeatedly?

How are sensual desires an eternal enemy?

How can we protect ourselves from sensual onslaughts?

03.43 Thus knowing oneself to be transcendental to the material senses, mind and intelligence, O mighty-armed Arjuna, one should steady the mind by deliberate spiritual intelligence [Krishna consciousness] and thus – by spiritual strength – conquer this insatiable enemy known as lust.

Impulse may run over intelligence, but don't let it take over intelligence

Suppose some invaders attack a fort suddenly. The defenders, being caught unawares, are stunned, and the invaders start plundering the fort. Nonetheless, the defenders soon recover and start resisting, forcing the attackers to retreat. But suppose the invaders tempt and corrupt a prominent defender, who defects over to them. Then, they can take over the fort permanently.

Our consciousness is like the fort, and sensual impulses are like the invaders. A prominent defender is our intelligence, which exposes impulsive indulgence to be deceptive: the short-lived pleasure is followed by lots of trouble (Bhagavad-gita 05.22).

However, impulse sometimes attacks so suddenly that our intelligence is stunned. Before we understand what's happening, we succumb to indulgence. After we indulge, the chemical surge within our consciousness soon subsides. As we realize that the actual pleasure was far lesser than the hype, our intelligence recovers. We start resisting the impulse, which then retreats from our consciousness. And we resume our efforts to purify ourselves of unhealthy impulses.

But sometimes, impulse can seduce our intelligence (03.40). If that happens, we start using our intelligence not to recover from indulgence, but to cover up the indulgence – to hide it from others and persuade ourselves that it was no big deal. Worse is if we rationalize our indulgence by claiming it as our right. When our intelligence starts defending indulgence instead of defending us from indulgence, we are in big trouble indeed.

How can we prevent such a disastrous take-over of our intelligence? By the devotional discipline of regular Gita study. Being guided by Gita wisdom, we learn to use our intelligence to situate ourselves on the spiritual platform (03.43). When we gradually become absorbed in spiritual reality and thereof relish spiritual satisfaction, we gain the best protection from impulse.

Think it over

How does intelligence defend our consciousness from impulse?

How can impulse run over or take over our intelligence?

How can we protect ourselves from impulse?

03.43 Thus knowing oneself to be transcendental to the material senses, mind and intelligence, O mighty-armed Arjuna, one should steady the mind by deliberate spiritual intelligence [Krishna consciousness] and thus – by spiritual strength – conquer this insatiable enemy known as lust.

To decrease unhealthy reactions, increase healthy reminders

Suppose we have some unhealthy habit such as impulsive overeating. Once some behavior becomes ingrained as a habit, we often react without thinking. If some food, even junk food, appears in front of us, we just grab and gulp it.

How can we regulate such unhealthy reactions? One way is by using our intelligence to create healthy reminders. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (03.43) urges us to use our intelligence to discipline our default desires.

Between any stimulus and our response to it is the gap where our free will operates. For our free will to choose wisely, our intelligence is meant to serve as a ready, reliable resource. If our intelligence were active or were activated, it would help us evaluate the stimulus before responding. But when we have unhealthy habits, our intelligence becomes inactive. Even if it gets activated, it is too late – we have already succumbed to a default reaction.

Given that our intelligence won't function fast enough once we encounter a tempting stimulus, what can we do? Use our intelligence before any encounter with sensory stimuli. How? By intelligently creating timely, thought-provoking reminders for ourselves. Such reminders can be quotes or insights that succinctly state points that inspire or empower us to evaluate our impulses. Those points could center on: what our deepest aspirations are, how we are different from our unhealthy reactions, and how giving in to those reactions deviates and degrades us.

We need to surround ourselves with such reminders, be they stickies in places where we relapse or digital stickies on our devices or memorized nuggets that we can recall instantly. Such reminders will create a wedge between stimulus and reaction, catalyze our intelligence, and raise our self-awareness, thereby equipping us to make healthier choices.

Think it over

How can reminders help us in choosing wisely?

What are the different kinds of reminders? Which reminders work best for you?

Make three reminders that can help you regulate an unhealthy reaction.

03.43 Thus knowing oneself to be transcendental to the material senses, mind and intelligence, O mighty-armed Arjuna, one should steady the mind by deliberate spiritual intelligence [Krishna consciousness] and thus – by spiritual strength – conquer this insatiable enemy known as lust.

To see our own stupidity, unvarnished and unjustified, is infuriating and invigorating

When someone we care for does something stupid, they often try to hide it from us, either denying it entirely or concealing it under various varnishes. But when we come to know clearly what they have done, we feel infuriated and invigorated. Infuriated at how they could have done something like that, and invigorated with concern to protect them from repeating their idiocy.

We need to similarly confront ourselves. Within us, in our mind and senses, we all have self-destructive desires that make us act foolishly. Under their spell, we often spend huge amounts of time, energy and money on sensual pleasures that are fleeting, unfulfilling and even degrading.

However, we don't usually see such indulgences as a colossal waste because we hide our stupidity from ourselves. Or rather, the same self-destructive desire that misleads our senses and mind also misleads our intelligence (Bhagavad-gita 03.41). Such a corrupted intelligence prevents us from taking a hard look at ourselves; it denies or rationalizes our wrongdoings.

On some occasions, however, we are brought face-to-face with the harsh realities of what we are doing and where we are heading. Such occasions usually come when the consequences of our actions hit us or when we study scripture and look at ourselves through the eyes of scripture. At those times, all the varnishing falls aside, and our actions stand before us, exposed in their folly. Such moments can be infuriating ("How could I have been so dumb?") and invigorating ("I am never going to let this happen again.")

Channeling the energy of such anger and vigor, we use our intelligence – or rather, the part of the intelligence that is uncorrupted – to connect with the supreme spiritual reality, thereby gradually freeing ourselves from those stupefying desires (03.43).

Think it over

How do we hide our stupidity from ourselves?

How are we brought face-to-face with our stupidity?

Is there anything you need to confront yourself about?

03.43 Thus knowing oneself to be transcendental to the material senses, mind and intelligence, O mighty-armed Arjuna, one should steady the mind by deliberate spiritual intelligence [Krishna consciousness] and thus – by spiritual strength – conquer this insatiable enemy known as lust.

The body reacts mechanically — don't take its reactions personally

Suppose we had a machine that was programmed to behave in a particular way, to respond to certain stimuli with certain actions. Suppose we didn't want that programmed reaction, but couldn't change the programming. Then whenever that reaction would start, we would consciously decide to reject that programmed reaction and choose differently; we wouldn't get too involved with either its reaction or our rejection.

The Bhagavad-gita (05.08-09) offers us this mechanized vision of the body when declaring that all bodily actions, that is, interactions of the senses with the sense objects, are just default actions that we needn't get involved emotionally in or take personally. For example, on seeing or smelling a delicacy, our tongue might water. But suppose we were fasting on that day from that item, then despite the tongue watering, we would still abstain from eating it. The tongue's watering is a mechanical reaction that needn't change our intention.

Gita wisdom illumines our inner world into three levels: body, mind and consciousness. Corresponding to these levels, all actions begin first as a physical reaction to an external stimulus, then as the emotional activation of the desire for that stimulus, and finally as the conscious intention to indulge in that object. If we learn to differentiate between these three, then we won't let the physical or emotional reaction grow into a conscious intention as an unthinking, unstoppable progression. We will see those reactions as just programming that we need to acknowledge. Thus, we can distance ourselves from our physical and emotional reactions.

Spiritual practices enable us to become more self-aware, taking us closer to our own spiritual essence and the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna, and enabling us to better perceive our body as different from us.

By thus seeing the body's actions mechanically, we can avoid taking its reactions personally.

Think it over

How are the body's reactions mechanical?

What are the three levels of progression in the actualization of action?

How can we distance ourselves from the body's reactions?

05.09 Because while speaking, evacuating, receiving, or opening or closing his eyes, he always knows that only the material senses are engaged with their objects and that he is aloof from them.

Turning away is not running away if we are turning toward something better

Suppose we see a person who constantly agitates us. Not wanting to interact with them, we turn away.

Are we being cowardly? Not necessarily. If we are on our way to meet someone else who is far more important for us, then turning away is not spinelessness; it is purposefulness. When we thus act purposefully, if we still encounter that agitating person, we won't get unduly agitated; we will be polite and brief, and move on.

We need to be similarly purposeful while dealing with agitating stimuli in the outer world. When we start living spiritually, we resolve to abstain from sensual temptations. To stick to our resolve, whenever we see a temptation from a distance, we can turn away from it. Unfortunately, we sometimes avoid turning away, deeming it cowardly. However, we aren't being cowardly; we are being canny, staying focused on our purpose.

What is our purpose? To turn inward. Within us resides the supreme spiritual reality, all-attractive Krishna. The Bhagavad-gita (05.21) assures that if we turn away from outer pleasures and toward inner spiritual reality, we relish imperishable joy.

We can access that joy by practicing bhakti-yoga and connecting with Krishna. While striving to connect with him, sensual temptations can be a major distraction. Why should we unnecessarily fuel such distraction by dwelling on temptation?

Of course, if we become obsessed with avoiding temptation, we may feel frustrated, even persecuted, because today's culture often features an almost unending parade of temptations. We need a balanced approach: whenever possible, we can avoid interacting with temptation; and whenever avoiding interaction is impossible, we can avoid prolonging the interaction.

By such purposefulness, we can, even in a temptation-filled world, stay spiritually connected and become devotionally enriched.

Think it over

Why is turning away from temptation not cowardly?

When dealing with temptation, how can we be balanced?

Which temptations can you turn away from? In those situations, how can you turn toward something higher?

05.21 Such a liberated person is not attracted to material sense pleasure but is always in trance, enjoying the pleasure within. In this way the self-realized person enjoys unlimited happiness, for he concentrates on the Supreme.

Intelligence shows how indulgence is harmful and how harmful indulgence is

Less than a century ago, smoking was considered harmless. It took decades of intelligent investigation to reveal that smoking harmed health, and harmed it so much.

We need a similar intelligent investigation to expose another glamorized activity: indiscriminate sensual indulgence. That investigation exposes the harms of sensual indulgence in two ways:

How indulgence is harmful: The Bhagavad-gita (18.38) stresses that though sensual indulgence initially appears enjoyable, it ends up making us miserable. The pleasure of indulgence is preceded by hankering and succeeded by lamenting. Hankering means that we want the pleasure, immediately and irresistibly. Lamenting means we resent that the pleasure ended so soon. Over time, the hankering and lamenting increase, whereas the intervening pleasure decreases. Eventually, the pleasure becomes just a short-lived relief from the self-inflicted torment of constant hankering and lamenting. Because indulgence is usually physical and visible, whereas hankering and lamenting are psychological and invisible, we need intelligence to see how indulgence is harmful

How harmful indulgence is: The Gita (03.39) warns that self-destructive desire is an eternal enemy. Indulgence infects our psyche with indelible impressions that haunt us far beyond our present lifespans. Apart from such psychological torment, indulgence can also sentence us to terrible karmic consequences. Most damagingly, indiscriminate indulgence fuels sensual obsession that obstructs spiritual absorption (02.44). And we stay deprived of the lasting happiness that is our right as blissful parts of the blissful whole. As all these consequences aren't visible, we need intelligence to appreciate how harmful indulgence is.

When we are guided by intelligence, we can wisely desist from indiscriminate indulgence (05.22). And by firmly turning our backs toward sensuality, we can determinedly practice bhakti-yoga to connect with the all-attractive whole, thereby accessing imperishable happiness (05.21).

Think it over

How can we understand that indiscriminate sensual indulgence is harmful?

How can we understand how harmful such indulgence is?

When we understand the harms of such indulgence, what can we do?

05.22 An intelligent person does not take part in the sources of misery, which are due to contact with the material senses. O son of Kunti, such pleasures have a beginning and an end, and so the wise man does not delight in them.

Obscenity is objectionable not because it shows too much of a person, but because it shows too little and obsesses people with the too little

Obscenity is becoming increasingly accessible and visible in today's media and especially on the Internet. And it has some aggressive proponents: "If people want to display their body, who are you to say that they are showing too much?"

The main problem with obscenity is not that it shows too much of a person, but that it shows too little. What explicit imagery shows is just the body, and not even the complete body; just the skin with its colors and contours.

Those who consume such imagery soon reduce sentient people to bendable bundles of flesh. In real life, if they can't bend other people, physically and emotionally, to their will, they deem all relationships messy and shift to the world of media-stimulated imagination. Avoiding the sacrifices necessary for establishing human connections, they court life-sapping loneliness. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (05.22) cautions that indiscriminate sensuality leads to inevitable misery.

Such misery also befalls those who depict themselves sensually; their sense of self-identity gets devalued to their sex appeal. And when that appeal declines with the passage of time, their self-worth falls precipitously, reducing them to a depressed, ghost-like existence.

Gita wisdom explains that the essence of the person is spiritual. Everyone is an eternal soul, part of the divine; their body is just their temporary dress. We souls in human bodies are not meant to merely copulate and reproduce; we are meant to evolve spiritually toward lasting love.

To evolve spiritually, we need to connect with the divine and with each other in the light of the divine. To connect thus, we need to appreciate others as complete persons, not just their bodies. Spiritual education, coupled with modest dressing, helps us grow holistically: emotionally, relationally and spiritually.

Think it over

How does obscenity harm its observers?

How does obscenity harm its depictees?

How can we connect deeply and grow holistically?

05.22 An intelligent person does not take part in the sources of misery, which are due to contact with the material senses. O son of Kunti, such pleasures have a beginning and an end, and so the wise man does not delight in them.

Even if we can't stop feeling sensual urges, we can stop feeding sensual urges

Suppose we live in a forest cabin. We may not be able to prevent the arrival of unwanted animals. But we can avoid feeding them, thereby taking away their incentive to return.

A similar dynamic applies to the arrival of sensual urges in our consciousness. When we strive to live a principle-centered life, we start viewing such urges as unwanted. However, despite our not wanting such urges, they still keep coming. Their recurrence may discourage us: "I am so impure; will I ever become purified?"

To counter such discouragement, we need to differentiate between feeling urges and feeding urges. To feel urges means to sense that urges are rising in our consciousness. Why do such urges arise? Because of outer perception of tempting objects or inner recollection of past indulgences or, most commonly, an indeterminate combination of both. Such triggering of urges is often inevitable. But it can be inconsequential, provided we don't feed those urges.

Feeding urges means investing our consciousness in them, letting our emotion and imagination engage with those urges, till they grow into intentions. When we act according to those intentions, we indulge physically, thereby increasingly implicating ourselves in the chain of events that lead to future relapses.

The Bhagavad-gita (05.23) points to the difference between feeling and feeding urges when it declares that if we tolerate our urges, we can become spiritually situated and satisfied.

How can we stop feeding our urges even when we feel them? By intelligence and intention. By intelligently differentiating between feeling and feeding urges. And by intentionally directing our attention toward something meaningful and fulfilling, such as the service of the all-attractive supreme, Krishna, thereby transcending those urges.

Think it over

Why do urges arise?

What is the difference between feeling and feeding urges?

How can we stop feeding urges even when we feel them?

05.29 A person in full consciousness of Me, knowing Me to be the ultimate beneficiary of all sacrifices and austerities, the Supreme Lord of all planets and demigods, and the benefactor and well-wisher of all living entities, attains peace from the pangs of material miseries.

If we think we have no vices, we are novices

A novice housekeeping employee may think that a room that appears to be clean is clean. But some dust may be so settled as to be not immediately visible. Only when they start cleaning vigorously will they realize how much cleaning needs to be done.

Similar is the thinking of novice spiritual practitioners. After some initial practice of bhakti, we may find that we are not much troubled by impurities such as lust, anger or greed. And we may start thinking that we now have no vices.

However, vices exist within us at multiple levels, conscious and subconscious. Just because they don't appear at the conscious level doesn't mean they no longer exist at the subconscious level. What appears at the conscious level is shaped significantly by our association, situation, and intention. When we spiritualize these three by practicing bhakti-yoga, our conscious thoughts naturally start becoming purer.

However, at a subconscious level, impurities still lurk, waiting for an opportunity to resurface and re-captivate. The Bhagavad-gita (05.23) cautions that vices such as desire and anger may keep surfacing lifelong; if we learn to tolerate their presence without giving in to their influence, we will be well-situated on the path to spiritual connection and satisfaction.

By acknowledging that vices still exist within us, won't we feel discouraged? Not necessarily; we will just be deterred from foolhardy complacency. The fact that vices don't appear so frequently at the conscious level is encouraging; it indicates that bhakti is working. The fact that they still sometimes appear indicates that the work is not yet complete; we need to let bhakti keep working.

How? By guarding our consciousness from impurities and by guiding it towards purity, specifically the supreme pure reality, Krishna. And by his supreme grace, he will ultimately free us from all vice.

Think it over

How are we novices if we think we have no vices?

Won't acknowledging that vices still exist within us discourage us?

How can we let bhakti keep working?

05.23 Before giving up this present body, if one is able to tolerate the urges of the material senses and check the force of desire and anger, he is well situated and is happy in this world.

We don't have to outweigh our urges; we just have to out-wait
them

Suppose a thief is trying to barge into our house by breaking the door. Suppose further that the door has a loose bolt that we need to physically hold in place. Suppose also that the door is too strong for the bully to break. If we just hold the bolt in place, they will eventually become exhausted and quit.

To not get intimidated, we need to remember that our confrontation with the thief is a test of patience, not power. We don't have to be stronger than them; we just have to wait longer than them.

Our lower urges are like such a thief that we need to outwait, not outweigh. When those urges hit us, they can feel so strong as to be utterly overwhelming. But they can't overwhelm us unless they enter into our consciousness. To enter, they need to get our attention. Indeed, the door to our consciousness is our attention. Many urges appear at the periphery of our consciousness but can't advance any further unless they get our attention.

Unfortunately, we often leave loose the bolt to the door of our consciousness. That is, we aren't always attentive about what we are paying attention to. Consequently, without our wanting or knowing, some urges can catch our attention. To keep them out, we need to consciously hold the bolt in place. That is, we need to carefully choose what we give our attention to.

When encountering an unhealthy urge, we can consciously redirect our attention elsewhere, preferably toward the all-attractive supreme, Krishna. Then, the urge may keep battering at the door of our consciousness, but it will be rendered powerless. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (05.23) assures that if we tolerate our urges, our consciousness will gradually become satisfied and spiritualized.

Think it over

How are our urges like a bully?

Why can't our urges break the door to our consciousness?

Do you become intimidated by your urges? How can you out-wait them?

05.23 Before giving up this present body, if one is able to tolerate the urges of the material senses and check the force of desire and anger, he is well situated and is happy in this world.

When we resist our urges, they may become scarier, but they don't become stronger

Suppose an animal trainer is domesticating a wild tiger by starving it till it becomes compliant. Like all other living beings that are kept hungry, the tiger's anger increases with its hunger. Unlike many other smaller living beings, however, the tiger's anger makes it look and sound scary. If the trainer is inexperienced, they may become unnerved and feed the roaring tiger without waiting till it becomes compliant. But if the trainer is experienced, they will persist in the starvation campaign. Eventually, the tiger will become too weak to keep growling and prowling – and will do whatever it is told to get food.

We need to similarly starve to submission our wild urges, especially the urges to act immorally or self-destructively. Such urges are like tigers: just as tigers can devour humans, our baser urges can devour our humanity. Just as tigers become compliant when starved sufficiently, our urges become compliant when starved sufficiently. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (05.23) assures that those who tolerate their urges become gradually situated in spiritual consciousness and happiness.

Unfortunately, our starving urges intimidate us like starving tigers: they growl and prowl inside our consciousness, threatening to make our life a living torment if we don't satisfy them, right away. Overwhelmed by their threats, we give in.

How can we resist our urges? Through knowledge and absorption.

Spiritual knowledge reminds us that we are indestructible souls who can't be hurt by our wild urges, no matter how much they scream. To persevere through their screaming, we can absorb ourselves in something elevating, empowering, enriching – ultimately, in the all-attractive supreme, Krishna.

By thus internalizing spiritual knowledge and cultivating devotional absorption, we can live with our urges till their roars reduce to whimpers and finally to silence.

Think it over

When we starve our urges, how do they deceive us into satisfying them?

How can we tolerate our urges?

Which urge intimidates you the most? How can you neglect it?

05.23 Before giving up this present body, if one is able to tolerate the urges of the material senses and check the force of desire and anger, he is well situated and is happy in this world.

When fighting temptation, focus just on surviving the present battle, not on winning the whole war

Suppose we were to fight a boxing match against a formidable opponent. Suppose further, before and during the fight, an acquaintance from the audience discouraged us repeatedly: “This opponent is too tough; he will keep coming back at you. How long can you keep fighting? Better give up now.” If we keep hearing their voice submissively, we will become discouraged and quit even if we weren’t defeated and weren’t even likely to be defeated.

We all have to fight an inner war against temptation. In that war, our mind is like a discouraging inner voice that keeps making our opponent seem bigger and tougher than what it actually is. Thus, the mind acts as our enemy (Bhagavad-gita 06.06).

When we are confronted with some temptation and try to resist it, the mind discourages us by whispering: “This temptation will keep tormenting you for the rest of your life. You can’t keep fighting forever. Just give up now.” Because the mind is inside us, we neither realize that it is different from us nor recognize that its monologue diverges significantly from reality.

How does the mind’s monologue diverge from reality? The war with temptation is not one never-ending struggle, but is a series of temporary battles, with each battle being like a round in a match. Who wins each round matters, but what matters more is who keeps fighting till the end and wins when it matters the most.

If we keep resisting temptation, over time, it grows weaker and we grow stronger. And if we simultaneously absorb ourselves in the supreme transcendence, Krishna, we increase our probability of winning.

By the combined power of resistance and transcendence, we can gradually overcome all temptations.

Think it over

In our war against temptation, how does the mind act like our enemy?

How does the mind’s depiction of the inner war diverge from reality?

In your inner war, how can you better use the twin weapons of resistance and transcendence?

06.06 For him who has conquered the mind, the mind is the best of friends;
but for one who has failed to do so,
his mind will remain the greatest enemy.

To regulate your eating, listen to your body, not to your mind

Our body is like a car. Both cars and bodies give signals when their fuel tanks or stomachs respectively start becoming empty. We respond to those signals by filling both. Interestingly, we hardly ever overfill the car tank, but we often overfill the stomach. Why the difference? It's often because of our mind.

The mind is meant to integrate various bodily signals and present them to us. However, it often distorts the body's signals; sometimes, it even generates its own signals, which it passes off as the body's signals.

For example, the mind often makes us hunger for more food than what the body needs. Sometimes, it even makes us hungry for junk food that the body doesn't need at all. Junk food doesn't energize the body; it only exhausts the body with all the work needed to ingest, process and excrete it – or to carry it around as extra fat.

How can we avoid such over-eating? One way is by becoming better at self-observation, thereby differentiating between the body's signals and the mind's signals.

The body's signals are often drowned out when the mind's signals become clamorous. To listen to the body, we need to calm the mind. How can the mind be calmed? One powerful way is the practice of yoga, especially bhakti-yoga, which connects us with the supremely calming ultimate reality, Krishna.

Once we are habituated to yoga practice, then whenever an untimely urge to eat attacks us, we can train ourselves to turn toward some calming yoga practice such as deep breathing, mantra chanting or wisdom quote contemplation. Such practice will lower our mind's volume, thereby enabling us to hear the body and act appropriately. When we thus regulate our bodily activities, yoga practice can equip us to free ourselves from unnecessary distress (Bhagavad-gita 06.17).

Think it over

How does our mind interfere with the body's signals?

How can we differentiate between the body's signals and the mind's signals?

What practice can best help you to calm your mind?

06.17 He who is regulated in his habits of eating, sleeping, recreation and work can mitigate all material pains by practicing the yoga system.

Those who think they aren't prone to evil are the most prone to evil

When we see someone doing something horrible, we may feel revolted, “How disgusting! I would never do anything like that.”

Shock at seeing people do evil things is understandable and desirable. Still, the presumption that we are far above such actions can be unjustified and unsafe.

Inside us exists a dark side: the accumulated impressions of the questionable actions we have done in the past, in this and previous lives. And outside us exist an array of temptations that can activate our dark side. Through such inner impressions and outer temptations, we all are targeted by the formidable forces of illusion (Bhagavad-gita 07.14). These forces are constantly on the attack, trying to find some chink in our inner armor. And a glaring chink is complacency, the notion that we aren't prone to evil. What such complacency ignores is illusion's attack strategy, which is insidiously incremental.

Initially, illusion tempts us not to evil, but to minor transgressions. The resulting impressions accumulate till eventually, they impel us to do things we would earlier have dismissed as obnoxious. For example, those who take their first drug shot never think that a few months down the line, they would be robbing to get money for their next drug shot. But it happens, more often than we think.

Someone may object, “But if I have no impressions that make me inclined toward a particular temptation, can't I say that I am safe from it?” Maybe, maybe not. The forbidden fruit sometimes seems the most fascinating. Given how today's materialistic culture dangles forbidden fruits all around us, we may not be as immune as we think.

By remembering that we all are prone to evil, we can cautiously guard ourselves against the temptations that lead us to evil.

Think it over

How are we all targeted by the forces of illusion?

How may we end up doing things that we would normally find obnoxious?

What temptation do you need to guard against?

07.14 This divine energy of Mine, consisting of the three modes of material nature, is difficult to overcome. But those who have surrendered unto Me can easily cross beyond it.

Just because we have drunk a sip of poison doesn't mean we have to drink the whole cup

Suppose we accidentally take a drink that is poisonous. As soon as we realize what we are doing, we will immediately stop drinking it and take some antidote.

When we gain spiritual knowledge, we understand that sensual indulgence acts like poison, even if it tastes initially like nectar (Bhagavad-gita 18.38). Despite understanding this, we still succumb to sensuality. Why? Because our conditions or conditionings highlight the initial nectar alone.

After some indulgence, when the initial nectar ends, we become aware of what we are doing. Still, our devilish mind eggs us on: “Now that you have fallen from your standards, just fall down completely and enjoy.” The mind is doubly wrong. First, we won't enjoy more by further indulgence because our awakened self-awareness will keep reminding us that such indulgence is toxic. Second, to choose to fall completely because we have fallen slightly is stupid, suicidally stupid – it's like drinking the full poison-cup just because we have drunk a sip.

Instead, we can immediately take an antidote. The best antidote is to remember Krishna, our all-pure Lord. When we remember him by practicing bhakti-yoga, we access a higher pleasure that makes giving up sensual pleasure easier. Moreover, remembering Krishna is powerfully purifying: it drives out impure sensual desires. Pertinently, the Gita recommends that, despite serious lapses, we keep practicing bhakti determinedly (09.30) and assures that we won't ever be destroyed, but will soon be situated in purity (09.31).

How does persevering in bhakti practice situate us in purity? When we strive to correct ourselves as soon as we realize we have erred, our self-awareness starts awakening faster. Eventually, we become so self-aware as to not just rectify indulgence quickly, but also resist it entirely.

Think it over

When the mind eggs us fall completely on falling slightly, why is the mind doubly wrong?

How does the antidote of remembering Krishna counter the poison of sensuality?

How does persevering in bhakti practice situate us in purity?

09.30 Even if one commits the most abominable action, if he is engaged in devotional service he is to be considered saintly because he is properly situated in his determination.

If we don't fix the broken doors to our consciousness, we will be robbed

Suppose our home has a broken door. If we don't want to be robbed, we need to fix that door asap.

Our inner homes often have broken doors. We as conscious beings interact with the world through our senses, which receive outer stimuli and execute physical actions. Thus, our senses are like the doors to our consciousness, as indicated in the Bhagavad-gita (14.11).

When are the doors to our consciousness considered broken? When our senses become default pathways for some agitating perception of temptation or some degrading indulgence in temptation.

How may a door break? By indiscriminate indulgence. When we repeatedly, nonchalantly indulge in some temptation, such indulgence gradually becomes compulsive. Thereafter, we indulge even when we have resolved not to. Often, we indulge without even realizing what we are doing. Thus, through this broken door, temptation robs us of our intelligence, time, morality, dignity, sensitivity, humanity.

Whenever we succumb to temptation, we often beat ourselves up for being weak-willed. Increasing our willpower is important, but even more important is learning how to better use whatever willpower we presently have. Even if we aren't strong enough to stop the thief when they are barging in through the broken door, we can still work to fix the door at other times.

How can we fix the broken doors to our consciousness? By three broad measures:

Distance ourselves from that temptation, either by physically keeping it afar or by creating some obstacles between it and us.

Remind ourselves of all the things we have been distracted from, all that we have lost, because of indulging, thereby deterring us from casual indulgence.

Direct our consciousness toward all-attractive Krishna, thereby providing ourselves satisfying alternatives to that temptation.

When we thus fix the broken doors to our consciousness, we can better resist temptation.

Think it over

How do the doors to our consciousness break?

For resisting temptation, what is more important than increasing willpower?
Why?

How can we fix the broken doors to our consciousness?

14.11 The manifestation of the mode of goodness can be experienced when all the gates of the body are illuminated by knowledge.

Our urges aren't like endlessly rising lines; they are like endlessly recurring waves – surf them patiently

Whenever some self-destructive urge attacks, we tend to think: “This urge is becoming stronger and stronger. Soon, it will become irresistible. When I will have to give in eventually, what is the use of struggling in vain to resist it?”

Such thinking presumes that our urges are like endlessly rising lines; so, resisting them is a lost cause. Actually, however, our urges are like endlessly recurring waves that keep going through crests and troughs.

Even though an urge may be rising now, it will eventually crest and then decline. The struggle to resist it will worsen while it is rising, but will ease once it flattens and then decreases. To resist that urge, we don't need infinite strength; we just need adequate patience.

How can we develop such patience? By learning to surf our urges. Sea surfers go up and down with the water waves without getting carried away by them. Similarly, we too can situate ourselves above our urges, observing their crests and troughs.

Equipping us for such inner surfing, Gita wisdom explains that we are souls, who are different from our mind with its many urges. The Bhagavad-gita (14.23) exhorts us to use this knowledge of our spiritual identity to dispassionately observe the arrival and departure of our urges.

We can best situate ourselves spiritually by determinedly practicing bhakti-yoga, which connects us with the highest spiritual reality, Krishna (14.26). No matter how high an urge rises, holding on to Krishna can keep us above it, surfing safely.

When we practice bhakti consistently, even if our urges keep recurring, we will gradually become sufficiently competent to surf them resiliently.

Think it over

When resisting our urges, what misconception makes us quit?

How can we surf our urges? How does bhakti practice make us expert surfers?

Which urge overwhelms you the most? How can you surf it?

14.23 He ... who is unwavering and undisturbed through all these reactions of the material qualities, remaining neutral and transcendental, knowing that the modes alone are active; who is situated in the self ... [– such a person is said to have transcended the modes of nature].

When the sensual deludes the eye, the spiritual eludes the I

The world around us is filled with innumerable sensual stimuli. And most such stimuli assault us through our eyes. When our eyes become captivated with tempting sensual objects, we start craving and slaving to get those objects for our enjoyment. And that pursuit so consumes us that we can't think of anything higher.

The Bhagavad-gita (02.44) states that material attachment abducts our consciousness, rendering it too unsteady to focus on spiritual reality. To perceive the spiritual, we need the eyes of knowledge (15.10). However, even if we gain spiritual knowledge, we still can't perceive the spiritual as long as we are situated in sensuality (15.11). Why not? Because waves of sensual desires flood our consciousness repeatedly, sweeping away any spiritual insight or even inclination.

Worse still, with the world becoming digitally connected, deluding sensual stimuli have become far more accessible to us than in the past. Indeed, today, a person with an Internet connection can get more sensual stimulation for their eyes in an hour than what the wealthiest collector from the past could accumulate over a lifetime. No wonder we find focusing on the spiritual dishearteningly difficult.

Thankfully however, technology can also make the spiritual more accessible to the eye. If we surround our physical environment with as many spiritual stimuli as possible, we give ourselves ready alternatives to contaminating sensual stimuli. Additionally, if we nourish our intelligence with Gita wisdom, the resulting conviction will empower us to redirect our consciousness from the sensual to the spiritual. And most importantly, if we strive to connect ourselves with the all-attractive Supreme by practicing bhakti-yoga, the resulting higher taste will make sensual temptations more resistible.

By thus connecting with the spiritual physically, intellectually and devotionally, we can gradually transcend sensual delusions.

Think it over

How does the sensual blind us to the spiritual?

How does the sensual delude the eye more nowadays than in the past?

How can we connect with the spiritual physically, intellectually and devotionally?

15.11 The endeavoring transcendentalists who are situated in self-realization can see all this clearly. But those whose minds are not developed and who are not situated in self-realization cannot see what is taking place, though they may try.

Even if we cover the tracks we make externally, the tracks we make internally still cover us

Suppose we wanted to hide what we are doing from others while we are going on a trek through the wilderness. We would cover our tracks. But suppose the soil was such that we couldn't erase our footprints. Then we would be much more careful of where we went and not presume that our tracks could be covered or had been covered.

That is exactly what we need to understand about our inner world and the tracks we make there. Whenever we do any action, it creates impressions on our mind. And if we do that action repeatedly, the impressions become deeper and stronger. And each impression pushes us to repeat that action till we eventually become habituated and addicted. That's why we need to carefully choose which actions we do.

Today's technology provides us through the Internet immense access to the whole world, with its countless temptations. And it also promises us the possibility to cover our tracks by using digital strategies for anonymity. So, we may feel we can easily cover our tracks. We can and yet we can't. Even if we succeed in maintaining our anonymity online, we will face the impressions that were formed within our mind. And when those impressions grow stronger and stronger with repeated indulgence, we will eventually find the corresponding urges increasingly irresistible.

The Bhagavad-gita (16.12) cautions that we are bound by a network of hundreds and thousands of desires. And each of these desires can enslave us, not just in this lifetime but for many lifetimes to come. Gita wisdom therefore urges us to choose our actions carefully according to the guidelines given in scriptures. Thankfully, we can use constructively the principle that actions form impressions: if we start doing good things, even if in small measure, we can eventually form good habits.

Think it over

Why can't we cover our tracks internally?

Why do we get the impression that we can cover our tracks?

To protect ourselves from being bound, what can we do?

16.12 Bound by a network of hundreds of thousands of desires and absorbed in lust and anger, the demoniac secure money by illegal means for sense gratification.

In dealing with our urges, if we don't consciously choose responsibility, we unconsciously choose slavery

We all treasure our freedom and would fight if someone tried to enslave us. Yet many of us unconsciously let ourselves get enslaved. How? By nonchalantly giving in to our unhealthy urges till they become so strong as to enslave us.

Each time we indulge in an urge, that indulgence creates an impression within us. And that impression prompts us toward repeated indulgence, till the indulgence become habitual and even addictive. Habitual means we don't think or need to think about acting out, and addictive means we can't stop acting out even if we want to. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (16.12) cautions that our urges can bind us like shackles, dragging us across ethical boundaries.

If we are already controlled by some unhealthy urge, are we bound to stay enslaved forever?

Yes, if we just resent its presence, beating ourselves up for being so impure; or resign ourselves to its power, deeming it uncontrollable.

No, if we act responsibly within our limitations. Our limitations may be that we can't prevent an unhealthy urge from rising within us or that we can't resist it when it pushes us toward acting out.

Still, within those limitations, we can start working responsibly in various ways such as:

Engage in purificatory spiritual practices that strengthen our intelligence and conscience to combat those urges.

Form regulated schedules for our daily life so that we don't have much time to indulge in those urges even if they arise.

Erect protective barriers between us and specific triggers that fuel those urges.

Keep readily accessible attractive spiritual stimuli to which we can divert our consciousness whenever those urges start arising.

When we thus deal with our urges responsibly, not resentfully or resignedly, we pave our way from slavery to freedom.

Think it over

How can our urges limit us in our choices?

Even within our limitations, how can we deal with our urges responsibly?
Which urge troubles you the most?

What can you do to respond to it more responsibly?

16.12 Bound by a network of hundreds of thousands of desires and absorbed in lust and anger, they secure money by illegal means for sense gratification.

Even if we can't close the door to temptation permanently, we can
close it presently

Suppose we live in a thief-infested locality. We will want a strong, permanent lock for our home door. But if somehow we can't have such a lock, we will at least bolt the door. Admittedly, determined thieves might force their way in. But some might move on, seeking a house they can break in easily.

A similar dynamic applies when we try to block temptation out of our consciousness. We may not always be able to go cold turkey and say an irrevocable no to temptation once and for all. Why not? Because our mind might see it as an unbearable burden. If we think that we have to resist tempting desires forever, we will end up giving up the resistance right now.

What, then, is the alternative? We can say no to temptation presently, wherein 'presently' means both 'now' and 'in the near future'. When temptation seeks to enter and plunder our consciousness, we can resolve to resist it right now and in the near future. And we will discover that not all tempting urges are equally strong. Some, even many, urges are circumstantial and casual – if they can enter easily, they plunder; if they can't, they leave. Admittedly, some urges may keep pushing till they force their way in. But we won't know which urges are casual and which irresistible unless we try to resist.

And bhakti-yoga empowers us to complement resistance with transcendence, by connecting us with Krishna, the all-pure, all-powerful, all-pleasurable ultimate reality. When we are powered by our inner connection with Krishna, each round of resistance makes us stronger, more absorbed in transcendence and more capable of resisting future temptations. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (18.37) assures that the same resistance to temptation that seems initially like poison will eventually become like nectar.

Think it over

How can we know which urges are irresistible and which resistible?

How can we transcend temptation?

Is there any urge you can resist presently?

18.37 That which in the beginning may be just like poison but at the end is just like nectar and which awakens one to self-realization is said to be happiness in the mode of goodness.

Contemplation on temptation changes our disposition from zero tolerance to zero resistance

Suppose a country is being infiltrated by drug traffickers and has adopted a zero-tolerance approach toward them. But suppose some drug traffickers approach the border security force and start talking sweetly with them. And soon those guards let those traffickers through. If those traffickers could sweet-talk guards into changing their approach from zero tolerance to zero resistance, that sweet-talking ability would make them dangerous indeed.

Unhealthy temptations pose a similar danger at the entry-point of our consciousness. Having indulged in those temptations in the past and having found them unfulfilling at best and degrading at worst, we often resolve to adopt a zero-tolerance approach toward them. Yet when that temptation knocks on the door of our consciousness, we meekly capitulate.

How does temptation change our disposition from zero tolerance to zero resistance? Because of its deceptively sweet appearance. It seems like nectar initially, despite being like poison eventually (Bhagavad-gita 18.38). When we contemplate temptation, we see only the initial nectar. That nectar seems so unobjectionable and enjoyable that resisting it seems like unnecessary self-deprivation. And we succumb.

When processing immigrants, guards need to focus on legal documents, not on sweet words. Similarly, when processing temptation, we need to focus on its eventual consequence, not its initial appearance.

How can we avoid being deluded by that initial appearance? By looking at temptation, if at all we need to look at it, with scriptural eyes, not physical eyes.

Additionally and more importantly, we need to use scriptural guidance to start contemplating the all-attractive supreme, Krishna. When such contemplation starts giving us sublime satisfaction, worldly temptations start seeming like unwanted distractions from that divine absorption. Thus, we get the conviction to maintain our zero-tolerance approach toward temptation.

Think it over

How does contemplating temptation change our disposition toward temptation?

How can we stick to our zero-tolerance approach toward temptation?

Next time when you feel tempted, observe whether your disposition toward temptation changes or stays fixed. What can you learn from your observation?

18.38 That happiness which is derived from contact of the senses with their objects and which appears like nectar at first but poison at the end is said to be of the nature of passion.

Intelligence is the last defense against indulgence – and also the first defense

An important fort usually has multiple layers of defense. The best security is placed at the innermost layer to protect the king. Simultaneously, strong security is placed at the outermost layer to nip attacks in the bud.

Our consciousness is like an important fort – it needs multiple layers of defense from the onslaught of temptation. The Bhagavad-gita (02.62-63) outlines how our consciousness falls to temptation: what begins with careless contemplation ends in degrading self-destruction. In this sequence, the last to fall before we fall is our intelligence. If temptation overcomes our intelligence, we no longer see any reason to abstain from indulgence. And our consciousness is defenselessly dragged into sensuality, immorality, even perversity. Undoubtedly, intelligence is our last defense against indulgence.

Simultaneously, intelligence can act as our first defense. How? It can prevent our consciousness from contemplating temptation and can redirect it toward spiritual reality (03.43). If we focus on the all-attractive supreme spiritual reality, Krishna, we relish a higher satisfaction that makes sensual indulgence less appealing (05.21).

Here's another way to understand these two defenses for our consciousness. The outermost layer of defense prevents distraction, which happens at the mental level. When we are intelligently absorbed in Krishna, we pay no attention to temptation; it can't gain even a toehold in our consciousness. The innermost layer of defense prevents degradation, which happens at the physical level. If our intelligence is reinforced by Gita's wisdom, even if we feel tempted mentally, we refuse to indulge physically. Why? We know that such indulgence will only aggravate future urges and implicate us further.

Pertinently, spiritually intelligent brahmanas exercise both mental discipline and sensual discipline (18.42) – they have both layers of defense. If we study and apply the Gita, we too can protect our consciousness with multi-layered intelligence.

Think it over

How is intelligence our last defense against indulgence?

How is intelligence our first defense against indulgence?

How are the two qualities of the brahmanas related to the two layers of defense?

18.42 Peacefulness, self-control, austerity, purity, tolerance, honesty, knowledge, wisdom and religiousness – these are the natural qualities by which the brahmanas work.

Perfectionism is a serial killer in high heels

We all have many areas where we can improve. Wanting to improve is desirable and laudable, but while trying to improve, we may struggle to become perfect. Such perfectionism or obsession with perfection is a destructive temptation – like a serial killer in high heels. Just as the glamor of someone in high heels lowers our guard, so does the glamor of perfectionism deceive us into lowering our guard. And then perfectionism strangles our spontaneity, creativity and humility.

Spontaneity: We often sense that certain things naturally attract us. That spontaneous attraction points to an area in which we can improve and contribute more easily than other areas. Such spontaneity can be a gift that helps us create a better life. But when we become perfectionists, we choke our spontaneity.

Creativity: When we are spontaneously attracted to something and if we nourish that spontaneous attraction, we can use our creativity to find some way to move ahead. And if we are creative, we can find pathways through obstacles and solutions to problems. But such creative attempts are not always perfect. By insisting on perfection, we stonewall ourselves.

Humility: If we do at all excel in some area, we become so proud of ourselves that we start looking down at others; we are stripped of our humility. And this loss of humility hurts our relationships not just with others, but also with ourselves. We become our own worst judges, holding all our endeavors against a past excellent achievement that we may just not be able to replicate. That past feat may be due to divine grace that acts independently independent of our plan.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (18.48) stresses that all endeavors are covered by faults just as fire is covered by smoke. By letting go of perfectionism, we can start and stay on the path to improvement.

Think it over

How is perfectionism like a serial killer in high heels?

What all does perfectionism kill?

In what areas is perfectionism choking you?

18.48 Every endeavor is covered by some fault, just as fire is covered by smoke. Therefore one should not give up the work born of his nature, O son of Kunti, even if such work is full of fault.

To best defend our consciousness from the world, raise it above the world

Suppose a city is under attack from powerful plunderers. If that city were at ground level, pushing back the attackers would be difficult. But if it were situated on top of a hill, the attackers would have to exert to climb the hill and would be easier to repel.

Our consciousness is like a city under attack by the world's temptations. Frequently, our consciousness is at the same level as the world – we live in materialistic consciousness, conceiving worldly pleasures as life's primary or only pleasures. Consequently, whenever we are tempted, we feel that saying no to temptation is like saying no to all pleasure. This acute sense of deprivation erodes our will to resist, and we succumb.

To better resist temptation, we need to raise our consciousness above the world. How? By time-honored practices such as bhakti-yoga that spiritualize our consciousness. The Bhagavad-gita (18.54) declares that the spiritually situated are free from hankering and lamenting, the feelings that arise when sensual pleasures appear and disappear respectively.

When we resolve to resist temptation, we often obsess over the actual moment when temptation strikes: we exercise all our willpower to repel that strike. And when we fail, as we often do, we beat ourselves up for being so weak-willed. Instead, we can use our willpower primarily to engage diligently in those practices that raise our consciousness. When our consciousness thus becomes spiritualized, the resulting inner satisfaction will make resisting temptation easier as and when it attacks.

Undoubtedly, we will still have to fight and may still sometimes succumb. Nonetheless, each day's diligent spiritual practice will make us more satisfied and secure, gradually making our triumph over temptation more probable and even inevitable.

Think it over

Why do we often fail to resist temptation?

How can our spiritual practices empower us to resist temptation?

Which practice raises your consciousness most effectively? How can you increase your commitment to that practice?

18.54 One who is thus transcendently situated at once realizes the Supreme Brahman and becomes fully joyful. He never laments or desires to have anything. He is equally disposed toward every living entity. In that state he attains pure devotional service unto Me.

Positive Attitude

When the mind says our victories are too small to count, cross-question it: “What other way is there to big victories?”

When striving for self-mastery, we sometimes succeed in taking small steps forward. For example, suppose we find it difficult to wake up early in the morning, but are able to do so for one day. After such successes, our mind may discourage us: “Anyway, you won’t be able to do this tomorrow or some day after that. This is such a tiny victory. How will it count?”

To avoid such discouragement, we need to counter-question our mind: “Even if this is a small victory, what other way is there to big victories? Whenever anyone does anything big, it is by beginning with, and continuing with, small steps.”

Anything, however significant, can be reduced to insignificance if placed in an inappropriate context. Consider a toddler who learns to take his first steps. If that one step is placed within the context of adults who take thousands of steps daily, the toddler’s one step may seem insignificant. But for the child, that step is significant – so significant that parents celebrate and commemorate the moment by clicking photos and videos.

Similarly, we all are toddlers in the journey toward self-mastery. Additionally and significantly, we also need to double as the adults who encourage the toddlers. When looking at ourselves, we need a healthy balance between the two extremes of complacency and minimization. On one hand, we shouldn’t become so proud of our small steps as to become complacent and not take any more steps. On the other hand, we shouldn’t let those small steps be reduced to insignificance either. The Bhagavad-gita (06.25) urges us to take the gradual, step-by-step approach in redirecting our mind toward self-mastery. By incremental improvement, we will eventually improve significantly, substantially, dramatically.

Think it over

In our journey toward self-mastery, how may our mind discourage us?

How does context determine the significance of things?

What is the healthy way to look at ourselves when taking our small steps toward self-mastery?

06.25 Gradually, step by step, one should become situated in trance by means of intelligence sustained by full conviction, and thus the mind should be fixed on the Self alone and should think of nothing else.

The essence of commitment is recommitment

We sometimes resolve to do something constructive such as exercising, meditating, studying wisdom-texts or becoming more tolerant in our relationships. But we often fail to stay committed to our resolutions. On experiencing repeated failures, we may become disheartened, thinking, “Maybe I don’t have what it takes to be committed.”

Thankfully however, we all have what it takes to be committed; we just need to understand how commitment works. It works not by our making one mighty resolution that transforms our life forever; it works by our returning to our resolutions repeatedly, no matter how much we deviate in between.

Why do we deviate? Because our mind is restless (Bhagavad-gita 06.34). We become committed when we learn to maintain focus in spite of our mind, not because our mind maintains focus. And that means whenever our mind wanders off, as it inevitably will, we refocus it, patiently and persistently (06.26).

Consider the example of driving. While driving, the key to staying on-course is to keep coming back on course whenever the vehicle goes off course, as it inevitably will because of its mechanics and momentum. As we become more experienced and expert drivers, we get the car back on course so swiftly that it appears as if it never went off-course.

What applies to driving also applies to becoming committed. We set ourselves up for failure when we expect that commitment means our mind should no longer be distracted. Instead, we need to expect our mind’s distractedness and prepare to recommit ourselves. Such preparation for recommitment means that every morning we begin by reminding ourselves of our resolutions and repeat the reminders throughout the day whenever we get distracted. When we become expert at swiftly recommitting ourselves, we become strongly and steadily committed.

Thus, when we ready ourselves for recommitment, sticking to our resolutions becomes less discouraging and more transforming.

Think it over

Why is commitment so difficult?

Explain how commitment works with an example.

What do you need to recommit yourself to? How can you do so?

06.26 From wherever the mind wanders due to its flickering and unsteady nature, one must certainly withdraw it and bring it back under the control of the Self.

When life is uncomfortable, thank God that it is not unbearable

We all experience discomfort at times. The discomfort may be because of loneliness, boredom, overwork, worry, annoyance and so forth. Such feelings are obviously not pleasant. Still, if we let them come upon us unchecked, they will overwhelm us, putting us in a foul mood that may recur and rise each time discomfort occurs till irritability may even become our default disposition.

How can we avoid this downward spiral of our emotions? One way is by short-circuiting those emotions. When an electrical current is flowing in a particular channel that is unsafe, if we cut off the wire, the current will no longer flow. The same can apply to the flow of our emotions too.

One way to short-circuit our emotions is to see our particular situation not in comparison with how we wanted it to be, but in comparison with the overall nature of the world. While we all aspire for happiness, the world can send distress our way in myriad ways. Indeed, distress is the most defining and most undeniable reality of life. Stressing this harsh reality about the world, the Bhagavad-gita (08.15) conveys that the world we live in is a place of distress.

Given the world's nature, we can always consider that however bad our situation is, it could always be worse. Such thinking is not meant to trivialize our discomfort, but to contextualize it. Even if our discomfort is real and undeniable, still if we consider that things could have been worse, we can paradoxically feel better. And if we can be thankful that things aren't worse, we can divert our energy from feeling sorry for ourselves to working on making our situation better. Such a combination of positive emotion, intention and action can surely make the situation better or at least make our consciousness better.

Think it over

How can our emotions make our situation worse?

How can Gita wisdom help us reframe our situation?

How can we make our situation better?

08.15 After attaining Me, the great souls, who are yogis in devotion, never return to this temporary world, which is full of miseries, because they have attained the highest perfection.

What differentiates spiritualists from materialists is not the absence of pain but the presence of healing

Some people ask spiritualists, “You go through the same problems as we do – what do you gain by your spiritual practices?”

To understand, consider two patients who are both sick and in pain. But one of them has been diagnosed and is being treated, whereas the other is undiagnosed and untreated. Though both of them are in pain, their future is dramatically different: the patient being treated will soon return to health, whereas the undiagnosed patient will stay sick or may even become sicker.

Similar is the difference between spiritualists and materialists. The world we live in is a place of misery; it's like a hospital. Everyone in this world has to, sooner or later, bear the brunt of the world's distressful nature.

But spiritualists have perceived life's spiritual dimension and are pursuing it purposefully. That spiritual level of consciousness, which is free from mortality and misery, is our supremely healthy state. And those who are practicing spiritual processes such as bhakti-yoga are progressing towards that sublime level of consciousness.

Gita wisdom explains that the fundamental problem of life is not the specific problems of life we are encountering – these will come and they will go. The fundamental problem is the materialistic level of consciousness where we are trapped because of our worldly attachments. And our spiritual practices are meant to raise our consciousness to the spiritual level – not to cover our pain temporarily which is what most material solutions do and which is what we ignorantly expect spiritual solutions to do.

To the extent we become absorbed in the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna, we can experience joy (09.02) – even in this world, what to speak of the next.

Think it over

How are spiritualists like the patient who has been diagnosed and treated?

How do spiritual solutions and material solutions differ?

How do spiritual solutions help us even in this material world?

09.02 This knowledge is the king of education, the most secret of all secrets. It is the purest knowledge, and because it gives direct perception of the self by realization, it is the perfection of religion. It is everlasting, and it is joyfully performed.

Learn to be comfortable with feeling uncomfortable

Life often makes us uncomfortable, through stress, boredom, overwork, loneliness, sickness and so forth. On facing such discomfort, we impulsively seek to get away from it by something, anything. Unfortunately, seeking such escape-way from discomfort often puts us in delusion, degradation and eventually greater distress.

Consider recovering alcoholics, for example. When they feel discomfort, their mind immediately proposes relief through alcohol. If they accede, they relapse into the addiction, which leads to far bigger trouble than any discomfort. To break free from their addiction, they need to devise a healthier response to discomfort.

For responding healthily, we need to change the way we look at discomfort: it may not be desirable, but it is not unnatural; it's just an inevitable part of everyone's lives. So, we don't need to escape discomfort at all costs. Encouraging such endurance, the Bhagavad-gita (09.33) states that the world is a place of distress.

Gita wisdom explains that this world is like a hospital. For all those admitted in a hospital, pain is natural. That doesn't mean they have to forever stay in pain, but neither does it pain that they take a morphine overdose daily, several times, to numb that pain. They need to take the proper medicine that will gradually heal them, thereby automatically making them pain-free.

We all are existing in this material world because we are spiritually sick. Despite being eternal spiritual beings, we are craving for temporary material things. To cure ourselves, we need to redirect our desires toward the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna. For such redirection, bhakti-yoga is a time-honored process.

While practicing bhakti, we will still experience discomfort. By understanding Gita wisdom, we can become comfortable about feeling uncomfortable and still persevere in our bhakti practice. Thereby, we will progress towards spiritual healing that gradually raises us above discomfort.

Think it over

How does escaping from discomfort increase our discomfort?

How is discomfort natural? Explain with a metaphor.

How does becoming comfortable about feeling uncomfortable help us?

09.33 How much more this is so of the righteous brahmanas, the devotees and the saintly kings. Therefore, having come to this temporary, miserable world, engage in loving service unto Me.

Where we are doesn't determine who we are

We might sometimes be at a terrible place in life — we may be addicted to something harmful. What could make us feel worse is if we had arrived at that place not because of factors beyond our control but because of our own mistakes and misdeeds. We might beat ourselves down with guilt and self-recrimination, thereby feeling worthless and hopeless.

At such times, Gita wisdom reminds us that at our core, we are still pure souls; we are eternally parts of the all-pure Supreme, Krishna (Bhagavad-gita 15.07). Even if the soul is covered by impure conditionings, those are circumstantial and ephemeral – they are like the smell acquired by the wind while going through certain areas (15.08).

The wind might smell foul after passing through a nauseous area, but that smell will soon disappear once it goes into a fragrant area. The same applies to us, though of course, conditionings may take longer to get cleansed. Amidst discouragements caused by our dark side, understanding that we have a core purity can be heartening. And if we strive to grow spiritually by connecting with Krishna, we can rapidly regain our core purity. Indeed, that remarkable transformational potency characterizes bhakti-yoga (09.31).

Undoubtedly, our present condition is important; we can't deny it or wish it away. If we are attached or addicted, we will have a long hard climb to raise our consciousness from there to the spiritual level where we can relish lasting happiness. Still, the ardor of that climb needn't dishearten us. Why? Because we don't belong where we are presently, at the bottom of a dark valley; we belong at the top of the mountain, in pure love for our Lord.

Knowing that his grace can empower us to get where we are meant to be, we can gird ourselves for the climb determinedly and confidently.

Think it over

How might our present condition dishearten us?

Why does our present condition not define us?

How can we go beyond our present condition?

15.08 The living entity in the material world carries his different conceptions of life from one body to another, as the air carries aromas. Thus he takes one kind of body and again quits it to take another.

Complaining is no one's birthright – and it has made no one's birth right

Some people are chronic complainers. They self-righteously justify their negativity, irritability and disagreeability, “Can’t you see how many things have gone wrong in my life? Complaining is my birthright?”

However, complaining is no one's birthright. Why not? Because suffering is universal, justifiable and bearable.

1. Universal: If we could know the full life-story of even an ordinary person, we would see many heartbreaks. Undoubtedly, some people suffer much more than others. Still, suffering can't be objectively quantified with a suffering meter, wherein a reading above a threshold gives the sufferer the right to complain.

2. Justifiable: No suffering is ultimately unfair. What we reap now is what we have sown earlier, even if the action-reaction correlation is often unclear to us.

3. Bearable: We have the capacity to endure suffering. Animals often suffer terribly, sometimes far worse than humans. Yet they bear their lot without becoming chronic complainers. Nature makes us capable of resilience, but our minds make us weak and whiny. The Bhagavad-gita (18.35) indicates that chronic negativity characterizes a mind steeped in ignorance.

Moreover, complaining has made no one's birth right. Why not? Because complaining simply dissipates our emotional energy in unproductive or counterproductive resentment. Of course, if some specific thing is wrong and is fixable, reporting it can help in correcting it. But such constructive specific complaining is far different from chronic generic complaining about the world's or life's unfairness.

Gita wisdom explains that we are at our core souls, who belong to an arena of happiness in the eternal spiritual realm. In the Gita's light, what is our birthright? Attaining spiritual level of consciousness, not complaining about our present material level of consciousness where we always remain suffering-prone. What will make our birth right? Stoically tolerating suffering by cultivating spiritual consciousness and eventually transcending

suffering by absorption in the all-attractive supreme spiritual reality, Krishna.

Think it over

Why is complaining no one's birthright?

Why has complaining made no one's birth right? What is our birthright?

How can we make our birth right?

18.35 And that determination which cannot go beyond dreaming, fearfulness, lamentation, moroseness and illusion – such unintelligent determination, O son of Prutha, is in the mode of darkness.

Everything in history is not in memory; everything in memory is not in history – intelligence means to know what belongs where, and to keep it there

History and memory are both records of the past. Yet they can differ significantly. Let's see how.

Everything in history is not in memory: Because our memory is finite, it can't remember everything that has happened in the past. It often remembers selectively according to its overall attitude. If we are proud, our memory remembers our achievements and forgets our blunders. If we see ourselves as victims, our memory remembers the wrongs done to us and forgets the wrongs done by us.

Everything in memory is not in history: Memory can be not just selective but also deceptive. Based on our defining attitude, we may have false memories, whereby we "remember" things that never happened. If we naively believe our false memories, we become creators of a distorted version of the past. Even when we don't consciously intend to mislead others, we are subconsciously misled by our memory.

If we don't understand the difference between history and memory, we may keep lamenting about the past without learning from it. Such is the plight of people who are stubbornly ignorant (Bhagavad-gita 18.35).

How can we best use our past? By seeking not an exhaustive understanding of the past, but a working understanding of the past that helps us work better in the present and the future. If something from the past is worth learning, then we keep it in our memory. If something from the past is unclear or doesn't teach us anything worthwhile, then we let it stay in history, without burdening our memory.

When we thus intelligently discern what to keep in memory and what in history, our past stops holding us from our future; instead, it helps us progress into the future.

Think it over

Do you have any experience of selectively remembering or forgetting the past?

Do you have any experience of false memories in yourself or in anyone known to you?

How can you best use your past?

18.35 And that determination which cannot go beyond dreaming, fearfulness, lamentation, moroseness and illusion – such unintelligent determination, O son of Prutha, is in the mode of darkness.

Look for the good in all situations, even in situations that don't look good

Whenever life subjects us to terrible situations, we often obsess over how bad things are. Such obsession makes us feel frustrated, burdened and drained – impelling us to act in ways that make the situation worse.

Should we stay blind to the bad? Certainly not. We need to deal with the reality of how things are.

Humility allows us to acknowledge that we don't know the full reality of things. And the biggest reality we don't know is God and his plan. Even in terrible situations, his plan still works, shaping things for everyone's ultimate good. How Krishna will act, how he will guide us to act, and how future events will play out – all these things are unknown to us.

Instead of stewing over the bad, we can seek the good. When we seek good, we see good. And when we see good, we seek further good. By such seeing and seeking, we start a positive feedback loop that ensures that our emotions won't become our enemies when dealing with difficult situations. Thus, helping us discover positives we'd been previously blinded to.

Every adversity contains the seeds of some opportunity – at least the opportunity to become more conscious of God. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (18.58) assures that if we become conscious of Krishna, his grace raises us above all obstacles.

Even if situations don't look good, the shift in our focus from situations to the ultimate positive reality, God, is always good: it elevates our consciousness and equips us to better tolerate difficult situations. And it may even empower us to transform those situations.

Think it over

How is looking for the good different from staying blind to reality?

Amid negative situations, how can we start a positive feedback loop?

Why is shifting our focus from the not-so-good situation to God always good?

18.58 If you become conscious of Me, you will pass over all the obstacles of conditioned life by My grace. If, however, you do not work in such consciousness but act through false ego, not hearing Me, you will be lost.

The less time we have for our problems, the less problems we have

We sometimes feel burdened by our problems, as if they were heavy weights on our back. And the more we obsess over them, the bigger they seem to become, till we end up feeling disheartened, deluded, drained. If we could somehow not think so much about those problems, we would feel less burdened. In effect, we would have less problems.

Does that mean we live like ostriches with our heads in the ground? No, we do need to think enough about our problems to find workable solutions. But we also need to ensure that we don't overthink – we need to note when thinking about problems is productive and when it starts becoming counterproductive.

To prevent such counterproductive thinking, we need a positive, empowering object of thought. Gita wisdom reveals that object: Krishna. He is the supreme reality and is the source of the supreme security and the supreme serenity. If we practice bhakti-yoga diligently, our thoughts become increasingly focused on him. And that focus provides relief and rejuvenation: relief from the onslaught of negative thoughts, and rejuvenation by understanding that Krishna is bigger than our biggest problems and that he is eager to help us deal with them. Being thus relieved and rejuvenated, we will be better positioned to think constructively about the problems, thereby devising the best way ahead. Pertinently, the Gita (18.58) declares that becoming conscious of Krishna equips us to cross over all obstacles.

When problems overwhelm us, we may feel we don't have time to do anything except solve those problems. But if we turn towards Gita wisdom, we will discover that making time to focus on Krishna will make our problems more manageable and solvable.

Think it over

How can our thinking about our problems increase those problems?

How does thinking of Krishna provide us relief and rejuvenation?

If we feel we have no time for anything except problem-solving, what can we do?

18.58 If you become conscious of Me, you will pass over all the obstacles of conditioned life by My grace. If, however, you do not work in such consciousness but act through false ego, not hearing Me, you will be lost.

Look up and things will look up

When things start going downhill, the more we think about the things around us, the more we feel depressed. To raise our spirits, we need to first look up.

Amidst trouble, most people who are believers turn toward the being high up, God. Sometimes even nonbelievers do so; many atheists change their colors in the foxhole. Turning toward God for any purpose is beneficial; it can bring positive change in ways we ourselves couldn't have done or even foreseen. Millions around the world turn toward something higher in prayer and worship. And they often get some answers; otherwise, why would they remain devoted?

But what about the times when our prayers aren't answered? We just need to change the way we look up – not sentimentally, but spiritually.

To look up spiritually instead of sentimentally means to not look toward the sky for some mystical intervention to set everything right. It means to raise our vision from the material to the spiritual, from the physical to the metaphysical, from the circumstantial to the transcendental.

How can we look up spiritually? First, by gaining spiritual knowledge as given in wisdom-texts such as the Bhagavad-gita. And second, by applying that knowledge using time-honored spiritual process such as bhakti-yoga.

Is such looking up spiritually possible amidst distresses? Yes; and it becomes easier if we have cultivated spiritual habits of scriptural study and devotional practice.

What happens when we look up? First, we perceive that we are indestructible beings. Second, we sense that a benevolent divine plan is still operating at the transcendental level, no matter how many things seem to be going wrong at the circumstantial level. The more we empower ourselves with such spiritual understanding, the more calmness, confidence and clarity permeate and animate us – as happened to Arjuna on hearing the Gita (18.73).

Think it over

What does looking up sentimentally mean?

What does looking up spiritually mean?

How does looking up help?

18.73 Arjuna said: My dear Krishna, O infallible one, my illusion is now gone. I have regained my memory by Your mercy. I am now firm and free from doubt and am prepared to act according to Your instructions.

The Art of Balance

Equality that is imposed doesn't raise everyone up; it brings everyone down

We live in an age where equality is celebrated. Any discrimination, based on race, gender, caste and so forth, is frowned upon, or even condemned. And certainly, unfair discrimination needs to be removed.

But inequality is just a fact of life. Right from the classroom, students who do well academically are mostly winners of a genetic lottery at birth. Academic performance rests on high IQ, and our IQ is largely determined at birth.

Can such differences be done away? Suppose a school decided to give all students equal grades, maybe the average of the grades of all the students. What will happen? All the low-IQ students will become complacent, thinking that they will get a better grade than what they would by their own effort. All the high-IQ students will become lethargic, thinking that their talent and commitment won't be rewarded; so, why bother to work hard?

Thus, when equality is imposed in terms of equal results for everyone, it makes everyone worse. Imposed equality may temporarily feel good to those who are imposing it and to some of those who are raised by it. But eventually, it brings everyone down. It takes away the impetus for everyone to improve: for the average to become above-average and for the above-average to become outstanding.

Rather than imposing equality at the material level, Gita wisdom helps us realize our equality at the spiritual level: we all are souls, who are equally parts of the divine. And then it offers a socio-economic division of labor called varnashrama (04.13) that accommodates our psychophysical diversities while enabling us all to contribute materially and evolve spiritually.

By thus providing everyone equal opportunity according to their psychophysical propensity, Gita wisdom provides everyone the opportunity to grow in a way that is individually and socially constructive.

Think it over

How is inequality a fact of life?

Why is imposed equality counterproductive?

How does the Gita deal with inequality?

04.13 According to the three modes of material nature and the work associated with them, the four divisions of human society are created by Me. And although I am the creator of this system, you should know that I am yet the nondoer, being unchangeable.

Don't just work on our conditionings – work with our conditionings

Suppose someone has a condition with no easy cure, such as blindness. Though they may keep trying to cure that condition, they will also work to create a good life within that condition.

What applies to conditions also applies to conditionings such as lust, anger, and greed. When we strive to grow spiritually, our conditionings drag us toward self-destructive indulgences. That's why we need to work on our conditionings, purifying ourselves of them by discipline and diligence. For such purification, the process of bhakti-yoga is remarkably potent. Why? Because it connects us easily and efficaciously with the all-pure, all-attractive supreme, Krishna.

Yet different conditionings may infect us to different degrees. If a particular infection is deep-rooted, overcoming it may take a long, long time. If we reduce our spiritual endeavors to working on our conditionings alone, we may not get much success, thereby becoming disheartened and quitting.

To prevent such discouragement, we need to also work with our conditionings: we need to keep practicing bhakti within the constraints imposed by our conditionings. The Bhagavad-gita exhorts us to continue bhakti even if we succumb to grievous wrongdoings (09.30-31) and declares that Krishna is the well-wisher of everyone (05.29) – not just of the pure or the self-controlled.

In bhakti, our conditionings are limitations, not disqualifications. Within those limitations, we can still practice bhakti and connect with Krishna. Through that connection, we will get inner satisfaction. That will empower us to persevere spiritually and to simultaneously work on our conditionings, even if with limited success.

By re-conceptualizing spiritual life as not just working on our conditionings, but also working with our conditionings, we can get a taste of transcendence, even while we are conditioned. Being thus encouraged, we can move toward Krishna steadily and eventually succeed.

Think it over

Why can working on our conditionings be discouraging?

What does working with our conditionings mean?

How can we move toward Krishna steadily?

05.29 A person in full consciousness of Me, knowing Me to be the ultimate beneficiary of all sacrifices and austerities, the Supreme Lord of all planets and demigods, and the benefactor and well-wisher of all living entities, attains peace from the pangs of material miseries.

Being conscious of the body is not bodily consciousness; being conscious only of the body is

Suppose a car driver is obsessed with their car. They drive around just to parade how attractive it is and to find some ways to make it more attractive. Being thus obsessed, they forget where they were meant to go and why.

Such obsession with a car is clearly undesirable. But just as undesirable is the other extreme: neglecting the car entirely, neither servicing it nor fueling it. Even if they want to get to their destination super-fast, they still need to take enough care of the car to keep it at least drivable.

We need to similarly take care of our body. Gita wisdom explains that the body is like a vehicle for us souls who are on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution.

Most people are obsessed with their bodies. They spend hundreds of hours and dollars on making it look better. And they spend almost their entire life craving and slaving for bodily pleasures. Being thus lost in bodily consciousness, they have hardly any time or inclination to explore their spiritual side. Gita wisdom deems such bodily consciousness reproachable.

Hearing these warnings, we may neglect the body entirely, mistaking any attention to the body's needs to be bodily consciousness. However, the body has basic needs that have to be fulfilled; otherwise, the yogic practices for spiritualizing our consciousness will become unnecessarily difficult. For our spiritual journey, the body is a vehicle that is irreplaceable, at least for this lifetime.

We need to be sufficiently conscious of the body's needs so that it can function smoothly as a vehicle for our consciousness. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (06.17) declares that if we regulate our bodily activities, avoiding the extremes of too much or too little, then our spiritual practices can take us beyond worldly distresses.

Think it over

Do you sometimes get obsessed with your body?

Do you sometimes neglect your body?

How can you make your body a better vehicle for your consciousness?

06.17 He who is regulated in his habits of eating, sleeping, recreation and work can mitigate all material pains by practicing the yoga system.

Better to be crazy in being busy than to be just crazy; better still is to be busy without being crazy

We sometimes feel, “I am so busy that I am going crazy. I need to slow down.”

Yes, slowing down can help, provided we use the time thus gained to refocus on the things that really matter.

However, slowing our life doesn’t automatically slow our mind. Why not? Because our mind’s pace is determined primarily by how much it is infected by the three modes of material nature: goodness, passion and ignorance.

The mind in passion is crazy in being busy: Today’s materialistic world is largely driven by the mode of passion. When our mind is infected by passion, we run around feverishly struggling to fulfill our mind’s many desires.

The mind in ignorance is just crazy: If we slow down, we will probably sink to ignorance. Gravity pulls down, not up. We succumb to lethargy, apathy or thoughtless hyperactivity; we waste our time, money and energy; we act as if demented.

The mind in goodness is busy without being crazy: To raise our mind to goodness, just slowing down isn’t enough; we need to use the time gained by slowing down to do activities that raise our mind up. Potent among such activities is yoga practice, especially bhakti-yoga, for it links us with the highest reality, Krishna. And contact with him purifies and raises our mind. As our mind rises to the mode of goodness, we learn to work at a pace that harmonizes with both our psychophysical nature and our spiritual purpose — we learn to be busy without going crazy.

When we thus practice bhakti-yoga and regulate our worldly activities, our mind gradually rises beyond worldly distresses (Bhagavad-gita 06.17). Thus, we attain the ultimate perfection of being busy and crazy for Krishna.

Think it over

Do you sometimes feel as if you are going crazy in being busy? How can you regulate those phases?

Do you sometimes act as if crazy? How can you eliminate those phases?

When are you busy without being crazy? How can you maximize those phases?

06.17 He who is regulated in his habits of eating, sleeping, recreation and work can mitigate all material pains by practicing the yoga system.

To live life fully, leave life regularly – take breaks before life breaks you

Suppose we use a machine continuously without turning it off. If it's not given enough time off, it will deteriorate rapidly. Downtime is essential for the machine to be functional and sustainable.

The same principle applies to us too, as we operate our body-mind machines. If we wear ourselves out too much, then we can't function.

To live life fully means to be available at every moment in life to experience, to learn and to contribute. For thus living fully, we need to be available emotionally, intellectually, spiritually. And we become unavailable when we are bored, distracted, drained and so forth.

To leave life regularly means to get out of our daily life's grinding routines and do the things that nourish our souls and rejuvenate us. The life we need to leave refers to the daily routines that center on our professional, financial and social obligations – routines that can over time become monotonous and sap our vitality, our life.

How can we leave our life? The most uplifting way is by turning to spirituality, especially bhakti spirituality.

Bhakti spirituality centers on connecting with the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna. That connection involves transforming the world and transcending the world, which correspond respectively with living life fully and leaving life regularly.

When we have a service attitude toward Krishna, we serve him by transcending the world whenever we focus exclusively on him during our daily spiritual time and periodic spiritual retreats. And we serve him by seeking to transform the world, or at least transform our world, by acting with spiritual consciousness in our daily activities.

For balancing between living life fully and leaving life regularly, the key is regulation. No wonder the Bhagavad-gita (06.17) urges us to stay regulated and connected while doing various worldly activities, assuring that thus we can transcend all distress.

Think it over

Why do we need to leave our life regularly?

How can we leave our life?

How does bhakti spirituality integrate living life fully and leaving life regularly?

06.17 He who is regulated in his habits of eating, sleeping, recreation and work can mitigate all material pains by practicing the yoga system.

During our idle time, our mind works overtime

We often look forward to holidays when we can just relax, free from life's daily grind. But unfortunately, during such breaks, small things get to our nerves.

Why does this happen? Because our hyperactive mind doesn't let us relax.

We live in a culture that is largely in the mode of passion. And we live with a mind that too is mostly in the mode of passion. Being internally and externally driven by passion, we feel in control only when we are running around, doing things that give us a sense of being in charge. During our break time, when we are not ticking our to-do list, the mind doesn't have anything passionate to get into. Consequently, it gravitates toward the mode of ignorance, where it starts hyperventilating about its apparent lack of control. It starts fretting over the many things that have gone wrong in the past. Or it starts fearing the many things that may go wrong in the future. When our mind works overtime in such fretting and fearing, small things soon start annoying us.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (06.25) reminds us that whenever our mind wanders, we need to refocus it. How do we apply this Gita directive to prevent the mind from spoiling our leisure time? By understanding that breaks may not automatically relax us; we may need to conscientiously plan to use those breaks for engaging our mind in wholesome activities that raise it to the mode of goodness. In that reflective mode, we can contemplate and appreciate the things that really count, including especially our benevolent Lord, who always stays with us in our hearts.

When we thus use our leisure time to gently uplift our mind, not to naively wander with it, our breaks will become relaxing and rejuvenating.

Think it over

How does our mind make us miserable during our idle time?

How can we use our breaks more fruitfully?

What can you do to gently uplift your mind during your leisure time?

06.26 From wherever the mind wanders due to its flickering and unsteady nature, one must certainly withdraw it and bring it back under the control of the Self.

Possessing wealth is not the problem; being possessed by wealth is

Some people think that to be spiritual is to be anti-material, that they need to give up everything material for attaining the spiritual.

However, the Bhagavad-gita doesn't recommend such world-rejecting spirituality. It concludingly assures that Arjuna, on becoming spiritually conscious, will attain victory and prosperity (18.78).

The essence of spirituality is not the rejection of the material but the realization of the spiritual. We need to realize both our own indestructible spirituality as souls and the all-attractiveness of the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna, thereby becoming lovingly absorbed in him.

For gaining such realization, the Gita conclusively recommends bhakti-yoga (18.65-66). In this yoga of love, we lovingly connect our consciousness with Krishna and also connect with him all the things prominently present in our consciousness, such as wealth.

However, if wealth becomes the driving presence in our consciousness, the resulting greed makes us act immorally. Some greedy people start thinking of wealth as the sole way to power and pleasure. To gain wealth, they may even go to any extremes, including murdering rivals (16.14). Being thus possessed by wealth is a serious problem, even a spiritual catastrophe because it banishes thoughts of life's spiritual side from our consciousness and makes us act inhumanely.

But such dangers associated with possessing wealth doesn't mean wealth itself has to be demonized and rejected. In this world, someone has to possess wealth. Best that the virtuous and devoted possess it, for they will use it for good. In this mood, the Gita exhorts Arjuna to attain a flourishing kingdom (11.33). Arjuna is so devoted to Krishna that we could say he is possessed by Krishna. Being thus possessed, he could and would and did use wealth for society's all-round wellbeing.

If we too strive to become devoted, we can possess wealth without being possessed by it.

Think it over

What is the essence of spirituality?

What does being possessed by wealth mean?

Why does the Gita exhort Arjuna to attain a flourishing kingdom?

18.78 Wherever there is Krishna, the master of all mystics, and wherever there is Arjuna, the supreme archer, there will also certainly be opulence, victory, extraordinary power, and morality. That is my opinion.

NOURISH YOUR RELATIONSHIPS

Emotional Maturity

Focus on the cause that brings us together, not on the conditions and conditionings that push us apart

We all are irreducibly individual. Naturally, we all have varying opinions on various issues. When these opinions differ strongly, conflicts occur. How can we deal with such conflicts maturely?

By understanding what pushes us apart, understanding what brings us together, and focusing on the latter.

What pushes us apart is our differing opinions. Our opinions arise from, among other things, our conditions and our conditionings. Our conditions refer to the physical, social and financial situations we are in and have been in. Our conditionings refer to the psychological impressions that have been formed within us, from this and previous lives. And because we all have different conditions and different conditionings, we naturally see things differently.

Amid such differing visions and opinions, what can bring us together? A common cause. That cause may be family, community, profession, social work or devotional service – or even a combination of these. Ultimately, the greatest unifying force is the connection we innately and eternally share with everyone: our spiritual connection. We all are souls, who are parts of the whole, the ultimate reality, Krishna. By focusing on his service and understanding that his service leads to everyone's ultimate good, we can come together, despite our differences.

The Pandavas brilliantly exemplify the unity of purpose amidst the diversity of personality. Each of them is a powerful individual in their own right, with their own talents and takes on issues. Perhaps the most radical difference was between the pacific Yudhishtira and the bellicose Bhima. Arjuna's personality was in between, offering balance.

The Bhagavad-gita's beginning depicts how the Pandavas were united in the service of Krishna – they all blew their conch-shells to signify their readiness to unitedly work for Krishna's cause (01.15-16).

By similarly focusing on our common cause, we can transcend mutual differences and work harmoniously.

Think it over

In our relationships, what pushes us apart?

In our relationships, what brings us together?

How did the Pandavas work unitedly?

01.16 King Yudhishthira, the son of Kunti, blew his conchshell, the Ananta-vijaya, and Nakula and Sahadeva blew the Sughosha and Manipushpaka.

To be assertive, we sometimes need to be aggressive, adequately and adeptly

The nature of people, and the nature of life itself, is such that we are sometimes put in confrontation with others. Amidst such face-offs, we can and should try to resolve things amicably. But seeking an amicable resolution doesn't mean that we let others walk all over us.

Broadly speaking, when faced with a confrontation, we can have three approaches: be passive, be aggressive or be assertive. To be passive is to act in the material mode of ignorance; such action often makes the opponent more domineering and exploitative. To be aggressive is to act in the mode of passion; such action leads to a tit for tat sequence that escalates the conflict. To be assertive is to act in the mode of goodness; such action checks the other person from stepping on our toes while ensuring that we don't step on their toes either. Being assertive enables us to protect our purpose while doing our best to maintain peace.

However, if the other person is relentlessly aggressive and if they rebuff all our efforts for resolving things, then we may need to be aggressive. Being thus aggressive is not being vindictive; it is just being strongly assertive. Of course, such assertiveness has to be regulated adeptly so that it doesn't escalate beyond the necessary level.

The setting of the Bhagavad-gita (01.19) depicts how the primary protagonist Arjuna had to be aggressive in order to be assertive. The opponents headed by the villainous Duryodhana had scornfully rejected all peace proposals, even those offered on the most accommodating of terms.

In our daily lives, we won't usually have to physically fight against anyone. Still, the Gita's setting demonstrates that while pursuing a virtuous cause, we sometimes need to take a stand, and stand firm.

Think it over

Amidst confrontation, what are the three broad approaches?

When does being assertive require being aggressive?

Why did the Pandavas have to fight against the Kauravas?

01.19 The blowing of these different conchshells became uproarious. Vibrating both in the sky and on the earth, it shattered the hearts of the sons of Dhritarashtra.

Never make irreversible decisions based on reversible emotions

Our emotions can easily mislead us. When we become strongly emotional, we tend to make snap decisions. Such decisions can be detrimental, sometimes devastatingly detrimental. In moments of anger, we may terminate relationships that have taken a lifetime to build. Worse still, in moments of distress, some people may even end their own lives — a scarily, terribly irreversible decision.

However, our emotions are ridiculously reversible. What we feel at one moment, we may feel differently or even oppositely later. When emotions are high, if we make a decision that is irreversible, we may well regret it throughout our lives.

The Bhagavad-gita is spoken to prevent Arjuna from taking such an irreversible decision based on a reversible emotion. He is the foremost archer of his times, about to fight the most important war of his life. This war was essential for establishing dharma, the ethical order for maintaining society. Yet he is overwhelmed by emotion and is about to quit the war (01.46).

Fortunately, Arjuna had the guidance of Krishna, who deterred Arjuna from that catastrophic decision by speaking the Gita. The Gita helped Arjuna see his emotions in perspective, in the context of his spiritual identity and ultimate purpose.

If we regularly equip ourselves with Gita wisdom, that can ground us in a purpose bigger than ourselves, thereby ensuring that we don't take our emotions too seriously. This doesn't mean that we neglect or suppress our emotions, but that we don't give them a monopoly on our decision-making process. We wait for the emotions to subside, analyze the situations as objectively as possible and then use our reason and emotion in tandem to make decisions.

With the combined backing of our head and heart, we become empowered to follow up on those decisions wholeheartedly, review them periodically and revise them as necessary.

Think it over

What is wrong with snap decisions?

How can we take decisions maturely?

Which reversible emotion are you most prone to? Which irreversible decision may you take because of that? Plan how you can prevent that.

01.46 Sanjaya said: Arjuna, having thus spoken on the battlefield, cast aside his bow and arrows and sat down on the chariot, his mind overwhelmed with grief.

Don't use others to feel better about yourself; learn from others how to become better

When we are distressed, we often need someone to unburden ourselves to. While that is an understandable and even essential human need, it can become a dependence, and a debilitating dependence at that. We may start using, and abusing, others to feel better about ourselves.

If we look around us, we probably know some people who start complaining, blaming and lamenting as soon as we meet them. We may want to be understanding with them, empathizing with all that they have gone through or are going through. Still, their unrelenting negativity dries out all our empathy. We become tense when we are about to meet them and heave a sigh of relief when the meeting ends.

Rarely do we realize that we ourselves may be becoming like them when we wallow in the negativities of our life. We find their company exhausting; if we become like them, won't others find our company exhausting? More damagingly, won't we find our own company exhausting? Why should we let ourselves become someone whose company we would want to avoid?

Do we have an alternative? Yes, certainly. We can't change all the negativity around us, but we can change the negativity within us. If we look around us, we probably know some people who remain steady and cheerful even amid great difficulties. Being with them can inspire us, increasing our faith in the resilience of the human spirit. If we could become like them, we could constantly have the company of someone inspiring. Wouldn't that be empowering?

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (03.21) invites us to act in a way that becomes exemplary for others. And to become thus exemplary, Gita wisdom stands ready to help us discover the enormous reserves of spiritual strength that lie untapped at our core.

Think it over

How may we become someone whose company we dread?

How may we become someone whose company we cherish?

How can Gita wisdom help us become better?

03.21 Whatever action a great man performs, common men follow. And whatever standards he sets by exemplary acts, all the world pursues.

If we justify our weaknesses by comparing ourselves with those who are weaker, we weaken our motivation to rectify ourselves

Suppose we have a weakness, say, a short temper. Driven by anger, we may speak and do things that we know we shouldn't. Indeed, anger can subject us to bouts of temporary insanity. After such bouts, we may justify our misbehavior by pointing to those who behave worse: "Everyone gets angry. Why blame me?"

While such an approach may protect our ego, it will endanger our soul. The Bhagavad-gita (16.21) cautions that weaknesses such as lust, anger and greed make our life hellish — they destroy our potential for spirituality. Gita wisdom explains that we are souls, sparks of divinity, who have immense reservoirs of untapped potential. We can be far better than what we are presently, provided we unleash our potential by linking with the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna. When spiritually unleashed, we can manifest godly virtues such as patience, diligence and resilience.

For manifesting such virtues, a primary motivator is our own misbehavior, especially when compared ourselves with the better behavior of others. But when we justify our weaknesses by comparing with those weaker than us, we strip ourselves of that powerful motivator. And we end up multiplying our weaknesses, not rectifying them. Instead of sabotaging ourselves, the Bhagavad-gita (03.21) urges us all to become models that others can emulate for their well-being.

Manifesting our potential is our responsibility to ourselves and to others. It's our responsibility to ourselves because it is we who will have to live the future we create by our present actions. And it's our responsibility to others because they will be affected by our actions, given that we live in an interconnected world.

If we take responsibility to unleash our spirituality by taking shelter of the supreme divinity, we will surprise ourselves with how much of a positive difference we can make.

Think it over

How does justifying our weakness endanger our soul?

When we compare ourselves with those weaker than us, how do we demotivate ourselves?

When dealing with our weaknesses, how can we make a positive difference?

03.21 Whatever action a great man performs, common men follow. And whatever standards he sets by exemplary acts, all the world pursues.

Between naivete and cynicism is the courage to trust

When we are inexperienced, we may naïvely believe that everyone is entirely trustworthy. Exploiting our naiveté, self-interested people will sooner or later take us for a ride.

On being disappointed or betrayed by those whom we had trusted, we may recoil to the other extreme, becoming cynical about everyone. We start attributing selfish motives by default to everyone, even those who are kind and affectionate. Such cynicism keeps us lonely and alienated.

Between these two extremes of naiveté and cynicism is the courage to trust, wherein we acknowledge that everyone has snakes inside them, as do we ourselves. Yet we also acknowledge that we have an innate need to love and be loved, a need that can't be denied forever. Therefore, we learn to complement our heart's longing with our head's probing; we open our heart gradually to some people, using our intelligence and experience. Whereas cynical people dismiss all trust as naïve, we see trust as an act of courage: the willingness to give at least some people the benefit of the doubt, as we give to ourselves and want others to give to us.

Such courage is required not just in our relationships with other human beings but also in our relationship with the supreme being. The Bhagavad-gita (04.39) states that only when we have trust can we attain transcendental knowledge. Significantly, the Gita urges us to complement our trust with sensual regulation and spiritual dedication. Why such regulation and dedication? Because through them, we use our head to mold our heart into a fit laboratory for conducting the experiment of bhakti-yoga and experiencing the result of loving, fulfilling absorption in the divine.

When we thus practice bhakti-yoga, our heart becomes enriched with sublime peace, love and joy, all of which become increasingly relishable with purification. And we realize that our courage to trust has been richly rewarded.

Think it over

What are the problems with naivete and cynicism?

How is trust an act of courage?

How can trust take us to transcendence?

04.39 A faithful man who is dedicated to transcendental knowledge and who subdues his senses is eligible to achieve such knowledge, and having achieved it he quickly attains the supreme spiritual peace.

Comparing is unavoidable, but comparing mentality is undesirable

In our competitive world, comparing is almost universal. In schools with any kind of assessment, who gets higher grades and who lower will be inevitably seen. Similarly, in workplaces, who earns more than who will naturally be noticed.

All such unavoidable comparison is functional. Significantly different from such contextual comparison is the comparing mentality, wherein we constantly compare ourselves with others and start basing our self-identity on that evaluation. For example, if we equate our net worth with our self-worth, we feel insecure and inferior on seeing those who earn more than us. If students equate themselves with their grades, they lose their confidence and fail to do justice to their specific talents. Due to the comparing mentality, we become envious of those better than us, and we loathe ourselves for not being that good. When we equate functional comparison with foundational self-identification, we sentence ourselves to incurable dissatisfaction.

How can we avoid the comparing mentality? By understanding that our essential identity is spiritual, beyond the world's comparisons. The Bhagavad-gita (05.20) states that those who realize their spiritual essence are not deluded by life's dualities. Such dualities often emerge or exacerbate when we constantly compare ourselves with others.

Existing above all worldly comparisons is our transcendental core. We all are eternal spiritual beings, precious parts of the benevolent whole, Krishna. In his scheme of things, we all have a role, a place, a contribution. When we connect with him by practicing bhakti-yoga, striving to serve him lovingly, we are guided to contribute in the way we are best suited to. And we relish who we always were, but had forgotten because of our obsession with worldly comparison.

When we thus become spiritually realized, then, irrespective of where we stand in the world's pecking order, we steadily savor sublime spiritual satisfaction.

Think it over

What is the difference between comparing and comparing mentality?

How does the comparing mentality hurt us?

How does realizing our spirituality raise us above the comparing mentality?

05.20 A person who neither rejoices upon achieving something pleasant nor laments upon obtaining something unpleasant, who is self-intelligent, who is unbewildered, and who knows the science of God is already situated in transcendence.

Boring people find people boring

We all probably know some people who bore us to death. Nothing they say or do interests us – and they keep saying and doing the same uninteresting things repeatedly. Such feelings are understandable because we all are individuals with our particular interests; naturally, some people interest us more than others. Still, we all are sometimes obliged to deal with uninteresting people.

To make such interactions more interesting, we can cultivate a learning mood by asking ourselves a bold, counter-intuitive question: Rather than people being boring, might we be boring? Boring in the sense that our scope of interests is too narrow.

Helping us expand our range of interests, Gita wisdom explains that we all are souls on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution. Such evolution centers on growth in our capacity to learn and to love, till we ultimately learn to love the all-attractive supreme, Krishna. The Bhagavad-gita (06.32) indicates that advanced spiritualists see how everyone is on a shared journey of spiritual evolution. In that journey, all our joys and sorrows are meant to further our evolution.

If we too strive to see others spiritually, we expand the scope of our interests – rather than treating people as boring because they don't provide us any material gratification, we can see them as interesting because they can help us learn things that further our spiritual evolution. No matter how boring their lives seem to be, they have had some experiences different from us. And understanding those experiences can teach us something valuable for our evolution, even if they had no intention of teaching that or even if they themselves had not learned that lesson from their own experience.

Thus, we can go beyond blaming others for being boring to taking responsibility for making our life interesting.

Think it over

When we find others boring, how might we ourselves be boring?

How does Gita wisdom expand our range of interests?

How can focusing on spiritual evolution make our boring interactions interesting?

06.32 He is a perfect yogi who, by comparison to his own self, sees the true equality of all beings, in both their happiness and their distress, O Arjuna!

The notion that love can exist outside of sacrifice is a dangerous lie

In today's world, many people equate love with feel-good. When they experience an overwhelming hormonal rush that makes them feel attracted and captivated by someone, they think they are in love. When that hormonal rush drops, they drop their "beloved" as if they were dropping a hot potato.

Such unstable relationships arise from a misconception: the notion that love can exist outside of sacrifice. This notion is a dangerous lie. Why? First because love requires sacrifice, including especially sacrifice of our feeling good; only then can we start doing what is good for our relationship. Second because it impels us to pursue commitment-free relationships, which don't even touch the heart, leave alone satisfy it.

Just as uncommitted relationships with others in the world are unstable and unfulfilling, so is an uncommitted relationship with God. Just as deep relationships call upon us to come out of ourselves, so does deep devotion. The Bhagavad-gita (09.14) states that those devoted to Krishna endeavor with great determination to internally and externally glorify him. Why is endeavor needed? Because expressing devotion requires an effortful striving against our mind's impurities and the world's hostilities.

Such striving centers on dedication and purification. Dedication means giving of our entire being to God even when our mind's moods make us feel like not giving even one part of our being to him. Purification means a purging of the many impure desires within us so that our pure spiritual core can manifest. When we thus become connected with and absorbed in Krishna, we relish a sublime spiritual richness that fills and floods the heart. That is the ultimate good feeling — a feeling that doesn't just make us feel good, but also makes us good.

Think it over

Why is the notion that love can exist outside of sacrifice a dangerous lie?

Why is endeavor needed in our relationship with God?

What is the ultimate good feeling?

09.14 Always chanting My glories, endeavoring with great determination, bowing down before Me, these great souls perpetually worship Me with devotion.

Thinking about worldly things is not attachment; being unable to stop thinking of them is

Attachment is a state of mental bondage wherein our thoughts compulsively gravitate towards the object of our attachment.

The Bhagavad-gita (01.01) begins with the words of Dhritarashtra that reveal his attachment to the Kuru kingdom, which he wanted to vicariously enjoy through his son. Because of his attachment, he became so emotionally and ethically stunted that even when his own nephews were being robbed and his daughter-in-law was being disrobed – even when such atrocities called for his immediate intervention – he couldn't stop thinking of the kingdom and feeling glee about attaining it soon.

Seeing how attachment can degrade dangerously, some people think that they should not even think of anything worldly. Significantly however, the same Gita (11.33) urges Arjuna to fight the Kurukshetra war and attain a flourishing kingdom by becoming an instrument of Krishna to establish dharma. To administer a kingdom, Arjuna would certainly need to think about it. This implies that thinking about the kingdom is not bad. Of course, the Gita's consistent directive is to always think of Krishna and to think of everything in relationship with Krishna.

Gita wisdom re-envisioned our various roles, resources, and responsibilities in the world as services to Krishna. To have such a devotional vision, we need to invest time in thinking of Krishna exclusively through our sadhana, dedicated spiritual practice. If we can't stop thinking of our worldly accouterments when we are meant to think of Krishna during our sadhana, that is a red signal of excessive attachment.

But if we strive to focus on Krishna during our sadhana and thereby become attached to him, then we can use worldly things without becoming attached to them. Thus thinking devotionally of various things won't entangle us, but will expand our service to Krishna.

Think it over

Explain how attachment stunted Dhritarashtra emotionally and ethically.

How can we see our worldly accouterments devotionally?

How can thinking of worldly things expand our service to Krishna?

11.33 Therefore get up. Prepare to fight and win glory. Conquer your enemies and enjoy a flourishing kingdom. They are already put to death by My arrangement, and you, O Savyasaachi, can be but an instrument in the fight.

Trying to get even with others gets us at odds with ourselves

Whenever anyone hurts us, a natural human tendency is to want to get even with them: “The way you have hurt me, I will hurt you back.”

If we go along with that tendency, we let ourselves become consumed by hatred and revenge fantasies. When revenge fantasies consume us, we forget both the things that are truly important for us as well as our spiritual evolution. Thus, we get at odds with ourselves. Eventually, we end up losing ourselves in our desperate effort to make someone else lose. We become centered on bringing about the downfall of the other person and in that process we can't have Krishna as our center. We can't attain love for God if we are filled with hatred for any part of God.

Does this mean that we never do anything even if others wrong us? No, it means that we don't lose perspective in trying to get even. When we strive to internally connect with Krishna and externally contribute to serving him according to our capacity, we can discipline others without making revenge our driving purpose. The Bhagavad-gita (11.55) exhorts us to not be inimical toward anyone while executing our material obligations and pursuing our spiritual evolution.

In mathematics, even numbers and odd numbers are non-overlapping categories; numbers that are even can't be odd and vice versa. But in life, getting even with others and getting at odds are overlapping actions. Understanding this, we can avoid both and focus on getting on with our spiritual evolution toward Krishna and a meaningful, fulfilling life thereof.

Think it over

How do we get at odds with ourselves while trying to get even with others?

How can we take action against those who have hurt us without losing ourselves?

Do you need to stop getting even with someone? How can you go about stopping yourself?

11.55 My dear Arjuna, he who engages in My pure devotional service, free from the contaminations of fruitive activities and mental speculation, he who works for Me, who makes Me the supreme goal of his life, and who is friendly to every living being – he certainly comes to Me.

Be childlike, not childish

Children have a charm to them. They have an innocence and freshness to them that lightens and brightens the world around them. They bring out the gentleness even among rough people.

Their charm notwithstanding, children are naïve. They can be easily misled and cheated. They can also act thoughtlessly, doing things that are mischievous or even dangerous. Though they rarely mean any harm, they can frequently do harm, to themselves and to others. That's why parenting is a round-the-clock job, which requires protecting children not just from others but also from themselves.

Children become adults not merely by growing biologically, but primarily by growing emotionally and intellectually. Whereas children may consider their toys the most important things in the world, adults know that many other things are much more important. Adults are responsible – they can keep small things small. While gaining maturity, however, adults often lose the innocence and sweetness of childhood. Life's adversities often make adults cynical and manipulative.

If someone could integrate the innocence of childhood and the maturity of adulthood, they would be loveable, reliable, admirable. Such are the saintly people, who are the well-wishers of everyone (Bhagavad-gita 12.13). Their consciousness exists at the spiritual level, which transcends all bodily stages, childhood and adulthood included. Being at the spiritual level, the saintly can manifest virtues that integrate the best of both childhood and adulthood. By virtue of their purity, the goodness of the soul manifests in them, unsullied by the mind with its impurities. By virtue of their devotion, the goodness of God manifests through them, unsullied by worldly calculations.

The saintly are innocent, but not naïve; mature, but not cynical; childlike, but not childish. They reveal the potential that we all can tap by growing spiritually.

Think it over

What is good and not-so-good about childhood?

What is good and not-so-good about adulthood?

How do the saintly manifest the best of both childhood and adulthood?

12.13 One who is not envious but is a kind friend to all living entities, who does not think himself a proprietor and is free from false ego, who is equal in both happiness and distress, who is tolerant ... [— such a devotee of Mine is very dear to Me].

Humility means to focus on how we can serve, not on what we deserve

In life, we frequently feel that we don't get what we deserve. For example, we may work tirelessly on a project, yet our team may not adequately appreciate our contribution. Similarly, in many other life-areas, we may feel undervalued and under-recognized.

Wanting some recognition and reciprocation is an understandable human longing. Yet just because a particular longing is understandable doesn't mean that its fulfillment is probable – the world is often an uncaring place. And if we long for recognition from people who don't seem to care about us, we make ourselves dependent on things beyond our control, thereby disempowering ourselves.

How, then, can we get the motivation to persevere in doing our part? By cultivating humility, which the Bhagavad-gita (13.08) states is the beginning of knowledge. Humility helps us remember our identity and purpose. Gita wisdom explains that we are souls and are meant to serve the Whole, Krishna (Bhagavad-gita 15.07). If we start working in a mood of service to him, that service gradually becomes our connection with him. Through that connection, we gain an inner stability that decreases our dependence on externals such as worldly appreciation.

Moreover, when we connect with Krishna, he gives us inner guidance to better understand ourselves as well as others. Thereby, we can seek like-minded association, wherein we are more likely to be understood, valued and appreciated. Being thus strengthened, we can better work with unlike-minded people whenever we need to.

If we focus on how we can serve the Whole and the various parts of the Whole, we start relishing the sublime joy of living with a positive service attitude. When our life becomes empowered with such inner fulfillment, we surprise ourselves with our perseverance and resilience. Thereby, we make significant contributions that stand tall on their own merit, irrespective of the world's appreciation.

Think it over

How does focusing on what we deserve disempower us?

How does focusing on how we can serve empower us?

How does spiritual knowledge empower us to focus on how we can serve?

13.08 Humility; pridelessness; nonviolence; tolerance; simplicity; approaching a bona fide spiritual master; cleanliness; steadiness; self-control; ... [– all these I declare to be knowledge].

Those who are not humble often help us to become humble

Dealing with arrogant people can be annoying and draining. To view such people positively, we can see interactions with them as opportunities to become humble.

The Bhagavad-gita (13.08) lists humility as a laudable virtue that is integral to knowledge. And humility is primarily a relational virtue; it is demonstrated and developed through our relationships with others. When people are polite with us, reciprocating similarly with them is relatively easy. But when someone isn't polite, we are forced to draw on our humility muscles to stay courteous with them.

Our muscles grow not by lifting the weights that we can easily lift, but by lifting weights that are a struggle to lift. Similarly, our humility grows not by dealing with people who respect us, but by dealing with people who don't respect us. Of course, if we lift weights that are too heavy too often, we damage ourselves physically. Similarly, if we deal too often with people who are too dismissive and derisive toward us, we damage ourselves psychologically; we become filled with negative emotions such as resentment, self-doubt and self-pity. We can keep a distance from malicious people, but not from difficult people.

How do we know when to draw the line? By focusing on the ultimate purpose of social interactions: service to Krishna.

Gita wisdom explains that we are souls on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution toward our source, Krishna. We evolve spiritually by infusing all our activities, including our social interactions, with an attitude of service toward Krishna. We can endure some barbs from some people if that's required for our service. Gradually, by our spirituality and humility, some humility may rub off on them too, thereby making interactions with them easier. And even if they don't become humble, still Krishna will see our persistent service attitude and bless us profusely.

Think it over

How do non-humble people help us become humble?

While dealing with others, when do we need to draw a line?

Are there any difficult people in your life? How can you be more patient with them?

13.08 Humility; pridelessness; nonviolence; tolerance; simplicity; approaching a bona fide spiritual master; cleanliness; steadiness; self-control; ... [– all these I declare to be knowledge].

Commitment is emotional investment, attachment is emotional dependence

In our relationships, we may wonder: How can we be committed without being attached?

By being emotionally invested, not emotionally dependent.

Consider the relationship between a doctor and a patient. The doctor needs to care for the patient's feelings: if the patient has an injury at a normal injection point, the doctor needs to inject elsewhere whenever possible. Still, the doctor can't care so much for the patient's feelings as to flinch from giving a necessary injection. In deciding how to treat, the doctor needs to consider the patient's feelings, but not depend solely on them.

A similar dynamic applies to our relationships. If we are apathetically detached, not caring for the feelings of our loved ones, we will hurt them unnecessarily. But if we are so attached as to shirk from opposing them even when they are doing something terribly unwise, we will have failed in our duty to protect them from unnecessary hurt.

Significantly, the Bhagavad-gita (13.10), while listing the twenty characteristics of knowledge, groups detachment from our loved ones with steady devotion to Krishna. What may this grouping signify? That bhakti can protect us from both extremes of emotional alienation and emotional obsession.

How can bhakti protect us from alienation? By reminding us that because we are Krishna's parts, we need to do a part of his will by acting as the well-wishers of our loved ones — we need to care for them.

How can bhakti protect us from obsession? By reminding us that Krishna is everyone's ultimate well-wisher (05.29); he will take care of our loved ones even if we can't — we needn't be obsessed with them.

Thus, when we care holistically for our loved ones — for both their feelings and their future — then we can be committed without being attached.

Think it over

When relating to our loved ones, what two extremes do we need to avoid? Explain with an example.

How can bhakti protect us from both emotional obsession and emotional alienation?

How can you move your key relationships from emotional dependence to emotional investment?

13.10 To those who are constantly devoted to serving Me with love, I give the understanding by which they can come to Me.

Mind your mind before you mind anyone else's mind

Suppose someone's misbehavior irritates us. We may tell them off: "Why are you letting your mind take you for a ride?"

Even if what we say is true, it is likely to come off as condescending. It can imply that they are so dumb as to let their mind control them, while we are so smart as to see what they can't see: that their mind is controlling them. If we delight in this feeling of superiority, we may not realize that we are ourselves being taken for a ride by our mind – it has deluded us into believing that we have controlled it, while actually keeping us in its control.

That's why before we mind anyone else's mind, we need to first mind our own mind. Undoubtedly, if others fail to mind their mind, their failure can trouble us. But, if we react to their failure by failing to mind our mind, we will act in ways that make bad things worse.

To understand, consider an out-of-control car driver. Suppose we are driving on a road and the driver next to us loses control over their car, which veers into our lane. Angry and alarmed, we may yell at them to control their car. But if we get so caught in yelling at them that we lose control of our own car, we increase the likelihood of an accident. We need to first focus on controlling our car and doing our part to avert the immediate danger. Then we can exhort or instruct them to control their car.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (13.28) urges us to see that we all are in the same boat – we are souls driving body-mind machines that tend to go out of our control. Equipped with this educated, empathic vision of our universal human predicament, we can better mind our mind.

Think it over

In telling others to mind their mind, how may we be failing to mind our own mind?

Why do we need to mind our mind's mind before we mind others' mind? Explain with an example.

What spiritual vision can help us better mind our mind's mind?

13.28 One who sees the Supersoul accompanying the individual soul in all bodies, and who understands that neither the soul nor the Supersoul within the destructible body is ever destroyed, actually sees.

Don't be annoyed that people are so bad; be amazed that they aren't worse

People can annoy us in innumerable ways – they can be incompetent, insensitive, forgetful, lazy, dumb. If we let ourselves get annoyed by them, we will stay irritated for the rest of our lives.

How can we avoid such irritation? By letting Gita wisdom educate our vision of people.

Everyone has troubles: The world is a tough place (Bhagavad-gita 08.15). Just as people don't know the issues we are facing, we don't know the issues they are facing. Just as our issues sometimes get to our nerves, so too can others' issues get to their nerves.

Everyone has a troublesome mind: Our mind can be our inner enemy (06.06) Just as our mind can subject us to a private inner hell, so can others' mind torment them. Just as others can't see our inner torment, we can't see others' inner torment.

Everyone's mind can react to trouble with malevolence: The world's reversals externally and the mind's reactions internally can conspire to bring the worst out of people: "If I can't have a good life, what right does anyone have to a good life?"

Pointing to all this turmoil going on inside people, the Bhagavad-gita (14.05) states that everyone is bound by the modes of material nature, which can drag them like puppets. When we are thus educated by Gita wisdom, we can increase our empathy toward others and lower our expectations from them. Then, if they are kind, thoughtful, responsible, we will be appreciative, even amazed. If they aren't so good, we will be better prepared.

If we become more empathic to others' predicaments, we can set an example that others will pick up, even if not immediately. Thus, we all can help each other make the difficult journey through this difficult world easier, not tougher.

Think it over

How can Gita wisdom educate our vision of others?

How can an educated vision reshape our relationships?

In your life, how can you be more empathic toward someone annoying?

14.05 Material nature consists of three modes – goodness, passion and ignorance. When the eternal living entity comes in contact with nature, O mighty-armed Arjuna, he becomes conditioned by these modes.

Find your own story or you will become a bit player in someone else's story

Suppose we have a significant part in a story being enacted in a mega-theater where multiple plays are going on simultaneously. But suppose someone misleads us into some other play, where we are made a bit player, doing an insignificant part that just wastes our time and talent. We will feel outrageously cheated.

We all run the danger of being similarly cheated. The world is like a mega-theater where multiple stories are being enacted. Herein, we can enact a grand story, provided we understand ourselves. Gita wisdom explains that we are eternal souls on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution. To enact the story of our evolution, we need to learn to lovingly serve the Whole, the all-attractive supreme, Krishna. To understand how we can best serve, we need to look within to identify what matters most to us, what we have been gifted with, what we feel deeply driven to do.

Unfortunately, instead of seeking such self-understanding, we get diverted by externals. In today's ultra-commercialized world, many agents of materialism sell us seductive stories by mouthing slogans such as the consumer is the king. When we buy into such stories, we become consumed by desires and become reduced to mere cogs in a vast economic engine that fills their pockets and empties ours. They bombard our mind and senses with myriad temptations, sending us on an exhausting and frustrating search for petty pleasures (Bhagavad-gita 15.07).

Thankfully, we don't have to enact this sorry story; we can find our own story. If we practice bhakti-yoga and connect with Krishna, we get, by his mercy, the inner calm and clarity to understand ourselves. Equipped with such healthy self-awareness, we all can chart for ourselves the path to a rich life of outer contribution and inner satisfaction.

Think it over

What is the grand story we are meant to enact?

How are we misled into enacting a sorry story?

How can we find our story?

15.07 The living entities in this conditioned world are My eternal fragmental parts. Due to conditioned life, they are struggling very hard with the six senses, which include the mind.

To be nice is not to be naive — it is to be free from the control of vice

Some people say, “If you are nice, you will be exploited by others.”

They equate being nice with being naive, with the starry-eyed belief that everyone is good and kind and trustworthy. The naive are headed for a big shock.

If we want to survive in the rough-and-tumble of life, we can't be naive. But we can still be nice. Being nice means that we aren't controlled by vice; that we aren't driven by envy, greed, anger etc in our dealings with others; that we are courteous toward others even while sticking to our principles and purposes. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (16.02) states that the godly are gentle and are averse to faultfinding — they are nice in the sense that they aren't harsh or hypercritical.

Ultimately, the difference between being nice and being naive boils down to adherence to dharma. Dharma centers on the roles we play and the duties we do. While doing the right thing, we can strive to be polite and gentle. But if someone stops us from doing our dharma, then we need to take a firm stand, even if that doesn't look nice.

The Pandavas exemplify being nice without being naive. When Duryodhana abused and defrauded them, his father, Dhritarashtra, tried to weasel out a solution that let Duryodhana keep all his ill-gotten gains while leaving the Pandavas with nothing to even survive or do their dharma. The Pandavas didn't naively fall for Dhritarashtra's ruse. Yet after they neutralized Duryodhana in the Kurukshetra war, they didn't target Dhritarashtra; they gave him the honor due to a father figure.

Thus, being nice doesn't mean being naive — it means being firmly devoted to virtue without becoming dominated by vice.

Think it over

What is the problem with being naive?

What is the essential difference between being naive and being nice?

In your relationships, how can you better tread the line between being naive and giving in to vice?

16.02 Nonviolence; truthfulness; freedom from anger; renunciation; tranquillity; aversion to faultfinding; compassion for all living entities; freedom from covetousness; gentleness; modesty; steady determination; ... [– these transcendental qualities, O son of Bharata, belong to godly men endowed with divine nature.]

Those who don't respect themselves are most agitated when others don't respect them

When others disrespect us, we naturally feel hurt. But some people go beyond feeling hurt to wanting to hurt others, and hurt them disproportionately.

Why do we all react differently to the same action? Because of our varying self-conceptions. How we regard ourselves shapes how we regard others' actions toward us.

Disproportionate reactions to disrespect stem from deep-rooted inner insecurity. If someone pushed us while they walked by us, we would feel annoyed. But if we felt those passing by weren't just pushing us but were knocking down the very house in which we were living, we would feel beyond annoyed; we would feel threatened and angered. And we might react far more aggressively. That's how those who are insecure feel when they are disrespected. The whole house of their self-conception is founded on how others respect them; they have no intrinsic self-respect.

Their inner insecurity often comes from materialism, which reduces us to a mere bag of biochemicals buzzing about temporarily. Materialism makes our self-worth dependent on our social worth. No wonder the Bhagavad-gita (16.04) declares that ungodly materialists are characterized by haughtiness and harshness – they demand respect and destroy verbally those who don't offer them respect.

To counter such inner insecurity, we need a more spiritual self-conception. Gita wisdom reveals that we are indestructible spiritual beings who are parts of the divine. We have intrinsic self-worth because we are always loved by God, irrespective of how society views us. By God's grace, we all can make a difference, small but significant, for our future and the world's future, even if the world doesn't value us. When we increase our self-respect, not in an egoistic sense, but in a spiritual sense by elevating our self-conception, we find disrespect less disturbing.

If we seek intrinsic self-worth, Gita wisdom stands ready to help us spiritualize our self-conception.

Think it over

How do you react when disrespected?

How does materialism deplete our sense of self-worth?

How does Gita wisdom infuse us with intrinsic self-worth?

16.04 Pride, arrogance, conceit, anger, harshness and ignorance – these qualities belong to those of demoniac nature, O son of Prutha.

Those who don't find the reprehensible reprehensible, are reprehensible

Suppose someone sits and works and lives in a place that is dirty and stinky. If they don't find anything wrong with their surroundings, we would wonder if something is wrong with them.

What applies to physical dirt applies all the more to behavioral dirt. When we function in an inter-connected, interdependent society, we all expect a certain basic standard of behavior from each other. Suppose someone doesn't act the right way, or, worse still, feels nothing wrong in doing something wrong or, worst of all, derives a devilish delight in doing wrong things that hurt others. We would wonder if something essential is missing in them.

Yes, what's missing in them is an active conscience. Conscience is our inner protector; it deters us from wrong actions and prompts us toward right actions. People with a demonic mentality have a conscience that is silenced and almost deadened. Why has their conscience become deadened? Because they have acted wrongly so many times, neglecting their conscience repeatedly till it is rendered numb and mute. Driven by greed, they may even murder their rivals and celebrate such viciousness as proof of their cleverness (16.14). Those people who don't see what is reprehensible as reprehensible are reprehensible.

Thankfully, even if someone is reprehensible, they aren't incorrigible. They are still parts of the divine, as are all living beings (15.07).

Nonetheless, people with a deadened conscience are scary reminders of how perverted a soul who is essentially just like us can become. Such reminders can inspire us: to stop being nonchalant about the morally questionable actions we may be considering; and to strengthen our conscience by practicing bhakti-yoga, thereby transforming ourselves positively and increasing our capacity to positively transform others.

Think it over

How does the conscience of some people become deadened?

How can encountering people with no conscience inspire us to strengthen our conscience?

Is there something wrong that you don't find wrong? What can you do to activate your conscience in that area?

16.14 The demoniac person thinks: "... He is my enemy, and I have killed him, and my other enemies will also be killed. I am the lord of everything. I am the enjoyer. I am perfect, powerful and happy."

The causes of anger rarely hurt us as much as the consequences of anger

Suppose someone insults us. Feeling angry, we lash out at them. They feel hurt and react defensively or aggressively, doing things that hurt us further. And we retaliate, leading to an ever-escalating cycle. Initially, there was only our hurt because of their actions, but now there is their hurt because of our angry outburst, and our hurt because of their reaction to our outburst. Thus, the consequences of anger hurt far more than the causes of anger. No wonder the Bhagavad-gita (16.21) cautions that anger can make our life hellish.

What makes things terrible is not our anger itself, but our thoughtless actions impelled by anger.

Even when anger indicates correctly that something is wrong, it doesn't always indicate correctly what is wrong. Anger impels us to snap judgments, whereby we think we know what has happened and why. If we judge wrongly and condemn others, our presumptuousness angers them. Even if we judge correctly, still anger impels us to use unnecessarily harsh words, thereby causing avoidable pain and alienation.

To address our hurt constructively, we need to first calm ourselves. For gaining such calmness, nourishing our spirituality is immensely helpful. What does nourishing our spirituality mean? Broadly, it means realizing two truths: we are at our core souls who are indestructible, and overseeing all events is our omnibenevolent Lord who can bring good out of everything, even the bad. Appreciating these truths, we experience inner security; we don't feel so threatened by others' actions. Being thus internally stabilized, we can understand the situation better and act with greater maturity to resolve the underlying issue.

By remembering that the consequences of anger hurt more than its causes, we can get the impetus to restrain our anger and then address the hurt constructively.

Think it over

How do the consequences of anger hurt more than its causes?

How does anger impel us to act thoughtlessly?

How does nourishing our spirituality help us deal with anger?

16.21 There are three gates leading to this hell – lust, anger and greed. Every sane man should give these up, for they lead to the degradation of the soul.

Even if we are feeling miserable, that doesn't give us the right to make others miserable

When something goes wrong in our lives, we may feel hurt, irritated, dejected. If we give in to bouts of self-pity and start repeating our sorry story to everyone around us, we become radiators of misery. Even if we just remain in a foul mood, those around us become tense and have to walk on tiptoe. Thus, we become unwitting demonstrators of the old saying: misery loves company.

That's why we all have a responsibility to be happy. This doesn't mean we suppress or deny our problems and put on a facade of happiness; it just means that we deal with our distress maturely. We need loved ones with whom we can unburden ourselves by sharing our fears, sorrows or irritations. But once such unburdening is done, we need to move on.

Suppose we have a physical wound. We need to get it treated by a doctor and then do what is needed for recovering, including informing those whose help we need during recovery. But beyond that, that wound doesn't need to dominate all our discussions. We need to be similarly pragmatic in dealing with our emotional wounds.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (17.16) states that cultivating satisfaction is an austerity of the mind. To cultivate satisfaction, we need to focus on the things that are right in our lives, not on the things that are wrong. Gita wisdom expands our understanding of all that is right in our lives: we are at our core souls who are indestructible; we are parts of an all-benevolent Whole, Krishna, whose love for us is inexhaustible; if we harmonize with him, we can evolve spiritually toward lasting fulfillment even if things go downhill materially.

When we thus cultivate satisfaction as a voluntarily chosen responsibility, we learn to treat our emotional wounds without letting them infect everyone around us.

Think it over

How may we become unwitting demonstrators of the saying: misery loves company?

How can we deal with our emotional wounds pragmatically?

Is there any negativity in your life that you tend to wallow in? How can you change that?

17.16 And satisfaction, simplicity, gravity, self-control and purification of one's existence are the austerities of the mind.

To be compassionate, be both caring and careful

Suppose a doctor is asked to travel to an epidemic zone to treat patients. To take up such an assignment, they would need to have compassion. And their compassion needs to manifest in two simultaneous ways: by being caring and careful. They need to be caring; otherwise, why would they go through all the trouble and risk of going to an infected area? And they need to be careful; otherwise, they might become infected by the very same disease they were supposed to treat.

A similar principle applies to us when we exercise compassion in any walk of life, even in spiritual life when we share spiritual wisdom with others. While sharing such wisdom, we often need to associate with people who live materialistically. We need to be caring, to recognize that living in materialistic consciousness is the recipe for dissatisfaction and frustration, a dark fate that we can help them come out of. Simultaneously, we need to be careful, knowing that their materialistic consciousness can infect us, thereby leading to our getting contaminated.

Even while we give charity to the needy, we need to be both caring and careful. If someone is starving, we need a heart that cares; only then will we want to offer them some help. But we also need a head that is clear enough to, say, check whether they are starving because of squandering all their money on alcoholism; whether they might misuse our charity to drink further; and whether they might commit further wrongs under the influence of alcohol.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (17.20) urges us to temper whatever charitable instinct we may have by considering time-place-circumstance. Such tempering essentially means a thoughtful combination of being caring and being careful. When we thus channel our compassion constructively, we can learn to help in a way that actually helps.

Think it over

Why does a doctor need to be both caring and careful?

While sharing spiritual wisdom, how can we be constructively compassionate?

While giving charity, how can we ensure that our help actually helps?

17.20 Charity given out of duty, without expectation of return, at the proper time and place, and to a worthy person is considered to be in the mode of goodness.

To resolve conflicts, begin with the 1% commonality, not the 99% differences

Whenever we have a conflict with someone, our attention naturally goes to the area of conflict: we want to do things in one way; they, in another way. However, focusing on differences thickens the wall of hostility that increases polarization.

To resolve the conflict, we need to conscientiously shift our focus to what we share, not where we differ. That shift brings us closer to a common ground, where we can start talking with each other instead of talking past each other.

What if we feel that we differ so much that we have nothing in common? Such a feeling hardly ever arises from reality; it usually arises because our perception of reality is distorted by the lower modes of passion and ignorance. The Bhagavad-gita (18.20) states that perception in the mode of goodness sees beyond material diversity to spiritual commonality.

How can we cultivate the mode of goodness? By regularly engaging in spiritual practices. And amidst provoking situations, by consciously calming ourselves through appropriate practices such as deep breathing or mantra chanting. With our consciousness thus elevated, we can better appreciate others' concerns and better articulate our own.

Often, conflicts escalate not just because of the issues, but also because of the emotions we bring to the issues. Starting with commonalities activates positive emotions, thereby offsetting extraneous negativities. With that positivity, we may well discover that whereas we earlier thought that our differences were 99%, actually our commonalities are 99%. We may well share the same overarching purposes and differ only about contextual processes. Even if we differ substantially, we still share the same ultimate purposes such as spiritual evolution and social contribution; the differences are therefore not worth fighting over endlessly.

By thus beginning with 1% commonality, we increase the likelihood of arriving at amicable resolutions.

Think it over

How does cultivating the mode of goodness help in conflict resolution?

How can we prevent the escalation of conflicts?

Are you presently in any conflict with someone? Can you list at least three commonalities you share with them?

18.20 That knowledge by which one undivided spiritual nature is seen in all living entities, though they are divided into innumerable forms, you should understand to be in the mode of goodness.

Self-pity makes feel-bad seem feel-good

Suppose we are in physical pain. We will naturally do whatever we can to free ourselves from that pain as soon as possible. While such a response is exhibited by all living beings for protecting themselves from pain, that response is distorted by our mind when we experience pain at the emotional level. One kind of distorted response is self-pity.

Self-pity is a peculiar emotional state wherein we feel bad and feel good about feeling bad. We parade our distress to the world and most certainly to ourselves and then seek sympathy about how we have been victimized and traumatized. And such showing our misery becomes the way we feel good about how bad we feel. Indeed, we humans seem to have a deep-rooted need to complain and to blame. And perversely, doing the things that make us feel victimized and to thereby justify our sorry state is the distressful way we subject ourselves to unnecessary pain.

The Bhagavad-gita (18.35) states that negative emotions such as fearfulness, lamentation and moroseness — all of which are typical of self-pity — characterize a perverse determination afflicted by the mode of ignorance.

Such is the deadly trap into which we may fall in our mind, knowing that it can become like a black hole to consume our consciousness, we need to ensure that we don't pseudo-medicate ourselves by feeling good about feeling bad. The best way to protect ourselves is by gaining access to processes by which we can not only feel-good but also become-good. Gita wisdom explains that the all-pure, all-powerful, all-pleasurable ultimate reality, Krishna, is our greatest well-wisher, and we can connect with him by the time-tested process of bhakti-yoga. When we habituate ourselves to connecting with Krishna, we get a steady inner shelter that enables us to identify outer situations more discerningly and thereby do what it takes to either tolerate or transcend difficult situations.

Think it over

How does our mind make us feel-good about feeling bad?

How can we deal with the mind's black hole?

How can spirituality help us avoid pseudo-medicating ourselves?

18.35 And that determination which cannot go beyond dreaming, fearfulness, lamentation, moroseness and illusion – such unintelligent determination, O son of Prutha, is in the mode of darkness.

When you feel like giving up, start looking up — not sentimentally, but spiritually

When life seems overwhelming, we may feel like giving up. As a last-ditch effort, we may look up. Whether looking up will help depends on whether we look up sentimentally or spiritually. To understand the difference between the two ways of looking up, consider a metaphor.

Suppose someone is flailing in a stormy ocean. They may look up for someone to come and calm the waves. Or they may look up for someone to rescue them from the ocean.

Spiritual texts often compare the material world to an ocean. The world may sometimes look calm, but things can go south in moments. To look up sentimentally means to hope that someone from above will magically fix our problems. To look up spiritually means to raise our consciousness to the spiritual level: to understand that reality has two levels, material and spiritual; that we as souls belong to the indestructible spiritual level; and that the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna, is our ultimate shelter. When we thus raise our consciousness, we aren't that much troubled by life's dualities.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (18.58) assures that if we become conscious of the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna, we will pass over all obstacles by his grace. The usage "pass over" signifies that obstacles may remain, but grace will enable us to get over them. Thus, this verse recommends not a sentimental looking up, whereby we hope for the magical removal of obstacles, but a spiritual looking up, whereby we evolve enough to ensure that obstacles don't hold us back.

If we look up sentimentally, we may sometimes feel that no one is helping us. But if we look up spiritually, we will surely find ourselves helped: our raised consciousness will always provide us relief.

Think it over

What does looking up sentimentally mean?

What does looking up spiritually mean?

What resources can help you to look up spiritually?

18.58 If you become conscious of Me, you will pass over all the obstacles of conditioned life by My grace. If, however, you do not work in such consciousness but act through false ego, not hearing Me, you will be lost.

Whose words we hear matters, but whose words we hold dear matters even more

Suppose we are lost while driving and ask for directions. If some people give us right directions and others give us wrong directions, where we end up will be determined by whose words we value.

We all sometimes feel lost during our life-journey, not knowing what life is ultimately meant for. If we don't feel lost, that's because we have uncritically accepted the prevailing materialistic worldview, which reduces our life to a doomed journey to the graveyard.

To direct our life-journey, the Bhagavad-gita is a time-honored guidebook. If we get to hear its words, we are fortunate. But more important than hearing the Gita is valuing the Gita. This principle is illustrated through two individuals who were blessed to hear the Gita: Sanjaya and Dhritarashtra. They valued its message differently and courted drastically different fates.

On hearing the Gita, Sanjaya became astonished and thrilled (18.74). And he applied the Gita by becoming joyfully absorbed in divine remembrance (18.76-77).

Dhritarashtra too heard the Gita but experienced no spiritual elevation. Why? Because he didn't value its message. He was attached to his son and to the Kuru kingdom. As the Gita threatened to expose the folly of his attachment, he neglected its words. Instead, he held dear those words that rationalized his attachments: words of diabolical advisers such as Kanaka, Shakuni's brahmin friend. Kanaka's pseudo-ethics (Kanaka-Niti) held that one's own gain is the supreme end and all means are acceptable for achieving that end. By letting such words mold his decisions, Dhritarashtra became complicit in the destruction of his entire dynasty.

If we hear the Gita regularly and treasure its message as our foremost guiding principle, it will make our life spiritually meaningful, fruitful and joyful.

Think it over

How are we lost in our life, even if we don't feel lost?

Why did Dhritarashtra not value the Gita?

What does valuing the Gita means? How does valuing the Gita benefit us?

18.74 Sanjaya said: Thus have I heard the conversation of two great souls, Krishna and Arjuna. And so wonderful is that message that my hair is standing on end.

How to speak effectively

Wrong philosophy may not obstruct people spiritually as much as our calling their philosophy wrong

Suppose we encounter people who follow some philosophy in which we can find many holes. We may be tempted to call their philosophy wrong.

We need to resist that temptation because more important than correcting people's wrong philosophy is connecting them with the purpose of philosophy and the purpose of life at large: Krishna. The Bhagavad-gita (07.14) indicates that people explore life's spiritual side for various reasons; metaphysical knowledge is just one of those. If people connect with some path, it's not always because of that path's philosophy; it's frequently because they seek something else such as peace, relief from distress or a sense of belonging. If they get what they are looking for, they develop some emotional bond with that path and especially with that path's teachers.

What happens when we call their philosophy wrong, and especially if we call their teachers wrong? Such criticism, no matter how logical, seems to them a direct attack on the things they consider sacred, things that have improved the quality of their life. Feeling threatened and wounded, they hit back at us or at least go away from us and from Krishna, deeming Krishna's devotees fanatical. Thus, through our philosophical arguments, we end up defeating the purpose of philosophical argumentation: to help people come closer to Krishna. Pertinently, the Gita (03.26) urges us to not disturb people's minds, but to encourage them in their gradual spiritual evolution.

Therefore, instead of criticizing others' philosophical conceptions, we can use our creativity to help them experience in Krishna a spiritual solace deeper than whatever they have experienced in their present paths. Enlivened by that experience, they are more likely to re-examine their philosophical conceptions and, more importantly, their life-direction.

Think it over

Why do people explore a spiritual path?

How may philosophical argumentation alienate people?

How can we help people in their spiritual evolution?

03.26 So as not to disrupt the minds of ignorant men attached to the fruitive results of prescribed duties, a learned person should not induce them to stop work. Rather, by working in the spirit of devotion, he should engage them in all sorts of activities [for the gradual development of Krishna consciousness].

Be mindful of people's perceptions, but don't make your mind full of their perceptions

When we practice spiritual life, we go against the overall materialistic current of the world. The road less traveled is the road we choose to travel. Consequently, we need to stand apart from the world, to stay detached from the ways of worldly people (Bhagavad-gita 13.11).

Simultaneously, the Gita recommends a world-embracing spirituality, not a world-rejecting spirituality. It doesn't approve of our withdrawing into our own cocoon for our spiritual growth without any concern for others' spiritual growth. It endorses an inclusive spirituality that makes us agents for spiritualizing those around us.

With this compassionate thrust, the Gita stresses that we shouldn't agitate people's minds (03.26). How can we avoid disturbing people's minds if we are not even aware of their minds? We need to understand how they are perceiving our words, our actions, our spirituality. Only then can we present spiritual principles and practices in ways that are appealing, not alienating. That's why we need to be mindful of people's perceptions.

While being thus mindful, two caveats are in order. First, we can't change central spiritual truths just because people find them agitating. Nonetheless, spirituality often comes with contextual accretions and accessories that are suitable for some people, but not for others. We need to carefully consider what is suitable for whom.

Second, we can't let our mind become full of people's perceptions. Our mind needs to be full of our Lord, Krishna. And because everyone is a part of Krishna, we need to be conscious of their perceptions. Why? So that we can best serve them by presenting our Lord according to their level of spiritual receptivity.

By thus being aware of people's perceptions while not becoming obsessed with those perceptions, we can be both committed and compassionate.

Think it over

Why do spiritualists need to stand apart from the world?

Why do we need to be mindful of people's perceptions?

While being mindful of people's perceptions, what caveats are in order?

13.11 ...Constant and unalloyed devotion to Me; aspiring to live in a solitary place; detachment from the general mass of people; ... [– all these I declare to be knowledge].

Just because we have a right to be angry doesn't mean we are right to be angry

Sometimes, people wrong us by acting foolishly, irresponsibly or treacherously. At such times, we feel angry with them and also feel that our anger is justified.

Still, acting angrily is usually not the right thing to do. Why not? Because to sustain any relationship, we need to focus not on claiming our rights, but on considering what is right.

However, anger gives us a deceptive certainty that we are doing the right thing, so we don't need to consider the consequences of our actions. The heat of anger melts the barricade of our intelligence and leaves us defenseless against the waves of violent impulses rising in our consciousness.

Just as anger sabotages our intelligence, it also sabotages others' intelligence. That's why if we get angry with others, we increase the chances that they will also get angry with us, thereby escalating a reconcilable difference into a litany of apparently irreconcilable differences. The resulting confrontation often damages far more things than the thing we were so concerned about protecting. Thus anger backfires. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita cautions that anger paves our way to a hellish life, in both this world and the next (16.21).

How can we focus on doing what is right, not on claiming our rights? By using our intelligence to contemplate the best course of action. When we feel provoked, just a few moments of contemplation will deter us by showing that acting angrily is the worst course of action.

Moreover, if we strengthen our intelligence by regular scriptural study and spiritual practice, we will stabilize our consciousness. Amidst provocative situations, we won't give in to anger, but will prayerfully and purposefully focus on determining our core concern and addressing it in a way that is least aggressive and most effective.

Think it over

How does anger affect our intelligence?

How can anger backfire?

Do you feel you have a right to be angry with someone? How can you shift your focus to doing what is right?

16.21 There are three gates leading to this hell – lust, anger and greed. Every sane man should give these up, for they lead to the degradation of the soul.

Don't forget to compliment those who complement you

We all have painful inadequacies that make us dependent on others who complement us. Indeed, almost all of life's important responsibilities require us to work with others.

Consider parenting, the activity that ensures the perpetuation of our species: parenting. During both conceiving and rearing children, parents complement each other. Even in solo activities such as individual sports, say, chess or tennis, players are complemented by their coaches.

When we work closely with others, that closeness can be eroded by two factors: friction and entitlement. Friction is inevitable because people working together often differ over various things, small or big. An entitlement mentality seeps in when we start taking them for granted, believing that they are meant to do what they are doing for us.

Both these dangers can be minimized if we learn to regularly compliment those who regularly complement us. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (17.15) recommends that we discipline our speech so that it is not just truthful and beneficial, but also non-agitating and pleasing. Instead of catching others when they do wrong and criticizing them, we can catch them when they do right and appreciate them. By offering genuine compliments regularly, we can strengthen and sweeten our relationships. Thereafter, whenever any unpalatable truths need to be spoken, it won't cause too much hurt.

To exercise such verbal discipline in our relationships, we need inner calm and clarity. An accessible and reliable way of getting such stability is by connecting with the supremely stable reality, Krishna. We are his eternal parts – he is the whole; connecting with him complements us. And one time-honored way to connect with him is by complimenting him, by speaking his glories in our prayers to him and by sharing those glories with others.

When we compliment the divine who eternally complements us, we can more easily compliment all others who presently complement us.

Think it over

Why do we need others to complement us?

How can close relationships get eroded?

How can we train ourselves to compliment others?

17.15 Austerity of speech consists in speaking words that are truthful, pleasing, beneficial, and not agitating to others, and also in regularly reciting Vedic literature.

Opening the mouth without opening the mind helps neither the mouth nor the mind

We all have had to sometimes bite our words. On seeing or hearing something, we made a snap judgment and spoke words that we later realized were wrong, sometimes even grievously wrong.

Such missteps happen because we voice our opinions and judgments about others without considering where they are coming from. We act based on our preconceptions about how things are meant to be or about how people are.

How can we overcome our preconceptions? By learning to open our mind before we open our mouth. This indeed is the essence of the austerity of speech recommended in Bhagavad-gita (17.15); this verse urges us to speak beneficial truth non-agitatingly and pleasingly.

To speak thus, we need to open our mind before we open our mouth.

To open our mind means to see things from others' perspective, to try to put ourselves in their shoes, to give them a fair chance to tell their side of the story, to be ready to give them as much benefit of the doubt as we would want them to give us if situations were reversed.

Opening our mind needs effort, however. It requires that we come out of our conceptual comfort zones where things exist in convenient categories of black and white and confront discomfoting realities where things exist in multiple shades of grey.

Comparatively speaking, opening our mouth is much easier – we can pat ourselves on the back for having put people in their places in our pre-fabricated compartments of black and white. However, such attitudes and actions only keep us both mentally and verbally undisciplined.

If we become ready to strive to open our minds, we learn so much about people and things; we grow in wisdom and insight; and we speak words that persuade, not alienate.

Think it over

Why do we have to sometimes bite our words?

What does opening our mind mean?

Why is opening our mind tougher than opening our mouth?

17.15 Austerity of speech consists in speaking words that are truthful, pleasing, beneficial, and not agitating to others, and also in regularly reciting Vedic literature.

Our tongue is like a loaded gun that we carry with us always

Suppose we have a powerful, loaded gun. We would be extremely careful that it doesn't get fired accidentally.

Scarily, we all have a powerful, loaded gun with us, within us. That gun is our tongue – it is loaded with words. While words may not kill people physically, they can cause hurts worse than death. The Bhagavad-gita (01.34) states that dishonor can hurt worse than death. And dishonor is often inflicted upon people by targeting them with derisive, dreadful words. Just as sadists delight in shooting innocent people, demonic people delight in using harsh words (16.04).

Undoubtedly, both guns and words have constructive use. Just as a gun can drive away or down miscreants, so too can the tongue dissipate or eliminate misconceptions that people may have. But just as those authorized to use guns may cause unnecessary hurts, so too can those who speak authentic knowledge, including authentic spiritual knowledge. If police are not careful while shooting wrongdoers, they may shoot innocent bystanders. Similarly, when we act as spiritual guides for others, we may want to use our words to destroy their misconceptions. But if we are not careful, we may end up speaking words that destroy their tender enthusiasm to enquire about life's spiritual side. We need to carefully discipline our speech so that we don't just speak the truth, but also speak it appealingly (17.15).

If a well-meaning police officer shoots someone accidentally, that victim may end up permanently maimed. Similarly, if people in authority positions such as parents or, teachers speak harshly, even if unintentionally, they may cause lifelong psychological scars on their subordinates.

The tongue is indeed like a loaded gun – when this sobering truth registers within us, we become conscientious about our words.

Think it over

How is our tongue like a loaded gun?

How may we unintentionally wound those whom we want to guide?

Have you ever been shot by others' gun-like tongue? How can that experience strengthen your resolve to not let your tongue shoot

accidentally?

17.15 Austerity of speech consists in speaking words that are truthful, pleasing, beneficial, and not agitating to others, and also in regularly reciting Vedic literature.

Speak in a way that educates and engages, not enrages and estranges

Suppose we have some knowledge that will be helpful or valuable for others. When we speak to share it with them, we sometimes find that they don't do what we recommend or don't even like our giving them such guidance.

We may wonder, "How can we speak in a way that is more effective? How can we know when our speech is effective and when ineffective?" The effectiveness of our speech depends on not just the content of what we speak but also on its consequence — not just whether we speak the right thing, but whether our speech inspires others to do the right thing.

Guiding us toward effective speaking, the Bhagavad-gita (17.15) states that austerity of speech is to speak in a way that is non-agitating, truthful, pleasing, beneficial and scripturally-grounded.

Based on this Gita guideline, we can summarize the characteristics of effective speech as follows: it educates and engages, not enrages and estranges.

Educate, not enrage: When we speak something, what we say needs to make sense to people — and make not just intellectual sense but also emotional sense. Rather than telling them that they are wrong, which is likely to come off as judgmental and enrage them, we need to communicate in a way that gives them the vision to see for themselves the counterproductive consequences of their way of thinking and acting, so that they can make a healthier choice.

Engage, not estrange: Any course correction, especially one that involves a significant lifestyle change, requires commitment and can be challenging. If people feel that the right thing is too lofty to be practical, they will get estranged. They need help to engage with truth and experience for themselves the benefit of such engagement — and our speech needs to show them the doors to such engagement.

When we thus discipline our speech, the likelihood of it being effective increases manifold.

Think it over

What determines whether our speech is effective?

How can our speech educate, not enrage?

How can our speech engage, not estrange?

17.15 Austerity of speech consists in speaking words that are truthful, pleasing, beneficial, and not agitating to others, and also in regularly reciting Vedic literature.

Learn to let go of what you think you are speaking and to hear what others are hearing

While communicating with others, we are often surprised, even shocked by how they misunderstand us: “I spoke something so obvious; why are they outraged? What they heard is so drastically different from what I spoke – how did that happen?”

That happened because words have both denotations and connotations. Denotations refer to what words literally mean, whereas connotations refer to what words contextually signify. When we speak, we have in mind a certain combination of denotations and connotations. In contrast, when others hear, they have in mind another combination of denotations and connotations. No wonder what we thought we spoke differs from what they heard.

How can we ensure a better match between what we speak and what others hear? By taking responsibility for what others hear, not just for what we speak.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (17.15) urges us to speak the truth in a way that is not agitating to others. This means we can't merely speak the truth and not care if people don't get it; we need to detach ourselves from what we think we are speaking and train ourselves to hear what they are hearing. This, in fact, is the essence of sensitivity. A simple way to become more sensitive is to ask others what they heard us speak and to hear them out without interrupting or countering.

Of course, we can't change how others respond to what we say, but we can change for the better how they hear what we say. If people don't accept what we say, that is their problem; but if people don't hear what we say, that is our problem.

When we thus take the responsibility to become sensitive, our communication will become much more effective.

Think it over

Why does what we think we spoke differ from what others hear?

How can we become more sensitive?

During communication, what is our problem and what isn't?

17.15 Austerity of speech consists in speaking words that are truthful, pleasing, beneficial, and not agitating to others, and also in regularly reciting Vedic literature.

Speak not just correctly, but also appropriately

When a doctor prescribes a medicine to a patient, they consider not just the patient's malady, but also the patient's case history. Sometimes, if a patient has some allergy or some other complication from the past, then a medicine that is normally curative can be counterproductive for that patient.

Spiritual wisdom is often compared to medicine for us, souls who are currently deluded by various kinds of worldly illusions. When we start sharing wisdom with others, we take on the role of spiritual doctors; we are meant to provide the wisdom-nuggets that can help our audience heal.

While prescribing thus, we need to take the responsibility to know the particular sensitivities of our audience so that they don't get unnecessarily alienated by peripheral points that make them unreceptive to core wisdom. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (17.15) recommends that we practice austerity of speech which begins with speaking in a way that doesn't agitate people's minds.

Does this mean we should never speak the truth if it is unpalatable? Not at all. Sometimes unpalatable truths need to be spoken, just as sometimes bitter medicines need to be administered. But just as everything bitter is not medicine, so too every unpalatable word is not the truth; we needn't presume that speaking in a way that agitates is evidence that we are good spiritual teachers.

Before administering bitter medicines, doctors need to gently explain to patients the necessity of that medicine. Similarly, before speaking unpalatable words, we need to speak appropriately to create in our audience the necessary foundation of trust and intellectual conviction.

When communicating with others, we need to consider not just the correctness of our speech, but also its appropriateness: is what we are about to speak the appropriate thing to inspire them spiritually. By such sensitivity, our words will become much more effective in bringing about the desired transformation.

Think it over

When we share spiritual wisdom, what responsibility do we need to accept?

Before speaking unpalatable words, what do we need to do first?

How can we make our speech more effective?

17.15 Austerity of speech consists in speaking words that are truthful, pleasing, beneficial, and not agitating to others, and also in regularly reciting Vedic literature.

We don't owe our friends a positive response, but we do owe them a sensitive response

Suppose we try something creative for the first time and are unsure about the quality of the product: "Is it good? Is it great? Is it passable? Is it terrible?"

When we seek feedback from our friends, especially those friends who know something about that creative field, we wouldn't want them to flatter or pamper us; we would want to genuinely know where we stand. Yet we all have finite capacities to stomach criticism, especially criticism of our 'babies', which is how creators often feel about their creations. If we get severe criticism, we might become so disheartened or even devastated as to never try that thing again, or maybe even never try anything creative again. That would be tragic, especially if we had talents that just needed honing, talents that went unexpressed with us to our graves because of one harsh criticism.

What applies to us also applies to our friends. Suppose they try something creative and seek our feedback. Just because we are their friends doesn't mean we owe them a positive response always; we may want to help them stay grounded. Simultaneously however, we don't want them to be buried alive; we don't want to permanently extinguish their creative spark. That's why we do owe them a sensitive response. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (17.15) urges us to discipline our speech by learning to speak non-agitatingly, truthfully, pleasingly, beneficially.

The same balance of accuracy and sensitivity is necessary when we share spiritual wisdom with others. If they have some misconceptions, we may need to educate them. But we need to be sensitive, all the more so if they are emotionally invested in their present conceptions.

When we thus learn to temper truth with sensitivity, our speech will become much more effective.

Think it over

What is wrong with feedback that is only positive?

What is wrong with feedback that is only critical?

For the next three days, notice whenever you speak negatively about anyone. Consider how you can be more sensitive.

17.15 Austerity of speech consists in speaking words that are truthful, pleasing, beneficial, and not agitating to others, and also in regularly reciting Vedic literature.

Appreciating others' achievement fosters extrinsic self-worth, appreciating their commitment fosters intrinsic self-worth

Suppose we are guiding someone, as when we are parents guiding our children. Guiding involves both correcting and appreciating: correcting them when they do something wrong, and appreciating them when they do something right.

Appreciating others is undoubtedly important, but what we appreciate about them is even more important. Suppose we appreciate them when they achieve something significant. That's good, but if that's the only time we appreciate them, they may start thinking that our love for them is conditional to their achieving something significant. Such thinking may make them base their self-worth on extrinsic things such as achievements: "Only if I achieve will I be appreciated, valued, loved." Such extrinsic self-worth can set them up for insecurity, inferiority complex and other mental health problems.

How can we foster intrinsic self-worth in them? By stressing that their existence has innate value, for we all are precious parts of the Divine (Bhagavad-gita 15.07). And by appreciating them for the things that are in their control such as their commitment, not for the things beyond their control such as achievement.

The Gita (18.14) stresses that the results of our actions depend on many factors; our endeavor is just one of them. When the remaining factors are favorable, our endeavor bears visible fruit – our commitment translates into achievement. When the remaining factors aren't favorable, results may not manifest, despite our best efforts. All we can do is stay committed till those factors become favorable.

What will keep us going when results aren't forthcoming? The understanding that our endeavors matter: that our endeavors always contribute to shaping a better future for us, even if that shaping isn't presently visible. That understanding is the essence of intrinsic self-worth. And intrinsic self-worth is fostered primarily when we are appreciated for our commitment, not just for our achievement.

Think it over

What fosters extrinsic self-worth?

Do you regularly appreciate others?

What do you normally appreciate them for? How can you appreciate them more for their commitment?

18.14 The place of action [the body], the performer, the various senses, the many different kinds of endeavor, and ultimately the Supersoul – these are the five factors of action.

The essence of education is enlightenment, engagement, and encouragement

If we wish to educate others about something – especially something that requires moral strength, discipline, and diligence – we need to provide them three broad things: enlightenment, engagement and encouragement.

Enlightenment: Enlightenment means showing others the way, providing them the vision to see which choices lead to which consequences. Instead of just prescribing certain things and proscribing other things, education provides them a holistic worldview for informed decision-making, thereby giving them the intellectual conviction to make the right choice. For example, to teach others sensual restraint, we need to logically explain why such restraint is beneficial, not hand it down as a diktat.

Engagement: Engagement essentially means providing people practical tools or methods to tread the way they have chosen. If they aren't provided such practical aids, they won't be able to persevere. For example, to teach someone to exercise daily, we may need to provide the appropriate exercise equipment and connect them with a group of regular exercisers in their age group.

Encouragement: Whenever anyone does anything new, they often face moments of doubt and discouragement. We need to provide them the confidence that they can succeed. Even if they err and need to be corrected, we can focus not on their mistake but on their potential. With that positive focus, we can inspire them to follow the process that unleashes their potential.

Significantly, Krishna integrates all these three when teaching the Bhagavad-gita to Arjuna. The whole book enlightens him about dharma, the right course of action, by analyzing which actions lead to which consequences. To help him engage in dharma, the Gita outlines various paths that aid him to live according to the principles of dharma. And the Gita concludes by encouraging Arjuna, assuring him that Krishna loves him determinedly (18.64) and will protect him from all consequences if he surrenders (18.66).

No wonder the Gita's education is so dramatically successful: it makes a despondent Arjuna determined (18.73).

Think it over

Why does education need to be enlightening?

How can education provide engagement?

Why does education need to be encouraging?

18.66 Abandon all varieties of religion and just surrender unto Me. I shall deliver you from all sinful reactions. Do not fear.

Before a prescription can inspire action, the diagnosis must inspire conviction

When we are in a position of guiding others, we sometimes find that people don't listen to us. If our inputs are repeatedly neglected or rejected, we may naturally get exasperated, irritated, infuriated: "Why don't they listen to me?"

To understand why, here's an example. Suppose we go to a doctor, who gives us a prescription hastily without duly hearing our symptoms. If we aren't convinced about that doctor's diagnosis, we will naturally be reluctant to take their prescription.

We often unwittingly take on the position of that hasty doctor. When others do something wrong, we may clearly see why and how it needs to be fixed. But they may not even recognize that they are doing anything wrong, leave alone accept that what we are recommending is the way to fix it. We need to first explain our perspective intelligibly and persuasively. Then our prescription is likely to be taken more seriously.

In the Bhagavad-gita, Krishna shows by example how to inspire conviction before seeking action. Though he is God himself, he doesn't draw on his divine position to impose his will on Arjuna. Instead, he speaks the Gita which is essentially a carefully reasoned thread of thought that enables Arjuna to see clearly the consequences of the choices before him. Throughout the Gita, Krishna patiently and persuasively answers Arjuna's various questions. And he concludes the Gita by checking whether his message has been heard and understood (18.72). The implication of Krishna's question, Gita commentators explain, is that he is ready to repeat his message, partly or even wholly, if it is not clear. Arjuna, being convinced by Krishna's message, naturally agrees to do Krishna's will (18.73).

Learning from Krishna's example, we too can precede prescription with persuasion, thereby increasing the chances of inspiring transformation in others.

Think it over

When people don't listen to us, what may be the reason?

How does Krishna inspire conviction before seeking action?

In your interactions with others, what can you do to precede prescription with persuasion?

18.72 O son of Prutha, O conqueror of wealth, have you heard this with an attentive mind? And are your ignorance and illusions now dispelled?

Nonjudgmental Attitude

An impurity censor makes no sense to those who don't have even an impurity sensor

An impurity censor refers to some regulator that filters out impure content. And an impurity sensor refers to some identifying mechanism that detects impure content whenever it appears.

Our society needs an impurity sensor because the culture today presents us with so much impure content, especially visual stimuli such as obscene imagery and verbal stimuli such as obscene language.

Our inner world is where our purity can manifest and empower us to rise toward manifesting our fullest potential. The soul is effulgent with purity and virtue, being a part of the supremely effulgent divine being, Krishna. However, it is presently covered by impurities that prevent the manifesting of that virtue. Worse still, these impurities bring out the worst within us, making us do things that hurt us and hurt others.

Being corrupted by such impurities, some people lack any impurity sensor: any inner sense to perceive whether something is pure or impure. Such people process all outer stimuli based on only one criterion: is it enjoyable? If yes, they want more and more of it, no matter how impure it may be. If some impurity censor regulates their access to such content, they just can't make sense of it, "Why are enjoyable things being kept away from me?"

The Bhagavad-gita (02.69) highlights this radical difference in values between materialists and spiritualists. If society imposes impurity censors, materialists who lack an impurity sensor oppose it fiercely. To change their attitude, simply condemning them as degraded is unhelpful; it may even be alienating. They need to be provided with philosophical education that explains the nature and consequences of impurity.

What if they reject such education? That's unfortunate. Still, not everyone will reject; some may be receptive. And the best chance to communicate the need for an impurity censor begins with providing education that equips individuals with an impurity sensor.

Think it over

Why does society need an impurity censor?

Why do some people lack an impurity sensor?

How can the need for an impurity sensor be communicated to materialists?

02.69 What is night for all beings is the time of awakening for the self-controlled; and the time of awakening for all beings is night for the introspective sage.

Don't try to be someone better; try to be an example of something better

When we strive to lead a principle-centered life by adopting spiritual practices, we start becoming more disciplined and self-controlled. As we become more virtuous than others, we may start becoming proud. Soon, we may focus more on feeding that pride, than seeking inner growth. And as we increasingly delight in pride, we will proportionately alienate others.

How can we avoid such pitfalls?

By shifting our focus from ourselves to the process that has transformed us.

Suppose we were sick because of an epidemic but had finally found a medicine that worked. We would be relieved, even delighted. And we would naturally want to discuss and demonstrate our improved health to others who were still sick – not to parade how we are healthier than them, but to inspire them to take the medicine.

Similarly, we are all spiritually sick: we are eternal beings who are presently attached to temporary things. How can we heal ourselves? By following the time-honored family of paths, known as dharma. The Bhagavad-gita (03.21) urges Arjuna to follow dharma, thereby setting the right example for others. Dharma culminates in bhakti, the path of spiritual love for the divine (18.66).

When we practice bhakti-yoga with proper philosophical understanding of our purpose, we stay conscious that our purity doesn't prove our greatness; it proves the greatness of bhakti in purifying even someone as fallen as us. Additionally, when people see that someone's greatness is not just because of that person, but also because of the process that person is following, they feel inspired to follow that process.

If we adopt this attitude of exemplifying something better – not being someone better – we can manifest greatness without losing humbleness. And instead of impressing others with our virtues, we will inspire them to manifest their virtues too.

Think it over

How can we shift our focus from ourselves to the process transforming us?

What are the fruits of adopting the attitude of exemplifying something better?

While interacting with others, how can you focus on inspiring them, not impressing them?

03.21 Whatever action a great man performs, common men follow. And whatever standards he sets by exemplary acts, all the world pursues.

Know when to give others space and when to give them pace

If someone intrudes into our personal physical space by coming too close to us, we feel uncomfortable. We similarly feel uncomfortable when someone intrudes into our personal psychological space by mandating what we should do or shouldn't do, how we should or shouldn't feel and so forth. In such cases, we may say, "Give me some space."

Whenever we guide anyone, we need to be mindful if they feel that we are intruding into their psychological space. We might have the best of intentions, wanting to protect them from bad choices. But if they feel suffocated by our guidance, they may just go away from us and then make those bad choices. Thus, our guidance will fail doubly: it won't prevent their bad choices and it won't protect our relationship with them. That's why we need to learn when to give people space.

While giving others space, we need to avoid the other extreme of never giving others pace, that is, never pushing them to overcome their inertia to do the things that are good for them. If not pushed, they may never realize their potential. They can be pushed by an encouraging pat, a raised eyebrow, a motivational talk, a chastising word.

The Bhagavad-gita (03.26) harmonizes the two imperatives: it urges us to not disturb people's minds, indicating the need to give them space; but it also urges us to engage them appropriately for their gradual elevation, indicating the need to give them pace. Thus, by carefully observing the effect of our action or inaction on others, we can discern when to give others space and when to give them pace.

Think it over

How can not giving people space be a problem?

How can not giving people pace be a problem?

How can we know when to give others space or pace?

03.26 So as not to disrupt the minds of ignorant men attached to the fruitive results of prescribed duties, a learned person should not induce them to stop

work. Rather, by working in the spirit of devotion, he should engage them in all sorts of activities [for the gradual development of Krishna consciousness].

Make judgments, but don't be judgmental

When doing anything responsible, we need to make judgments: we need to evaluate who is suitable for doing what and who isn't. If someone tends to overeat, our making them in-charge of food at a get-together would be an error of judgment. By learning to make sound judgments, we can get things done effectively.

However, while making judgments, we can easily cross the line from evaluating to labeling, thereby becoming judgmental. When we become judgmental, we affix permanent labels on people based on their limitations and even reduce them to those labels, say, gluttons. Even if we try to be externally polite, we give off negative vibes that alienate them. Worse still, becoming judgmental can infect us with a constant critical mentality that may impair all our interactions and relationships.

How can we avoid becoming judgmental? By learning to see and focus on the good in others. Gita wisdom aids such a shift of vision by stressing that everyone is essentially a pure soul, a part of the all-pure Supreme, Krishna. Their limitations are due to the impurities temporarily occupying their mind and body.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (03.26) urges us to not disturb the minds of those who are ignorant and attached, but to instead engage them expertly for their gradual spiritual growth. This verse conveys the need to make judgments: we need to discern if someone is lacking in knowledge or detachment. Simultaneously, it doesn't recommend becoming judgmental: rather than labeling them as ignorant or attached, we can evaluate how they can grow from where they are. Then, we can direct them along that way – sensitively, intelligently, encouragingly.

When we thus learn to make judgments without becoming judgmental, we can help others bring out their higher side and manifest their spiritual potential.

Think it over

How is making judgments helpful?

How is becoming judgmental harmful?

How does Gita wisdom help us to make judgments without becoming judgmental?

03.26 So as not to disrupt the minds of ignorant men attached to the fruitive results of prescribed duties, a learned person should not induce them to stop work. Rather, by working in the spirit of devotion, he should engage them in all sorts of activities [for the gradual development of Krishna consciousness].

See the addicted not as demented or degraded, but as tormented

Suppose someone becomes addicted to drinking. Despite being urged to give up drinking and despite even promising to give up, they keep drinking. We may view such drunkards as demented or degraded.

Demented: We may think, “For the momentary pleasure of a drink, who will risk losing their reputation, relationships, wealth, health, even their life itself? Only someone insane.”

Degraded: We may think, “For such fleeting pleasure, who will trample over their sacred values and hurt grievously those who love them? Only someone degraded.”

However, such assessments of the addicted are usually unhelpful. Why? Because when we affix such labels on people, we start looking down at them. And our condescending attitude makes them unreceptive to whatever help we might offer them for overcoming their addiction.

Additionally, these assessments are inaccurate. Why? Because despite their demented or degraded behavior, their inner reality is that they are tormented by desires that goad them toward indulgence.

If someone started goading us externally, we would try to push them away or run away from them. But we can do neither when we are goaded internally; we can only helplessly bear the pain till it becomes unbearable. Finally, desperate for some relief, however short-lived, we succumb.

Voicing this universal human predicament, the Bhagavad-gita (03.36) raises the question: what impels us to wrongdoing, as if by force, against our will? That inner tormentor is the self-destructive force of lust (03.37).

How can we protect ourselves from this inner tormentor? Through spiritual knowledge and practice, which act as both our inner armor and inner elevator. Initially, they shield us from lust’s goads and eventually, they raise us beyond lust’s reach.

When we learn to see the addicted as tormented – not as demented or degraded – we can empathically equip them with spiritual resources for freeing themselves.

Think it over

Why is seeing the addicted as demented or degraded unhelpful?

Why do the addicted relapse, despite knowing that they shouldn't?

How does the Gita equip us against our inner tormentor?

03.36 Arjuna said: O descendant of Vrishni, by what is one impelled to sinful acts, even unwillingly,

as if engaged by force?

Spiritual vision sees people not as philosophical categories, but as conscious beings

When we gain spiritual knowledge, our zeal to share it with others may blind us to basic human courtesies. While interacting with people, we may start reducing them to philosophical categories: “This person is an impersonalist; this person is a materialist; this person is an atheist.”

What’s wrong with such reduction? For most people, their philosophy is not their defining identity. They may have heard some philosophical ideas somewhere and uncritically adopted those ideas. When we reduce people to philosophical categories, we start treating them impersonally and judgmentally. And such cold treatment alienates them, hurting their spiritual prospects far more than their philosophical misconceptions.

What if someone has made their misconceived philosophy their defining identity? Still, they are human beings like us; we all share universal human dreams, fears and troubles. Seen from a spiritual perspective, they still remain souls, conscious beings, parts of the divine.

Such an empathic vision characterizes the spiritually elevated. The Bhagavad-gita (06.32) declares that the topmost spiritualists see the equality of all living beings in both their happiness and their distress.

We all want people to treat us respectfully, as conscious beings who will make good choices if we are helped to see how that choice is good. Just as we feel angered and alienated if someone treats us contemptuously, so too do others. Just as we feel more open to hear others if they are courteous, so too do others.

That’s why we need to focus on establishing a human connection with people, not on slotting them within a philosophical categorization. By such empathy, we will sense how spiritual knowledge can be applied in a way that is intelligible and practical for them. And we will discover or devise creative and effective ways of helping them forward on their spiritual evolution.

Think it over

While interacting with people who don't share our faith, how might we misapply spiritual knowledge?

How can we treat people as conscious beings?

Do you treat anyone as a philosophical category? How can you start treating them as a conscious being?

06.32 He is a perfect yogi who, by comparison to his own self, sees the true equality of all beings, in both their happiness and their distress, O Arjuna!

We may have to fight against others, but we don't have to be against others

When we strive to lead a principle-centered life, those who feel that their interests are threatened by our principles will oppose us. If they attack us repeatedly, we may have to fight against them. But we don't have to treat them as our enemies intrinsically.

Such distance between disposition and action becomes easier to maintain when we have spiritual knowledge. Gita wisdom explains that we are all souls, parts of the all-pure supreme. In our essence, we are all pure, though presently we all are covered by different degrees of impurities. Some people, because of being excessively covered by impurities, may be so inimical and destructive as to need to be curbed forcibly. Such antisocial elements need to be curbed by those who are trying to live purely, especially if they are the martial guardians of society.

That was the responsibility of the Pandavas when they had to fight against the Kauravas, who had remorselessly committed many atrocities, with ever-increasing arrogance and malevolence. Consequently, the Kauravas had to be neutralized by force as a reaction to their grievous misdeeds. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita urges Arjuna to become an instrument in the fight to fulfill the higher arrangement of punishing the Kauravas (11.33). Yet the Gita also cautions Arjuna to not be inimical to anyone if he wants to evolve in his consciousness and attain the divine (11.55). Thus the Gita stresses the need to retain this distance between action and disposition.

By doing the necessary in action according to our social responsibility, but not swerving in our disposition from being spiritually purposeful, we can both contribute to establishing order externally and cultivate spiritual consciousness internally.

Think it over

How can spiritual knowledge help us see antisocial elements holistically?

How can we maintain a distance between aggressive actions and spiritual intentions?

How can we harmonize our social and spiritual roles?

11.55 My dear Arjuna, he who engages in My pure devotional service, free from the contaminations of fruitive activities and mental speculation, he who works for Me, who makes Me the supreme goal of his life, and who is friendly to every living being – he certainly comes to Me.

Don't reduce people to their group identity – differences within groups often exceed differences across groups

We often have certain preconceptions about certain groups of people. Driven by such preconceptions, when we come to know a person's group identity, we presume we know everything worth knowing about them. For example, if we label people belonging to a particular religion as fanatical, we reduce everyone from that religion to that label.

However, people's behavior is determined not so much by their group identity as by their own individual level of consciousness. Gita wisdom explains that everyone is an individual soul with free will. The group in which they were born and brought up certainly shapes their behavior, but so do their conditionings from previous lives.

Phrased in terms of the Gita's analysis of the three modes of material nature, how we use our free will is affected by the modes infecting us. These modes are constantly competing with each other (Bhagavad-gita 14.10). Such a tussle between the modes happens not just within individuals but also within groups. Every group has some people in each of the modes. And those people, despite being in the same group, will differ significantly from each other based on their modes.

Even within a religion commonly considered fanatical, many individuals will be moderates, being in the mode of goodness. Moderates from different religions may concur on how to calmly address their differences. In contrast, extremists from the same tradition may attack or even assassinate each other over differences that they deem heretical. People's behavior is shaped much more by their modes than by their group identity.

By learning to treat people as autonomous souls, we can check prejudices and foster mutual understanding.

Think it over

How do moderates and extremists deal with differences differently?

What are the advantages of treating everyone as an autonomous soul?

Has interacting with specific individuals from a group led you to revise your preconceptions about that group?

14.10 Sometimes the mode of goodness becomes prominent, defeating the modes of passion and ignorance, O son of Bharata. Sometimes the mode of passion defeats goodness and ignorance, and at other times ignorance defeats goodness and passion. In this way there is always competition for supremacy.

The desire that the dark be darker defines a dark mind

Suppose we know that someone is short-tempered. Suppose further we hear through the grapevine that they have assaulted someone. If we presume the rumor to be true or desire that it be true, that tendency points to our own ungodliness, independent of their ungodliness.

We all have our weaknesses. When we tend to believe the worst about others, without confirming the facts, that tendency reflects our own critical mentality. Such a mentality characterizes a dark mind. In contrast, the godly are characterized by an aversion to faultfinding (Bhagavad-gita 16.02). They prefer to give people the benefit of the doubt. The godly consider people innocent unless proven guilty, whereas the ungodly consider people guilty unless proven innocent.

When our mind is dark, we alienate others by our suspiciousness and judgmentality. And we dim our own spirituality. Why? Because spiritual consciousness means that first, we see everyone as potentially divine, being eternal parts of Krishna (15.07); and second, we try to equip and encourage others to manifest their good side.

Of course, we can't be naïve believing that people are good when the evidence screams otherwise. To stay between the extremes of being naïve and being cynical, we need to cultivate a service attitude towards Krishna and others in relationship with Krishna.

With such a spiritually-grounded positive attitude, we see the good in others and encourage them to develop it more. And when we do need to address their faults, we do so in a gentle, non-judgmental way that is most likely to kindle a positive change.

Indeed, the desire that the bright be brighter defines a bright mind, a mind lit with Krishna's grace that uplifts us and uplifts others through us.

Think it over

How do the godly and the ungodly differ in their attitude toward others?

How can a service attitude improve our vision of others?

Do you tend to think the worst about someone? What can you do to see them spiritually and positively?

16.02 Nonviolence; truthfulness; freedom from anger; renunciation; tranquillity; aversion to faultfinding; compassion for all living entities; freedom from covetousness; gentleness; modesty; steady determination; ... [– these transcendental qualities, O son of Bharata, belong to godly men endowed with divine nature.]

The Power of Letting Go

Attachment is the inability to say no, whatever the cost

Suppose we are buying something. Usually, we would compare its cost with its value: is what I have to pay commensurate with what I will get from it? If the cost is far more than the value, then we will negotiate to get a more reasonable price or may refuse to buy. However, when we are attached to something, we buy it, whatever the cost.

What applies to negotiating for commodities also applies to negotiating with people. If someone wants us to do something, we usually consider the cost of their desire: what all we will have to do, in terms of time, money and effort. And we compare that cost with the value: how important that person is for us.

However, when we are attached to someone, we don't consider the cost – we have to please them, or at the very least, we can't see them displeased. An oft-overlooked cost in relationships is the moral cost: how much our moral principles will be compromised to do their bidding. If we are attached to them, we may end up doing horrifying things for their sake.

Such inability to say no, whatever the cost, caused the huge fratricidal war before which the Bhagavad-gita was spoken. Dhritarashtra, the acting king of the Kuru dynasty, was so attached to his wicked son, Duryodhana, that he couldn't say no to Duryodhana, even when Duryodhana attempted to defraud, dishonor and destroy his cousins, the Pandavas. In the Gita's first verse (01.01), Dhritarashtra's attachment comes out in his referring to his sons as his own people, thereby treating his nephews as his enemies.

The Gita's setting graphically demonstrates how the inability to say no can have catastrophic consequences. And the Gita's substance – its message of spiritual strength – empowers us to say no when necessary.

Think it over

How does attachment disturb the balance between cost and value?

When we are attached to someone, what cost do we often overlook?

What do the Gita's setting and substance tell us about attachments?

01.01 Dhritarashtra said: O Sanjaya, after my sons and the sons of Pandu assembled in the place of pilgrimage at Kurukshetra, desiring to fight, what did they do?

Detachment is the absence of emotional dependence, not the absence of emotion

Some people fear, “If I become detached, will I become emotionless, uncaring, stone-hearted?”

No, detachment empowers us to care truly for others, for it frees us from emotional dependence on them. When we are emotionally dependent on someone, we make decisions based on considerations of their pleasure alone without considering any higher principles or purposes. Being driven by such narrow considerations, we often act against their best interests and even our best interests.

In general, if getting others’ approval becomes the sole determiner of our actions, we can’t act assertively even when it’s necessary. For example, if a physician hesitates to give an injection to a child just because the child starts screaming at them, they will fail in their duty. Multiply this scenario a million times over in gravity and we get a sense of Dhritarashtra’s dereliction of duty because of his excessive attachment to his son, Duryodhana. Because he was so emotionally dependent on Duryodhana, Dhritarashtra could never strongly put his foot down, even when Duryodhana wanted to do reprehensible things to the extent of killing his cousins or even disrobing their wife in public.

Dhritarashtra’s attachment comes out in the Bhagavad-gita’s first verse (01.01) wherein he sees only Duryodhana’s party as his party, and he treats as enemies his nephews, even though they revered him like a father figure and even though he was meant to act as a surrogate father after the untimely demise of their father. If he had been even slightly detached from Duryodhana, he could have acted assertively to give the Pandavas their due, to protect Duryodhana from a painful death and to protect the world from the catastrophic Kurukshetra war.

Dhritarashtra's example illustrates that attachment weakens, whereas detachment empowers. When we cultivate detachment, we become empowered to have emotions without having emotions subvert our principle-centered life.

Think it over

How does detachment enable us to care truly for others? Explain with example.

How did emotional dependence disempower Dhritarashtra?

How can detachment empower us?

01.01 Dhritarashtra said: O Sanjaya, after my sons and the sons of Pandu assembled in the place of pilgrimage at Kurukshetra, desiring to fight, what did they do?

When we are attached to someone, we don't care much for them;
we care much more for what they think about us

Suppose a doctor needs to give an injection to a sick child. But the child starts crying and complaining about the doctor: "You are so cruel; instead of helping me, you are hurting me." If the doctor cares too much about the child's crying and doesn't give the injection, the child will end up crying much more in the future.

We often behave like that doctor when we are attached to someone. Though we think we care a lot about them, actually, what we care about most is that they shouldn't think bad about us. Of course, it's natural that we don't want to be thought about negatively by anyone, what to speak of by those close to us. But we also need to consider their welfare; if their long-term good requires us to do something that temporarily displeases them, then the readiness to do that is the test of our love. And attachment looks like love but makes us fail in the vital test of love: to care for the future of our loved ones, not just their present feelings. Such was Dhritarashtra's failing in his relationship with his son, Duryodhana.

Dhritarashtra's attachment is evident in the Bhagavad-gita's first verse (01.01), wherein he sides with his sons and labels his nephews as others. Even though Duryodhana did horrendous wrongs, Dhritarashtra never censured or checked him. Dhritarashtra's passivity fueled Duryodhana's animosity, ultimately triggering the catastrophic Kurukshetra war that resulted in Duryodhana's death. Thus, by caring too much about staying in his son's good books, Dhritarashtra ended up losing his son. And he placed his son's name as well as his own name among the bad guys in history's books.

When we care for both others' feelings and their future, then that balanced caring comprises genuine love.

Think it over

What is the vital test of love?

How did Dhritarashtra's attachment to Duryodhana hurt both of them?

In your relationships, what can you do to rise from attachment to love?

01.01 Dhritarashtra said: O Sanjaya, after my sons and the sons of Pandu assembled in the place of pilgrimage at Kurukshetra, desiring to fight, what did they do?

Tolerance empowers us when we focus on our purposefulness, not on our powerlessness

Some people feel that tolerating makes them powerless: “If things are going wrong and I just tolerate them without doing anything about them, am I not passively giving in to the situation?”

Not necessarily. When we tolerate a situation, our purpose is not to give in to that situation, but to take on some other situations.

Suppose we are studying in a crowded, noisy, messy environment. If that is the only place we have to study, we may decide that we just need to tolerate. However, while tolerating, if we keep dwelling on how powerless we are and keep lamenting about our situation, then we aren’t helping ourselves. Instead, if we use our tolerance to dwell on our purpose of studying and on how important and interesting our studies are, then that focus will make our studies increasingly absorbing, fulfilling and fruitful. Eventually, our studies will empower us to create a better life for ourselves and for our loved ones.

Thus, even if we initially started tolerating because of our powerlessness, we need to eventually tolerate based on our purposefulness. Only when we focus on our purpose will we discover the empowering effects of tolerating. Indeed, people who achieve anything worthwhile choose their battles by tolerating; they focus on fixing some things while living with other things.

Significantly, it’s instructive to see how the Bhagavad-gita (02.14) frames its call for tolerance by revealing a higher identity initially (02.13) and then revealing a higher purpose (02.15). First, it stresses that our core is spiritual, beyond all material changes (02.13). Then, it highlights the fruit of tolerating: spiritual realization, that is, realizing our indestructible identity and raising our consciousness to relish inexhaustible joy (02.15).

Thus, when we let our tolerance be guided by higher knowledge and purpose, tolerance becomes empowering, extraordinarily empowering.

Think it over

How may tolerance disempower?

How can purposefulness empower us amid disagreeable situations?

How does the Gita frame its call for tolerance? How does such framing affect the result of tolerating?

02.15 O best among men [Arjuna], the person who is not disturbed by happiness and distress and is steady in both is certainly eligible for liberation.

The mind makes us fight wars that aren't winnable and wars where victory is not even definable

During our life-journey, we often have to fight against various adversities and adversaries. Among these fights, the fight we focus on is frequently determined by our mind, which can be our worst enemy (Bhagavad-gita 06.06). How does the mind act inimically? By misdirecting our fighting in two broad ways:

Fighting wars that are unwinnable: The mind often makes us resent all the wrongs that have happened to us. But many of these wrongs can't be changed. When we keep resenting the unchangeable, we are essentially fighting unwinnable wars.

Fighting wars where victory is not even definable: The mind often gets us fighting hot and cold wars against our loved ones. Suppose they have done something that upsets us. The mind impels us to lash out against them for all their wrongdoings, present and past, actual and imagined, intentional and unintentional. The mind even impels us to attack them behind their backs. Even if we succeed in proving that they are wrong, it is we who will have to live with a humiliated partner. They will be miserable, and their misery will inevitably make us miserable. Where is the victory in that?

Does the preceding analysis mean that we never try to change anything? Some situations certainly need to be changed, as do some people's some opinions. But deciding what to change and how to go about changing it requires prudence, which the mind sorely lacks.

To be prudent, we need to focus on the most important war: the war to stay connected with our indwelling Lord, Krishna, in a mood of loving service. By that devotional disposition, we become receptive to his guidance from within (10.10). Being thus guided, we can carefully choose to fight those battles that make things better, not worse.

Think it over

Are you fighting any unwinnable war?

Are you fighting any war where victory is not even definable?

Which war is the most important? What can you do to focus on it?

06.06 For him who has conquered the mind, the mind is the best of friends; but for one who has failed to do so, his mind will remain the greatest enemy.

If we are grateful when ability manifests through us, we can be graceful when it doesn't

Amid life's challenges, we all look for some ability that enables us to stand apart. On finding such an ability, we may become proud, delighting in the superiority over others that it bestows us.

However, ability can be frustratingly elusive. Even the best authors may run into a writers' block. Even the best sports players may go out of form. When our defining abilities desert us, we may feel distressed, devastated, even suicidal.

How can we prevent such negative reactions? By reconceptualizing our abilities. The Bhagavad-gita (07.08) states that our abilities are not exactly ours; they are gifts of the divine manifesting through us. Because they don't belong exclusively to us, they won't always be available at our command.

If our defining abilities are so unstable, how can we stay stable? By acquiring a spiritual vision of our identity and purpose.

Gita wisdom explains that we are souls who are on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution. To evolve, we need to devotionally connect with the all-attractive ultimate reality, Krishna. On the foundation of that connection, we can make the optimal material contribution by using our entire being, including our abilities, in a mood of service to Krishna.

With this understanding, we can be grateful to Krishna when the abilities he has gifted us manifest through us. And when they don't, we can accept gracefully, knowing that he can use us as he chooses and use others when he chooses. In all situations, we remain his eternal parts meant to serve him. And our loving connection with him through service remains our ever-present solace and strength.

When we thus base our identity on our spirituality, then we can always have stability independent of ability.

Think it over

Why is becoming proud of our abilities problematic?

How does the Gita help us reconceptualize our abilities?

How can we be stable amid the instability of our abilities?

07.08 O son of Kunti, I am the taste of water, the light of the sun and the moon, the syllable om in the Vedic mantras; I am the sound in ether and ability in man.

Solutions that try to satisfy everyone usually sway no one and solve nothing

Whenever we face problems, different people suggest different solutions. Because everyone is irreducibly individual, people often have irreducibly different opinions. While deciding which solution to adopt, we may fall prey to a common human weakness: wanting to satisfy everyone.

However, life often gives us limited options, wherein we just can't satisfy everyone. If we somehow come up with a compromised solution to satisfy everyone, we will probably find it too impotent to actually solve the problem. And when the solution fails, the same people whom we had struggled so much to satisfy will say, "I had already told you: this won't work."

What, then, can we do? To stand up. If we are strongly convinced, using our God-given intelligence and experience, that a particular solution is the best, we may need to stand apart from those who differ. Of course, before finalizing, we can give their suggestion due consideration and while finalizing, we needn't insensitively diss them. But sensitivity isn't sentimentality; when necessary, we need to unsentimentally stick to our choice.

The courage to stand apart is needed when facing not just life's many specific problems, but also life itself. Life is inherently problematic being marred by mortality and misery (Bhagavad-gita 13.09). Gita wisdom recommends the spiritualization of human consciousness as the ultimate solution for both life's problems and life itself. When we evolve spiritually, we can deal with problems better: either by resolving sustainably or tolerating gracefully.

When we choose to become spiritual, many non-spiritual people may be upset; we will need to distance ourselves from them and their mundane interests (Bhagavad-gita 13.11). In due course, when our spirituality keeps us internally strong amid life's challenges and helps us tackle complex situations effectively, non-spiritualists may be won over.

Essentially, we can't be populists if we want to be spiritualists.

Think it over

Why does trying to satisfy everyone backfire?

While adopting spiritual solutions, why do we need to stand apart?

How may we win over non-spiritualists?

13.11 ... Constant and unalloyed devotion to Me; aspiring to live in a solitary place; detachment from the general mass of people; ... [– all these I declare to be knowledge].

Value those who value you and don't overvalue those who devalue you

Suppose we are giving a talk. If the audience is responsive and appreciative, we feel enthused to speak. But if the audience starts frowning and glaring, we become guarded, even feel choked or disheartened.

What applies to public speaking applies to all areas of life. We are social creatures. Whenever we do anything, we watch how people react to our actions. Accordingly, we moderate and modify our actions. Such social feedback can be constructive if it is given by people who share our values and desire to help us. But it becomes destructive when it is given by people who don't share our values and are viscerally opposed to us.

Suppose we are to give an important talk wherein we plan to take principled positions that will be unpopular among some hearers. To deliver that talk effectively, we need to focus on those hearers who are supportive or at least receptive, not on those who have judged and condemned us even without hearing us.

Whatever we do in life, some people will devalue us and some will value us. Unfortunately, we often overvalue those who devalue us; we crave and slave for getting one word of appreciation from them, and we despair because we never get it. In that obsession, we take for granted those who value us. If only we had reciprocated appropriately with them, the result would have been meaningful interactions, even deep connections, with them.

The Bhagavad-gita (13.11) urges spiritual seekers to stay detached from people in general, knowing that such people, being materialistic, will not value their spirituality. Instead, serious seekers delight in associating with like-minded seekers and seers (10.09).

When we thus value those who value us and don't overvalue those who devalue us, our social interactions become energizing, not exhausting.

Think it over

When is social feedback helpful and when unhelpful?

Do you overvalue someone who devalues you? How can you change that?

Do you value those who value you? How can you do this better?

13.11 ... Constant and unalloyed devotion to Me; aspiring to live in a solitary place; detachment from the general mass of people; ... [– all these I declare to be knowledge].

Don't pack what is back — the past — in your backpack

Suppose we are going trekking with just a backpack. We will carefully decide what all to pack in it. If we fill it with novels and have no space for food and water, we will get into big trouble indeed.

During our life-journey, we frequently let past hurts and issues stay in our minds. Just as our backpack's capacity is finite, so too is our mind's capacity. Just as carrying too many things physically burdens us, so does carrying too many things mentally. Dwelling on the past makes us feel hurt, wronged, helpless, resentful, disheartened.

Most damagingly, the past takes up the mental space we need to give to the present. No matter how bad our past might have been, we can always create a better future for ourselves, if we can act constructively in the present. Unfortunately, by dwelling on the bad past, we unwittingly make our present and future bad too. Such self-destructive thinking characterizes the mode of ignorance (Bhagavad-gita 18.35).

How can we stop packing the past in our backpack? A common answer is: live in the present. Though valuable, this advice is not easily practical. Why? Because our present is inextricably linked with our past; focusing on the present may keep reminding us of the past.

To live in the present, we need to live for something bigger than the present. Gita wisdom reveals the biggest reality: God, Krishna. He is the master of all phases of time: past, present, and future. Even if we don't know what the future holds, we can know who holds the future: Krishna. He is with us in our own hearts, always. If we strive to serve him diligently in the present, he can bring good even out of a bad past and lead us to a brighter future.

Think it over

How does packing the past in our mind hurt us?

Why is it difficult to live in the present?

How can Gita wisdom help us to live in the present?

18.35 And that determination which cannot go beyond dreaming, fearfulness, lamentation, moroseness and illusion – such unintelligent determination, O son of Prutha, is in the mode of darkness.

NOURISH YOUR DEVOTION

Divine love

The love that leads us to evil is evil masquerading as love

Suppose in a war, an enemy soldier dresses like a defending soldier and enters into the defending army. If the defenders aren't alert enough to recognize the masquerade, they will be deceived and destroyed.

We all are vulnerable to similar deceitful attacks in the war for our consciousness between godly and ungodly forces. At our core, we are souls, parts of God; we are meant to be on the godly side – especially when we start aspiring to live spiritually.

To thwart us, the ungodly forces often impersonate the most cherished aspiration of our heart: the longing to love and be loved. This longing stems ultimately from the soul's longing for the all-attractive Supreme, Krishna. Unfortunately, that pure longing gets distorted by materialistic influences. When distorted, love becomes a tool for evil to penetrate our consciousness, gaining first a foothold and then a stronghold.

Sometimes, people in sacred relational bonds act immorally; their actions break hearts and destroy families. While acting immorally, they claim to be in love. But is it love? Sometimes what appears to be love may just be lust, which can be a self-destructive evil force (Bhagavad-gita 03.37). Lust just puts on a masquerade of love.

How can we know whether what we feel is love? By looking beyond our emotion to our action and its consequence. Love is not just the emotion we feel in the presence of someone; love is the dedication of our actions for everyone's holistic well-being. Love inspires us to become our best so that we can offer our best to our beloved. And ultimately love is seen in how it takes us closer to the source and object of all love, Krishna – not away from him.

Think it over

What war is going on in our consciousness?

How do ungodly forces penetrate our consciousness?

How can we evaluate whether what we feel is real love?

03.37 The Supreme Personality of Godhead said: It is lust only, Arjuna, which is born of contact with the material mode of passion and later transformed into wrath, and which is the all-devouring sinful enemy of this world.

God keeps the door to him unlocked from his side till every soul,
however degraded, comes to him

Some religions hold that God gives us just one chance; if we don't surrender to him in this life, he casts us into hell forever.

Such a conception of God is undeniably unmerciful. Even an ordinary parent gives an errant child multiple chances. Is the flawless divine parent less loving than a flawed human parent?

Gita wisdom reveals a far more loving vision of God. He gives unlimited opportunities for every soul to come to him. He descends periodically and repeatedly as incarnations; he manifests as his eminently accessible holy names; he makes himself available as his deities. Even if some godless souls never turn to any of these divine manifestations, he makes himself available to them right in their own hearts. He accompanies every living being as the indwelling Supersoul. Even if a soul is godless, God is not present less in their hearts.

Why, then, are we alienated from God? It's because we have locked the door to him from our side, not he from his side.

What might prompt us to open that door? During our life, we will sometime feel existentially dissatisfied because whatever we pursued as our life-goal was unattainable or unfulfilling or unenduring. At that time, he will speak from within, as the still small inner voice, prompting us to unlock the door to him. The Bhagavad-gita (04.36) declares that those who ascend the boat of transcendental knowledge, even if they are the most sinful, can cross beyond the ocean of distress to the shore of eternity. Such is God's unlimited, unending, untiring grace.

When we understand the magnitude of his grace, we feel inspired to discover the door to him, open it and walk through to his shelter.

Think it over

What is wrong with the idea that God gives us only one chance?

How is the door to God always open from his side?

What might prompt us to open the door to God from our side?

04.36 Even if you are considered to be the most sinful of all sinners, when you are situated in the boat of transcendental knowledge you will be able to cross over the ocean of miseries.

When we make God our friend, we become our own friend

We are often our worst enemies. When we get some lucky breaks, we let them slip away because of laziness, distractedness and impulsiveness. When we face some problems, we often sink into self-pity, resentment and envy, thereby making those problems seem overwhelmingly huge. By thus neglecting opportunities and aggravating problems, we hurt ourselves.

What makes us act in such self-defeating ways? Our mind, explains the Bhagavad-gita. The mind can be both our enemy and our friend (06.05). When uncontrolled, it is our enemy (06.06). It becomes calm when we become conscious of God (06.07).

To become conscious of God, Krishna, we need to appreciate him as our foremost friend. He is always our friend, but we aren't always friendly to him. How can we befriend him? By bringing him closer to us than our mind. That means we turn to him for shelter and guidance before we listen to our mind's propositions about how to face the world's situations. That means we approach life with a positive service attitude, knowing that the world moves for our spiritual evolution, even when it moves against our material gratification.

If we focus on asking, "How can I serve Krishna in this situation?" instead of asking, "Why is this happening to me?" we can find ways to evolve in all situations. When faced with problems, we can avoid getting overwhelmed by seeing beyond the problems to Krishna's benevolent controllership of everything. And when we get opportunities, we can see them as openings provided by Krishna for expanding our service.

When we thus make God our friend, we start making wise choices – choices that keep our problems in perspective and choices that tap our opportunities wholeheartedly. By such choices that prevent our mind from sabotaging us, we become our own friends, aiding God in creating the best future for us.

Think it over

What makes us act self-destructively?

What does making God our friend mean?

How does making God our friend make us our friend?

06.07 For one who has conquered the mind, the Supersoul is already reached, for he has attained tranquillity. To such a man happiness and distress, heat and cold, honor and dishonor are all the same.

Krishna is just one thought away from us – always

When we practice spiritual life, we may feel forlorn: “I am trapped in this material world and Krishna is in the spiritual world, so far away from me.”

While such feelings are understandable, they arise from an often-unexamined notion: Krishna is a finite person like us, situated in only one place, the spiritual world. Even if we know philosophically that Krishna is omnipresent, we don’t often assimilate or even contemplate his omnipresence.

Nonetheless, advanced spiritualists relish Krishna’s omnipresence constantly. They see Krishna in everything and everything in Krishna; he is never lost to them; nor are they ever lost to him (Bhagavad-gita 06.30).

Krishna cares so much for all of us that he accompanies us constantly in our hearts (18.61). Indeed, he is always closer to us than the person closest to us can ever be, even if they hold us in the tightest of hugs.

How can we realize Krishna’s presence and proximity? Simply by thinking about him. When our thought-energy reaches him, we start feeling calm, clear and confident – and all these bespeak of his presence. If we are highly distracted, we may not immediately sense these symptoms of his presence. But if we persevere in thinking of him, these symptoms will become increasingly manifest. The emotional dryness that tastes like poison will give way to an emotional richness that tastes like nectar (18.37)

How can we habituate ourselves to thinking of Krishna? By practicing bhakti-yoga diligently, using its many practices and resources to direct our consciousness toward Krishna. While practicing direct bhakti activities, if we consciously and conscientiously strive to think of Krishna, that endeavor will make Krishna-thoughts habitual. By such habituation, we can more easily think of him at other times too.

When regular Krishna-thoughts bridge the distance between Krishna and us, we relish his proximity constantly.

Think it over

Krishna is far away from us – why is this an uninformed feeling?

How does thinking of Krishna help us realize his presence?

How can we habituate ourselves to Krishna-thoughts?

06.30 For one who sees Me everywhere and sees everything in Me, I am never lost, nor is he ever lost to Me.

Devotion commences when God becomes our guide and culminates when he becomes our goal

To embark on any journey, we need to know the starting and ending points. In our devotional journey toward God, what are the starting and ending points? They are based on our conception of God: initially, we see him as a guide to some goal; ultimately, we see him as the supreme goal.

Amid life's difficulties, we sometimes feel the need for help from someone stronger or wiser or both. When this need inspires us to turn to God as a guide, our devotion commences (Bhagavad-gita 07.16). At this stage, we have our own life goals, but we regard God respectfully as a reliable guide for achieving those goals.

If we start practicing bhakti-yoga, the time-honored process for nurturing devotion, such practice stimulates an evolution in our conception of God. We start seeing him not just as the provider of good things but as the ultimate good thing. Everything attractive manifests a spark of his all-attractiveness (10.41). In his highest manifestation, he reveals himself as the supremely loving and supremely lovable person, Krishna. When we appreciate him as the embodiment and fulfillment of our heart's deepest aspirations, we realize that directing our longing for love toward him can provide us the supreme satisfaction. Thus, we make him our supreme goal (07.19). Seeing him thus as the greatest goal is the culmination of devotion.

A question may arise: Isn't attaining Krishna's abode to live with him the purpose and perfection of devotion? Yes, but loving absorption of our mind and intelligence in him, which happens gradually when we make him our most cherished goal, is non-different from living with him (12.08). Thus, both perceiving and pursuing him as our highest goal comprise the culmination of devotion.

Think it over

When do we start seeing God as a guide?

When do we start seeing God as the greatest goal?

What attributes of God inspire you personally to pursue him as your ultimate goal?

07.19 After many births and deaths, he who is actually in knowledge surrenders unto Me, knowing Me to be the cause of all causes and all that is. Such a great soul is very rare.

We are like birds on a branch — our wings need to grow before the branch breaks

Suppose a bird is perched on a branch. Does it live in constant fear that the branch under it may break? No, because it knows it can fly with its wings at a moment's notice. Though the branch is its present shelter, its wings are its foremost shelter.

But suppose that bird is a baby bird with undeveloped wings. Then it will need to grow its wings before the branch breaks.

We are all like that baby bird. At our core, we are souls. We are meant to fly to the eternal spiritual sky with the wings of our devotional attraction for the supreme spiritual being, Krishna. Presently however, our wings are undeveloped. Worst still, we aren't even aware that we have spiritual wings; we are too caught in pursuing worldly pleasures and treasures. Complacently, we settle on various material shelters such as possessions and positions.

But all worldly shelters are breakable branches. Before they break at death, our wings need to develop sufficiently. How can we develop our spiritual wings? By practicing bhakti-yoga, which increases our spiritual attraction for Krishna (Bhagavad-gita 12.09). Through such bhakti practice, if we strive to remember Krishna throughout our life, then by the time of death, our love for him will exceed our love for everything else. Our love for him will power our spiritual wings to propel us to his abode for eternal life with him (08.05).

When we learn to see our worldly shelters not as places for settling comfortably in material life, but as places for preparing seriously for spiritual life, we gradually become like birds with developed wings. We live in the world, but not for the world — we live for Krishna in this world and in the next world too.

Think it over

How are we like a bird on a branch?

How can we develop our spiritual wings?

What is a healthy attitude toward our worldly shelters?

08.05 And whoever, at the end of his life, quits his body remembering Me alone at once attains My nature. Of this there is no doubt.

See Krishna's reciprocation more in spiritual absorption than in material protection

While practicing bhakti, suppose we face problems and pray to Krishna for help. If we don't get the sought protection, we may doubt, "Why is Krishna not reciprocating with me?"

To address this question, we need to first understand what Krishna's reciprocation means. Bhakti centers on forming a relationship with Krishna, and like any other relationship, clarification of expectation is essential for the relationship to be steady and strong.

We often expect Krishna to protect us at a material level from various problems – and in such protection, we see Krishna's reciprocation. And an oft-quoted verse from the Bhagavad-gita (09.31) suggests this. Or rather, a part of a verse is oft-quoted to support this idea: "O Arjuna, declare that my devotee shall never perish." This verse can be deeply reassuring and encouraging, and Krishna does protect us many times during our material distresses.

Yet to better understand this verse's import, let's look at its context. The first half of the verse declares that the devoted soon become virtuous and thereby attain lasting peace. And the previous verse declares that even if the devoted succumb to misdeeds, they are still to be considered saintly, for their determination is rightly directed. These two verses indicate that Krishna's stress is on protecting our consciousness, not on protecting us from worldly difficulties. And that protection is best offered not just by immunizing us from temptation but also by inspiring us towards absorption in our Lord's all-attractiveness.

Ultimately, old age, disease and death are inevitable in material existence, but if we can become absorbed in Krishna, then we can tolerate and transcend the emotional trauma associated with those life-phases.

Therefore, Krishna's ultimate protection is in revealing his attractiveness and granting us absorption in him. With this vision, we can see him reciprocating with us even amidst distresses provided we just focus on practicing bhakti-yoga and gain absorption therein.

Think it over

How do we often expect Krishna's reciprocation?

What does the proclamation of Gita 09.31 mean in context?

How can we see Krishna's reciprocation even amidst distress?

09.31 He quickly becomes righteous and attains lasting peace. O son of Kunti, declare it boldly that My devotee never perishes.

Praying to get our need fulfilled isn't our need – praying is our need

When we pray to God for something, we may fear, “What if my prayer is not answered? Won't my faith in God weaken? If God doesn't answer my prayer, does he really care?”

God certainly cares – and he always addresses our need. To understand how, we need to first appreciate what our most important need is.

When we face problems, we often feel that getting some specific thing will solve those problems. However, even if we get that need, if our mind is not calm and clear, we may well mess things up by our thoughtlessness. Indeed, calmness and clarity are one of our fundamental needs.

How can we feel calm and clear? By raising our consciousness to the spiritual level, where we sense the indestructibility of our souls and the infallibility of our Lord.

Of course, we have practical necessities. And we can and should strive to get those necessary things. But as the world is a place of limited resources and unlimited desires, some resources may sometimes fall short for some of us.

If we see prayer as a means to get things done from God, then, if we don't get those things, we may sometimes feel that prayer is useless. But if we see prayer as a means of connecting with him, then the very act of praying will establish that connection. And through that connection with him, a sublime calm and clarity will stream into our consciousness. The Bhagavad-gita (10.10) assures that if we connect devotionally with Krishna, he will give us the intelligence for making wise decisions.

When we thus appreciate that our fundamental need is fixing our consciousness on Krishna, not fixing whatever is wrong in the outer world, then we will experience that prayer always works.

Think it over

Why may our need not be fulfilled sometimes?

Based on Gita wisdom, how can we re-envision prayer?

Has prayer itself ever offered you relief even in the presence of problems?
If not, try next time to pray for connecting, not solving.

10.10 To those who are constantly devoted to serving Me with love, I give
the understanding by which they can come to Me.

Sensual hope deludes, spiritual hope delivers

We all need hope. Without hope, life becomes unbearable, even unlivable. But we need to choose carefully where we pin our hope, lest we are misled.

Suppose we are lost in a desert and see mirages around us. If we hope to find water in a mirage, that hope will delude and destroy us. But suppose a reliable guide appears and promises to lead us to an oasis. Putting our hope in that guide will save our life.

The world we live in is like a vast desert. Here, we crave for pleasure and are captivated by myriad sense objects. However, these objects are like mirages; they promise us immense pleasure, but deliver at best just a few drops of pleasure. And we have ourselves experienced this anti-climax, repeatedly. Yet we hope that the next sensual indulgence will make us happy. Such a hope entraps us in worldly consciousness, alienated from our spiritual identity. This sensual hope deludes and destroys us.

Thankfully, we have a reliable guide: Krishna, our indwelling Lord. He is not just a guide to the oasis; he is himself the oasis, for he is the reservoir of all pleasure. When we connect lovingly with him, we start accessing and relishing his attractiveness. Bhakti-yoga is the process that establishes and enriches our loving connection with Krishna – it is the path from the desert to the oasis.

While treading this path, whenever we feel discouraged in our bhakti practice, we can take hope from Krishna's assurance that he swiftly delivers the devoted (Bhagavad-gita 12.07). This hope in Krishna's benevolence will energize us to practice bhakti determinedly till we become lovingly absorbed in him. On thus reaching that divine oasis, we can drink fully and forever from the ocean of his unlimited glories.

Think it over

Why are sense objects like a mirage?

How is Krishna like the oasis?

How does hope in Krishna deliver us?

12.07 But those who worship Me, giving up all their activities unto Me and being devoted to Me without deviation, engaged in devotional service and always meditating upon Me, having fixed their minds upon Me, O son of Prutha – for them, I am the swift deliverer from the ocean of birth and death.

The appreciation we get for our service is not as consequential as the absorption we get in our service

Whenever we do anything, we usually have various levels of motivation for doing that thing. And depending on how deep or substantial our motivation is, we persevere in that activity when we face obstacles.

The same principle applies in our practice of bhakti too. We often want a sense of acceptance and respect in our community. And if that community is pious or spiritual, the kind of services we do therein determines our stature. So, we may do services to gain appreciation.

Such appreciation isn't always a craving of the ego, it can also be a basic human need for reciprocation, wherein we do something for someone and naturally expect them to speak a few words recognizing what we have done.

Still, because of the unpredictable nature of the world, sometimes our service may not produce results noteworthy enough to be appreciated. Or even if we do something worth appreciating, others may not appreciate us because they may be going through their own moods and issues.

That's why if appreciation from others remains our sole motive for doing service, our bhakti practice will soon become erratic and sporadic. To develop a steadier and deeper motivation, we need to understand that our ultimate purpose in practicing bhakti is to connect with Krishna. And that connection comes in the most enriching and fulfilling way through absorption in him. Indeed, if our mind and intelligence are absorbed in him, then we will attain him at the end of our lives (08.07). Not only that, we are already living in him (12.08), and our elevation to his abode is just a matter of time.

If we get absorption in a service, that is itself a great treasure worth cherishing and relishing, because such absorption will keep us with Krishna, now and forever.

Think it over

What is the problem with seeking appreciation for our service?

What is the glory of absorption in Krishna?

Think of a service in which you can absorb yourself.

12.08 Just fix your mind upon Me, the Supreme Personality of Godhead, and engage all your intelligence in Me. Thus you will live in Me always, without a doubt.

The test of success in bhakti is taste for bhakti

When we practice bhakti, we may wonder, “How do I know if I am progressing and succeeding?”

On the spiritual journey, our destination is Krishna, or more specifically, love for Krishna. And if we are enriched with love for him, we will naturally long to practice the activities that connect us with him. Bhakti-yoga is the time-honored process that offers us a rich gamut of practices to connect with him. Therefore, by our practice of bhakti and our progress towards Krishna, our taste for bhakti activities should increase and our desire for connecting with Krishna should increase. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (12.09) asserts that the disciplined practice of conscientious bhakti strengthens our desire for Krishna.

When we ensure that our criteria for success is right, we won't get sidetracked if we don't happen to get external results such as prosperity or popularity. Many people practice religion to gain more wealth and others, to gain more followers. Those of us who are earnest seekers may not start our spiritual practices with that intention – we may genuinely want to grow in our love for Krishna. But over time, as we keep practicing bhakti in the material world where our consciousness is prone to be contaminated by materialism, we too may get distracted by worldly considerations. Thus, we may start subtly craving for prosperity or popularity and comparing ourselves with others in terms of who gets more prosperity or popularity.

What if we get these worldly gifts without craving for them? We can use them as resources for increasing our service to Krishna. But to use them, we need to be sufficiently attached to Krishna to avoid getting attached to them.

That's where the reminder that the test of bhakti is taste for bhakti will keep us safe and strong in our spiritual journey.

Think it over

What should be happening if we are growing spiritually?

What external results do many people crave from bhakti?

How may we get distracted in bhakti? How can we protect ourselves?

12.09 My dear Arjuna, O winner of wealth, if you cannot fix your mind upon Me without deviation, then follow the regulative principles of bhakti-yoga. In this way develop a desire to attain Me.

To have fixity in purpose, we need flexibility in pace

Suppose we are driving to a distant place for some important work. If the road is clear, we will drive at the highest legal speed. But if the road becomes crowded, we will drive slowly. If we become inordinately irritated by how slowly we are moving, we may just give up and never get there. To maintain fixity of purpose, we need flexibility of pace.

We need a similar attitude if we wish to progress steadily on our spiritual journey. This is a journey from being attached to the world to becoming attached to the source of the world, Krishna.

We drive on this journey by our spiritual practices such as studying scripture, meditating and worshiping. But sometimes our worldly obligations don't let us spend too much time on spiritual practices. If we equate spiritual progress only with spending lots of time on explicitly spiritual activities, we may become disheartened, deeming spiritual life impractical for us. Instead, we can understand that these times are like high-traffic zones for us. We need to slow down and move at whatever pace we can. Later, when other obligations become less pressing, we can start moving faster again.

The Bhagavad-gita points to such a multi-paced approach towards spiritual growth when it outlines various levels at which we may connect with Krishna. Best is to be lovingly absorbed in him (12.08). If not, we can strive to be focused on him (12.09). If not, then we can work for him (12.10). If not, we can sacrifice for some good cause, thus cultivating a mood of selflessness (12.11).

By thus providing the facility for flexibility of pace in connecting with him, Krishna reveals himself to be an understanding God who eagerly wants us to attain him. If we strive sincerely, he will soon deliver us (12.07).

Think it over

How does flexibility of pace help us maintain fixity of purpose?

What is Gita's multi-paced approach to spiritual growth?

What does Gita's multi-paced approach reveal about Krishna?

12.10 If you cannot practice the regulations of bhakti-yoga, then just try to work for Me, because by working for Me you will come to the perfect stage.

Everything that happens may not be God's plan, but God can make his plan work through everything that happens

When something terrible happens, we may question, "Is this God's plan? Did God want this thing to happen?"

Some people answer firmly in the affirmative, believing that they're demonstrating their abiding faith in God. Though, if we ourselves do something stupid or sinful, did God want us to do it? If yes, then wouldn't God be responsible for the consequent suffering we get, because ultimately he made us do it?

Such complexity is best addressed by turning to the Bhagavad-gita (13.23), which declares that God is the overseer and sanctioner of everything, not the desirer or doer of everything. This declaration acknowledges that God has given each one of us free will. And we can misuse that free will to do things that God doesn't want us to do.

Does that mean we can defy God's plan? Not exactly, because God's plan isn't simply one pre-decided course of action; it's more of a direction than a path. He is resourceful enough to further his plan even through our mistakes and missteps. To put succinctly, everything that happens is within God's plan, even if it's not God's plan.

Understanding how God's plan works is both sobering and encouraging. Sobering because when things go wrong or when we do wrong, we don't have to naively or perversely accept such wrongs to be God's plan – we can resolutely fix things that need fixing. This, in turn, encourages us because we don't need to lose heart thinking that everything is doomed due to our mistake – God's plan is still working.

If we thus keep working in a mood of service to God, he will keep working with us, on us and for us, eventually bringing good even out of the bad.

Think it over

Everything is God's plan – what are the problems with this assertion?

Can we defy God's plan?

How does understanding the nature of God's plan help us?

13.23 Yet in this body there is another, a transcendental enjoyer, who is the Lord, the supreme proprietor, who exists as the overseer and permitter, and who is known as the Supersoul.

We may be circumstantially distanced from Krishna, but we don't have to be devotionally deprived of Krishna

Life sometimes puts us in situations where we don't get what we want or even need. If we are deprived of material resources while practicing spiritual life, we may see that deprivation as an impetus to develop detachment and to intensify our devotion. But if we are deprived of spiritual resources required for practicing bhakti-yoga, how can we see that deprivation positively?

By understanding that our devotional access to Krishna depends not on the suitability of our situation, but on the strength of our intention.

Suppose we are circumstantially distanced from Krishna because, say, our professional or familial obligations take us to a place where there are no temples or devotees. Understandably, we may feel deprived of those powerful spiritual resources.

Still, intention matters more than the situation. For example, we may be living in a temple, but if we aren't strongly aspiring to grow spiritually, all the devotional richness of our situation won't enrich us. In contrast, even if we are living far away from a temple, but if we have a strong intention to move toward Krishna, then we can feel his presence wherever we are. After all, he is present in our own hearts, and is the giver of knowledge, remembrance and forgetfulness (Bhagavad-gita 15.15).

He can enrich us with his remembrance from within or enable us to relish other resources such as books, podcasts and videos. Not only that, he can even empower us to find spiritually inclined souls in our particular situation and inspire them to move forward in their journey toward Krishna, thereby making us instruments in creating spiritual association where none existed earlier.

By thus understanding that we are never devotionally deprived of Krishna, we can stay positive and purposeful in our bhakti practices in all situations.

Think it over

In spiritual life, how does intention matter more than situation?

When we are circumstantially distanced from Krishna, how may he help us?

Do you have any experience of inner enrichment amidst outer impoverishment?

15.15 I am seated in everyone's heart, and from Me come remembrance, knowledge and forgetfulness. By all the Vedas, I am to be known. Indeed, I am the compiler of Vedanta, and I am the knower of the Vedas.

With God, everyone is accepted, but everything isn't acceptable

Some people ask, "If God is all-loving, why does he prescribe so many do's and don'ts? Why doesn't he accept us as we are?"

To understand God's love, let's differentiate between who he accepts and what he accepts.

Everyone is accepted: The Bhagavad-gita declares that God loves everyone so much that he stays constantly with everyone in their heart. Even if they have grossly anti-devotional desires that take them to the darkest places, he's still unconditionally with them (18.61). To understand the significance of his constant companionship, we can compare him to a doctor who goes into an epidemic zone to treat patients, not distinguishing where they are and how sick they may be.

Gita wisdom explains that the material world is like an epidemic zone where everyone is infected by the disease of sensual desires. Such desires promise pleasure but deliver trouble (05.22). This disease is best cured by acquiring spiritual knowledge that culminates in bhakti-yoga. To heal us, God stays with us at the center of this epidemic zone, right in our hearts. From inside us, he untiringly prompts us to heal ourselves by exploring life's spiritual side.

Everything isn't acceptable: Even the most compassionate doctor will forbid patients from activities that aggravate their infection. For example, amid an epidemic of lung disease caused by smoking, the doctor will disallow smoking for patients admitted in a hospital.

Similarly, God forbids those activities that aggravate our infection with worldly desires, especially in sacred places such as temples that are like spiritual hospitals. And he recommends those activities that purify us of worldly desires, thereby enabling us to relish inexhaustible devotional joy. Therefore, while he remains our unconditional companion (18.61), he also urges us to surrender if we want to attain lasting peace (18.62).

Thus, God's accepting everyone and not accepting everything are both expressions of his unfailing love.

Think it over

How are we infected? What's the cure?

How is everyone accepted by God?

Why is everything not acceptable to God?

18.61 The Supreme Lord is situated in everyone's heart, O Arjuna, and is directing the wanderings of all living entities, who are seated as on a machine, made of the material energy.

Even our best race to the end will require the Best's grace in the end

Suppose we feel inspired to achieve something wonderful and we work hard to achieve it. Despite our best efforts, we sometimes fall short. At such times, we may recognize that we need the favor of higher factors that are beyond our control. Among all such higher factors, the highest is God's grace.

The Mahabharata narrates how God's grace plays a decisive role. During the Kurukshetra war, Arjuna fought to his best ability, throughout the war. He fought especially diligently and ferociously during the fourteenth day when he resolved to bring down Jayadratha. That wicked warrior's opportunistic connivance had caused the death of Arjuna's son, Abhimanyu. For Arjuna, that day's fight was a race against time as he had to fell his target before sunset. Despite fighting his best, Arjuna fell short, being held back by the combined last-moment assault of his opponents. At that time, Arjuna's ability was complemented by Krishna's infinite ability. And Krishna's miraculous intervention by temporarily covering the sun enabled Arjuna to honor his vow. Thus, Krishna demonstrated a key Gita teaching: whatever abilities we have, Krishna has all those and much more – because he is the source of everything attractive in all attractive living beings (10.41).

Like Arjuna on the fourteenth day of the war, we all are racing against time to bring down the demon of our forgetfulness of Krishna, before our present lifespan ends. We can and should cultivate his remembrance by practicing bhakti-yoga throughout our life, as the Gita recommends (08.07). After such lifelong practice, even if we are somehow unable to remember Krishna at death, his grace will enable us to remember him at that most critical moment of our life.

No wonder the Bhagavad-gita (18.62) urges us to surrender to Krishna, assuring that such surrender will lead to the supreme peace.

Think it over

Why is our best race not enough?

How is the Best's grace demonstrated in the Mahabharata?

How can access Krishna's grace?

18.62 O scion of Bharata, surrender unto Him utterly. By His grace you will attain transcendental peace
and the supreme and eternal abode.

Don't ask God to fix your problems, ask God to fix you so that you can fix your problems

Some people think that if they just pray to God, he will fix their problems.

However, such outsourcing of problems to God is problematic. If our problem doesn't get fixed, we lose faith in God. If our problem gets fixed, we start expecting that our other problems will be similarly fixed. And that expectation sets us up for frustration because life sometimes presents problems that just can't be cured; they need to be endured.

How, then, can we better relate with God? By honoring the nature and role that God has given us.

The Bhagavad-gita (15.07) indicates that we all are souls who are parts of God, Krishna. He has made all of us as conscious beings. And he has given us intelligence, initiative and talent. We are meant to use these gifts for playing our part in the unfolding of a divine plan for our lives, thereby contributing socially and connecting spiritually with our Lord.

The Bhagavad-gita demonstrates such an initiative-centered approach to God. At the start of the Gita, Arjuna is mortified at the prospect of a catastrophic war and asks Krishna for help. By the end of the Gita, Krishna has not fixed Arjuna's problem: the agonizing war still confronts Arjuna. But Krishna has fixed Arjuna: the Gita's message has fixed Arjuna's confusion, thereby fixing him in devotional determination to shoulder his responsibility (18.78).

Learning from the Gita, we can avoid making our relationship with God conditional to his fixing our problems. Instead, we can pray that our relationship with him becomes fixed so that we can face life's problems gracefully. Being thus devotionally fixed, we can fix problems that are solvable and not fixate on problems that are unsolvable, growing through both in everlasting spiritual realization.

Think it over

What is the problem with outsourcing our problems to God?

By speaking the Gita, what did Krishna do and not do for Arjuna?

What prayer is most conducive to our spiritual growth?

18.78 Wherever there is Krishna, the master of all mystics, and wherever there is Arjuna, the supreme archer, there will also certainly be opulence, victory, extraordinary power, and morality. That is my opinion.

God is always ready to work with us, are we ready to work with him?

Suppose a reputed coach, who has helped many athletes excel, is eager to work with a budding athlete. That athlete would be profoundly grateful. But instead, if that athlete is uninterested, that would be foolish and self-sabotaging.

Yet that's what we often do. Here's how. To do well in any field, we need inner mastery to tap whatever ability we have. Otherwise, we will be sabotaged by our own mind with its many wild cravings, feelings and false reasonings.

For gaining inner mastery, the greatest coach is omniscient Krishna. If we mold our life according to his guidance, he helps us unleash our spiritual power to regulate our mind. Fortunately for us, Krishna is eager to work with us – so eager in fact that he always stays with us in our heart as the Supersoul. Yet we are often apathetic or even averse to him. And then we wonder why while pursuing our dreams, we often turn out to be our own worst enemies.

How turning to Krishna empowers is demonstrated at the start of the Bhagavad-gita. Though Krishna was with Arjuna on the same chariot, eager to work with him, Arjuna still became paralyzed by his mind's muddled moralizing. But when he became ready to work with Krishna, after hearing Krishna's guidance given through the Bhagavad-gita, he became empowered to win, as the Gita's conclusion assures (18.78).

What applies to Arjuna applies to us too. In the chariot of our body, Krishna resides and awaits. If we turn devotionally toward him, he will guide us to manage our messy mind and act effectively.

Thus, the Gita's concluding assurance could be universalized as: whenever we become ready to take help from Krishna, who is ever-ready to help, our future will be bright.

Think it over

Has the lack of inner mastery ever sabotaged your ability?

How can turning to Krishna empower us?

What can you do to increase your readiness to work with Krishna?

18.78 Wherever there is Krishna, the master of all mystics, and wherever there is Arjuna, the supreme archer, there will also certainly be opulence, victory, extraordinary power, and morality. That is my opinion.

Logical Spirituality

Just as our body needs physical nutrition, our soul needs metaphysical orientation: a sense of place and purpose in the world

If we lack physical nutrition, we have no energy to do anything. We become similarly de-energized when we lack metaphysical orientation.

Usually, we orient ourselves by thinking of ourselves as beings situated at a particular place and moving according to a particular purpose. For example, we may be in our car and driving to meet a client. In more abstract senses, we may be a marketing executive, working to climb the corporate ladder; or we may be Indian immigrants, striving to get American citizenship. We can conceive our place and purpose at increasingly higher levels of abstraction, beginning with our physical context.

Suppose we lived on an island, where existed our family, colleagues, social circle — our whole world. If a tsunami drowned that island and somehow we survived, we would be utterly disoriented, as paralyzed as if we were starving.

We don't recognize how important higher-level metaphysical orientation is – till lower levels of orientation are lost. Usually, we keep ourselves oriented with various lower-level orientations such as our various roles, routines, responsibilities and recreations. However, such orientation doesn't explain what our existence is ultimately meant for; it provides us no place or purpose in life's big picture. When life's upheavals steal our current sense of place and purpose – and they will, sooner or later – we will be devastatingly disoriented, as was Arjuna at the Bhagavad-gita's start (01.30).

Gita wisdom oriented Arjuna metaphysically, explaining that beyond his various roles, he was an indestructible soul, a part of the Whole. He was situated in a cosmos intended ultimately for furthering his loving union with the Whole.

Just as the Gita energized Arjuna with metaphysical orientation, it can energize us too.

Think it over

What does metaphysical orientation mean? Why do we need it?

Think of three levels at which you can orient yourself, making sense of your place and purpose.

Have you ever felt metaphysically disoriented? How did you regain your bearings?

01.30 I am now unable to stand here any longer. I am forgetting myself, and my mind is reeling.

I see only causes of misfortune, O Krishna, killer of the Keshi demon.

Opinions are like onions — know when they need to be sealed and when peeled

When we have an opinion about something, we may hold on to that opinion irrationally, even if it exasperates those around us. We can understand others' emotions if we turn the situation around, if that person were holding on to an opinion that we felt was irrational.

To be reasonable, we need to understand how we form our opinions; it's rarely based on reason alone, and even more rarely based on the reason we articulate as the basis for our opinion. That doesn't necessarily mean that we are speaking falsely; it often means that our minds are complex and multilayered, and we ourselves aren't aware of the layer from which a particular opinion is emerging.

In their multi-layered nature, opinions are like onions. In the Bhagavad-gita, Krishna helps Arjuna peel the onion of his opinions about what to do on the battlefield. Arjuna initially wanted to fight and then didn't want to fight and then he ended up confused (02.06). Krishna peeled the various layers that obscured Arjuna's self-understanding, which in turn shaped his understanding of his duty. Only when that peeling had gone to the core, helping Arjuna understand that he was a soul, who was a part of the Whole, did Arjuna's opinion become stabilized.

Just as opinions need to be sometimes peeled, they need to be sometimes sealed. Otherwise, the multilayered nature of opinions also means that we may keep second-guessing ourselves endlessly. Even after we arrive at a reasonably sensible decision, our mind, from some of its layers, may come up with some counter-opinion that may well be unreasonable and improbable.

When onions are to be transported, they need to be sealed. Similarly, when we need to act wholeheartedly, we need to seal our opinions, as Arjuna did after becoming convinced by the Gita's message (18.73).

Think it over

How are our opinions like onions?

When do opinions need to be peeled?

When do opinions need to be sealed?

02.06 Nor do we know which is better – conquering them or being conquered by them. If we killed the sons of Dhritarashtra, we should not care to live. Yet they are now standing before us on the battlefield.

Proving that we are right is not as empowering as probing if we are wrong

We sometimes think that we know a lot. Yet no matter how much we know, still, what we know is always lesser than what we don't know. We usually operate within what we know, establishing our routines and executing our responsibilities within that zone.

Yet periodically, we encounter things that we don't know – not just factual details that a Google search reveals, but also foundational insights about unknown aspects of known things. For example, we might think that we have our life mapped out, but something or someone might turn out in a way that we didn't expect. At such times, we might, if we have sufficient power, force our belief on reality, but for how long? Facts always win, simply because of being facts.

The same holds true if we impose our opinion on someone who has a better grasp on reality than us. If we try to use our specious logic or brute force to crush their opinion, we will defeat ourselves in the long run.

Whenever confronted with the unknown, if we strive to check whether we are wrong, that learning attitude will not only empower us in that situation but also help us learn something new about the structure of reality that can empower us lifelong.

Indeed, a learning attitude was what Arjuna adopted when he surrendered to Krishna, seeking understanding (Bhagavad-gita 02.07) and acknowledging the futility of all the reasoning he had been doing till then (02.06). He became empowered by the Gita's timeless wisdom because of his willingness to learn. We too can be empowered if we seek Gita wisdom amidst our confrontation with the unknown.

Think it over

What is wrong with proving we are right?

How does probing whether we are wrong empower us?

Is there any situation where you may be better off probing rather than proving your understanding of things?

02.07 Now I am confused about my duty and have lost all composure because of miserly weakness. In this condition I am asking You to tell me for certain what is best for me. Now I am Your disciple, and a soul surrendered unto You. Please instruct me.

The human spirit is too big to stay satisfied within any material cage, however grand

Birds naturally long to fly. Even if kept in the most comfortable cages, they still look for ways to escape into the sky and fly to their hearts' content.

Similarly, the human spirit longs to fly in the infinite sky toward life and love eternal. Something within us calls us to discover whatever exists beyond, in the vast unknown. Since time immemorial, that inner adventurer has inspired humans to face ferocious beasts and raging storms, to dive deep into the ocean and rise high into space, to probe inside atoms and inside psyches – seeking that elusive something which will thrill and fulfill.

Normally however, we don't recognize that we are longing for the infinite; we keep longing for many worldly things. Yet such longings, even if fulfilled, can't fulfill us. Being mundane and finite, they keep us inside the cage of materialism.

Unfortunately, though we are often dissatisfied, we don't often become dissatisfied enough to look outside the cage, for the infinite. Why? Because materialistic culture allures us with seemingly infinite pathways to pleasure. Allured, we keep seeking forever in places where nothing lasts forever.

Fortunately, the doors of the material cage open slightly on special moments when we start asking ourselves earnestly: "What really counts?" Such moments can occur when we are about to lose everything we hold dear or when everything we hold dear is exposed to be unfulfilling.

In the Bhagavad-gita (02.07), Arjuna had such a spiritual eureka moment when he recognized the futility of the conventional path to prosperity and power. As soon as he became receptive, the Gita provided him a time-honored path to the infinite.

The Gita stands ready, inviting us all to unleash our inner adventurer.

Think it over

How does human adventurousness express the longing of the human spirit?

Even if dissatisfied with the finite, why do we not seek the infinite?

When do the doors of the material cage open?

02.08 I can find no means to drive away this grief which is drying up my senses. I will not be able to dispel it even if I win a prosperous, unrivaled kingdom on earth with sovereignty like the demigods in heaven.

We aren't merely physical beings seeking sustenance, safety and sex; we are essentially spiritual beings seeking purpose and progress

Today's materialistic worldview holds that we are just physical creatures, who will be satisfied if provided with a steady supply of sustenance, safety and sex.

Undoubtedly, certain physical resources are necessary for survival. But are they sufficient? These things are available adequately, even abundantly, in the Western world, yet people are distressed; mental health problems are becoming epidemic. Their existential emptiness indicates that we humans need something more in life.

That something more is a sense of purpose and progress. We need a sense of purpose, a sense that moving in a particular direction will bring about a worthwhile change: for ourselves, for our loved ones, for the world at large. And we need a sense of progress, a sense that with the passing of time, we are actually moving forward in a worthwhile direction.

Materialism strips our life of purpose and progress. It holds that we are just bags of protoplasm hurling unstoppably from creation to destruction. Whatever we do will be lost irretrievably at death. And death can befall us at any moment, through just a bang or a bug.

Gita wisdom offers a much more salutary worldview. Our longing for something more comes from the core of our being: our soul. The Bhagavad-gita (02.13) explains that we are non-material souls inhabiting and animating material bodies. We are on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution. How can we solve the problems of materialism? By seeking to connect with the ultimate reality, the all-attractive supreme person, Krishna. And by striving to contribute to the world in a mood of service to him. Everything we do can further our evolution. Our existence counts, our endeavors count, we count.

A life thus infused with purpose and progress is profoundly meaningful and sublimely joyful.

Think it over

What indicates that we aren't just physical beings with physical needs?

We need a sense of purpose and progress. Explain.

How does Gita wisdom provide us a sense of purpose and progress?

02.13 As the embodied soul continuously passes, in this body, from boyhood to youth to old age, the soul similarly passes into another body at death. A sober person is not bewildered by such a change.

More important than understanding what we observe is understanding what it is that observes

Every day, and indeed at every moment, many things pass through our visual range. If we observe such things carefully, we can understand a lot about how things work. In fact, most of modern science has progressed by careful observation of the world around us.

While understanding what we observe is important, even more important is understanding what it is that observes. Why? Because our well-being and satisfaction are determined much more by the state of our inner world than the state of our outer world.

Just as the foundation is the basis of the entire building, self-understanding is the basis of all understanding. Most people's attention doesn't easily go to the foundation of a building — they are captivated by the superstructure. Similarly, most people's attention doesn't go to the self — they are caught by the many worldly things the self can observe.

However, when a quake occurs, the stability of the building is determined not by its superstructure, but by its foundation. Similarly, when a quake of adversity occurs in our life, our stability is determined not by how well we understand the world, but by how well we understand ourselves.

In the Mahabharata, Arjuna faced such a quake when he was confronted with a fratricidal war. And he sank into confusion and dejection — till Krishna illumined him by speaking the Gita and explaining how no war could destroy the self. At our core, we all are eternal souls, meant to pursue spiritual evolution through life's ups and downs. The Gita stands ready to similarly illumine all of us.

Just as understanding what we observe has empowered us externally, understanding what it is that observes can similarly empower us internally. Once we experience how self-understanding fills our life with meaning and purpose, we find the notion that anyone can live without self-understanding amazing — amazingly absurd (Bhagavad-gita 02.29).

Think it over

Why don't most people bother about self-understanding?

If we don't have self-understanding, what is the problem?

How does self-understanding benefit us?

02.29 Some look on the soul as amazing, some describe him as amazing, and some hear of him as amazing, while others, even after hearing about him, cannot understand him at all.

What we know doesn't define us as much as what we want to know

Suppose someone who is in a disaster-hit area knows the path to a safe, prosperous area. Naturally, they will be respected for their knowledge by all those who want to get to safety. However, if they become proud of their knowledge and use it simply to get praise from others and not to chart and follow a way out of danger, they will court disaster.

Gita wisdom explains that the material world is a disaster zone where distress and death can befall at any moment. Beyond this material world is a supremely safe zone: the personal abode of the all-attractive ultimate reality, Krishna.

Those with such spiritual knowledge can chart the way from material consciousness to spiritual consciousness – not just for themselves but also for others. However, they may become proud of their knowledge, exhibiting it by quoting complicated verses and esoteric points, and delighting in the resulting praise. By their actions for thus seeking pleasure in this world, they show that deep down, they don't believe essential spiritual truths such as the following: this world is distressful, and Krishna is all-blissful. Their desire is not to go from the world to Krishna, but to show the world how much they know about Krishna. Because of such misdirected desires, their knowledge becomes nullified (Bhagavad-gita 03.32).

In contrast, suppose others who don't know many esoteric scriptural points still want to know about life's essential truths and ultimately about Krishna. Their wanting to know those truths will not only increase their knowledge but will also take them toward spiritual realization. As their desires are directed toward Krishna, they will be elevated and eventually liberated (03.31).

Thus, on the spiritual path, we are defined not so much by what we know as by what we want to know.

Think it over

How can spiritual knowledge become nullified?

When following a spiritual path, what are we defined by? Why?

Contemplate whether your spiritual knowledge is changing the direction of your desires.

03.32 But those who, out of envy, disregard these teachings and do not follow them regularly are to be considered bereft of all knowledge, befooled, and ruined in their endeavors for perfection.

We are not masters in our own house, but we don't have to be slaves

Suppose we are living in a house where the doors suddenly creak open and bang shut, and lights randomly turn on and off. Suppose we come to know that we are sharing that house with someone disruptive. Then we will negotiate with them to live as peacefully as possible.

If we compare our body to our house, then we are not our house's master or even its sole occupant. Residing with us is our mind, which is filled with innumerable impressions. These impressions make us attached to some things and averse to some things. Impelled by these impressions, various moods often arise within us, without our intent or even our consent. Due to such moods, we often fail to stick to our various resolutions to improve ourselves. Becoming disheartened, we may stop making resolutions and passively drift with our moods. If we cave in like this, we become slaves in our own house.

Thankfully, we have a better option; we can negotiate with our mind's moods. As in any negotiation, we need to give something to gain something. We may agree to do something we feel good about, just to get ourselves to do something important for us, even when it doesn't feel good.

For negotiating effectively, we need to know what we can give and what we can't give. Our inner impressions can be classified into two broad categories: our basic psychophysical nature – ministerial, managerial, mercantile and mechanical – and our various human weaknesses: lust, anger, greed, envy, pride and illusion. The Bhagavad-gita recommends that we accommodate our basic nature without repressing it (03.33), but regulate our human weaknesses without pandering to them (03.34).

By thus learning to negotiate with ourselves, we can bring out our best.

Think it over

How are we not the masters in our own house?

How may we become slaves in our house?

How does the Gita guide us for negotiating with ourselves?

03.34 There are principles to regulate attachment and aversion pertaining to the senses and their objects. One should not come under the control of such attachment and aversion, because they are stumbling blocks on the path of self-realization.

Covering our tracks thoroughly is not intelligence; choosing our tracks thoughtfully is

Our impure desires sometimes impel us to do something wrong. After such wrongdoings, we often cover our tracks thoroughly so that we don't get caught. Over time, we may even start thinking that being able to thus hide our lapses shows our intelligence.

However, it doesn't. Why not? Because even if we are not caught for our wrongdoings, we will be caught by our wrongdoings. The wrongs we do will create impressions or tracks within our mind. Those impressions will impel us to do further wrongs, thereby creating a vicious circle of obsession, degradation and self-destruction.

Our mind functions like a computer browser. Each time we visit a particular site, that visit is stored in our browser history and it comes as an auto-complete during our future browsing sessions. And the more we visit that site, the more frequently and forcefully it comes as an auto-complete. Eventually, it may even become the default site that opens as soon as we click the browser. Such is the addict's mind; it gravitates toward the object of addiction, from the moment they wake up to the moment they sleep – and maybe even in their dreams.

Similar will be our dark destination if we indulge in impure pleasures and think we can get away with it just by covering our tracks. The intelligence that makes us think thus is intelligence captured by impurity (Bhagavad-gita 03.40).

Thankfully, this impressionability of the mind works for positive things too. If we practice bhakti-yoga and choose to consistently connect with the all-positive, all-pure supreme reality, Krishna, the consequent impressions will make connecting with him easier, faster and sweeter. Till we become joyfully absorbed in him and transcend all impurity.

Therefore, choosing thoughtfully the tracks we form on our mind is real intelligence.

Think it over

How does our mind function like a browser?

How can we use our mind's impressionability positively?

Do you have any habit where you cover your tracks? What can you do to instead choose your tracks better?

03.40 The senses, the mind and the intelligence are the sitting places of this lust. Through them lust covers the real knowledge of the living entity and bewilders him.

Seeking requires believing: believing that something worth seeking exists and that we have the capacity to find it

Some people say, “Be a seeker, not a believer.” This differentiation rests on the notion that believers are sentimental and gullible, whereas seekers are intellectual and enterprising.

But is the distinction between the two that categorical? Is seeking possible without believing? Whenever we seek anything, we believe, at the very least, that something worth seeking exists and that we have the capacity to find it. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (04.39) states that faith is the precondition for knowledge. In other words, believing precedes seeking.

Suppose we seek some buried treasure in the ruins of an ancient prosperous city. To begin the onerous task of digging, we need to first consider credible — that is, believe — the reports of buried treasures. We also need to believe that those treasures can be uncovered by the resources we have, be they physical strength, technical tools or archaeological skills. Absent either of those beliefs, we won’t even start digging.

This principle that believing precedes seeking applies even to science. All scientific research is founded in two notions that are considered axiomatic, that is, believed without questioning. First, the universe works according to laws. Second, those laws are comprehensible to our human minds.

‘Believing precedes seeking’ applies to our spiritual quest too. Therein, we seek either deeper meaning and purpose in the world or deeper peace and bliss within our heart. In both cases, we need the twin beliefs that such purpose or bliss do exist and that they are not so far-off as to forever elude us.

Undoubtedly, believing blindly can be dangerous, but so can be blindly belittling all believing. To succeed in our quest for understanding, we need both a seeker’s inquisitiveness about the nature of reality and a believer’s humbleness about the intelligibility of reality.

Think it over

Why does believing precede seeking?

How does science rest on belief?

In our quest for understanding, what two things do we need?

04.39 A faithful man who is dedicated to transcendental knowledge and who subdues his senses is eligible to achieve such knowledge, and having achieved it he quickly attains the supreme spiritual peace.

What the moonlight of reason shows dimly, the sunlight of revelation shows clearly

Some people think, “Reason and revelation are contradictory. If I accept revelation, I will be giving up my rationality and end up believing crazy things.”

Their apprehension is understandable, but it presumes the belief that reason keeps us sane. However, why should reason perform this function of distinguishing the sensible from the senseless? Why should the universe function rationally when it is supposed to be the product of unguided natural forces that had no rational faculty, to begin with? More fundamentally, why should we have the capacity for rationality? If we were fashioned by unguided natural forces, why did we end up with a reasoning capacity?

The most reasonable understanding of the utility of reason is that it is a gift from a higher source. From where has this gift come? Might it be that the same higher intelligence that has made the universe according to a rational order has also given us a rational intelligence that helps us unravel the secrets of the universe? Might that same higher intelligence have also shared at certain momentous moments in history some far greater wisdom, the wisdom that is traditionally called revelation?

If this were true, then reason and revelation could work in a delightful harmony that illumines us with deeper understanding during our life-journey.

Considering that the universe is so vast and what we know of it is so little, we could say that what we know with our reason is like what we see in the night with moonlight. But the big picture of what life is meant for might be visible through revelation, which is like the sunlight.

Echoing the motif of harmonious illumination through various ways of knowing, the Bhagavad-gita (04.39) states that faith is the gateway through knowledge, be it through reason or revelation or both.

Think it over

How does rationality point to a higher source?

How can rationality point to revelation?

How can reason and revelation work harmoniously?

04.39 A faithful man who is dedicated to transcendental knowledge and who subdues his senses is eligible to achieve such knowledge, and having achieved it he quickly attains the supreme spiritual peace.

Our longing for equality points to our spirituality

In today's world, equality is among the most cherished values. Few things provoke as much indignation as incidents of discrimination or even allegations of discrimination. Such outrage is healthy, for it helps create a world where everyone has equal opportunities.

Still, what is the basis for our longing for equality? Intuition, we might say; we innately feel that everyone should be treated equally. Yes, but what is the basis of that intuition? In other words, what is the worldview that grounds this intuition in a coherent living framework? The prevailing worldview of materialism offers no basis.

Consider various parameters often used to rate people: height, weight, strength, complexion, IQ. People score differently on all such metrics. Whatever material metric we use for comparing people, it shows that they are different. Materialism tells us that people are different, not equal.

To ground our longing for equality in reality, we need an alternative worldview: a spiritual worldview. The Bhagavad-gita states that all of us are souls who are essentially similar in our core characteristics; we are eternal, conscious and joyous. And we are parts of the divine.

Those who understand this truth see all living beings equally (05.18) – not just all human beings, but all living beings. Such seers acknowledge the variety that characterizes living beings at the material level, but they focus on seeing beyond that variety to their essential equality.

That spiritual vision is the foundation for a most inclusive sense of equality. To the extent we can focus on developing our own spirituality and helping others develop theirs, to that extent we will be able to place the aspiration for equality on a stronger foundation. The more we raise our consciousness to the spiritual level by potent purificatory practices, the more we will seek equality, see equality and savor equality.

Think it over

How does materialism militate against our longing for equality?

How does the Gita ground our longing for equality in reality?

How can we help create a more equal world?

05.18 The humble sages, by virtue of true knowledge, see with equal vision a learned and gentle brahmana, a cow, an elephant, a dog and a dog-eater [outcaste].

When the mind insinuates, it is often more insidious than when it incites

Suppose a politician speaks hate speech against a particular community. Hearers can easily detect and reject such speech as emotional manipulation. But suppose that politician cunningly plants innuendos and rumors about the targeted community. Hearers get subtly affected: they don't openly voice those doubts, but they just start treating that community with reservation and suspicion.

Inside us is our mind which is wiler than the wildest politician. The Bhagavad-gita (06.06) warns that the mind can be our worst enemy. It acts inimically by inciting us toward sensual pleasures, triggering lower desires within us. But it acts even more inimically when it starts insinuating and planting doubts within us: Does God really exist? Is this religion stuff for real? Are these devotees just a bunch of religious nuts?

Having such doubts is not the problem; they can occur in any thoughtful person. And these doubts can be addressed by expert spiritual teachers who present spirituality rationally.

But the mind often creates a vague cloud of doubt whereby we don't voice our doubts or subject those doubts to rational scrutiny. Instead, we just become aloof and suspicious about our faith-tradition and especially about its ultimate purpose: pure love for the all-attractive supreme, Krishna. When we keep ourselves at an emotional distance from Krishna, we can't get any taste in him. And such phases of tastelessness increase, our doubts: "What is the point of doing all this?" Those doubts trigger a vicious cycle that increasingly alienates us from Krishna.

To protect ourselves from being thus misled, we need to first understand the mind's manipulative modus operandi. And then we deploy our rational faculty not just to question our faith but also to question our doubts. If we let Gita wisdom guide us in monitoring our mind, we can counter it when it incites and when it insinuates, thereby outsmarting it.

Think it over

How is the mind like a wily politician?

How does the mind alienate us from Krishna?

How can we outsmart our mind?

06.06 For him who has conquered the mind, the mind is the best of friends; but for one who has failed to do so, his mind will remain the greatest enemy.

Reason can't reach beyond reason, but it can give us reason to reach beyond reason

Reason, or our rational faculty, is said to be the foundation of the scientific method that has dramatically transformed the way we interact with the natural world. Impressed by the achievements of scientific reason, some people hold that we should stick to reason alone in gaining any knowledge; so, we should reject anything spiritual as it can't be known through reason.

While reason can help us better understand the world, reason itself can't provide much of an explanation of why reason works. After all, if the world is the result of unguided subatomic particles, why should such particles have ever organized themselves in ways that are rationally intelligible? More foundationally, why should our mind, which too is supposed to be a product of unguided natural forces, be structured to work according to reason? The very presence of rationality in the world points to a reality beyond rationality.

The Bhagavad-gita (07.07) illustrates metaphorically how a trans-rational ultimate reality underlies and unifies all of perceivable reality. When we behold a beautiful pearl necklace, our attention is first drawn to the pearls that comprise the necklace. But if we analyze more deeply, we realize that the visible pearls are held together by a thread, even if it isn't immediately visible. So too can we perceive a divine reality as the underlying thread of truth that unifies the many diverse manifestations that reason discovers.

While reason can point to a reality beyond reason, it can't discern the specifics of that reality. For that, we need to elevate our consciousness and purify our heart, thereby accessing nonmaterial ways of knowledge acquisition that we normally never access. One powerful way is the process of bhakti-yoga which makes us receptive to the revelation of the supreme spiritual reality.

Thus, when we contemplate the reason for reason, it can prompt us to reach beyond reason

Think it over

How does reason point to a reality beyond reason?

What metaphor does the Gita use to explain the reality beyond reason?

How can the reality beyond reason be known?

07.07 O conqueror of wealth, there is no truth superior to Me. Everything rests upon Me, as pearls are strung on a thread.

Our belief system doesn't just shape our perception of reality; it becomes our reality

What we believe, that we perceive. This is a well-known principle in philosophical circles. When we observe the world, we don't experience it in a value-neutral way; we experience it as it is mediated through our belief system. For example, if we believe that people are untrustworthy, we obsess over the times when others have betrayed us and we overlook the times when others have helped us.

While our belief system always filters our perception of reality, such filtering can increase in today's digitally connected and politically polarized world. Here, we can live in our own echo chambers, wherein we get social media feeds only from people who share our biases. And thus we start believing that our polarized opinions are the unchallengeable reality.

Significantly, our belief system doesn't just shape our perception of reality, it also shapes our reality. Here's how. Essentially, our belief system centers not on our political opinions, ideological orientations or religious affiliations; it centers on our conception of pleasure and value. What we think is the source of the greatest pleasure and the greatest value, that becomes the pivot of our reality. That core attachment of ours becomes our default object of thought throughout our life and even at the end of our life.

The Bhagavad-gita (08.06) declares that our state of mind at the end of our present life becomes our state of being in our next life. For example, if we desire sensuality unfettered by any morality, we will be taken to a subhuman level of reality devoid of the acute moral sense that characterizes and constrains humanity.

By understanding how consequential our belief system is, we can seriously scrutinize our belief system so that it aligns increasingly with the ultimate reality, thereby leading us to that reality.

Think it over

How does our belief system shape our perception of reality?

How does our belief system shape our reality?

What can you do to align your belief system with reality?

08.06 Whatever state of being one remembers when he quits his body, O son of Kunti, that state he will attain without fail.

The environment is not ours to take or leave; it is ours to make

We are living in an age of considerable climate change. For the past several centuries, the mainstream cultural ethos was that the environment is ours to take. Driven by this notion, we exploited natural resources indiscriminately, disrupting delicate ecological balances and setting loose forces that can wreak unimaginable havoc. And the consequences of this presumptuously proprietary predisposition toward nature are evident in the climate specters threatening us.

However, such rising environmental concern has triggered an extreme reaction among some, who deem much of today's environmental discourse as alarmism. They hold that we need to just leave the environment alone, and it will take care of itself.

However, the environment is not ours to leave. Even if we leave it, we still have to live in it – and so will our descendants. If we humans soil our ecological bed, we will have to sleep on this soiled bed.

The problem with both these lines of thoughts – taking or leaving the environment – is that they presume the environment is ours. But it isn't; it belongs to God. The Bhagavad-gita (09.10) states that nature works under divine supervision.

Though the environment is not ours, it is still ours to make. How? The power that we as conscious beings have in shaping the environment needs to be used purposefully. Gita wisdom indicates that the environment is the setting for us to pursue our spiritual evolution. This evolution culminates in harmonization of our consciousness with the Whole.

As we become adept yogic practitioners pursuing spiritual evolution, we start sensing how the environment shapes our consciousness and how we can channel this shaping power constructively. By appreciating the environment's sanctity in belonging to the divine and its potentiality in shaping our consciousness, we can make it a hospitable setting for our all-round development.

Think it over

Why is the environment not ours to take?

Why is the environment not ours to leave?

How is the environment ours to make?

09.10 This material nature, which is one of My energies, is working under My direction, O son of Kunti, producing all moving and nonmoving beings. Under its rule this manifestation is created and annihilated again and again.

Everything expensive is not valuable, everything valuable is not expensive

We all long for the best in life, be it in looks, careers, positions, possessions, or relationships. While seeking the best, we need to differentiate between the expensive and the valuable.

Expensive things are defined by the price they demand from us, whereas valuable things are defined by the value they bring to us. Here's how the two are different.

Everything expensive is not valuable: Most people are attracted to things based on their appearance. Even if something is low-quality, if it looks glamorous, people become ready to pay big for it, thereby driving its price up. Such attraction to appearance is seen not just in worldly fields, but also in the religious field. People are often impressed by rituals that are exotic, elaborate and expensive. The Bhagavad-gita cautions that such rituals, when driven by mundane consciousness, don't yield lasting results (09.20-21).

Everything valuable is not expensive: Necessities such as air, water or sunlight don't look glamorous, but their value is immeasurable; we can't live without them. To appreciate their value, we need the intelligence that sees beyond appearance to substance. A similar intelligence in the spiritual field helps us see beyond rituals to essentials. The essence of spiritual life is love: the love between us souls and the all-loving supreme soul, Krishna. This love that links our core with our whole can fulfill our heart, both in this life and beyond. For expressing such devotional love, we don't need any grandiosity; we just need sincerity — the sincere desire to please our Lord. This desire can be expressed by offering something as simple as a leaf, a flower, a fruit or a little water (09.26).

If we aspire to seek the best in life, Gita wisdom stands ready to equip our intelligence to see beyond the expensive to the valuable.

Think it over

What is the difference between the expensive and the valuable?

If something is not valuable, why may it still become expensive?

Why does spiritual life not require anything expensive?

09.26 If one offers Me with love and devotion a leaf, a flower, a fruit or water, I will accept it.

Our clock may stop, but time doesn't — don't waste time

Suppose we are working on a deadline-driven project. While we are racing against time, suppose our clock suddenly stops, giving us the illusory feeling that we have a lot of time. Later, when we realize that the clock had stopped and that we have missed our deadline, we will feel foolish.

Our situation becomes similar when we forget our mortality. We all have a finite amount of time in our lives. From the moment of birth, we are inexorably moving toward death. Sometimes, we are aware of our inevitable mortality, but most of the time, we aren't. We are so caught in pursuing worldly pleasures and treasures that we don't even think that we are running out of time. Nonetheless, whether we are aware or not, time is passing relentlessly, pushing us inexorably toward death.

The Bhagavad-gita (11.32) states that time is a manifestation of the divine; time manifests the divine's omnipotent destructive power. Just as God's will can't be thwarted, the flow of time with its attendant destruction can't be thwarted.

Thankfully however, we can save ourselves from this destruction if we strive to do during our finite lifespan something that transcends destruction. The best such something is pursuing our spiritual evolution and help others pursue their spiritual evolution.

Gita wisdom explains that we are at our core indestructible spiritual beings, souls, who are parts of the supreme spiritual being, Krishna. By linking with him in love, we are meant to attain life in his abode where we relish eternity and ecstasy.

If we use our time to love and serve Krishna – and to center our whole life on such loving service – such time will be an investment that will give us the return of immortal life.

Think it over

Why do we forget our mortality?

Why do we recoil from thoughts of our mortality?

How can we best use our time?

11.32 The Supreme Personality of Godhead said: Time I am, the great destroyer of the worlds, and I have come here to destroy all people. With the exception of you [the Pandavas], all the soldiers here on both sides will be slain.

Education centers not on building our resume, but on broadening our reality

Today's academic culture often makes students obsessed with building their resume. When they have to decide which course to take or which co-curricular or extracurricular activity to join, they reflexively reject anything that can't be added to their resume. Indeed, today's ethos makes them believe that education is meant to paint their profile so that they can impress others, sound smart and get lucrative jobs.

However, education is meant for a far bigger purpose, as is implicit in its etymology. Education comes from the Latin *educare*, which means to bring out what is within. Within us are undiscovered interests and talents that make us who we are, that equip us to make our distinctive contribution and find sublime satisfaction. Ultimately, within us lies our spiritual essence, our soul. Education is meant to broaden our reality so that we see beyond the material reality glamorized by today's culture to the spiritual reality, the reality that matters the most for our fulfillment.

Stressing this self-discovering and self-developing purpose of education, the Bhagavad-gita (13.08-12) describes knowledge in terms of qualities that enhance our character and expand our consciousness. In this list of twenty qualities, the last two are: the awareness that spiritual knowledge alone is eternal and the metaphysical search for understanding the nature of reality. And this list concludes by declaring that everything apart from these qualities comprises ignorance. This declaration doesn't deny the practical utility of other forms of knowledge; it just stresses the ultimate futility of any knowledge that doesn't illumine our essence.

If we wish to fulfill the ultimate purpose of education, the Bhagavad-gita stands ready. It provides a magnificent worldview that reveals who we really are, what matters most to us, and how we can lead a life that is meaningful, purposeful and joyful.

Think it over

According to today's ethos, what is the purpose of education?

What is the actual purpose of education, as indicated by the word's etymology?

How does the Gita help us fulfill the purpose of education?

13.12 accepting the importance of self-realization; and philosophical search for the Absolute Truth – all these I declare to be knowledge, and besides this whatever there may be is ignorance.

Education is meant to remove ignorance and restore innocence, not
remove innocence and reinforce ignorance

Education is a central part of human society. We get educated for several decades early on in our life when we have the most energy. Enabling us to shape our future while preparing us to shape the world's future.

To do all this, education needs to remove the two things that impede us internally: misconceptions and impurities. Misconceptions prevent us from knowing what to do, and impurities prevent us from doing what we know we should do. Thus, education needs to remove ignorance and restore innocence. Innocence here refers essentially to purity, the state of the soul in its pristine state, the state where our natural virtues manifest for our and others' well-being.

Unfortunately, today's education does the opposite: it removes innocence and reinforces ignorance. While getting educated in universities, students often get exposed to a hyper-sensual culture that fills them with impurities. In conspicuously concupiscent campus cultures, even students who come from pious backgrounds get entangled and degraded.

Further, today's education often indoctrinates students with materialism. Whereby they end up believing that they're just blobs of protoplasm that somehow came to life, being sandwiched between two infinities of non-existence. Even those who don't get indoctrinated into such fanatical materialism still end up becoming lulled and dulled into functional materialism. Wherein this world becomes their be-all and end-all. And the other world, if it is at all believed to exist, is relegated to irrelevance amid their ever-expanding to-do lists.

Significantly, the Bhagavad-gita (13.12) asserts that real knowledge is that which fosters spiritually conducive virtues. Thus acknowledging the centrality of life's spiritual dimension, which helps students ultimately find their soul.

Even if mainstream education fails to fulfill our best interests, the Gita stands ready to fulfill it – its potent wisdom can remove ignorance and restore innocence.

Think it over

What two things is education meant to remove?

How does today's education remove innocence?

How does today's education reinforce ignorance?

13.12 ... Accepting the importance of self-realization; and philosophical search for the Absolute Truth – all these I declare to be knowledge, and besides this whatever there may be is ignorance.

Thinking that thinking is troublesome, is troublesome

Some people avoid thinking about life's big questions such as: "What is life meant for? What happens after death? What really counts?" They deem such thinking ultimately inconclusive, confusing and troublesome.

However, the results of not thinking are also troublesome, unavoidably troublesome. Whatever else we think and work for in our lives, we will lose all of that at the time of death.

Some people may object, "Why lose the opportunity to enjoy life now by thinking about things like death that can anyway not be avoided?"

However, we humans can't really enjoy life without having a deep purpose. Animals can live driven by survival instinct. But if we live only for survival and for the associated drives of eating, sleeping, mating and defending, then we end up degenerating toward a life of ennui, depression, addiction, and self-destruction. Without a higher purpose, we don't just hurt ourselves and live miserably; we also bring out our worst and hurt others too. For example, the earth's ecological future is endangered largely by us humans, not by any other species. Our human search for enjoyment has led to indiscriminate exploitation and the concomitant unintended disruption of delicate balances in our biosphere.

Thinking deeply to discover a sublime purpose infuses our life even in this world with meaning and fulfillment. Living as if life has a higher non-material purpose benefits us even in this life, leave alone in the next. For discovering such purpose, Gita wisdom stands ready as a time-tested guidebook.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (13.12) declares philosophical inquiry to explore life's spiritual side to be the concluding characteristic of knowledge. When we reject the preconception that deep thinking is troublesome, we discover that deep thinking guards us against acting in ways that become troublesome for ourselves and for others too.

Think it over

How is not thinking troublesome?

How does thinking benefit us in this world?

Plan how you can devote quality time to think about life's big questions and orient your life accordingly.

13.12 Humility; pridelessness; nonviolence; tolerance; simplicity; approaching a bona fide spiritual master; cleanliness; steadiness; self-control; ... [– all these I declare to be knowledge].

Insight comes by catching sight of the link between things already in sight

Whenever we encounter some especially insightful people, we may wonder, “How do they get such insights?”

Insightfulness may be an inborn gift in some, but we all can develop it by conscious effort.

One way to get insight is by catching sight of something unapparent that links known things. On seeing such links, multiple discrete things click into a coherent whole, leading to a delightful aha moment.

Aha moments are valuable and pleasurable in any area of life. But they are especially empowering if they help us make sense of life itself. This is what is done by spiritual knowledge. Let’s see how. What are life’s fundamental truths already in sight? We all have two deep longings: to live forever and to love forever. But we can’t do either: we can’t live or love forever because everyone’s lives are terminated by death.

What insight can link our immortal longing and our mortal living? The Gita insight that real-life beckons us at the spiritual level, beyond the death that besets all things material. There, we as souls live forever and love forever the all-attractive supreme soul, Krishna. When this insight animates our devotional journey, we become purposeful in moving toward Krishna through life’s ups and downs.

If we extend this link to life’s various areas, we can gain insight by linking knowledge in any area with the object of that knowledge. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (13.18) explains that Krishna is knowledge, the object of knowledge and the objective of knowledge.

When we connect our consciousness with Krishna by practicing bhakti-yoga, we start catching sight of the link between all things and Krishna. Gradually, various places, people, events, emotions and experiences start falling in place as parts of Krishna’s plan, thereby making our life sublimely insightful.

Think it over

How can insights give us aha moments?

How can spiritual knowledge provide us insight?

What insight has recently inspired you? What points did it link together?

13.18 He is the source of light in all luminous objects. He is beyond the darkness of matter and is unmanifested. He is knowledge, He is the object of knowledge, and He is the goal of knowledge. He is situated in everyone's heart.

Materialism reduces organism to mechanism

Materialism is the ideology that matter is all that exists. Mechanism is a material system that works according to material laws, with certain causes producing certain effects. Organism refers to conscious beings who respond to stimuli by their own volition.

Materialism treats organisms as if they were simply insentient material particles interacting according to impersonal mechanical laws.

However, mechanisms differ from organisms biologically, experientially and philosophically.

Biologically: Mechanisms go through just three broad phases in their existence: creation, deterioration and destruction. In contrast, organisms go through six broad phases: birth, growth, maintenance, reproduction, deterioration and destruction.

Experientially: Organisms experience a gamut of emotions such as pain, pleasure, fear, hope and anticipation. In contrast, mechanisms experience nothing. A robot may clean a house, just as the owner of the house might. But the robot won't experience any joy in seeing the cleaned house, as might the owner. Even if the robot says, "The house looks so good," it does so only because it has been programmed like that. If its programming were changed, it might say, "This house stinks" even when it is perfectly clean.

Philosophically: Why this difference between mechanisms and organisms? Because organisms have an inner source of consciousness that is the locus of experience and the energizer for bodily transformation through six phases. That source of consciousness is the spiritual essence, the soul. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (13.27) asserts that existence comprises not just matter but also spirit. Matter is insentient; no matter how sophisticated be its organization, as in a robot, it can't experience anything.

Such reflection can help us recognize that the picture of reality offered by materialism is distressingly depleted. Thereby, we can get the impetus to break free from the cage of materialism. And if we are guided by Gita wisdom, we can fly free into the vast sky of spirituality, realizing and relishing our joyous spiritual essence.

Think it over

How do mechanisms and organisms differ biologically?

How do mechanisms and organisms differ experientially?

How do mechanisms and organisms differ philosophically?

13.27 O chief of the Bharatas, know that whatever you see in existence, both the moving and the nonmoving, is only a combination of the field of activities and the knower of the field.

Just because a wound is painless doesn't mean it is harmless – even when we are not hurting, we still need healing

Suppose we had a painless injury. We would go on living normally, while the wound would worsen, eventually felling us.

We all are souls who are spiritually wounded. When the soul is indestructible, how can it be spiritually wounded? Because its capacity for spiritual awareness can be impaired. We are meant to perceive and pursue the eternal love and joy that the soul can have when its consciousness is raised to the spiritual level. However, because we are spiritually wounded, we live in material consciousness, craving worldly pleasures that bring trouble in their wake. The more we are spiritually wounded, the more we chase sensual pleasures indiscriminately, bringing suffering on ourselves.

A question may arise, “what about people who live moderately, eschewing wanton sensual indulgences? They seem quite happy.” They are like people with painless wounds. The Bhagavad-gita (14.06) states that those who live in the mode of goodness are happy, but their very sense of happiness can bind them. How? By taking away their impetus for spiritual growth. Feeling secure in the comfortable cocoon of their present life, they become disinclined to explore life's spiritual side. They give little thought to the reality that their cocoon will inevitably burst in future, subjecting them to disease, debility and death, and hurling them to an unknown destination.

Thankfully, the same regulated living that fosters material contentment can also facilitate non-material growth, provided those living thus become spiritually inquisitive. Their spiritual interest can be sparked if they encounter the Gita and those living the Gita. By such encounters, they come to appreciate how spiritual growth can immensely enrich their lives with sublime meaning and fulfillment. Then, even if they are not presently hurting, they start seeking spiritual healing.

Think it over

How can the indestructible soul be spiritually wounded?

How are those in the mode of goodness like those with painless wounds?

How can those in goodness start healing spiritually?

14.06 O sinless one, the mode of goodness, being purer than the others, is illuminating, and it frees one from all sinful reactions. Those situated in that mode become conditioned by a sense of happiness and knowledge.

The resilience of the human spirit reflects our longing for and our belonging to transcendence

Life is tough. The difficulties that befall us can be morale-sapping. One thing that inspires us to persevere is stories of people overcoming challenges. Their resilience is often astonishing and thrilling.

Some such stories are celebrated, but many more remain unsung. What makes so many people so resilient? At one level, the answer is the character of those people: their determination, creativity and vigor. At another level, however, the answer is a universal underlying human conviction: “We are meant for something better than just struggling, suffering and succumbing.”

Gita wisdom explains that this conviction reflects our belonging to transcendence. We are spiritual beings who are parts of the all-attractive Supreme, Krishna, the reservoir of all bliss (15.07). We long for joy because our innate nature is joyful.

As long as we don’t know about our spirituality, we seek joy in materiality: in worldly possessions and positions. And in such pursuits, some people are remarkably resilient. While their stories are heroic, their stories are also tragic: everything falls apart with the eventual onslaught of old age, disease and death.

Thankfully however, that tragedy is avoidable: the joy we seek at the material level is found enduringly at the spiritual level. Everything attractive manifests a spark of Krishna’s all-attractiveness (10.41); whatever we seek resiliently in material things, it is found in its fullness in Krishna.

If we redirect toward Krishna the resilience we usually exhibit in pursuing material things, we will get far greater returns. In fact, we humans have that capacity for spiritual resilience. The human spirit is so resilient because in human beings, the soul’s consciousness is developed enough to intuit some sense of transcendence: that something exists beyond the material. We all long for transcendence. It’s because we belong to and long for transcendence that we untiringly pursue joy and ultimately relish it.

Think it over

How are people resilient?

What makes some people so resilient?

How do we have the potential for spiritual resilience?

15.07 The living entities in this conditioned world are My eternal fragmental parts. Due to conditioned life, they are struggling very hard with the six senses, which include the mind.

Spiritual growth is defined not by the possessions we give up, but by the conceptions we give up

We live in a glamor-driven world; we tend to look at things externally, making inferences about their nature by their appearance. We may carry this tendency into spiritual life too by, say, equating renunciation with spirituality. That is, if someone gives up a lot of possessions, we may consider such donation or detachment as indicators of the giver's spiritual stature.

While renunciation is important, the purpose of that renunciation is even more important. Put another way, more important than giving up worldly possessions is giving up worldly conceptions. The Bhagavad-gita, while outlining the transmigration of the soul from one species to another (15.07-10), states that what we carry from one body to another is our conception of life: what we think life is meant for.

Suppose we hold on to materialistic conceptions such as: "I am a product of matter, or I am the doer, or the things of this world are sources of happiness (and those things can include non-physical things such as fame)." Then even if we give up some possessions, as long as our conceptions stay materialistic, we will continue our worldly existence. Indeed, to give up possession to gain the reputation of being renounced is not renunciation; it defeats the purpose of renunciation.

How can we give up such conceptions? We can't give up conceptions entirely; we can only replace incomplete or incorrect conceptions with more evolved conceptions. Just as consciousness is integral to us, conceptions are integral to consciousness.

Gita wisdom equips us to increasingly harmonize our conceptions with reality by understanding our spiritual identity and our eternal relationship with the whole, Krishna. The more we re-conceptualize ourselves as spiritual parts of the spiritual whole meant to function in loving harmony, the more we savor and share all-round growth.

Think it over

What tendency may we carry from material life to spiritual life?

How can we give up worldly conceptions?

What are your driving conceptions of life? How can you change them?

15.08 The living entity in the material world carries his different conceptions of life from one body to another, as the air carries aromas. Thus he takes one kind of body and again quits it to take another.

To believe whatever we see is to live like an animal

Some people assert, “Seeing is believing.” Their intent in making this assertion may be good – they don’t want to unintelligently, gullibly believe anything and everything.

Despite their good intention, their assertion is problematic. Why? Because “seeing is believing,” if applied literally, stunts human knowledge. We grow in knowledge not merely by seeing and believing, but by thinking about what we see and integrating our observations into coherent inferences.

Consider how science progresses. Not merely by seeing and believing, but by using specific observations as starting points to arrive at universal principles. Newton didn’t just believe what he saw when an apple fell in front of him. He thought about what he saw and thereby inferred the principle of gravity. Suppose, instead of Newton, a monkey had seen the apple fall. It wouldn’t have thought about what had made the apple fall – it would have just believed that the apple had fallen for it to eat and gobbled it.

Just as scientific knowledge grows by making inferences from observations, so does spiritual knowledge. When we see people, we may believe what we see and presume that they are just their physical bodies. But if we think about what we see, we will realize that they have consciousness, whereas the physical body is made of insentient matter. Where does consciousness come from? From a nonmaterial, invisible source: the soul (Bhagavad-gita 15.10).

If we restrict our vision only to the visible, we won’t gain any deep knowledge. “Seeing is believing” will sentence us to an ignorant, animalistic existence. But if we see and think about what we see, and then decide what to believe, then we will grow in all-round knowledge, in spiritual insight, in a life of meaning and fulfillment.

Think it over

How would “seeing is believing” stunt scientific progress?

How does spiritual knowledge grow by the same method as scientific knowledge?

How can going beyond “seeing is believing” help us grow?

15.10 The foolish cannot understand how a living entity can quit his body, nor can they understand what sort of body he enjoys under the spell of the modes of nature. But one whose eyes are trained in knowledge can see all this.

Arrogance keeps us not just in ignorance, but also in ignorance about the extent of our ignorance

Suppose someone swims in an ocean, knowing that the ocean is so vast that they hardly know anything about it. While swimming, they will be duly cautious. But if someone thinks that the ocean is just like a tiny pond that they know very well, they will fall prey to dangerous sharks whose very existence they are blind to.

We all are souls swimming in the vast ocean of material existence. When we are ignorant, we don't know the way to success and happiness. But at least we know that we don't know. And we humbly seek knowledge.

But when we are arrogant, we don't even know that we are ignorant. We think that we have already got the world figured out, that we know the way to success and happiness. Such arrogance characterizes the demonic (Bhagavad-gita 16.04). They believe that life is just a power game, where wealth is their primary password to power, and power is their gateway to success and happiness. Seeking power at all costs, they, knowingly or unknowingly, trigger their lower side, which is capable of unspeakable malevolence. Over time, they may find themselves deriving perverse pleasure in plundering and murdering as they pursue success and happiness (16.13-15). In due course, they all are devoured by the inescapable sharks of material existence: old age, disease and death. But life isn't finished with them – they are undying souls who will have to account for all their grievous actions in their future lives.

In our pursuit of success and happiness, we may not become so demonic, but arrogance can blind us all.

How can we protect ourselves? By becoming receptive to Gita wisdom. It can show us the timeless spiritual path to inner satisfaction and outer contribution, thereby raising us beyond both ignorance and arrogance.

Think it over

Why is ignorance about ignorance worse than ignorance?

How does the arrogance of the demonic lead to malevolence?

Have you ever been struck with the awareness that you don't know the way to a fulfilling life?

16.04 Pride, arrogance, conceit, anger, harshness and ignorance – these qualities belong to those of demoniac nature, O son of Prutha.

To make people suffer for the sake of making them suffer is the very essence of evil

Suppose we accidentally step on someone's foot. We'll immediately apologize. But suppose someone deliberately steps on someone else's foot – and not just steps but also stomps upon it. If the stomper has a sinister smile on their face, most observers would be appalled. Such intentional infliction of suffering upon another is the very essence of evil.

To better understand the nature of evil, we need to differentiate it from suffering, because all suffering is not necessarily evil. Some suffering is just intrinsic to existence, as is freezing cold in polar areas. Additionally, some suffering may serve a higher purpose, as do surgical cuts in a severely sick person. Such suffering is not evil. Evil is essentially the suffering that's inflicted for no purpose other than to make the victim suffer.

The Bhagavad-gita (16.04) indicates that demonic people are characterized by harshness. The more they make others writhe, weep and wilt, the more they consider themselves strong. They also may delight in eliminating their rivals (16.14). Such people are undoubtedly evil.

What then makes people evil? The circumstantial causes can be many, but the ultimate cause is one: distance from God. The closer we are to God, the more we manifest the godly nature that we share with him as his parts (15.07). He is the well-wisher of everyone (05.29); when we become godly, we too become the well-wishers of everyone (12.13).

We might not be overtly evil, but covert evil exists as traces within all of us. On seeing outright evil in someone, we can resolve to never become like that. How then can we prevent evil from enveloping us? By committing ourselves to spiritual practices that keep us close to God and help us manifest our godly nature.

Think it over

What is evil? What makes people evil?

When is suffering not evil?

How can seeing evil in others inspire positive change within us?

16.04 Pride, arrogance, conceit, anger, harshness and ignorance – these qualities belong to those of demoniac nature, O son of Prutha.

Some people get many insights from one sight, others don't get even one insight from many sights

Some people learn so much from small incidents in daily life, whereas others forget the lessons learned through big blunders. Why the difference? Are some people genetically designed to success and some, to fail?

Gita wisdom explains that we aren't genetically designed, but we are karmically inclined. We all are souls on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution. On this journey, we all carry from one life to the next many mental impressions that we have acquired from our previous lives. And those impressions are such that they impel us toward certain kinds of behavior. The Bhagavad-gita (16.06) declares that all living beings can be classified into two broad categories: godly and ungodly. We all are born with divine or demonic impressions that have formed in our minds based on the kinds of actions we have done in our previous lives. These impressions shape our perceptions, convictions and actions.

Those with godly impressions have the insight to not fall for sensual temptations, even if those temptations look very alluring. In contrast, those with ungodly impressions continue believing that sensuality will soon give them immense pleasure, even if that pleasure has eluded them millions of times.

Though our past impressions impel us toward certain actions, they don't compel us. Even though they push us in particular directions, we can use our free will to counter-push. And our counter-pushing capacity increases manifold if we learn to harmonize our human will with divine will, thereby gaining access to God's omnipotent grace.

By acknowledging that we are products of our past, we can be prepared for our inclinations. And by asserting that we are not prisoners of our past, we can practice bhakti-yoga diligently and create a freer and more fulfilling future.

Think it over

Why do we have certain inclinations?

How can we overcome our inclinations?

Which limb of bhakti empowers you to resist your unhealthy inclinations?

16.06 O son of Prutha, in this world there are two kinds of created beings. One is called divine and the other demoniac. I have already explained to you at length the divine qualities. Now hear from Me of the demoniac.

We may forget gravity, but gravity won't forget us

Suppose an intoxicated person forgets about gravity and steps off a ten-story building. Gravity won't forget them; it will act and put them out of action.

Just as the law of gravity is universal and inexorable, so are various other laws that govern the behavior of matter and the interaction of material objects. Indeed, science has discovered that laws govern the universe at every level from the microscopic to the macroscopic. Yet we think, unscientifically, that consciousness is an exception to the scientifically-demonstrated law-abiding nature of nature. We think that actions of conscious beings – our own actions – are exempt from any accountability. Except for whatever moral standards we decide individually or legal standards we decide collectively.

Gita wisdom stresses that conceptions of moral relativism are hallucinatory. Our actions are governed by stringent laws known as the laws of karma. Whatever goes around does come around; we all have to incur the consequences of our actions.

What about people who seem to be enjoying immoral indulgences? They are foolhardy, like people falling down, who don't look at the ground toward which they are crashing. Even if they feel thrilled at their rapid descent through the air, their thrill will last only till they hit the ground.

What about people who seem to be not getting any consequences? They are like people who have risen to a great height, having done a lot of good karma. By their present immoral actions, they are falling down, but they may not hit the ground immediately. But hit they will, in due course. And when they hit, it won't be a pretty sight. The Bhagavad-gita (16.07) characterizes as demonic those who don't consider consequences while deciding what to do and what to not do.

Understanding that karma won't forget us even if we forget it, we can choose our actions carefully.

Think it over

How are we unscientific in thinking about the accountability of our actions?

How are people enjoying immoral pleasures foolhardy?

How do some immoral people enjoy immorally without getting any consequences?

16.07 Those who are demoniac do not know what is to be done and what is not to be done. Neither cleanliness nor proper behavior nor truth is found in them.

Even if our worldview stays out of view, it shapes our every view

Suppose a beautiful bird is seen in the sky. A nature lover would reach for a camera to shoot its photo, whereas a hunter would reach for a gun to shoot it down. Why are their responses different? Because of their particular worldviews: the world as an arena of natural beauty or of potential prey.

Similarly, our worldview shapes everything we view. Today's prevailing worldview is overall materialistic; it makes us believe that material pleasures are life's ultimate purpose (Bhagavad-gita 16.08). Even if we hear about non-material realities such as soul or God, we nonchalantly neglect them as irrelevant or even condescendingly condemn them as imaginary.

Unless we are introspective, our worldview usually stays out of view. Yet it invisibly shapes our every view, including our view of religion. A materialistic worldview makes us view religious rituals as tools for material gains such as prestige in a religious society or pious credits for future worldly benefits.

As long as we are governed by a materialistic worldview, we can't pursue life's spiritual side. Even if we somehow desire to become spiritual and try to abstain from anti-spiritual sensuality, we still see such sensuality as immensely, irresistibly enjoyable – and, sooner or later, relapse into it.

How can we challenge our materialistic worldview? By studying and applying the Gita.

The Gita's cogent philosophical analysis exposes materialism's inadequacies and fallacies. And its recommended process of bhakti-yoga gives us access to the serenity and sweetness of the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna, thereby making the spiritual experientially real. With such philosophical conviction and personal realization, our worldview gradually changes, consciously and subconsciously, from material to spiritual. We start seeing everything in terms of its spiritual potential, that is, its connection with Krishna.

With such a Krishna-centered worldview and view, we become absorbed in Krishna – steadily, increasingly, joyfully.

Think it over

How does a materialistic worldview shape our view of religious rituals?

How does a materialistic worldview sabotage us spiritually?

How can we change our worldview from material to spiritual?

16.08 They say that this world is unreal, with no foundation, no God in control. They say it is produced of sex desire and has no cause other than lust.

Everyone has values, but not everyone's values reflect real value

Many people lament the corruption and degradation in today's world: "People just don't have any values nowadays."

Actually however, everyone has values – just that their values may not reflect real value. Consider a doctor who seeks to earn extra by subjecting patients to unnecessary tests. That doctor values money more than the patient's prompt recovery. Or consider a lazy car-testing officer who allows substandard cars to pass through quality control. That officer values personal comfort more than road safety.

Valuing the less important above the more important is tragically commonplace. And such distortion of values often arises from a fundamental distortion wherein we value the material more than the spiritual. Ultimately, we value the world more than the source of the world, God. The Bhagavad-gita points to this progression of distortion from atheism to hedonism – the demonic reject the existence of God and deem selfish sensual pleasure as life's ultimate purpose (16.08). For such pleasures, they destroy their eternal souls (16.09) – they squander their chance to realize their spirituality and to thereby relish lasting life and love.

If our values don't reflect real value, we will realize the valuelessness of everything we have worked for when we face life's ultimate reality check: death. Therein, we will be stripped of everything except our soul's essential characteristic, our consciousness, whose enrichment we had neglected lifelong.

How can we prevent this tragedy? How can we ensure that our values reflect real value? By studying scripture. Through incisive analyses and inspiring narratives, scripture draws our attention to the things that really matter – to our soul, to the soul's relationship with the Whole, and to choices that further that divine relationship.

When our values reflect real value, our life becomes profoundly meaningful and perennially fruitful, uniting us in love with the Source of all value.

Think it over

How do even people who act without values still have values?

What fundamentally causes distortion of values?

How can our values reflect real value?

16.08 They say that this world is unreal, with no foundation, no God in control. They say it is produced of sex desire and has no cause other than lust.

Moral relativism makes wrongdoing tough to identify, tougher to rectify and toughest to purify

Many people nowadays argue for moral relativism: “What is wrong and what is right is relative; if something feels right to me, then you have no right to tell me it is wrong.”

However, we are interdependent beings. To maintain law and order during our social interactions, we need some objective basis for discerning right and wrong. But if everyone has their own standard of right and wrong, then wrongdoing becomes tough to even identify. What can't be identified as wrong can't be rectified; why would anyone want to rectify something if they think they can get away with it?

Actually however, no one gets away with it. Even if we aren't punished for our wrongdoings, we will be punished by our wrongdoings.

Consider the history of obscenity, for example. As moral relativism went mainstream, prurient imagery became increasingly acceptable. But as people started fantasizing with digitally doctored images of people, they became increasingly incapable of connecting with real people and found themselves becoming more lonely, more depressed. The very imagery that stimulates the senses deadens the heart. Consequently, many people have recognized that public depictions of obscenity are harmful for their emotional and relational well-being. Unfortunately, even if they want to stop consuming such imagery, purifying themselves of impure desires is almost impossible in today's culture. And that is the worst consequence of moral relativism: while claiming to champion moral freedom, it ends up making immoral living easy and moral living difficult.

The Bhagavad-gita predicts such anarchy when it outlines the sequence from godlessness to pleasure-centered relativism (16.08), followed by self-destruction and world-destruction (16.09).

If we wish to avoid moral anarchy, the Gita stands ready to guide us; it presents morality not dogmatically but rationally, as a means to a higher consciousness and a better life.

Think it over

Why can't society function if it accepts moral relativism?

What is the worst consequence of moral relativism? Explain with an example.

In a culture of moral relativism, what can the Gita offer us?

16.08 They say that this world is unreal, with no foundation, no God in control. They say it is produced of sex desire and has no cause other than lust.

Materialism reduces you to a number and glamorizes things that make you number

Most people nowadays are materialistic: they live to seek materialistic sensations and possessions.

Yet most of them haven't thought through the philosophical implications of materialism. If matter is all that matters, then what is the significance of the emotions of joy and love that they seek through their materialistic pursuits? Where do those emotions come from? Merely from the white and grey matter of their brains? Is generating enjoyable electrochemical pulses in our brain cells the purpose of life? Is the love a mother feels for her newborn baby nothing but some electricity zipping through her cranial cavity? Materialism reduces us to a number; a materialistic worldview implies that the essence of our personality is nothing more than a figure that represents the electrochemical pulsations in our brain.

Such a vision of existence is so dreary and dehumanizing that hardly anyone can entertain it, leave alone base their life on it. Even if we accept that life is devoid of meaning, life is still not devoid of distress. To make such distress bearable, we need some meaningful purpose. Sadly, materialism leaves no room for such purpose. Consequently, we desperately seek to numb ourselves through escapeways such as mindless entertainment. And ironically, materialism often glamorizes as evidence of progress the many technological gadgets and media that provide us new ways to numb ourselves.

Foreseeing this descent toward meaninglessness, the Bhagavad-gita cautions that those who accept material pleasures as life's all-in-all (16.08) end up destroying their own souls — they strip their lives of the things that make life meaningful and worthwhile (16.09).

If we seek a more life-affirming vision of reality, Gita wisdom offers a magnificent vision that infuses our life with enduring meaning and profound purpose.

Think it over

How does materialism reduce us to a number? How does materialism glamorize things that make us number?

Have you ever experienced the emptiness of a materialistic way of life?

How can you use your experiences to reorient yourself spiritually?

16.09 Following such conclusions, the demoniac, who are lost to themselves and who have no intelligence, engage in unbeneficial, horrible works meant to destroy the world.

If we put gravity to test, gravity will put us to rest

Suppose someone decides to test gravity by walking off the parapet wall of a fifty-story building. Gravity will soon put them to rest, stripped of limbs or life itself. Why would anyone want to test gravity? Because they give their feelings more weight than their intelligence; because they consider only the thrill of the jump, not the horror of the crash.

Just as gravity is a physical law of nature that operates at the physical level, there exists a law of nature that operates at a subtler level. This is the law of karma which holds us accountable for our actions. Why would anyone want to test karma? Because they let themselves be driven by whatever feels good, without considering its consequences — as do people who start taking drugs without considering the danger of getting addicted.

Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita cautions that poisonous passions such as lust, anger and greed make our life hellish (16.21-22). For keeping these self-destructive passions in check, scripture gives us time-tested guidelines (16.24). If we neglect such guidelines and pander to our lower passions indiscriminately, we sentence ourselves to misery (16.23). If we defy the laws of karma, we don't just become motionless in pain; we become pushed helplessly by our dark passions into a painful journey to ever-increasing distress. And that predicament continues till we muster the strength to resist those drives.

Thankfully, if we decide to stand up to our lower passions, our all-powerful, all-merciful Lord, Krishna, stands ready to strengthen us. And we will eventually have to stand up to those passions when our karmic distress becomes unbearable. Then, why not resist them now and save ourselves from a dark future? By linking devotionally with the Lord who wants the best life for us, why not start creating a better life right now?

Think it over

What makes us put gravity or karma to test?

How are the consequences of defying karma worse than those of defying gravity?

How can we get the resolve to stand up to our lower passions?

16.23 He who discards scriptural injunctions and acts according to his own whims attains neither perfection, nor happiness, nor the supreme destination.

The choices you make, make you

During our life, we constantly make choices. Even when we know that our choices are consequential, we may not realize how consequential they are. Why? Because we consider only the external consequences of our actions, not their internal consequences.

We may think of our choices like choosing a particular turn at an intersection while driving. But our choices are more like choosing the structure and design of the house in which we are going to live. These choices determine whether our house will be sturdy or flimsy.

Our choices don't just shape where we go externally; they also shape who we become internally — they determine the structure and strength of our inner house. Our inner house is made primarily of our subtle body which can be referred to in shorthand as our mind. We are essentially souls who are occupying homes made of our minds and our bodies.

We often carefully choose the kind of food we eat, knowing it will shape our physical body. But we don't carefully choose the kind of thoughts we entertain, the kind of desires we enjoy and the kind of intentions we cultivate — we forget that these inner choices will shape our mind. And we make all these choices based on our faith. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (17.03) states that we make our faith and our faith makes us, and thus we make our fate. By making wise choices, we make ourselves wise. By making firm choices, we make ourselves firm. By making spiritual choices, we make ourselves spiritual.

When we thus understand how consequential our choices are, irrespective of whether they have external visible consequences or not, we become more judicious about choosing the components that build our inner home: our thoughts, desires, intentions, actions, essentially our faith.

Think it over

With two metaphors, explain what our choices are like and aren't like.

What shapes our inner home?

How can you ensure that your inner home is sturdier?

17.03 O son of Bharata, according to one's existence under the various modes of nature, one evolves a particular kind of faith. The living being is said to be of a particular faith according to the modes he has acquired.

Just as bigotry can blind emotionally, ideology can blind intellectually

In today's social justice ethos, if someone makes a racist or sexist statement, they are called out immediately. Prejudices of any kind are frowned upon. Usually, bigoted people are seen to be blinded by their emotions.

However, emotions aren't the sole cause of prejudices. Even the intellect, which is normally meant to regulate our emotions and balance our perceptions, can blind us. Such intellectual blinding happens through ideology, specifically, through ideological obsessions.

When we buy into an ideology, we see the whole world filtered through that ideology. Rather than using the ideology as a tool to make better sense of the world, we reduce the world to that ideology. Whatever doesn't make sense within that ideology's framework is neglected or rejected. Or it is explained away through various rationalizations, arguments used to arrive at self-serving conclusions that are often irrational. The Bhagavad-gita (18.22) deems such ideological obsession as knowledge in the mode of ignorance, wherein all of reality is reduced to a fragment.

Thus, for example, people driven by leftist ideologies presume that anyone wealthy or powerful has become so by exploiting others. They don't consider the role of talent and commitment in fostering success. When they reduce the world to a struggle between exploiters and exploited, they become blinded to the many common causes for which the poor and wealthy can work synergistically.

And such blinding is itself ideology-blind; just as leftist ideologies can blind, so can rightist ideologies.

Doesn't the Gita also offer an ideology? Not exactly. The Gita offers spirituality and a philosophy that delineates the pathway for spiritualizing our consciousness. When our consciousness is thus raised above both emotional and intellectual blinders, we can then see things as they are. And seeing everyone as essentially spiritual beings is the best way to overcome bigotry.

Think it over

How does ideology blind intellectually?

Do you know anyone who is ideologically blinded? Might you yourself be similarly blinded?

How is Gita wisdom different from an ideology?

18.22 And that knowledge by which one is attached to one kind of work as the all in all, without knowledge of the truth, and which is very meager, is said to be in the mode of darkness.

Science is the study of matter, spirituality is the study of what matters

We live in an age of science and technology. Technological advancement has increased enormously our knowledge of the world around us, especially our knowledge to reshape that world according to our wishes.

While such knowledge can be empowering, it can also be blinding. Why blinding? Because science and technology focus on the study of matter: the study of how the material objects in the outer world interact. But more important than the study of matter is the study of what matters: what is truly important for us, what brings meaning and fulfillment to our life.

Unfortunately, we often get obsessed with technology, especially with the associated allurements of ever-faster devices. Amidst such obsession, we often forget whether technology is providing us what truly matters. The Bhagavad-gita (18.22) declares as ignorance inducing that knowledge which makes us obsessed with one slice of reality.

While Arjuna had sophisticated knowledge of weapons – of matter – that knowledge didn't protect him from utter confusion when confronted with life's inevitable dilemmas (02.06). Only when the Gita provided him the knowledge of what matters could he become calm enough to use his knowledge of matter effectively (18.73).

Despite all our technological knowledge, we too are experiencing enormous distraction and disorientation. Indeed, such problems seem to be increasing with technological advancement. For example, the more we get hooked to social media, which is created and extended by technology, the more we become alienated from pursuing those things that bring fulfillment into our life.

To address such problems, we need to begin by setting our priorities straight, putting the knowledge of what matters before the knowledge of matter. Just as the Gita helped Arjuna to focus on the things that matter, it stands ready to help us too.

Think it over

How can knowledge of technology be blinding?

How is technological advancement increasing our distraction?

What can you do to prioritize the knowledge of what matters above the knowledge of matter?

18.22 And that knowledge by which one is attached to one kind of work as the all in all, without knowledge of the truth, and which is very meager, is said to be in the mode of darkness.

Technology may change our world for the better, but let it not change our worldview for the worse

We live in a world that has been dramatically transformed by technology, be it through electricity, airplanes or net connectivity. Many places whose extreme weather made them almost uninhabitable are now habitable because of technological aids such as artificial heating or cooling.

The changes technology brings in our world are tangible, but the changes it brings in our worldview are often intangible. Those intangible changes center on fostering the belief that we are controllers.

Technology increases our capacity to control our outer world, which is helpful as far as it goes. However, that increased capacity can make us entertain fantasies such as the following: technology can help us overcome every difficulty in life, go beyond mortality and make this material world a paradise. These beliefs are delusional because mortality and misery are intrinsic to the material body and material world we live in. Such delusional beliefs set us up for the mental health epidemic plaguing our world today – the more we expect to be controllers, the more we feel frustrated when we can't control, thereby driving our mind mad.

Moreover, indiscriminate adoption of technology deters us from exploring anything beyond the material. Equating one narrow slice of reality with all of reality characterizes knowledge in the mode of ignorance (Bhagavad-gita 18.22). Thus, the age of technology traps us in the cage of materialism that fragments us from reality and frustrates us with our mortality.

Protecting us from a misleading materialistic worldview, Gita wisdom explains that we are, at our core, souls on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution. The Gita's holistic worldview explains our identity and destiny, and empowers us with a fulfilling life-purpose that utilizes everything, including technology.

Think it over

What beliefs can technology trigger within us?

How can technology foster knowledge in the mode of ignorance?

How can you harmonize your use of technology with life's spiritual purpose?

18.22 And that knowledge by which one is attached to one kind of work as the all in all, without knowledge of the truth, and which is very meager, is said to be in the mode of darkness.

Learn to wonder and ponder, not wander and pander

Babies tend to wander and pander. They wander wherever they can without considering where they are going and why. They typically pander to their tongue, seeing all of existence as potential food.

In babies, such wandering and pandering may be endearing, but it becomes appalling when seen in adults. Why would adults behave like infants? Because even in adults, the mind often remains infantile. The mind wanders here, there and everywhere, seeking anything that promises sensual pleasure. It then panders to any desire that pops up, thereby wasting our time, energy and money on things that are at best trivial and at worst destructive.

Nowadays, with the availability of technology, especially the Internet, this wandering and pandering has multiplied manifold. People too lazy to get up from their sofas wander in every corner of real or imaginary worlds and pander to the darkest desires produced by their or others' minds.

Though all such wandering and pandering can seem titillating, it soon turns out to be boring, frustrating, and degrading. What tastes like nectar initially tastes like poison eventually (Bhagavad-gita 18.38).

Gita wisdom explains that life is meant for something higher: for wondering and pondering. When we look at the vast sky, we can wonder, "Where did it come from? Where did we come from? Why do we exist?" Such wondering can go beyond idle curiosity when we ponder those questions by reading wisdom-texts such as the Gita that have pondered similar questions millennia ago.

Such wondering and pondering can be like poison initially. When we are struggling to find meaning while the rest of the world lives on in blissful ignorance then we taste the poison. But, that struggle becomes like nectar eventually when we align with our deepest purpose in harmony with our source (18.37). In such a harmonious life, we make fulfilling material contributions and relish enduring spiritual evolution.

Think it over

How do we wander and pander?

How has technology affected our wandering and pandering?

How can we learn to wonder and ponder?

18.37 That which in the beginning may be just like poison but at the end is just like nectar and which awakens one to self-realization is said to be happiness in the mode of goodness.

Spiritual knowledge is meant to make us devotionally fit, not intellectually fat

Food nourishes our body, gives us energy and makes us fit to face life's responsibilities. However, if eaten excessively or inappropriately, the same food makes us fat and reduces our fitness.

Spiritual knowledge is like food. It is meant to nourish and energize us to face life's challenges and thereby grow spiritually.

Unfortunately, we sometimes seek spiritual knowledge to parade how much we know and to delight in the praise we get from others who are impressed by our knowledge. Being thus misdirected, we start gobbling down spiritual knowledge. We especially devour those sound bytes that roughly approximate as spiritual knowledge which will earn wows for us by people who say, "I have never heard that point."

The knowledge we acquire thus stays only in our head; it doesn't enter our heart, leave alone transform it. This knowledge increases our love for the world and for the praise we garner in the world, not for the Lord who is the purpose of all spiritual knowledge. Thus, our knowledge ends up making us intellectually fat – bloated with knowledge – yet unable to face life's challenges resiliently and resourcefully as we could if our knowledge had energized us.

The essence of spiritual knowledge is that we all are spiritual beings who are parts of a whole bigger than ourselves: the all-attractive supreme, Krishna. If we strive to serve him, doing our best according to our capacities and responsibilities, he empowers us to tolerate and transcend the world's pleasures and troubles, while persevering in our purpose.

This is how Arjuna became empowered after hearing the Bhagavad-gita (18.73). As a warrior, he had always been physically fit, but Gita wisdom made him devotionally fit, ready to face life's toughest challenges. And the Gita can similarly empower all of us.

Think it over

How is spiritual knowledge like food?

How may spiritual knowledge make us intellectually fat?

How can spiritual knowledge make us devotionally fit?

18.73 Arjuna said: My dear Krishna, O infallible one, my illusion is now gone. I have regained my memory by Your mercy. I am now firm and free from doubt and am prepared to act according to Your instructions.

Ritual to SpirituaL

Keep the mind on one track, don't keep a one-track mind

To keep the mind on one track means to keep our attention focused on one overarching life-purpose, whatever distractions the world may present. Those with their mind on one track can pursue goals persistently.

To have a one-track mind means to be obsessed with one thing alone, to reduce the entire world to that thing, to not be able to relate with anyone who is not interested in that thing. Those with a one-track mind come off as eccentric, obsessed, fanatical.

The Bhagavad-gita (02.41) urges us to keep our mind on one track to Krishna, to make him our life's overarching purpose. But we may misunderstand this injunction and start keeping a one-track mind, whereby we alienate people by thrusting Krishna on them during any interaction on any subject.

To avoid alienating people, we need a more inclusive understanding of Krishna. He is not a world-denying deity – devotion to him doesn't have to be world-rejecting. He is the Whole who has all living beings as his parts (Bhagavad-gita 15.07); he is the source of the attractiveness of all attractive things (10.41); he is the indwelling benefactor of all living beings (05.29, 15.15). When we thus appreciate Krishna's pervasiveness, we celebrate others' abilities as his gifts (07.08) and their work as a potential way of worshiping him (18.47).

When we learn to see Krishna even in ordinary things, we can value people where they are. We can connect their current interests with Krishna and creatively conceive ways to connect them with Krishna from where they are.

Thus, when we keep our mind on the Krishna-track, we learn to care for others spiritually in terms they can appreciate, thereby attracting them towards us and Krishna.

Think it over

Why is keeping the mind on one track helpful, but keeping a one-track mind unhelpful?

How can an inclusive understanding of Krishna enable us to relate better with others?

How does keeping our mind on the Krishna-track help us relish life?

02.41 Those who are on this path are resolute in purpose, and their aim is one. O beloved child of the Kurus, the intelligence of those who are irresolute is many-branched.

If an ideal inspires more regret than reform, an intermediate ideal is required

Suppose a hospital gym has weights so heavy that they can't even be budged by those patients who need to exercise. Such weights will make patients so discouraged that they may give up trying to exercise. Even if those heavier weights need to be eventually lifted by those who wish to recover, the gym needs to provide them lighter weights that they can lift in their present conditions.

The same principle can apply to our spiritual recovery. We are all weak and sick because of our many impure desires. The practice of bhakti-yoga is the cure for our sickness. While practicing bhakti, we are expected to follow certain standards. However, such standards or ideals need to be presented in a way that is productive, not counterproductive.

An ideal is productive when it inspires reform: "I am meant to be up there, at that level. What am I doing languishing down here? I will take steps to start rising right away." An ideal is counterproductive when it inspires regret: "That ideal is so high up; I will never come to that level; maybe I should just give up and stay where I am."

When an ideal inspires more regret than reform, an intermediate ideal becomes necessary. This doesn't mean we bring down the ideal; it just means we create steps that make reaching the ideal easier. Such inclusiveness is demonstrated in the Bhagavad-gita (03.26) when it disapproves giving lofty instructions that simply agitate the minds of the attached; instead, it recommends that everyone be engaged appropriately for their gradual elevation.

When ideals are made attainable, more people seek self-transformation, thus creating a better life for themselves and a better world for everyone.

Think it over

When is an ideal productive?

When does an ideal become counterproductive?

If an ideal inspires more regret than reform, what needs to be done?

03.26 So as not to disrupt the minds of ignorant men attached to the fruitive results of prescribed duties, a learned person should not induce them to stop work. Rather, by working in the spirit of devotion, he should engage them in all sorts of activities [for the gradual development of Krishna consciousness].

Without going deeply into one tradition, we can't deeply appreciate any tradition

When we start exploring life's spiritual side, we may hesitate to commit ourselves to any particular spiritual path: "Won't that make me close-minded and incapable of appreciating other paths?"

Possibly. But if we don't commit ourselves to one path, we may never appreciate any path.

To understand why, consider the metaphor of climbing a mountain. The top of the mountain is spiritual consciousness, wherein we relish the ultimate reality. The bottom of the mountain is material consciousness, wherein we pursue worldly objects as life's greatest pleasures. Various time-honored spiritual traditions are different paths up this mountain. Pertinently, the Bhagavad-gita (04.11) indicates that all seekers are on the same journey to the one ultimate reality.

If we climb the mountain by any one path, we start perceiving things from a higher perspective. Then, if we interact with others who have climbed the mountain by other paths, we can better understand their perceptions: both perceptions that concur with ours and perceptions that differ.

Similarly, when we commit ourselves to one spiritual tradition, that committed practice raises our consciousness to a higher, non-material level. When we thus gain some spiritual experiences ourselves, we can better appreciate others' spiritual experiences. Then, if we study different traditions, we can sense both the universalities underlying all traditions and the specificities characterizing various traditions.

If, however, we don't commit to any tradition, we are like reluctant trekkers who don't climb the mountain. Staying at the bottom of the mountain, we can't see things from a higher perspective; we can't appreciate any tradition deeply. In contrast, if we commit to spiritual traditions that raise our consciousness, such commitment doesn't close our mind – it opens our mind to higher realities, as revealed in both our and other traditions.

Hence the paradoxical principle: to deeply appreciate various traditions, we need to first go deep into one tradition.

Think it over

How is exploring life's spiritual side like climbing a mountain?

How does hesitation to make spiritual commitments keep us deprived?

How can committing to one tradition help us better appreciate other traditions?

04.11 As all surrender unto Me, I reward them accordingly. Everyone follows My path in all respects, O son of Prutha.

Ritualists see hierarchy above equality, spiritualists see equality above hierarchy

We cherish equality; we don't want anyone to be discriminated against. Simultaneously, our hard-nosed side cautions that some hierarchies are essential for the orderly conduct of things.

Consider driving. If anyone were deprived of the right to drive, that would militate against equality. But if there were no hierarchy in terms of drivers being monitored by traffic cops, driving would become chaotic and dangerous. Therefore we need a balance of equality and hierarchy.

On the spiritual path too, both equality and hierarchy exist. Gita wisdom explains that spiritually we all are equal, for we are souls, who are parts of Krishna (15.07). We are all meant ultimately to rejoice in a life of eternal love with him. While we strive to attain love for him, we need an orderly society, which requires some functional hierarchy. In dharmic traditions, such a hierarchy was provided by varnashrama.

Every hierarchy is prone to abuse, and varnashrama is no exception. Because some upper-caste people became power-hungry, they perverted varnashrama into the discriminatory caste system, which made people's birth the defining decider of their life's trajectory. The Gita (04.13) itself strikes a cautionary note against such perversion, emphasizing that one's social position is to be determined by qualities and activities, not birth.

Unfortunately, such philosophical subtleties are lost to ritualistic followers, who reduce practices meant for spiritual transformation to mere rituals that must be conformed with. Such ritualists consider hierarchies the tradition's essence and deem non-conformity with those hierarchies an inexcusable deviation.

Significantly however, the Gita stresses equality above hierarchy. It (05.18) reveals the vision of the spiritually realized: they see everyone from the lowest social position to the highest as essentially equal.

By such an inclusive vision, the Gita addresses contemporary concerns for social justice and presents a spirituality that is inclusive, attractive, effective.

Think it over

How are equality and hierarchy both important?

How did varnashrama degenerate into the caste system?

How does the Gita stress equality above hierarchy?

05.18 The humble sages, by virtue of true knowledge, see with equal vision a learned and gentle brahmana, a cow, an elephant, a dog and a dog-eater [outcaste].

To respect Krishna, respect the time we have carved out for Krishna

Suppose we are to meet someone who says they respect us profusely. But suppose they don't turn up for the meeting – and that happens not once or twice, but repeatedly. If they don't respect the time they have allocated for us, their claims about respecting us will start ringing hollow.

Might we be doing something similar in our relationship with Krishna? If we have some basic piety, we would never say that we don't respect God. Yet despite professing our respect for him, we frequently don't respect the time we allocate for him.

Suppose we resolve to engage in some bhakti-yoga activities such as studying the Bhagavad-gita at particular times. However, at those times, we often let other things take priority, thinking that bhakti can always be practiced later. When we thus stand Krishna up repeatedly, we end up disrespecting him, even if unwittingly.

To respect our time for Krishna, we can take three steps: schedule seriously, adhere diligently, reschedule only if necessary.

We need to schedule time for Krishna as seriously as we would schedule an appointment with our favorite VIP. After all, isn't Krishna the supreme VIP? Then, we need to stick to that schedule. If something else comes up that seems unavoidably urgent, we can ask ourselves: If I had a meeting with my favorite VIP, would I cancel it for doing this? Only if we would honestly answer in the affirmative, then that situation warrants rescheduling our Krishna-commitment.

To be so serious about our time for Krishna, we need to be determined in our devotion, as are earnest bhakti-yogis (09.14).

When we thus respect the time we have carved out for Krishna, we gradually carve out a place for him in our heart. And his presence becomes increasingly manifest, making our heart supremely enriched.

Think it over

How may we unwittingly disrespect Krishna?

How can we respect our time for Krishna?

What happens when we respect our Krishna-time?

09.14 Always chanting My glories, endeavoring with great determination, bowing down before Me, these great souls perpetually worship Me with devotion.

Don't let our desire to use something for Krishna become greater than our desire for Krishna

Suppose we are driving to meet someone dear to us, and we get a desire to offer them a special gift. But we get so caught in searching for a good gift that we lose our way and don't reach for the meeting. By our mistaken priorities, we end up displeasing the very person we wanted to please.

On the spiritual path, we may similarly undermine our relationship with Krishna. While practicing bhakti, we may desire to offer him something special. But that desire may become stronger than our desire for him, thereby distracting us from him.

Suppose we desire to earn a lot of money to build a grand temple for Krishna. Even if we eventually get that wealth, we may have become so immersed in materialistic consciousness that our desire to use the wealth for Krishna may have decreased or even disappeared. And if we don't get that wealth, we may become so irritated or disheartened as to give up our bhakti practice.

Does this mean that we shouldn't desire to offer Krishna grand things? Certainly, we should; love naturally wants to offer the best of everything to the beloved. But presently, our love for Krishna is not very strong. In trying to give the world to Krishna, we shouldn't end up giving our heart to the world.

Moreover, in bhakti, grand offerings aren't essential; what is essential is just a devoted heart. The Bhagavad-gita (09.26) declares that Krishna accepts even the simplest of things if offered with devotion. Therefore, we need to prioritize direct bhakti activities that increase our devotional desire for Krishna (12.09).

By such proper prioritization, when we keep our desire for Krishna the foremost desire in our consciousness, we can offer him wonderful things whenever possible and offer him our heart always.

Think it over

How can the desire to offer something to Krishna distract us from him?

What is the most essential offering in bhakti?

How can we maintain proper prioritization in bhakti?

09.26 If one offers Me with love and devotion a leaf, a flower, a fruit or water, I will accept it.

Fanatics use God's name to give God a bad name

The news often reports how religious fanatics kill innocent people and justify their barbarity in the name of God. Such reports, coupled with ghastly imagery, fill many people with revulsion toward not just religious fanaticism but also religion itself. Even those who don't become averse toward religion view it with suspicion or at least apathy. And because religion is centered on God, it is God who ends up getting bad press, all because of those who press his name into service for their extremist agendas.

Foreseeing such misappropriation of religion, the Bhagavad-gita (16.17) states that demonic people often perform religious activities in name only. Such people want to boost their prestige or power in society's eyes and in their own eyes, not in God's eyes. They don't want to become an instrument for God's purposes; they want to make God an instrument for their purposes.

Fanatics don't represent God. The Gita describes that God is the well-wisher of everyone (05.29). and those devoted to him similarly become well-wishers of everyone (12.13). In fact, the devoted are described as gentle, kind, tolerant, humble, composed (12.13-20) — qualities that are opposite to those found in fanatics.

How can fanaticism and the associated bad press be prevented?

By martial and intellectual measures.

Martially, fanatics need to be penalized. Intellectually, vigorous education is needed about the true nature of devotion, about the errors in fanatical conceptions of devotion and about how such conceptions are peddled by self-interested people for furthering their own interests. Such education can minimize the mass alienation from religion which happens as a reflex reaction to terrorism. It can also help those targeted by radicalization to see how their faith is distinct from its fanatical spinoffs.

Thus, the way to fight fanaticism is to promote better philosophical understanding of God's purpose and greater practical alignment of our purpose with his purpose.

Think it over

How do fanatics misappropriate God for their own purposes?

How is fanaticism the opposite of devotion?

How can fanaticism be countered?

16.17 Self-complacent and always impudent, deluded by wealth and false prestige, they sometimes proudly perform sacrifices in name only, without following any rules or regulations.

Fanatics don't see how God is present everywhere; they see how God is absent everywhere

Religious fanatics often attack those whom they deem heretics. They usually justify their actions by claiming that they are fervently devoted to God.

However, their focus is often opposite to the focus of true devotees. Whereas devotees see how God is present everywhere, fanatics see how God is absent everywhere. Let's understand this difference.

How fanatics obsess on God's absence: Fanatics operate based on their own narrow conceptions of the correct way to approach God. They consider rigid adherence to their ways as the only way to access God. If anyone deviates even slightly, they deem such deviation as evidence of God's absence. And they condemn those 'deviants' and often consider it their sacred duty to issue such condemnations.

Obsession with one small thing, equating it with everything, characterizes perception in the mode of ignorance (Bhagavad-gita 18.22). Fanatics exhibit such ignorant perception by obsessing on how certain details are missing, not on whether God is manifesting.

How devotees focus on God's presence: The devoted understand that God is present in everyone's hearts and is acting to further everyone's spiritual evolution (18.61). No matter how different someone's ways may be from ours, those differences don't debar God from acting in their lives. God, being omnipresent, can manifest wherever and however he chooses. Devotees are open to all of God's manifestations, not just those that conform to their expectations. They know that God's ways are bigger than their conceptions.

Does such openness license religious laissez-faire? No, it's not that anything anyone does is religious. If God is manifesting in someone's life, that should tangibly increase their commitment to life's higher values, to inner cultivation, to God.

In conclusion, devotion is seen in receptivity to God's expansive ways, not in reducing God to conformity with one's own ways.

Think it over

How do fanatics obsess on God's absence?

How do devotees focus on God's presence?

How does openness to God's ways not license religious laissez-faire?

18.22 And that knowledge by which one is attached to one kind of work as the all in all, without knowledge of the truth, and which is very meager, is said to be in the mode of darkness.

Let your practices make you a spiritual fruit, not a religious nut

Religious nuts are those people who in the name of religion become fanatical, irrational, disagreeable. In contrast, spiritual fruits are those religious practitioners who manifest virtues such as humility, sensitivity, forgiveness.

What makes some people religious nuts and others, spiritual fruits? Often, it's their conception of spiritual growth.

Let's compare the bottom of a mountain to material consciousness and the top of the mountain to spiritual consciousness. Religious practices are meant to raise people from material consciousness to spiritual consciousness. However, some religious practitioners become too attached to the externals of their particular path. They hold that their path is the only way up the mountain and those on any other path are dangerous deviants destined for hell. Such conceptions make them religious nuts.

Those people become spiritual fruits who appreciate that there can be many paths up the mountain. They are not naive, though. They understand that not all paths will take people up the mountain, some may take them down into a valley too. They commit themselves to the practices of their path, while constantly monitoring whether their practices are actually raising their consciousness. And they assess others based on their overall consciousness, not their specific practices.

Gita wisdom offers an inclusive vision of the ultimate reality wherein all people are seen to be on the one shared journey of consciousness (04.11). The Bhagavad-gita (18.66) urges us to give up all religious formularies and focus only on the essential principle of love for the divine, a love that is expressed through wholehearted, unreserved surrender. When we learn to appreciate love of God, wherever it is found, we become spiritual fruits, not religious nuts.

The more we apply the Gita the more we can become spiritual fruits. And the more we share the Gita, the more we can help others become spiritual fruits, thus helping raise global human consciousness.

Think it over

How can we identify religious nuts?

How does the Gita urge us to become spiritual fruits, not religious nuts?

How can we help raise human consciousness?

18.66 Abandon all varieties of religion and just surrender unto Me. I shall deliver you from all sinful reactions. Do not fear.

Understanding Gita Concepts

To understand one thing, we sometimes need to revise how we understand everything

Suppose we are struggling to solve a mathematical sum, but are getting nowhere. The problem is that we have blundered in the first step itself; no matter how much we strive to get the answer right, we can't succeed, till we retrace our steps back to the first step.

Similarly, when we face perplexities in life, the consequent questions are like hydras – mythical monsters with multiple heads that, even if chopped off, reappear. Hydras need to be slain by determining where their life lies and attacking there.

Arjuna faced such a hydra at the start of the Bhagavad-gita. His perplexity seemed to be about a simple question: should I fight or not? But answering that question was extraordinarily difficult because duty could be said to call him in both directions. So, he needed to re-examine his understanding of dharma, which referred essentially to the right thing to do (02.07). To know what the right activity was for him, he had to revisit his understanding of both his identity and his destiny – who he was and what his life was meant for.

Similarly, when we face perplexities, we can paper over the problems by coming up with some platitudes or pep talks. But those won't offer us any lasting relief or transformational insight. Indeed, it was only when Arjuna rejected such advice and insisted on addressing life's fundamental questions that Krishna, the supreme mentor, started speaking the Gita.

Significantly, because Arjuna extended his enquiry from a circumstantial concern to a universal human necessity, the Gita itself has acquired enduring relevance. When we too recognize the need for re-examining our fundamental worldview or at least become open to such re-examination, the Gita's profound wisdom will enrich us forever.

Think it over

How are life's perplexities like hydras?

How was Arjuna's question not simple?

When can Gita wisdom enrich us forever?

02.07 Now I am confused about my duty and have lost all composure because of miserly weakness. In this condition I am asking You to tell me for certain what is best for me. Now I am Your disciple, and a soul surrendered unto You. Please instruct me.

Choose the good when it protects you from the bad, but not when it deprives you of the best

Suppose we had to choose between a low-quality product for a high price and a high-quality product for a high price. We would naturally choose the high-quality product.

But suppose the context changes. Suppose a third choice comes up, which offers a high-quality product for a low price. If we are too caught in a tunnel vision, then we may not notice the expansion of context; we may stick to the good choice and cheat ourselves of the best choice.

The Bhagavad-Gita (02.49) offers a similar expansion of context when it urges us to give up small-minded work that is attached to worldly results and take up large-minded work that aspires for eternal spiritual realization.

At the start of the Gita, Arjuna saw two options: fight against his relatives to regain his kingdom or avoid bloodshed by forfeiting his right to the kingdom. The Gita expanded his context beyond the material conception of life by explaining our essential identity as indestructible souls. We all are transmigrating through various bodies on a multi-life journey of spiritual evolution. What propels us onward in this evolutionary journey is harmonious action: action that is in harmony with the whole, the all-attractive Supreme Person, whose eternal parts we are. That Whole, Krishna, had manifested on earth to establish dharma. And he wanted Arjuna to fight in the war for establishing dharma.

Concerns for others and the concomitant desire for nonviolence are good; they are way better than self-centered indulgence that is harmful to others. However, concern for others shouldn't be limited to their bodies, but should also extend to their souls. And if something physically unpleasant is spiritually beneficial, we need to toughen ourselves to do what is best, without settling for the good.

Think it over

How does the Gita expand our vision of our choices?

How did the Gita expand Arjuna's context?

For any perplexity confronting you, can you use Gita wisdom to expand your context?

02.49 O Dhananjaya, keep all abominable activities far distant by devotional service, and in that consciousness surrender unto the Lord. Those who want to enjoy the fruits of their work are misers.

The capacity to trade the present for the future is the defining human characteristic

All living beings live at the fleeting junction of the past and the future. That junction is the present, which is there at one moment and gone the next.

All living beings follow their bodily impulses to eat, sleep, procreate and protect, but we humans can do something more. We can regulate these impulses that offer some pleasure in the present and can instead focus on creating some better arrangements for the future. Indeed, all the progress that has lifted humanity above the animal world has come from this ability to trade the present for the future.

For example, when Newton famously saw an apple falling, he traded the present pleasure of food for the future pleasure of an increased understanding of reality. By that sacrifice, he discovered the principle of gravity and stimulated the scientific revolution that has transformed our outer world.

This same principle underlies the widespread traditional practice of sacrifice. Done in various cultures across the world, this practice was meant not just to appease some unknown gods, but also to empower humans to improve themselves by delaying present gratification for gaining some higher future satisfaction.

Underscoring the universality and potency of sacrifice, the Bhagavad-gita (03.09) states that it can take us from bondage in material consciousness to liberation in spiritual consciousness. The central ingredient to be sacrificed here is our consciousness. Instead of offering our consciousness to the various worldly things that promise us pleasure, we can offer it lovingly to the all-powerful, all-merciful, all-loving supreme, Krishna. And he will reciprocate by raising our consciousness from the material level to the spiritual level, to him.

Indeed, a life of devotional sacrifice can help us live meaningfully, both in the here and the hereafter.

Think it over

What is the common characteristic underlying all human progress?

What is the rationale for sacrifice?

What sacrifice can take us to the eternal world? How?

03.09 Work done as a sacrifice for Vishnu has to be performed; otherwise work causes bondage in this material world. Therefore, O son of Kunti, perform your prescribed duties for His satisfaction, and in that way you will always remain free from bondage.

The Gita is not inciteful; it is insightful

Self-interested people sometimes pursue their own agendas by inciting others to violence. And in today's globally connected world, such hate speech can trigger widespread frenzy and fury. Understandably, those new to the Bhagavad-gita may feel concerned on knowing that it urges a reluctant warrior to fight a war.

However, the Gita is not in the least inciteful. It doesn't mention even once the many atrocities that Arjuna and his family were subjected to by their evil cousins, the Kauravas. It doesn't ever call for vengeance against the wrongdoers. It doesn't contain any hate speech at all.

The Gita does ask Arjuna to fight, but the fight is to establish the rule of law, of dharma – not to settle any personal scores. And the Gita's thrust is not on fighting, but on cultivating a consciousness of purity and spirituality with which we can do all activities constructively. The Gita's battlefield setting is meant to stress how consciousness matters everywhere, even in those exceptional situations that necessitate assertive action such as war.

Consider the call to fight given in the Gita (03.30). That call is preceded by exhortations to give up lethargy and possessiveness and to cultivate spiritual awareness and devotional surrender. Such exhortations indicate that the Gita's thrust is on the inner war to fight against our own darker desires.

The Gita is insightful in the sense that it gives us inner sight: an understanding of the inner world with its subtle dynamics. It explains how we are pure souls, parts of the divine, and how we can reclaim our core goodness by overcoming the dark desires within us.

Far from inciting people to violence, Gita's insightful message equips people with the self-understanding that decreases their vulnerability to inciteful propaganda and increases their capacity to act constructively for creating a more harmonious world.

Think it over

How is the Gita not inciteful?

What is the thrust of the Gita? What is the purpose of its battlefield setting?

How is the Gita insightful and how can it protect people from getting incited?

03.30 Therefore, O Arjuna, surrendering all your works unto Me, with full knowledge of Me, without desires for profit, with no claims to proprietorship, and free from lethargy, fight.

Krishna retains his divine position even while he reclines in a supine position

Those who see Krishna's pastimes as a child sometimes wonder: "How can such a child be God?"

To unravel this mystery, let's first look at how Krishna as a child is far more than a child. Srimad-Bhagavatam describes how he performed extraordinary pastimes even while he was just a baby. When the witch Putana came to poison him, he was so small that he couldn't even crawl. He was just a newborn who would lie mostly in a supine position. And yet when Putana offered him her poison-smeared breast, he sucked out not just her milk but also her life-air. Though she tried desperately to push Krishna away, even growing to monstrous proportions in a last-ditch effort to save herself, she couldn't dislodge him even a wee bit.

Krishna's power doesn't depend on his size; he is always the Supreme. Even when he appears to be a helpless child who can't even stand on his own feet, he has the power to knock the most powerful demons off their feet.

If Krishna is always all-powerful, why does he assume a childlike form? To facilitate love. He delights not in displaying his godhood, but in reciprocating love with his intimate devotees. These devotees love him not because he is God but because he is so lovable. For reciprocating with such devotees, especially those who long to love him in a parental mood, he assumes a childlike form.

To understand these deep devotional dynamics, we need a proper philosophical perspective. When we appreciate how loving and lovable Krishna is, we don't just appreciate his childlike form; we also fall in love with him and make entering into his world of love our life's supreme purpose. The Bhagavad-gita (04.09) assures that those who understand the truth of his pastimes attain him.

Think it over

Illustrate how Krishna remains all-powerful even in a powerless childlike form.

Why does Krishna assume a childlike form?

What happens when we see Krishna's pastimes through a proper philosophical perspective?

04.09 One who knows the transcendental nature of My appearance and activities does not, upon leaving the body, take his birth again in this material world, but attains My eternal abode, O Arjuna.

Karma is not like a mysterious contagious disease; it is logical, not diabolical

When we understand the principle of karma – of how we are accountable for our actions – we become cautious to avoid wrong actions and choose right actions. However, such caution can have unwanted spinoffs. We may start treating people who do bad karma as untouchables, dreading that contact with them will infect us with their karma.

However, karma is not a mysterious contagion that may infect by accidental contact. After all, karma is not diabolical, causing misery for no reason. It is logical, giving us the due consequences for our choices. Beyond this central principle of accountability, the workings of karma can be incomprehensible (Bhagavad-gita 04.17). It's impossible to correlate our innumerable pasts choices with our variegated present situations.

Rather than becoming paranoid about karma, we can focus on the essential purpose of karmic accountability: to encourage us to do the right thing, thereby furthering our spiritual evolution toward the ultimate reality, Krishna. And integral to doing the right thing is treating everyone with the dignity they are due as our fellow human beings and as parts of Krishna. Such empathy increases as we evolve spiritually. Those who see Krishna everywhere (06.30) also see everyone equally in their pleasure and pain (06.32).

How does empathy apply with regard to those doing bad karma? Just as we will feel alienated if someone looks down at us because we are doing something that we don't even know is wrong, others too will feel alienated. If our karma consciousness makes us seem like pompous do-gooders, thereby repelling others from the spiritual wisdom we present and represent, we will end up doing the wrong thing – in the name of karma.

When we focus on being Krishna conscious, not karma conscious, we do the right thing, in a way that attracts others to do the right thing.

Think it over

How can karma consciousness have unwanted spinoffs?

Why is a judgmental attitude arising from karma misinformed?

When dealing with those doing bad karma, how can we be empathic?

04.17 The intricacies of action are very hard to understand. Therefore one should know properly what action is, what forbidden action is and what inaction is.

A missed apostrophe can be a catastrophe – we are God's, not Gods

Some people hold, “We are all Gods, for we are all the same impersonal omnipresent spirit that is commonly known as God.”

This monistic claim is questionable, both logically and scripturally. Logically, if we were Gods, why aren't we omnipotent? Why are we controlled by time which forces us to grow old, get diseased and die?”

Scripturally, the Bhagavad-gita states clearly that we are parts of God (15.07). And this is not a conditioned vision, but an enlightened vision – Those in knowledge see that all living beings belong to God and are situated in him (04.35). Meaning we are God's, not that we are Gods.

These two understandings differ only in an apostrophe, but failing to understand that difference can lead to a catastrophe. How? By depriving us of love and grace.

Deprived of love: If we are ourselves Gods, then there's no being outside of us that we can cherish as an object of love. Liberation becomes reduced to spiritual solipsism, wherein we alone exist as undifferentiated consciousness with no one to love or be loved by. Such lonesome liberation is hardly a recipe for bliss.

Deprived of grace: To get to liberation, we have to struggle lifelong through this temptation-filled world. During that demanding journey, monism leaves us with no higher being to seek help from; our reason is our only weapon. And battling temptation with mere reason unaided by spiritual love and divine grace is a recipe for failure.

Even if we have some spiritual inclination, our monistic misconception massively misleads us; the missed apostrophe sets us up for a catastrophe.

How can we overcome monistic misconceptions? By studying the Gita, we can gain proper self-understanding and embrace bhakti-yoga. Practicing this yoga of love, we can access divine grace and progress toward everlasting ecstatic devotional liberation.

Think it over

How is monism questionable, logically and scripturally?

How does monism deprive us of love?

How does monism deprive us of grace?

04.35 Having obtained real knowledge from a self-realized soul, you will never fall again into such illusion, for by this knowledge you will see that all living beings are but part of the Supreme, or, in other words, that they are Mine.

Doubt is a disease that makes the patient believe the doctor is sick

Suppose a patient rejects a doctor's advice, arguing that it is the doctor who is sick. Such a patient would be considered mentally sick. But suppose the patient is infected by a germ that could make its victim believe that the doctor is sick. That germ would be lethal indeed.

Unfortunately, we all are prone to such a germ, which can afflict us with spiritual sickness. That germ is doubt. Whenever we embark on the spiritual path, we need to repose our faith in the existence of a higher spiritual reality and in the path that can help us experience that reality. While doubts are natural on the spiritual path, that doesn't make them desirable and certainly not reliable. Put another way, our doubts don't naturally deserve our trust. We need to doubt our doubts. Equipping us for dealing with our doubts, Gita wisdom provides us powerful resources: a profound philosophy that gives reasoned arguments and a time-tested process that gives transformative experiences.

However, when doubts grip us, we neglect all these resources and start looking down at believers as naive. We think that we are not as gullible as them, that we are intellectually superior because we have higher critical faculties.

While many believers may be naive, some are not; they aren't just believers but are also seers. They have higher spiritual realizations, and they are expert spiritual doctors who can treat our doubts. But doubts can impel us to dismiss their wisdom as a delusion, without even considering that it may be we who are in delusion. No wonder the Bhagavad-gita (04.40) cautions that doubters create a dark future for themselves.

Thankfully, we can protect ourselves from being deluded by doubt if we understand its modus operandi and equip ourselves with reliable spiritual resources.

Think it over

How is doubt like a deadly infection?

For dealing with doubt, what resources does Gita wisdom provide?

Have you ever felt superior to 'naive' believers? How can you best deal with those feelings?

04.40 But ignorant and faithless persons who doubt the revealed scriptures do not attain God consciousness; they fall down. For the doubting soul there is happiness neither in this world nor in the next.

As long as we are self-seeking, we can't be a seeker of the self

Self-seeking people care for their own pleasures, without caring for anyone else. Such people can't be seekers of the self because what they seek is peripheral to their actual self.

What does seeking the actual self mean? It means to see beyond the designations that cloud our perception of our identity and interests.

Gita wisdom explains that our actual self is spiritual. The more we pander to our senses, the more we get caught in craving and slaving for worldly pleasures, and the further our consciousness goes from spiritual awareness. The Bhagavad-gita stresses that the materially attached can't be spiritually absorbed or even spiritually attracted (02.44) — they can't be seekers of the self.

How can we seek the self? Not merely by intellectual enquiry, but primarily by embarking on a spiritual journey. That journey begins by understanding that the self is meant to be a part of something bigger than the self. Constitutionally, we are all parts of the Complete Whole, the all-attractive supreme person, Krishna (15.07). Functionally, we are meant to love and serve him. When we connect lovingly with him, we gain clarity and purity. Clarity because a devotional connection with all-wise Krishna illuminates us internally with divine wisdom to see ourselves more clearly. Purity because a devotional connection with all-pure Krishna purges us of the impure desires that take us away from our self. When we thus see ourselves with clarity and purity, we wholeheartedly serve Krishna and compassionately serve all living beings in relationship with Krishna. Indeed, the Gita (05.25) declares that when spiritualists become purified and strive for everyone's welfare, they progress toward spiritual perfection.

Equipped with purity and clarity, when we thus go beyond self-seeking, we become initially seekers of the self and eventually seers of the self.

Think it over

Why can't self-seeking people be seekers of the self?

How can we seek the self?

How can purity and clarity help us seek the self?

05.25 Those who are beyond the dualities that arise from doubts, whose minds are engaged within, who are always busy working for the welfare of all living beings and who are free from all sins achieve liberation in the Supreme.

Analyzing a spiritual text without applying it is like examining food without eating it

Suppose someone is starving. If they are given food and they spend all their time examining the food, such behavior would be strange indeed.

Food is meant to be eaten, not just examined. Of course, we need to examine food before we eat it, especially if we are eating at an unfamiliar place that may be unhygienic. But if the food has been eaten and relished by many, and if we have examined it duly, then to keep examining it without eating it is to deprive ourselves.

The same principle applies to the study of spiritual texts such as the Bhagavad-gita. The Gita is essentially a guidebook for living. If we are new to it, we need to analyze it to check if it makes sense. For those wanting to analyze it, the Gita offers an intriguing worldview whose fundamentals are as follows. We are spiritual beings; our life becomes meaningful and fulfilling when we evolve spiritually; we can evolve spiritually by connecting with the supreme spiritual being, Krishna.

The Gita explains that these spiritual truths can be not just realized but also relished by those who practice bhakti-yoga (09.02). By bhakti-yoga practice, our knowledge blossoms into realization, granting us sublime satisfaction (06.08). The Gita has served as a trustworthy guidebook for millions for millennia, including for many of the wisest people to have walked the earth, who have all feasted on its wisdom and found enduring bliss.

Given the Gita's potency to fulfill our longing for happiness, why should anyone merely analyze it without applying it? Why keep oneself hungry when food is ready?

Think it over

What is the Gita's fundamental worldview?

How can we relish Gita wisdom?

How can you better apply any one teaching of the Gita in your life?

06.08 A person is said to be established in self-realization and is called a yogi [or mystic] when he is fully satisfied by virtue of acquired knowledge and realization. Such a person is situated in transcendence and is self-controlled. He sees everything – whether it be pebbles, stones or gold – as the same.

We are in illusion, but we are not an illusion

Suppose someone we trusted implicitly betrays us totally. Being devastated, we may ask ourselves: “What is real? How do I differentiate reality from illusion?”

Faced with such difficult differentiation, some people say, “Everything is an illusion – not only things out there but also whatever is inside. Even our sense of I-ness is an illusion.” By such blanket generalization, they put themselves in illusion about the scope of illusion. Illusion essentially means a false perception. But for any kind of perception, real or illusory, the perceiver has to be real. Without a real perceiver, there won’t be any perception at all, not even an illusory perception. The sight of water in a desert can be an illusion, but the seer can’t be an illusion; if the seer were an illusion, there would be no seeing.

Pertinently, Gita wisdom asserts that we all are real because we are parts of the supreme reality (15.07). That supreme reality, the source of everything, the inexhaustible reservoir of all potency and beauty is the all-attractive transcendental person, Krishna. While analyzing the nature of existence, the Bhagavad-gita states that unconscious matter is Krishna’s inferior energy (07.04) and we conscious beings comprise Krishna’s supreme energy (07.05).

Though we are real, we are presently dragged by our mind and senses from reality into illusion. What is the illusion? It is to mistake the temporary to be eternal; to pursue ephemeral material things that offer meager pleasure as if they were sources of lasting pleasure. This illusion can be best countered by connecting ourselves with our source. Bhakti-yoga offers a time-honored process for aligning ourselves with the all-attractive source of everything, Krishna. When we, the infinitesimal reality, bond lovingly with the infinite reality, we relish joy eternal and become fully free from illusion.

Indeed, enlightenment centers not on rejecting our existence, but on realizing our spiritual essence.

Think it over

We are an illusion – how is this statement an illusion?

How can we become free from illusion?

What is enlightenment?

07.05 Besides these, O mighty-armed Arjuna, there is another, superior energy of Mine, which comprises the living entities who are exploiting the resources of this material, inferior nature.

Don't reduce scripture to your conceptions of what scripture should be teaching; expand your conceptions to understand what scripture is actually teaching

When we study scripture, our preconceptions often act as a subconscious filter. This filter highlights those parts of scripture that confirm our conceptions and downplays those parts that confound our conceptions. After such study, we may think we know scripture, but we don't. To actually know scripture, we need to look at our preconceptions through scripture, not look at scripture through our preconceptions.

Consider a Bhagavad-gita teaching that is often reduced and distorted by people's preconceptions: the Gita's vision of the divine. Some people who consider the Hindu tradition to be polytheistic hold that the Gita, being a Hindu scripture, teaches polytheism. And they highlight verses wherein the Gita talks about multiple gods (07.20-23). Others who consider the Hindu tradition monistic argue that such Gita references to many gods point to the temporality of all objects of worship: ultimately, the worshiper and the worshipped unite in an undifferentiated oneness; and the various gods are interchangeable objects for intermediate meditation.

But what is the Gita's actual vision of divinity? It's a sophisticated theological structure that can be called polymorphic monotheism. Monotheism because it refers to one ultimate reality, who is neither personal like us nor impersonal; that reality is trans-personal, being a personality that is transcendental to the limitations that beset all mundane personalities. And polymorphic because that ultimate reality has many manifestations. These manifestations exist at different levels, with different degrees of power, and they attract godless souls of various mentalities to progress toward God-consciousness. The powers of these manifestations (or deities) come from the Ultimate (Bhagavad-gita 07.21), as do the deities themselves (10.02).

This remarkable vision of divinity is a small sample of the profound knowledge that scripture shares with those who can put aside their own filters.

Think it over

How do our preconceptions affect our scriptural study?

What is the Gita's vision of the divine? How is it often distorted?

What conceptions do you hold strongly? How do they affect your scriptural study?

07.21 I am in everyone's heart as the Supersoul. As soon as one desires to worship some demigod, I make his faith steady so that he can devote himself to that particular deity.

To forget that the world is a hurtful place is to place ourselves on a path full of hurts

Suppose we walk out on a thorny path without any footwear. We will hurt our feet. If someone warns us that the way is thorny, they aren't being pessimistic; they are simply preparing us for the inevitable.

Similar is the Bhagavad-gita's warning that the world is a place of distress (08.15). Hurts can come upon us at any moment from our own body and mind, from the people around us and from nature. To prepare ourselves for the hurts of material existence, we need to equip our consciousness with spiritual attachment and absorption.

Wherever our consciousness is, that's what we experience most intensely. For example, if we are attached to cricket, then our consciousness may get so caught in a cricket match thousands of miles away that we become oblivious to things and events around us. Similarly, if we are attached to the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna, we will become so absorbed in him that life's ups and downs won't affect us that much. Unfortunately, most of us stay in material consciousness, being captivated by the promise of worldly pleasures. And thus we put ourselves on the path to suffering.

Gita wisdom explains that though we can't avoid getting hurt in this world, we can resize the hurt. If our consciousness is locked into the world, that hurt gets maximized. If our consciousness has expanded beyond the world, that hurt gets minimized. When our consciousness is thus expanded, we don't fixate on specific hurts; we need to see the world's overall nature and seek to spiritualize our consciousness. Then, if and when it is possible, we can work to rectify the specific hurt.

Most importantly, by striving to spiritualize our consciousness, we can raise ourselves not only above that particular hurt but also become more connected to the one who is the shelter beyond all hurts.

Think it over

When is the Bhagavad-gita's declaration that the world is a hurtful place not pessimistic?

How does the location of our consciousness determine our experience?

How can Gita wisdom help us minimize the world's hurts?

08.15 After attaining Me, the great souls, who are yogis in devotion, never return to this temporary world, which is full of miseries, because they have attained the highest perfection.

Even if we fare well in life, we still have to say farewell to life

We all wish to fare well in life; we seek positions and possessions as markers of our progress and success. Often, we lament because we haven't fared as well as we would have liked to.

To avoid unnecessary lamentation, we need to see things in perspective. And the most important perspective-restoring insight is that everything in this world is temporary. All paths in life, no matter how successful and trailblazing, end ultimately in one place: the graveyard. No matter how well we fare in life, we eventually have to say farewell to life. And the farewell won't be joyful; it will be tearful and fearful. Why? Because everything we have craved and slaved for will be ripped away from us in one excruciating moment at death. Underscoring the temporariness of everything in the material world, the Bhagavad-gita (08.16) stresses that even the places of the highest achievements are marred by death, which pervades the entire cosmos.

Does this mean that we shouldn't try to fare well in life, that we should just passively resign ourselves to our fate? No, we need to expand our conception of what faring well in life means. Gita wisdom explains that we are eternal souls who are meant to delight in eternal love with our all-attractive Lord, Krishna. If we practice bhakti-yoga during our lifetime and thereby make Krishna our dearest object of love, we will attain his abode after death (08.05). Thus, we won't have to say farewell to the one we love, but will be united with him forever.

Indeed, when we live in such a way that we never have to say farewell to what is the dearest to us, that is the life in which we truly fare well.

Think it over

What perspective can protect us from unnecessary lamentation about our status in life?

Why is farewell in life not joyful?

What defines a life in which we truly fare well?

08.16 From the highest planet in the material world down to the lowest, all are places of misery wherein repeated birth and death take place. But one who attains to My abode, O son of Kunti, never takes birth again.

Just because we can do the impossible doesn't mean we can do everything

Impossible is a word in a fool's dictionary – what is the spiritual perspective on this saying?

To understand, let's first differentiate between doing the impossible and doing everything.

We can do the impossible: Many of our limitations are self-imposed; they are justifications of our lazy mind, which is averse to the hard work necessary for doing anything ambitious. Disregarding our mind, when we strive determinedly in a mood of service to the divine, he empowers us to do things that we had considered impossible.

We can't do everything: Though some of our limitations are merely mental constructs, not all are. Materially and spiritually both, we have limitations. We are finite souls, presently living in fallible, fragile, fleshly bodies. We are not God; only God is God. When God empowers us, we may do the impossible. But God is not bound to empower us to do everything. Even if we long to do something, he may empower someone else to do it. Or he may decide that it needn't happen at all.

To illustrate this difference between the impossible and everything, consider Arjuna's example. He was urged to fight the Kurukshetra war with the assurance that his enemies were already killed by divine arrangement (Bhagavad-gita 11.33). During that war, he achieved the impossible on several occasions, most famously when he penetrated through the entire Kaurava army to fell Jayadratha, the vile prince responsible for the death of Arjuna's son, Abhimanyu. Yet despite achieving such impossible feats, Arjuna couldn't achieve everything – he couldn't save Abhimanyu.

Divine empowerment is both unquestionably real and unquestionably independent. By understanding these twin truths about empowerment, we can resolutely push against the limitations coming from our lethargic mind and gracefully accept the limits coming from divine will.

Think it over

How can we do the impossible?

Why can't we do everything?

What are two truths about divine empowerment? How does understanding them will shape our actions?

11.33 Therefore get up. Prepare to fight and win glory. Conquer your enemies and enjoy a flourishing kingdom. They are already put to death by My arrangement, and you, O Savyasachi, can be but an instrument in the fight.

Death is meant to point to enlightenment, not be a plot point in entertainment

Death is one of life's most sobering realities, being the irreversible closing of curtains on our present lifetime.

Before that terminal encounter, we frequently encounter death nowadays in entertainment media. Novels and movies often depict death vividly, to evoke our emotions and to engage us with the storyline. However, though we experience vicariously the agony of death befalling fictional characters, the overall setting of entertainment puts a comfort blanket around us. Hardly ever do we contemplate that death will befall us too, at any moment. We see death largely as a plot point in entertainment.

However, trivializing death thus deprives us of a powerful pointer to enlightenment. The Bhagavad-gita (13.09) recommends that we unsentimentally contemplate life's universal distresses including death. Such contemplation forcefully highlights the glaring incompatibility between our core longing and our current living.

We all long to live forever and to love forever. Yet all things in the world, we included, are bound to die. We deny this frustrating incompatibility by busying ourselves in mundane concerns, including entertainment. But our ostrich-like obliviousness to death's imminence is jolted when we encounter death at close quarters, as when it misses us narrowly or befalls someone close to us.

Such encounters impel us to ask: when death is so unavoidably natural in this world, why do we feel it so shockingly unnatural? Wisdom-texts such as Bhagavad-gita provide an answer: Because we don't belong to this world. We are souls who belong to the spiritual world, where we are meant to delight forever in loving harmony with the supreme spiritual reality, Krishna. Indeed, to realize and relish that life of immortal love is to be enlightened.

Pointing us toward that enlightened state, so that we aspire to attain it, is the ultimate purpose of contemplating death.

Think it over

How does entertainment media distort our vision of death?

How can death point us to enlightenment?

When did you encounter death at close quarters? What did that encounter teach you?

13.09 ... Renunciation of the objects of sense gratification; absence of false ego, the perception of the evil of birth, death, old age and disease; ... [– all these I declare to be knowledge]

When the part offers its whole to the Whole, the Whole makes the part whole

We often feel a sense of incompleteness, a feeling that something is missing in our lives. Usually, we try to overcome this feeling by getting something from outside: wealth, possessions, positions and so forth. However, such efforts only leave us craving for more.

How can we feel complete? By connecting with the Complete Whole, the all-attractive Supreme, Krishna.

The Bhagavad-gita (15.07) states that we are souls, who are parts of Krishna. By our constitutional nature, we are meant to love and serve him, and relish unending love and joy therein. Unfortunately, we are presently misled by our mind and senses into pursuing various worldly objects – a pursuit that is endless and keeps us restless.

We can never become independently complete; disconnected from Krishna, we can never be satisfied. But we can become connectedly complete, that is, by connecting with Krishna, we can relish the fullest satisfaction accessible to us finite beings.

Thus, the way to completeness is counterintuitive: not seeking to get the best from outside inside, but getting out our best from inside us and offering it to the One who is the best outside and inside.

When we act in a mood of service to Krishna, offering our consciousness to him, he becomes pleased and manifests himself in our heart. And he alone can satisfy us – the capacity of all worldly objects to provide satisfaction is like a spark, whereas his capacity is like that of the sun, the source of all the sparks (10.41).

When we offer our entire consciousness to Krishna, he reciprocates by filling our entire consciousness with his supremely sweet presence.

Thus, when the part offers it whole to the Whole – we offer our entire consciousness to Krishna – the Whole makes the part whole: Krishna helps us relish completeness.

Think it over

Why does seeking worldly objects not remove our feeling of incompleteness?

How can we relish completeness?

How can offering our whole to Krishna satisfy us?

15.07 The living entities in this conditioned world are My eternal fragmental parts. Due to conditioned life, they are struggling very hard with the six senses, which include the mind.

A God who pretended we had no shortcomings would be a God who did not take our potential seriously

Suppose a coach tells a trainee-athlete, “You are perfect; you have no shortcomings.” Such pampering suggests that the coach doesn’t see any potential in that athlete. Since they can’t improve, maybe it’s best that they feel good about being where they are. If the coach takes an athlete’s potential seriously, they would prescribe a rigorous regimen for manifesting that potential.

God, Krishna, is our ultimate coach; he takes our potential seriously, far more seriously than what we ourselves do. He can see that we can do so many more things than what we are doing presently and that we can be a far better being than what we are presently. While expert coaches can see their trainee’s potential in their particular field of expertise, omniscient Krishna can see our potential in all fields. Beyond whatever material potentials we may have, he sees our spiritual potential: we are souls, his eternal parts. If we connect lovingly with him, we can become channels for his supreme light to shine through, making our world brighter.

However, this divine light is obscured by the cloud of our many impurities. To dissipate these clouds, Krishna provides us time-tested guidelines through scripture (Bhagavad-gita 16.24). However, having our impurities highlighted can be humbling. And working to eliminate them can be exhausting. To overcome such negative feelings, we need to see scriptural guidelines positively – they are like an expert coach’s training regimen for a talented athlete. Following the regimen can be rewarding, far more rewarding than any sports achievement.

When we become purified by living according to scripture, we will start manifesting our potentials materially and spiritually. And we will be amazed at how much outer contribution we can make and how much inner satisfaction we can get.

Think it over

When may a coach pamper a trainee? Why?

What all potential can God see in us?

Why do scriptural guidelines seem demanding? How can we see them positively?

16.24 One should therefore understand what is duty and what is not duty by the regulations of the scriptures. Knowing such rules and regulations, one should act so that he may gradually be elevated.

Scripture is meant to be not just mapped, but also mined

Suppose we are in a territory rich with buried treasures. We may need to initially map the territory, but we will become rich only when we mine it.

Scripture is a territory rich with the treasure of spiritual wisdom. When studying a scripture such as Bhagavad-gita, we may need or want to map it. To that end, we may analyze how one verse leads to the next, how one theme segues into another and how one chapter links with its adjacent chapters.

Simultaneously however, the essential treasure of scripture is found not through mapping but through mining. Mining scripture means going deep into scriptural verses for assimilating and applying them. Only through such internalization of the scriptural message will our consciousness expand, enabling us to relish spiritual reality, including the ultimate spiritual reality, the all-attractive supreme, Krishna.

The Gita itself stresses that scripture is meant to be mined, that is, used as a guidebook for action (16.24). Moreover, its conclusion demonstrates how mining it is sublimely enriching. Sanjaya applies the Gita's core message – to focus the mind on Krishna – and relishes constant joy (18.76-77).

While studying the Gita, we can map it as much as possible. Mapping the Gita is valuable to the extent it helps us in mining it systematically. But mapping shouldn't become an end in itself; nor should it consume us so much that we forget to mine what we read. To be more concerned with linking verses than applying them is counter-productive. We need to focus primarily on contemplating what the verse means to us and how we can internalize it.

If we develop this mood of mining the Gita, especially by associating with those Gita savants who are expert miners, even one Gita verse can provide us endless enrichment.

Think it over

What is meant by mapping and mining of scripture?

How can mapping scripture help or hinder mining scripture?

Which Gita verses would you like to mine? How can you mine them?

16.24 One should therefore understand what is duty and what is not duty by the regulations of the scriptures. Knowing such rules and regulations, one should act so that he may gradually be elevated.

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- Chaitanya Charan

Books by Chaitanya Charan

THE SPIRITUAL SCIENTIST SERIES

The Spiritual Scientist' Series, Volume 1 & 2

This compilation of articles published in Times of India and other leading Indian newspapers empowers you to rediscover the missing spiritual dimension of life. The memorable examples, the soothing language, the eloquent words and the convincing logic will equip you with fresh spiritual perspectives for personal contemplation and rejuvenation as well as for group discussions and interviews.

Science and Spirituality (Spiritual Scientist Series, Volume 3)

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Demystifying Reincarnation

Demystifying Reincarnation explores questions of our identity and destiny scientifically, historically and philosophically. Scientifically, pioneering researchers have documented fascinating cases of: Children who recollect past lives, giving details that they had no normal way of knowing. People who, despite being medically unconscious, were conscious of their vicinity and beyond. Historically, the principle of reincarnation has enjoyed acceptance in most parts of the globe throughout the ages. Philosophically, reincarnation is the bedrock of a profound world view that reflects our intuitive sense of justice, our innate need for hope and our universal longing for immortality. Demystifying Reincarnation expands our understanding of what it means to be human and reveals new horizons for our deepest aspirations.

Frequently Unanswered Questions

Frequently Un-Answered Questions (FAQ) is an intellectual treat that systematically answers common and uncommon questions about life and living, science and spirituality, Vedic wisdom and self-improvement through spirituality. The answers are phrased in eloquent language, permeated with clear logic, based on timeless wisdom, and illustrated with modern examples, revealing statistics and memorable quotes. Every one of the over 50 answers is like an illuminating ray of insight that will show the way to the treasure of love hidden in our own hearts.

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Presented in an engaging question-answer format spiced with everyday examples, Idol Worship or Ideal Worship? illuminates a wide variety of historical, social, cultural and scriptural issues surrounding the traditional Indian practice of Deity worship. Some of the questions answered in this book are:

- Does a form not limit God?
- Why is an image made of stone considered to be God?
- If the Deity is God, then why can't the Deity blow away a fly on his face?
- Is Deity worship meant for less intelligent people?
- When we place food in front of the Deity, does anything really happen to the food?
- Why do we move various items in circles around the Deity during aratis?
- Is Deity worship of any practical use in our modern times?
- This book will offer: Deeper insights into the meaning and necessity of Deity worship to those already practicing it.
- Systematic logical, philosophical and scriptural answers to those having questions about Deity worship

- Refreshingly new perspectives to those equating Deity worship with idolatry

Why do we need a temple?

Presented as a lively and lucid conversation centered on the acronym T.E.M.P.L.E., Why do we need a temple? provides logical and authoritative answers to common questions about spirituality in general and a temple in particular.

My Little Bhakti Companion

My Little Bhakti Companion answers eighteen questions that address many common challenges confronting sadhakas:

- Why do I misidentify with my mind so much?
- Why do I feel so mentally exhausted?
- Why does my consciousness change suddenly from devotional to sensual?
- How can I increase my faith in Krishna?
- Should I forgive someone who has hurt me badly?
- Why do I find chanting boring?
- How can I understand that loving Krishna will fulfill my longing for love? By making Krishna's wisdom our bhakti companion, we can progress steadily towards reuniting with our unseen companion.

Prabhupada: The moments that made his movement

This book depicts pictorially and describes in capsules the defining moments in the life of Srila Prabhupada, the great modern-day saint who pioneered the spread of bhakti wisdom all over the world.

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What turns friends into worst enemies? Is accepting misfortunes as our destiny fatalistic or pragmatic? Can we regulate our emotions without repressing them? Seeking answers to such universal questions, Wisdom from the Ramayana: On Life and Relationships taps into the timeless wisdom of the Ramayana, encompassing many of its characters and reflecting on the complex dynamics of their relationships. By analyzing

the thought processes of these characters and the principles they lived by, this self-help book offers guidelines to build lasting relationships and lead a spiritually fulfilling life.

SPIRITUAL OBSERVER BOOKS

Oh My God! Re-answering the Questions

The Bollywood Movie Oh My God! fittingly exposed the arrogance and hypocrisy of godmen. It also made several important points about specific religious practices as well as the generic role of religion in society. Oh My God! Re-answering the Questions responds to those points through thirty-two question-answers like: Do we need middlemen to approach God? Does God help atheists and oppose godmen? Is religion made by man or by God? When we don't chant "Papa, Papa", why should we chant "Krishna, Krishna"? Does religion make people violent or helpless? When God is present everywhere, why should we worship him in temple stone images?

GK for PK

PK exposes insightfully the shenanigans of godmen and the gullibility of their followers. But in its negative stereotyping of religion, it mixes superstitions with meaningful spiritual practices and reduces God to an irrelevant cipher. GK for PK! responds to the issues raised in PK by drawing on logic, humor, scripture, science and common sense.

Some of the questions answered are:

- Can we reject as wrong numbers the rituals that don't make sense?
- Do people who are afraid go to temples?
- Are there two gods: the god who created man and the god whom man created?
- How can worshipping a cow get one a job?
- Does a stone smeared with colored powder become God?
- Why are we not born with our religion stamped on us?
- Why does God not respond to our prayers? Concise and penetrating, these twenty-five answers illumine universal principles of

living and loving that can help you see religion, God and life in a refreshingly new light.

Timeless Wisdom on Current Issues

Gain the eye of wisdom to see timeless principles in action amidst the world's seeming randomness and let those principles empower you to be an agent of change in your own life and in the world.

What is the root cause of gang-rapes?

- What do scientific advances like the discovery of the God particle imply?
- Why do we see the paradox of misery amidst prosperity?
- Can we be spiritual without being religious?
- Why was the Bhagavad-gita mislabeled as extremist in Russia?
- Are ancient scriptures like the Ramayana and traditional festivals like Janmashtami relevant today?
- How can we live spiritually in a materialistic age?
- How can devotion help us in times of trial?

The Searching Eye

The Searching Eye seeks spiritual wisdom for making sense of life amidst our complex contemporary world. Find time-honored insights that shed light on current issues such as sexual assault, match-fixing and suicide. Appreciate how the Bhagavad-gita's vision affirms life, strengthens relationships and illumines love in its deepest aspects. Understand what the mind is, how it misleads and how we can lead it well. Learn how to turn the bad into good, seeing positives in life's negative events. Redefine life as a reciprocation of endless spiritual love.

GITA DAILY SERIES

The Eye to See the "I"

The Eye to See the I makes spiritual knowledge easily accessible through 121 brief reflections on various verses of the Gita.

Some of the reflections are:

- Money talks – and walks away as it is talking
- We can't replace the mind, but we can replace it
- The soul seems far out because it is far in
- Free love is a self-contradiction
- The heart of knowledge is the knowledge of the heart
- Let repetition be a re-petition
- The past won't last if to Krishna we hold fast

With punchy titles that distill each article's central message, these articles provide the Gita's insights on a wide variety of issues, all meant to help us realize and relish the innermost core of our being.

Gita for Daily Enrichment

Is life a doomed journey from a station called birth to a station called death with a bit of pleasure and a lot of pain sprinkled between? Though we rarely think of life in such stark terms, isn't that its unvarnished reality? No, it isn't. Life has a higher, richer, sweeter dimension – a spiritual dimension – that we frequently overlook amidst the horse-race pace of our current civilization. The Gita for Daily Enrichment makes life's spiritual dimension readily accessible throughout the year with its 365 brief reflections that can be read in just a few minutes. Meditate daily on the timeless wisdom of the Bhagavad-gita and enrich yourself with the sublime wealth of potent, pleasant and penetrating thoughts.

Belong

Belong addresses our heart's longing to belong to something bigger than ourselves – a longing that is nourished and fulfilled by the Bhagavad-gita's transformational message of spiritual love. While presenting that message in accessible 300-word nuggets, Belong shines the light of the Gita on many themes important for our inner growth:

Optimism: Our willingness is more important than our willpower

Resentment: Possibilities expand when we begin from where we are instead of where we should be

Happiness: Temporary relief from self-inflicted torture is not pleasure

Association: Our desires are not just linear, but also triangular

Temptation: We don't have to defeat our lower desires – we can just let them lose

Discipline: Rules free you to be you

Devotion: Krishna is the master before whom we stand truly erect These 121 reflections prompt the head and the heart to move closer towards be-longing to the one in whom our potentials attain the fullest development and we find the deepest fulfillment.

Mind It!

Nothing shapes our perceptions, emotions, actions, and ultimately our destiny as much as our mind. Though the mind is a constant inner presence, we rarely realise its presence, leave alone evaluate its effect. Mind It! offers sixty-four reflections on ten verses of the Bhagavad-gita, an ancient classic on mind management. Each of these reflections is like an inner torchlight for observing whether our mind is working for our interests or against them.

Some of the reflections are:

- The mind is a tormentor, not a mentor.
- The mind may replay, but we don't have to play
- If we let the mind fill in the blanks, it will overwrite the sentence
- The mind is like a dog that barks, but can't bite – unless we let it
- When the mind cries wolf, know that the mind is the worst wolf
- Play the part of the part and the whole will fill the hole
- Meditation minimizes inner friction and maximizes outer contribution

- The mind is the TV – and the TV-thief
- When you shake an apple tree, don't be blind to the falling of mangoes
- When you shake an apple tree, don't be blind to the falling of mangoes

With catchy, concise titles that convey the gist of each of its reflections, Mind It! is a ready re-source for spiritual empowerment in our inner battle for fulfilling our potential.

Inner Change

Drawing from the timeless philosophical classic, the Bhagavad-gita, Inner Change features 121 thought-provoking, action-inspiring reflections on a wide gamut of human issues. Each reflection is encapsulated in an attractive title that doubles as a tangible carry-home message.

Managing the mind: We are not our feelings – we are the feelers of our feelings. Cultivate a tender heart, but cover it with a thick skin.

Growing through pain: We can't delete our memories, but we can choose what we remember. Focus not on letting go of things – focus on taking hold of your thoughts.

Relationships: In the war of egos, the winner is the bigger loser. We may be unloved, but we are never unlovable. Inner Change is your aid to a richer life, today and every day.

Gita Wisdom Through Quotes

Offering a thought for each day of the year, Gita Wisdom Through Quotes is a collection of aphorisms inspired by the Bhagavad-Gita. Composed by Chaitanya Charan, a monk who has studied the Gita for over two decades and taught it worldwide, these quotes illumine human concerns ranging from the intra-personal to the inter-personal, from the psychological to the eco-logical, from self-improvement to self-realization. Each quote is your pathway to a more meaningful and joyful life.

Bhagavad Gita: 365 Reflections for Daily Mindfulness

The Bhagavad-gita is a time-honored guidebook for Conscious living

Bhagavad Gita: 365 Reflections for Daily Mindfulness takes the insights of the Gita and presents them as brief, practical reflections. Each reflection comes with a title that succinctly summarizes the key point and three thought-provoking questions for further contemplation and application. These 365 reflections are classified into three major sections: nourish yourself, nourish your relationships and nourish your devotion. Each section is further divided into relevant categories such as Growing through Adversities, Mindfulness, Empower Yourself, Emotional Maturity, From Ritual to Spiritual and Overcoming Temptation. Each reflection is your pathway to a deeper, richer, better life.

The 365 Reflections for Daily Mindfulness include

Emotional Maturity: Value those who value you and don't overvalue those who devalue you.

Empower Yourself: No one has a right to mistreat you, not even you.

Overcoming Temptation: Obscenity is objectionable not because it shows too much of a person, but because it shows too little and obsesses observers with the too little.

Divine Love: Everything that happens may not be God's plan, but God can make his plan work through everything that happens.

Mindfulness: Mind your mind to know when it is in order, when on the border and when out of order.

SELF HELP

E.N.E.R.G.Y. – Your Sutra for Positive Thinking

Drawing from the insights of ancient wisdom traditions and modern management gurus, this book presents powerful principles and practices to experience the peace and power of meditation, break free from negative attitudes and habits, uncover your spiritual qualities and increase your willpower. Filled with easy to remember acronyms, memorable quotes, striking examples, entertaining stories and revealing statistics, E.N.E.R.G.Y will energize you for all-round success.

Recession – Adversity or Opportunity?

Filled with eye-opening analysis, powerful quotes, moving stories, and striking examples, this book combines ancient spiritual wisdom with modern socio-economic insights to present a dynamic, grassroots level action plan for transforming the adversity of recession into an opportunity for personal growth.

10 Leadership Sutras from Bhagavad Gita

Presented as an engaging question-answer discussion between a corporate leader and a leadership consultant, 10 Leadership Sutras from Bhagavad-gita makes the timeless wisdom of the philosophical classic, the Bhagavad-gita, accessible to the contemporary mind. Condensing the relevant principles from the Gita into 10 sutra-like statements, it brings a richer, more spiritual appreciation of life, work and success.

It provides principles and practices addressing daily concerns such as:

Managing stress – Be concerned, not disturbed

Team building – Words shape worlds; watch your words

Facing reversals – Life determines our problems; we determine their size Suited not just for present and potential leaders but also for all those who wish to lead themselves more effectively, 10 Leadership Sutras from Bhagavad-gita paves the way towards stronger commitment, greater achievement and deeper fulfillment.

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About the Author

Chaitanya Charan is an author, a motivational speaker and a traveling monk. He has been studying the Bhagavad Gita for over two decades and sharing its wisdom in universities and companies worldwide, giving some 400 talks across 100 cities every year. Author of 25 books on purposeful living and yoga wisdom, he has also been writing daily for the last ten years the world's only Gita-daily feature, a 300-word reflection on the Bhagavad Gita.



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